朔日手记
Notes on Shuori

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启程的祷声
Safe Travel NS-01

Bedroom, St. Petersburg
彼得堡卧室内

"The smoke of the fatherland is sweet and pleasant to us," especially in the early morning when someone is about to travel far from home.
家乡的灰尘总使身处其中的人感到愉快和甜蜜，在有人即将再度远行的清晨更是如此。

However, it's not obvious to this complaining lady.
至少，正要启程的人是这样认为的。

Noble Lady: Newspaper? Their cart hasn't been here for a long time. They said the price was too low and they were short-handed. Those vendors are as greedy as a bottomless pit, like those farmers.
贵族女性：——报纸？驿马车早就不过来了，说是价码不高，人手不够……都跟那些农民似的，一样贪心，恨不得把别人的舌头都吞进自己肚皮里去。

Noble Lady: The smoke, the dust, and the opportunists are the last things needed in this poor town.
贵族女性：这城里什么都缺，就是不缺烟尘和见风使舵的人。

Noble Lady: *sighs*
贵族女性：……唉……

Noble Lady: Last time, she was away for a whole year and didn't write a single letter back. Now, she's leaving again, to the places where she can only make friends with mosquitos, lice, and exiles!
贵族女性：上次出去转头就是一整年，中间半点消息也没有，这么快又要走。还要去那些地方，去跟摇蚊、虱子和流放犯交朋友。

Noble Lady: Sweet Mary forbid she should get sick or come back blind, like that woman.
贵族女性：……圣母保佑她不会落得一身病，或者像那个女人一样弄瞎了眼被赶回来。

Noble Lady: Oh, you mean the medal awarded by His Majesty. It's made of bronze. Who knows how many rubles it's worth? Not to mention the balls she had missed. Young cavaliers had come and gone, but she hadn't had the chance to meet any of them ...
贵族女性：哦，您说陛下的奖章。可铜打的奖章能值多少个卢布？不如来说说前一年她错过的那些舞会吧。许多年轻的近卫军都来了，可她却一个也没见过……

The grumbles easily sneak into the room through the window with the floating dust.
这些反对的声音很容易顺势飘进房间里，就像窗外的灰尘一样。

The one being complained about closes the door. She needs to pack carefully in a room free of noise and interruptions. For a long journey, everything is too essential to forget.
只有拉上门，得到一个足够安静平和的环境，被谈论的主角才好继续收拾行李，使整理的思绪不被打断。毕竟每样东西对远行来说都足够重要，不能忘记。

???: ... Route confirmed ...
???: ……路线确认……

???: Clothes, maps, carriage ticket, reference letter, glass bottles, rock hammer ...
???: 衣物、地图。车马券、介绍信、玻璃瓶、地质锤……

???: And the knife, in my pocket. Oh, I need to waterproof the papers.
???: 小刀在身上……纸质的东西要裹起来。

???: Linen, it's emm ... Oh, here it is.
???: 亚麻布，我记得——啊。在这儿。

The fabric, left from the last trip, has a broader width than remembered. Perhaps because it is holding paper for only one user this time, it seems much more empty than it had been.
上次旅行前裁切的布料，幅面比记忆中宽大，在仅需承载一人使用的纸张时，更因空旷而显得慷慨了。

Using such a large fabric is a luxury for her.
她很少有这样大手笔的时刻。

???: I can bring more new parchment this time.
???: 新的羊皮纸可以多带一些了。

???: ...
???: ……

???: Hmm? Wait, why is it ...
???: 嗯？奇怪，这上面怎么有……

???: ... already used?
???: ……这么多的字?

A written document is hidden between blank sheets of paper. The handwriting is inconsistent but neatly penned. It seems to have been deliberately forgotten and is now being rediscovered at this very moment.
隐藏在空白纸张中间的文字记录，字迹不一，但排列整齐。似乎被人刻意遗忘，直到现在重新发掘。

—Fortunately, there are signatures in the margins, left as a discreet footnote on each page.
——幸运的是，她能在边角处找到签名，就像每页的一枚谨慎脚注。

"Recorded by"
“记录人”——

"Yenisei"
“小叶尼塞”。

Yenisei: It's a record I wrote from dictation.
小叶尼塞: 这是……我的听写稿件。

Yenisei: Judging from the handwriting, I must have done it in the wilds. The edge is ragged, so probably it's been stored for over a year since it was dried.
小叶尼塞: 笔迹看起来像野外速记，页边磨损，已经干燥保存一年以上……

Yenisei: Over a year ... Oh, it's the travel diary Madam Bessmert asked me to write down for her.
小叶尼塞: 一年……噢，这是别斯米尔女士曾委托我记录的游记。

Yenisei: Maybe I should call it travel "notes"? Haha ...
小叶尼塞: 或者说，应该叫“手记”？哈哈……

Yenisei: Either way, I think I had completed the arrangement and sent the original to her.
小叶尼塞: 无论是什么，我都应该已经整理完成，寄给她了才对。

Yenisei: There's no way I forgot such an important thing. So what is it doing here?
小叶尼塞: 我不会忘记这种事。它怎么会还在这里?

Yenisei: And it's ... it's missing a few days of records.
小叶尼塞: 上面的记录也断了几天——

Yenisei: October 10, October 16, October 17 ...
小叶尼塞: 十月十日，十月十六，十月十七……

Yenisei: "... October 17, cloudy. We sold the carriage and rented boats from the local farmers to sail along the Om River before it froze ..."
小叶尼塞: “……十月十七日，天气阴。我们卖掉马车，改租当地农民的船只，以顺利渡过尚未进入结冰期的鄂木河……”

Yenisei: "In this way, we might be able to enter the city of Omsk without passing the north gate."
小叶尼塞：“这样我们便能找到另一种可能，规避掉从鄂木斯克北门进城的路线。”

Yenisei: "After all, the travelers from the Far East had said ... the city was heavily guarded like a fortress, and the guards would not overlook the slightest inconsistency between people's stories and their documents."
小叶尼塞：“毕竟在远东的旅行者口中……那里防备森严，如同堡垒；守卫从不放过任何说辞与文书不匹配的细节。”

Yenisei: "We had to go through this trouble because we were in such a rush when we set off that we had little time ..."
小叶尼塞：“之所以这样大费周章，都是由于出行匆忙，我们临时拼凑起的证明文书——”

???: "... to prepare the documents. They were far from authentic enough to convince the guards."
???：“——根本经不起那样严格的检验。”

???: "Before we left, I gave several speeches to raise funds for the travel. The last speech was in a new park in the downstream area of the Om River."
???：“为了筹集行程经费，我多次召开游说演讲。我还记得最后一次演讲的地方，正位于鄂木河下游的新建公园之中。”

???: "My assistant described to me that the park was crowned by a large pile of cumulate rock, which was burdened with the European Russian vegetation, all in its best time of year."
???：“据我的助手描述，那里生有一片高耸的堆积岩，上面遍布正处于茂盛期的欧洲俄罗斯植被。”

???: "This is the note on the 17th. The day after ..."
???：“这便是十七日的记述。那么，第二天后……”

???: "Emm, October 18th ..." I have almost no recollection of that day. Child, do you recall anything?
???：“唔，十月十八日”……这天我缺少印象。小叶尼塞，你还记得吗?

The girl is busy checking her records, but after a while, she opens her mouth to respond.
女孩忙于检查自己的记录，一小会儿后才终于出声回答。

Yenisei: October 18 ... I do. After we took a break and collected the supplies we needed, you talked to the governor.
小叶尼塞：十月十八日……我记得。在适当休整和获取补给之后，您与总督进行了面谈。

Yenisei: He introduced you to a historian and sent a land surveyor ...
小叶尼塞：他将负责历史研究的文员介绍给您，并派遣测绘员——

???: Oh. Yes, I remember it now. Bits of trivia. Let's skip that day for now.
???：噢，我想起来了，都是不重要的事情。那让我们跳过它吧。

Yenisei: Yes, Madam.
小叶尼塞：……好的。

???: "October 19, partly sunny. I elaborated on my plan in my speech in the park. One of my arguments mentioned the Dùshuò Festival in the Eastern Land."
???：“十月十九日，天气较为晴朗。我在公园里正式阐述了我的计划，所用论据中，就包含着部分我所了解的东方‘度朔节’传说。”

Yenisei: Legend ... of the Dùshuò Festival ...
小叶尼塞：“度朔节”，传说……

???: "... I was gratified to see that the audience was drawn to the relations between land worship and the historical geological features in Asia and the investigation materials about a long-lost arcane skill."
???：“……里面那些与亚洲土地崇拜相关的古代地质学猜想，和对佚散神秘术的考察资料，都成功引发了听众的兴趣。”

???: "While the forms of land worship vary from one religion to another, the stories about an Eastern arcane skill known to the merchants as Ask and Acquire are almost identical."
???: “土地崇拜会随‘保护神’的更替有所不同，而类似‘所求必应’的东方神秘术，却在行脚商人的口口相传中长久地存在。”

???: "In those stories, men and women with determined minds overcame the highest mountain and the deepest canyon to seek an answer ..."
???: “在那些绘声绘色的描述里，主角们常怀着用至高信念换取答案的决心，飞跃高山，横跨天堑……”

???: "... They patiently endured the suffering like the ascetics, pleading for the Gods of Shètí's motherly mercy and hoping to be given what they asked."
???: “……他们一如苦行僧般企望着摄提神的怜悯，亟待自身所求能够灵验。”

The girl quickly makes a note of these important words. From unknown to familiar, she has known these names for a long time.
年轻人快速地记录下这些关键词。从陌生到熟悉，她已经与这些名字相识长久。

???: "Even till this day, after the seekers are long gone, the god has never shown Itself to any one of us ... But we know It was there, for there is no better proof of the Ask and Acquire than this revived land."
???: “即使那人从此失去踪迹，神明也从未显露真身……但从枯寂中复现丰润的大地上，我们仍能窥见，‘所求必应’这一古老神秘术确实施行起效。”

???: "There is a sureness in people's remarks on Ask and Acquire. They are certain about its authenticity, like any geologist would not doubt the difference of soils in flood plains and mountains."
???: “毕竟他们的语调就像是地质学家研究河滩低地后，认为其土质与大部分山地有显著不同一样笃定。”

???: "That's right. Do we really have to see it to believe it? None of us have ever touched one sedimentary rock, but we can infer that such a thing exists ..."
???: “没错。人们没有亲手触摸过沉积岩，却不能因此便认为它不存在……”

The girl's speedy transcription follows in close synchronization with the speaker's words. But even so, she hesitates at this moment.
年轻人记录的速度已经能与口述者的话语保持相当的同步。但即使如此，到此处她还是迟疑了。

Yenisei: Madam, your analogy ...
小叶尼塞：别斯米尔女士，这个类比……

Bessmert: Is there a problem?
别斯米尔：嗯？有什么问题吗?

Yenisei: The existence of sedimentary rock can be verified, but that of the "lost arcane skill" cannot.
小叶尼塞：低地沉积岩是可以被验证的，“失落的神秘术”似乎并不是。

Bessmert: Which is what I'm going to do now—to find the last piece of the jigsaw puzzle.
别斯米尔：所以我才更应该亲自找到它。

???: Pardon me, ladies.
???: 请原谅我，女士们……

A third voice rings out. A young man in glasses tidies up his clothes and walks towards them.
第三人的话音响起，戴眼镜的青年整理着衣服，往两人所在的方向走来。

???: She's right. We do need to find something; otherwise, how are we supposed to make up for this time we've spent running and waiting?
???: 我们确实应该“找到”些什么，否则如何度过这在躲避中被浪费的数日呢?

Yenisei: What?
小叶尼塞：什么？

???: Take a good look around you.
???：睁开眼睛看看吧。

The girl realizes that there will be nothing more for her to record today, and puts away her pen and paper. Then she stands to take in a complete view of the steppes now that the roaring wind and rain had ceased.
女孩意识到今天不会再有东西可记了，于是依言将纸笔收好，站了起来，好去完整地看到骤雨狂风肆虐后的草原。

Vultures, the same color as the dark earth, hover above their heads, gazing with a scavenger's intent at all the creatures below them that seem to have stopped moving.
与大地呈现同样黑棕色彩的秃鹫于头顶盘旋，平等地凝视底下所有疑似不再动弹的生物。

Yenisei: The rain has stopped.
小叶尼塞：……雨停了。

???: Don't act like you just noticed it, Miss.
???：别表现得好像完全没注意到似的，小姐。

???: How much longer are we going to wait? Long enough for the vultures to eat our flesh and bones?
???：我们究竟还要等多久？等到那些秃鹫来啃掉我们的皮肉和骨头？

Yenisei: You ...
小叶尼塞：你——

Bessmert: Mr. Krolik. You're troubled by unnecessary concerns.
别斯米尔：克罗利克先生，您的担忧是没有必要的。

Bessmert: The vultures are scavengers. They are here only for the animal corpses brought by the thunderstorm. They will leave us alone.
别斯米尔：秃鹫食腐，如果它们一直在不远处盘旋，应当是为了寻找被风暴卷去后坠落的小动物，而不会来招惹我们。

Krolik: So they don't pose a threat. Then what's with the waiting?
克罗利克：既然没有任何威胁，那我们还在等什么？

His hurried speech reveals his nervousness. Though Yenisei doesn't understand why.
急促的吐字方式显露出他的紧张。小叶尼塞却不明白那是为什么。

Yenisei: If you are trying to get us back on the road, you have the right to propose it directly.
小叶尼塞：如果您想赶快继续上路，是可以直接提出来的。

Yenisei: The team discusses to decide the next step. That's how things have worked all the way. We are not trying to waste your time.
小叶尼塞：队伍一直都这样商量着前进，并不是我们在刻意拖延。

Krolik: That's what I mean. We should get going now.
克罗利克：这就是我想说的。我认为我们应该继续上路了。

Yenisei: I see. We will suggest the directions as usual, and everyone will vote to decide ...
小叶尼塞：我明白了。像之前一样，我们会给出之后的方向，然后所有人投票表决——

Krolik: Oh, no, you don't get it. There's no need to discuss or vote.
克罗利克：哦，不，你没明白。没有表决和讨论的必要。

Yenisei: Hmm?
小叶尼塞：嗯？

Krolik: Because we are not going forward, but going back! That's the only direction available.
克罗利克： 因为我们会往回走，而不是向前。这就是唯一的方向。

Yenisei stares silently at Krolik. She disagrees, but politely waits for him to finish speaking.
小叶尼塞沉默地注视克罗利克。她不赞同，却也会礼貌地等待对方说完。

Krolik: I'm not the only one with this idea, Ms. Bessmert.
克罗利克： 这不仅是我的想法，别斯米尔女士。

Krolik: Those legends from the East, that ... Dùshuò Festival, is it? And the arcane trick you call "Ask and Acquire" ...
克罗利克： 那些东方的传说，度朔节的狂欢？或者“所求必应”的神秘学把戏……

Krolik: None of them matter more than our lives!
克罗利克： 没有哪一件能比我们的命重要。

He is right. The girl can only turn her head in silence further away, to that desolate, boundless, snowless winter landscape, all that remained of the temperate land after its withered grass scattered with the wind.
道理的确是这样，女孩只能无言转过头去。更远处，一片寂寥无边的无雪冬景，是枯草散落后的温带大地。

The storm they had encountered had blown through here as well, sweeping away almost every living thing.
一行人先前遭遇的那场风暴，几乎席卷了此地所有能够喘息的生命体。

And the young man's purpose is as clear as the open land that lies in front of them.
而青年人的目的就像眼前这片空旷的草地一样一览无余。

Krolik: Can anyone promise there won't be another emergency like this? What if we can't find a shelter next time?
克罗利克： ——谁能保证不会再遇上一次这样的突发情况？如果下次我们找不到这样能遮蔽风雨的石林呢？

Krolik: Yeah, we'll be lying dead out there, just like those corpses.
克罗利克： 找不到，下一次变成外面那些死物的就是我们。

Bessmert: I hear you.
别斯米尔： ……我知道了。

It has been 37 days since they left Omsk heading south. The fifth day on these steppes they have gone without fresh water.
这是离开鄂木斯克向南而去的第三十七天。也是队伍在这片缺乏活水的草原上逗留的第五天。

If everything had gone according to plan, they would've already been sitting in the supply station drinking tea.
如果一切都按照计划进行，此时，所有人都应该已经坐在补给站的房屋内喝着热茶。

If they hadn't encountered this sudden storm ...
前提是，队伍没有遇上突如其来的风暴天气——

Yet, the two people, who put this very team together, did not anticipate such an eventuality.
即使如此，最初召集起队伍的两人，也不会对这样的时刻有所准备。

Bessmert: Given what happened earlier, it is only reasonable that you would wish to return.
别斯米尔： 鉴于我们先前的遭遇，您的诉求是合理的。

Yenisei: ...
小叶尼塞： ……

This marks a moment of disagreement, when all the half-met measures sow the seeds of discord.
这种标志半途而废的分歧时刻。

6#1
6#1

柔板
Adagio NS-02

There is neither a single voice of opposition nor one of support from their fellow travelers.
近处的其他同行者中，没有人表达支持，也没有人出声反对。

If Bessmert could see their expressions, she might realize that this silent assent had actually been the sound of plotting minds.
假如别斯米尔能瞧见他们的表情，就会意识到那种沉默的“不约而同”实则意味着早有预谋。

Krolik: So, are we on the same page?
克罗利克：那么，我们达成共识了？

Bessmert: I fully understand where you're coming from, and I acknowledge your reasoning.
别斯米尔：我是说，我知道您的想法，也认同您提出诉求的合理性。

Krolik: What are you trying to ...
克罗利克：有什么不同——

Bessmert: But we still need a vote to decide.
别斯米尔：但我们依然需要投票表决。

Krolik opens his eyes wide, pure joy flickering within them, and waits for the person in front of him to utter the words he longs to hear.
克罗利克睁大了眼睛，喜悦在其中闪烁。他正等待着眼前人说出这句话。

Yenisei: Wait!!
小叶尼塞：——等等——

Yenisei couldn't stop the inevitable. The explorer, with a knack for speeches, always seems to have a strong belief in her own persuasiveness.
小叶尼塞阻拦不及。擅长游说的探险家对自己劝服他人的能力深信不疑。

Krolik: No problem, of course. It's the civilized way to solve it.
克罗利克：没问题，当然。这是文明的做法。

Krolik: But I require we skip the speech. We have no time to waste on your monologue.
克罗利克：但我要求——跳过发言环节。因为时间紧迫，我们没有空闲听您长篇大论。

Bessmert: Alright.
别斯米尔：……可以。

Yenisei: Madam!
小叶尼塞：女士！

Krolik: Alright, gentlemen. If you agree to go back, please raise your hand.
克罗利克：好，先生们。选择原路返回的，请举手表决。

As these words land on the listeners not far behind him, the people slowly begin to raise their hands to their ears, fingers crossed.
话音落下，他身后不远处，几人缓缓抬手，中食两指交叉放至耳旁。

In the end, Krolik has it. He faces both of them, simply raising his hands, as though grandstanding somewhat, and a victorious smile stretches across his face.
到最后，才是克罗利克。他面对着两人，同样只举起手，却仿佛是在示威一样扩大了脸上笑容的胜利意味。

Krolik: Four to two. See, we can make decisions in no time, right?
克罗利克：四对二。您看，这样不就很快有结果了？

Bessmert: ...
别斯米尔：……

Yenisei: This is their trap, Madam! We can't just ... Are you really fine with going back empty-handed like this?
小叶尼塞：女士，他们早就商量好了！我们不能就这么——难道您真的要这样回去吗？

Krolik: The vote was required by Ms. Bessmert, not me.
克罗利克：这是别斯米尔女士自己要求的投票，可不是我。

Krolik: And you, I'll take it that you're challenging me to a duel if you continue with the slander.
克罗利克：至于你……如果再不停止对我的污蔑，那我将认为这是你要求决斗的信号。

Bessmert: No, good sir, please don't take her the wrong way. We don't have to go physical.
别斯米尔：不，先生，那不是她的意思。我们没有动武的必要。

Yenisei: What about Mr. Jurien? He has not voted yet, so the vote is not over!
小叶尼塞：——尤利恩先生呢？他还没有投票，结果还是无效的！

The girl believes she has reached the heart of the matter, even if her rational mind knows that a single vote would be of no use.
少女认为自己找到了事情的关键，哪怕她的理智知道再多一票也于事无补。

Still, she insists.
她仍然坚持。

Krolik: Oh, he's too tired to show up, but I'm sure he shares the same idea with us, because ...
克罗利克：哦，他很累，所以没有过来。不过他的想法肯定与我们一致，毕竟……

Krolik: We are all humans. Of course, he's on our side.
克罗利克：我们都是人类。他当然会站在我们这边。

Yenisei doesn't intend to say much to the young man, and decides to cross over to the group of people ahead to search for their final voter.
小叶尼塞并不打算与青年男子多说，决定越过眼前这群人，去寻找剩下的那个投票者。

That is until another tall man stands up, seemingly to block her path.
直到另一个高大的男子站了出来，似有若无地挡住了她的去路。

Team Member I: Say no more, Krolik. Pack your things. Let's head back.
考察队员 I：不用多说了，克罗利克。收拾物资，我们往回走。

Yenisei: ...!
小叶尼塞：……！

Yenisei: Fine. We'll split up from here, then.
小叶尼塞：那我们就在这里分头行动——

Team Member I: We'll take all the supplies with us, or we can't make our way back. No discussion.
考察队员 I：我们会带走剩下的所有物资，才能保障顺利返回。这没得商量。

Yenisei: ...
小叶尼塞：……

He looks even tougher than the communicators they sent, and after saying his piece, he brushes past Yenisei down through the narrow rock crevice and leads the way toward the supply box behind them.
他比他们派出的沟通者更为强硬，说完就与小叶尼塞在狭窄的岩石缝隙中擦身而过，率先走向两人身后的物资箱。

A moment ago, they were all there, recounting their previous journey together.
片刻前，她们都还在那里总结着先前的旅途。

Bessmert: Gentlemen, the team was put together in good faith. Perhaps we should negotiate, not ...
别斯米尔：先生们，大家都是自愿加入这趟旅途的，也许我们应该好好谈谈，而不是——

Yenisei's solution is to chase after him and plant herself between the man and Bessmert.
小叶尼塞的回答是快步追过去，用身体拦在了男人与别斯米尔之间。

Yenisei: The compass doesn't work here. You need me to find the way back.
小叶尼塞：指南针失效，你们需要我来指出回去的方向。

Yenisei: Leave our supplies, and I'll show you the way.
小叶尼塞：留下我们那份物资，我可以给你方向。

Team Member I: You have to do this the hard way.
考察队员 I：……看来你还是选择了决斗。

The man shakes his head, clearly unwilling to accept the proposal.
男人摇头，显然并不接受这个交易。

In her shock, Yenisei instinctively protects the person behind her, realizing that confrontation seems inevitable.
小叶尼塞惊愕地护住身后人，意识到武力的对峙似乎不可避免。

???: *coughs* That, my friends, is not how civilized people solve their problem.
???: ——咳咳……这样太野蛮了，朋友们。

The voice is calm and composed, but its gravity brings a swift end to the playful duel.
这声音沉稳，平静，其中的分量却恰好能够介入这场儿戏一样的“决斗”。

Bessmert: Mr. Jurien!
别斯米尔：啊，尤利恩先生！

In a makeshift team of this sort, the eldest member is often bestowed a special prestige based on their experience.
在这样一支临时组成的队伍里，最年长的人通常有着阅历赋予的天然威信。

Krolik: Mr. Jurien ...
克罗利克：尤利恩先生……

Jurien: Mr. Krolik. I thought you were here to discuss the reallocation of supplies with Madam Bessmert. I didn't expect this ...
尤利恩：克罗利克先生。我还以为您要与别斯米尔女士谈重新分配每日物资的问题。但我没想到……

Krolik: Well ...
克罗利克：呃……

Jurien: It's true that you didn't choose to be here. You are here because you have an important mission given by the governor to complete.
尤利恩：您的确不是自愿来的，但您也肩负着总督授予的重要使命。

Jurien: We have come this far. Do you really want to give up now?
尤利恩：既然已经出发了，为什么又在半途中放弃完成任务的信念?

The man's frame visibly shrinks. Their pretense of "communication" has been exposed, and every word spoken by his elder makes it more and more impossible for him to offer a rebuttal.
被点到名的人缩了缩身子。“沟通”的假意暴露无遗，年长者的每一句话都令他无法反驳。

Jurien: As for you gentlemen ... Petrov, I'm surprised you're here too.
尤利恩： 至于这几位先生……竟然连你也不愿继续前进了，彼得洛夫。

Jurien: It's a risk that none of us expected, but it shouldn't have broken your will. I remember you showed a great interest in those ancient strata in the South when we were at the speech.
尤利恩： 只是一点谁也无法预料的风险，就把你吓得不敢动弹了？我记得演讲时，你对南方那些古老地层表现出了相当的兴趣。

Team Member I: All we need is safety.
考察队员 I： 我们也只是需要一些保障。

Team Member I: There will always be a buffer period after extreme weather. We should seize the chance and head back.
考察队员 I： 极端天气过后通常有缓冲期，能在此期间回去是更好的选择。

Team Member I: If you persuade Ms. Bessmert to give us a confirmed date, before which we can find the running water and come back, we can stick to the original plan.
考察队员 I： 不过……如果您能让别斯米尔定下一个足够往返的期限，且在期限内找到活水，我们也能按原计划不变。

Jurien: Madam Bessmert?
尤利恩： 别斯米尔女士?

Bessmert: Certainly. You see, these are all negotiable.
别斯米尔： 没问题，您瞧，这都是可以商议的……

Yenisei: Wait. About the date, we can only decide after making an inventory.
小叶尼塞： 等等。还有一点，这个期限要等我们清点完剩余物资才能决定。

Upon hearing these words, the man takes out his pocket watch, shakes it twice, and shows Yenisei the current time.
听见这话，男人掏出怀里的袖珍钟，晃了两下，展示给小叶尼塞现在的时间。

Team Member I: You have 30 minutes.
考察队员 I： ……给你三十分钟。

Yenisei: That's enough.
小叶尼塞： 足够了。

A brief consensus is reached, and the others scatter back to their former places, gathering supply boxes together and waiting for a response from the two in charge.
短暂的共识达成，其他人回到原先分散的地方，将物资箱收拢到一起，等待两人给出答复。

Bessmert cautiously touches the wooden boxes. The young girl comes to her side with a pen and paper, making a quiet record of things.
别斯米尔小心翼翼触碰那些木箱，年轻的女孩也带着纸笔来到她的身边，安静地记录起来。

For a moment, the only sound between them is of pen on paper.
一时间，周围只剩下纸笔动作的声响。

Bessmert: You know ...
别斯米尔： 其实……

Yenisei: Hmm?
小叶尼塞： 嗯?

Bessmert: Mr. Jurien is very interested in arcanum and arcanists. He is the keenest supporter of our journey, besides the governor.
别斯米尔：尤利恩先生对神秘学家和神秘术很感兴趣。他本来就是除总督之外最支持这趟旅途的人类。

Bessmert: Even if his understanding of Ask and Acquire is significantly different from mine ...
别斯米尔：即使他对“所求必应”的认知和理解，与我有很大的不同……

The girl continues her rummaging and recording, while responding gently and deftly to Bessmert's habitual broaching of this parallel topic.
少女没有停下手中翻找和记录的动作，同时也轻声回应着别斯米尔像往常一样突然展开的话题。

Bessmert: The legend of Ask and Acquire, as told by many merchants, always involves a certain price. The price takes different forms in the stories, but mostly it is a great danger.
别斯米尔：那些商人提到过，“所求必应”的实现需要付出代价。但这个代价并不是固定的。只是在民间传说中，多数都需要以身犯险。

Yenisei: I believe that refers to "the highest mountain and deepest canyon" in those stories.
小叶尼塞：我以为那些无法越过的悬崖，和难以攀登的高山，就是这个意思。

Bessmert: I reckon so. But Mr. Jurien, as a human historian studying the arcane skill, believes it's a form of exchange that arcanists make with nature ...
别斯米尔：它理应是。而尤利恩先生作为一名研究神秘术的历史学家，则认为这是神秘学家与自然进行的某种交换仪式……

Yenisei: Mm-hmm. And you think he's wrong?
小叶尼塞：嗯。但您认为，这是错的?

Bessmert: At this stage, we can't verify anything, so all these assumptions will have to remain assumptions. However, as we are getting closer to that mysterious land, my craving for its knowledge is also becoming stronger.
别斯米尔：在无法验证的阶段，所有的猜想都可以被认定为可疑。只是我们越靠近这片大陆，我对那神秘知识的渴求，便变得越强烈。

Between these words, Bessmert walks around to another box and notices that the closer the instrument is placed to it, the more distinctly she can smell the alcohol.
话语间，别斯米尔绕到另一个箱子的面前，发觉越靠近放置仪器的部分，便越能闻见掺水的酒精。

It is obvious that the alcohol prepared for boiling point measurements had been used as an "emergency resource" during the night when the temperature dropped drastically.
显然，为测量沸点所准备的纯酒精，已经在气温骤降的夜里被当作“应急物资”使用了。

We shouldn't ask too much from such a ragtag team.
……对这样一支中途拼凑起来的队伍实在不应苛求太多。

Bessmert: What do we know about the supplies?
别斯米尔：物资的情况怎么样了?

Yenisei: Put aside the water problem, the supplies can feed everyone for eight days, maybe twelve if we economize. We can hold even longer if there are any preys or herders along the way.
小叶尼塞：刨去饮用水，所有人常量使用大概最少八天，紧凑再加四天。如果能猎到小型动物，或者遇上牧民，还能坚持更久。

Bessmert: Are there any supply stations?
别斯米尔：补给站呢?

Yenisei: Our supply stations are not on these plains, at least not on the map.
小叶尼塞：这片草原上没有我们的补给站。至少地图上没有。

Bessmert: How much drinking water and alcohol do we have left?
别斯米尔：饮用水和酒精还有多少?

Yenisei: Approximately ...
小叶尼塞：应该有——

Yenisei: Oh, great. These idiots put water in the alcohol. Now we are short of both.
小叶尼塞：哦，好极了。他们疯到把水倒进纯酒精里，现在我们两样都缺了。

Bessmert: At least the alcohol has kept them warm.
别斯米尔：至少，喝酒可以取暖。

Yenisei: They could have just drunk the alcohol.
小叶尼塞：他们也能直接喝酒精。

Bessmert: Alright, alright, child. Now we should focus on the direction for the next step, not these bits of trivia.
别斯米尔：不是这样的，孩子。比起追究这些东西，或许我们更应该先定下路线。

Bessmert: Regarding which, just to be clear, what I have in mind is only slightly better than nothing.
别斯米尔：事先声明，我目前的想法只比“毫无头绪”好上一点。

Yenisei: Better how?
小叶尼塞：哪一点?

Bessmert: The moist air and the soil. Have you noticed? The soil beneath our feet is way too sticky, even for a land after a thunderstorm.
别斯米尔：湿润的气息，和土质。发现了吗？对于风暴过后，腐料还没深入土壤的阶段来说，这里的土质过于黏稠了。

Bessmert: I'm not entirely sure about this ... But I tend to think that there is groundwater beneath us.
别斯米尔：虽然不是准确判断……但我倾向于认为，这是有地下水的标志。

Bessmert: Which means we are close to running water.
别斯米尔：有地下水，就会有活水。

Yenisei: Alright. Let me think about how to get us there.
小叶尼塞：好吧，让我想想。

Bessmert: Can't you use your arcane skill?
别斯米尔：你的神秘术不能用吗?

Yenisei: What?! Just because you don't know what to do doesn't mean you should count on this thing. You are not like them!
小叶尼塞：什么？您不能像他们一样，因为一无所知就把希望都寄托在这上面。

Bessmert: I just want to make use of everything we have ...
别斯米尔：我只是需要把可能性都考虑进去……

Yenisei: Fine. I told you how it works. Without new running water, the old samples in the bottles can only show us the way back. That's the best they can do.
小叶尼塞：好吧。我向您解释过它的运作方式，现在没有新的活水可用，这些瓶子里的东西，在最好的情况下，能指出的也只有回去的方向。

To prove this, the girl takes a glass bottle from her person and places it in the waiting, doubtful hand.
为了证明，女孩从身上取下一枚玻璃瓶，放到对方的手中。

Yenisei: This one is from the lower course of the Om River. The arcane energy I can use for divination has almost faded away.
小叶尼塞：这是鄂木河下游的水。里面可用于占卜方向的活跃气息已经很淡了。

Yenisei: Can it show us the way back? Sure, but that's not what we want. Only Mr. Krolik and his men would be happy to hear that.
小叶尼塞：跟着它走回去？能做到，但这不是我们想要的。只有克罗利克先生他们会高高兴兴上路。

Upon hearing this, Bessmert stands up straight. Although she cannot see her eyes, her silent posture alone seems to affect an aura of rapid thought.
听到这儿，年长的女人直起身来。虽然看不见眼神，但她沉默时的姿态，总是看上去在进行快速的思考。

Yenisei looks up at her and can almost hear the sound of gears spinning in her skull.
小叶尼塞抬头望她，几乎能听到那些齿轮在头壳中转动咬合的声音。

Bessmert: To think on the bright side, we still have a chance to go home.
别斯米尔：往好处想，这确保了我们能够回去。

Yenisei: But I didn't leave my homeland to go back there, Madam.
小叶尼塞：可我离开不是为了回去，女士。

Bessmert: Yes, yes, I know. I feel the same. I'm not suggesting we turn back immediately. It's just an option.
别斯米尔：是的，我知道，我知道。因为我也一样。这并不意味着现在就往回走，它只是一份保障。

Bessmert: To the best of my recollection, such moist soil is often found in the mountains and floodplains of the temperate zone, especially in the forest steppes covered with chernozem. The landscape is very different from where we are now.
别斯米尔：那种润湿量的土质，印象中最接近温带山地河滩，一般位于那种覆盖森林植物的黑土草原，和我们踏入这里所认识的地貌不同。

Bessmert: Before we sheltered from the thunderstorm, you told me about a mountain in the southeast. It blocked the horizon from our sight, right?
别斯米尔：在我们找到躲避的位置前，你曾向我描述过东南方有一座山切断了地平线，对吗？

The girl's eyes widen upon hearing these words—the expression of a hopeful epiphany.
听到这句话，女孩睁大了眼睛。那是逐渐意识到关窍的惊喜表情。

Bessmert: Based on this, I would assume, the thunderstorm was the result of a stronger convection coming from the other side of the mountain. Now, on the steppe, to form a cloud large enough to bring a thunderstorm would require a large amount of running water ...
别斯米尔：由此可以假设，我们遇上的风暴，正是强对流翻山而来的结果，在草原上，如果要形成这么大团的云雨，必须有足够的活水——

Yenisei: And the source of the running water is probably on the other side of the mountain!
小叶尼塞：而活水的来源可能就在那个方向！！

Bessmert: Exactly ... We can set off in that general direction.
别斯米尔：没错……有了这个大致方向，我们就能继续前进。

Bessmert: We might not find any water there. That's the worst result. In that case, we can still return here with the help of your arcane skill.
别斯米尔：而且，即使得到最坏的结果，翻过山去，我们没有找到活水，你的神秘术也能带我们回来。

Bessmert: As long as we have that glass bottle with us.
别斯米尔：只要玻璃瓶还在。

Yenisei: That's right.
小叶尼塞：是的。

Bessmert: We tell them we need another five days ...
别斯米尔：然后，我们定下五天的期限……

Bessmert grips the glass bottle in her hand as though clinging on to one final trace of hope.
别斯米尔抓紧了手中的玻璃瓶，像是抓住了最后一点希望。

Bessmert: They won't accept more days than that. If they won't even settle for this, I will convince them, like I did when I first got them on the team.
别斯米尔：这可能也是他们能接受的最大期限。就算不行，我也会像游说时那样，再次说服他们。

6#1
6#1

仙子草地
The Fairyland NS-03

Bessmert did indeed succeed.
别斯米尔的确做到了。

On one hand, as she clearly points out the direction of her thinking and provides reasons and arguments for her judgment, her human companions are easily convinced.
一方面，当她肯定地指明方向，并给出判断来由和论据的时候，人类同伴其实是容易被说服的。

On the other hand, all other concerns soon cease to be of significance—
另一方面，一切别的担忧也很快都不再成为问题——

Two days later
两日后

Yenisei: ...!!!
小叶尼塞：——！！！

The girl's eyes widen as she looks blinking at the flowing stream appearing seemingly from thin air not far from them—as though staring at it might restore it all to its original state.
年轻的女孩瞪大了眼睛，难以置信地望着不远处几乎凭空出现的活水溪流，好像瞪视就能使它恢复原状一样。

She remembers clearly when she was only a mile from here yesterday evening, there was nothing to indicate the presence of such a miraculous hidden feature.
她清晰记得，昨天傍晚在身后一俄里处驻扎下来时，四周可没有任何东西能向他们展示这样的“奇迹”。

Jurien: Ladies ...
尤利恩：两位女士……

Jurien: This is a miracle. I'm glad we didn't give up and go back.
尤利恩：这可真是令人印象深刻，不是吗？还好我们先前没有选择返回。

Yenisei: Wait, something's not right ... I ...
小叶尼塞：奇怪，请稍等……我……

Krolik: What-what are we waiting for?
克罗利克：等什么？

Not intending to wait for an answer, he runs toward the stream. An unheeded reaction to the long labors of their journey through the desolate wilderness.
他并不打算等待一个回答，便焦躁地奔向溪流。这是于荒原上长途跋涉后必然出现的情境。

Krolik: We are on the right path. I have nothing to say.
克罗利克：既然看起来方向没错，那我也没什么可说的了。

The humans move briskly toward the rushing stream.
同行的人类都向涌动的溪流快步走去。

For a moment, only the two arcanists remain skeptical about this new variable.
一时之间，竟然只有两位神秘学家对眼前的状况保持怀疑。

Bessmert: No ... Wait! Please don't ... !
别斯米尔：不对……等等，请先不要！

Unable or unwilling to heed her shouts, they rush into the stream. Sinking their faces into the water and pulling them out, with smiles as wide as if they had never seen such natural beauty before.
他们当然听不见这无力的呼喊，很快踏入了溪流之中。将脸埋进水里又拔出来时，他们快活得像第一次步入野外的城市之子。

Standing beside Bessmert, who had failed to stop their advance, the red-haired girl cautiously retreats as well, marking a sharp contrast with the humans who embrace the water like a fish too long in the air.
在阻止不及的别斯米尔身边，红发女孩警惕地后退了，与这些热情投向活水怀抱的人类相反。

Yenisei: Wh-What ...
小叶尼塞：这、这是……

Yenisei: Madam, you didn't tell us the running water was right on the side when we pitched camp yesterday.
小叶尼塞：女士，昨天我们驻扎的时候，您似乎没有提到这么近的地方存在活水。

Bessmert: Yes, because I didn't notice any signs of water.
别斯米尔：是的，因为我根本就没有发现。

Yenisei: I thought it was your doing!
小叶尼塞：我还以为是您做了什么！

Bessmert: I wish it was, but, sadly, this is beyond my power. I'm not even sure if we are still staying on the planned route.
别斯米尔：很遗憾，我什么也没做。我的神秘术也做不到这个。我甚至不确定我们是否还走在先前决定的道路上。

This is obviously not good news, as Yenisei's silence reveals. Bessmert immediately realizes the ambiguity of her words.
这显然不是一个好消息，小叶尼塞的沉默显示了这点，别斯米尔也立刻意识到了自己话语的歧义。

Bessmert: Indeed, I can hear the river flowing and running against the stones and shores.
别斯米尔：我是说，我能听见它现在的声音，那些撞击岩石和浅滩的响动，但也仅此而已。

Yenisei: Have you noticed anything else?
小叶尼塞：您是不是还察觉到了其他的事情?

Bessmert: Yes, um, I'm not an expert, though.
别斯米尔：我并非这方面的专家，但……

Bessmert: The soil here is moist too, but it feels different, like just dampened by frequent spring rains.
别斯米尔：这里的草地也很湿润，却是春季经常落雨才会有的那种短暂情况，与土质无关。

Bessmert: The dry air of winter has completely gone.
别斯米尔：早前那种干枯的，像野火过后烧焦草垛一样的冬日气息，已经完全消失了。

Yenisei: And the grass here looks nothing like the temperate grass we should be seeing in December. It's so green, as if it were April or May now.
小叶尼塞： 而且这里草地的颜色，也不像我们应经历的温带草原的十二月，而是四月、五月，那样的绿色。

Bessmert: But we haven't gone that far. Is this ...
别斯米尔： 可我们没有走那么远，那么久，所以……

Bessmert: Is this some kind of illusion brought by arcane power?
别斯米尔： 这难道是某种神秘术制造的幻觉?

Yenisei: Whether it's an illusion or something else, there must be something wrong with the water they drank.
小叶尼塞： 如果这是幻觉，或者其他的异常，那他们喝下的那些水就会有问题。

Bessmert: You're right. We can't let them drink it.
别斯米尔： ……你说得对，这样不行——

Yet, their rational repudiations could not change the fact that their companions had already drunk from the abnormal water.
理智的接连否认，也不能改变此时同伴已经饮下异常流水的事实。

Bessmert instinctively runs forward, wishing to minimize the damage before things get worse.
别斯米尔下意识向前跑去，想要在事情进一步恶化之前，及时止损。

Bessmert: Gentlemen, please listen! The water ...
别斯米尔： 先生们，请听我说！那些水——

Yenisei: Hold on, Madam! It's too late!
小叶尼塞： 女士！他们已经跑得太远了！

Yenisei grabs her hand, trying to prevent Bessmert from running in a panic and potentially suffering a fall.
小叶尼塞拉住她的手，试图防止年长者因慌乱而在奔跑中跌倒。

Bessmert still wishes to rush forward, but finds herself unable to break free.
别斯米尔仍要向前，却发现自己挣脱不开。

Bessmert: I have to tell them. I am the reason why they are here.
别斯米尔： 但这可能是因为我指出的方向有问题，我必须去啊。

Yenisei: Listen. They have filled the water bags and are coming back.
小叶尼塞： 您看，他们已经装完水，上岸开始往回走了。

Their momentary joy at finally being able to move forward is rapidly diluted.
能够继续前进的喜悦被异常很快地冲淡。

The only consolation is that the human walking back toward the two of them still appears to be normal.
唯一的安慰是，此时正在朝两人走回来的同伴，看上去并无异常。

Team Member I: What's wrong? Are you not going to fill your water bags?
考察队员 I： 怎么了？你们不去补充水袋吗?

Yenisei: Nothing. We'll go later.
小叶尼塞： ……不，没事。我们会去的。

Team Member I: The water is clean. You can even see the trouts swimming. Too bad, we need to keep our packs light.
考察队员 I： 这水很清澈，里面甚至有鳟鱼。只可惜带不走太多。

Yenisei: ...
小叶尼塞：……

Bessmert: Thank you. We'll fill our bags once we figure out which way we should go next.
别斯米尔：谢谢您。我们想先确定接下来的方向，再补充水源。

Team Member I: Krolik is still by the river. He seems parched. Is he the reason you didn't go there?
考察队员 I：克罗利克还在水边，看上去渴坏了。你们是因为他才不愿意过去?

Yenisei: No.
小叶尼塞：不是。

Team Member I: Alright, no problem, then. I'll go check and fill the rest.
考察队员 I：那就没关系。我先去补充其他的水袋了。

Their tall companion nods and walks past the two of them, and toward the previously set-down baggage.
高大的同行者在点头后，与两人错身而过，往先前被放下的辎重走去。

Once he is gone, Yenisei speaks once more.
等到他完全离开之后，小叶尼塞才再度开口。

Yenisei: Please wait here, Madam. I'll go check ...
小叶尼塞：女士，请您等在这里，我会过去查看——

Jurien: Madam Bessmert.
尤利恩：——别斯米尔女士。

Bessmert: Mm? Mr. Jurien, did, did you drink the water?
别斯米尔：嗯？尤利恩先生，您——您也去那边喝水了吗?

Jurien: Oh, we ... I did. Just like Petrov said, the water is clean, a bit sweet to taste, even.
尤利恩：哦，是的。就像彼得洛夫那小子说的那样，水很清澈，甚至有些甜味。

Bessmert: That's good, that's good then. You were looking for me. Is there a problem?
别斯米尔：……好的，好的。那么，您叫我，是有什么问题吗?

Jurien: No, no. Look, I know you don't need any compliments, but thank you for leading us to the running water. I'm glad you once again earned their trust.
尤利恩：也许夸赞对你来说是不必要的。但现在我们的确找到了活水，你用能力赢回了大家的信任。

Bessmert: Maybe we should thank the "Ask and Acquire."
别斯米尔：又或许只是因为“所求必应”听见了我的渴望。

Jurien: Haha, perhaps.
尤利恩：哈哈，也许是吧。

Jurien: Now, it's time for us to set out again for the Eastern arcane skill you mentioned.
尤利恩：总之，现在我们可以重新确定方向，继续向前，去寻找你说的东方神秘术了。

Jurien: But before we do that ... I remember you once mentioned your assistant during your speech, saying her arcane skill was related to water and could find directions in the wild.
尤利恩：而在这之前……我的记忆告诉我，你在游说时提起过你的助手。她的神秘术似乎与水有关，能指引方向?

Bessmert: Yes, you remember it correctly.
别斯米尔：是的，您的记忆一点儿也没错。

A glad smile of acknowledgment appears on the face of the middle-aged man, his enthusiasm compelling him to ask one question after another.
得到确认的喜悦笑容出现在中年人的脸上，热忱驱使着他接连发问。

Jurien: Ah, that is so wonderful! Earlier, you said that this was a safeguard, but at the time you did not explain in detail how it would work ...
尤利恩：啊，那真是太好了！先前，你还说过这是一道保险，当时却没有继续详细说明，这个保险要怎样运作……

Jurien: Now, may I have the honor to witness it? How does she communicate with water? Will she be possessed?
尤利恩：现在我们能有幸看到了吗？她怎样通过这样的流水获取指引，需不需要请灵上身？

Jurien: Or like those mystics in the Palace ...
尤利恩：是否就像皇宫里的那些法师一样——

Yenisei: Sir, my arcane skill cannot predict what will happen precisely, and it is not cast through "possession."
小叶尼塞：先生，我的神秘术并非精准预言，也不通过“降灵”施行。

Yenisei: Please do not overestimate what you don't understand and simply count on it.
小叶尼塞：您不能把全部的希望都寄托在自己无法理解的事物之上。

Jurien: I know, child. I'm only curious and hoping to see it with my own eyes ...
尤利恩：我知道，孩子。我只是感兴趣，想亲眼看一看——

Yenisei: No, Sir. It is not an exhibit in the museum or a play in the theater.
小叶尼塞：不行，先生。这不是什么观赏品，也不是剧院里的演出。

Jurien: Oh ...
尤利恩：是吗……

The girl shakes her head and firmly refuses Jurien's request once again.
少女摇头，笃定地再次拒绝了尤利恩的要求。

But he doesn't care. He has received more of an answer than he expected, and as he leaves, he smiles and straightens his collar again, bidding goodbye to both of them, respectively.
但年长的人类并不在意。他已得到比预想更多的答案，在离开时微笑着再次整理自己的领口，向两人分别致意。

Yenisei: They look alright.
小叶尼塞：……他们看上去可没什么问题。

Bessmert: For now, yes. I feel uneasy about it. I have to go there ...
别斯米尔：也许只是暂时的，我还是很担心，我得去——

Yenisei: There's little you can do even if you go there, given the condition of your eyes. I will go check them, one by one.
小叶尼塞：您的眼睛不方便，过去的作用实在不大。我会去那边查看一下他们每个人的状况。

Bessmert: Wait. Mr. Jurien just asked about your arcane power. Maybe now it's a good time.
别斯米尔：等等，还有。刚才尤利恩先生提到你的神秘术……或许现在的确正是合适的时机。

Yenisei: What?
小叶尼塞：什么？

Bessmert: When you look for the direction with your arcane skill, check if the "water" is real.
别斯米尔：你过去查看后，可以施展你的神秘术，在占卜方向的同时，也实际验证那水，是不是真的活水。

Yenisei: What if it's not?
小叶尼塞：如果不是呢？

Bessmert: ...
别斯米尔：……

Bessmert: In that case, child, we have no choice but to divine our way back, with the water in your bottle.
别斯米尔：那么，好孩子，你就继续用玻璃瓶中原来的水，占卜出回去的方向。

Bessmert's worried and helpless words echo in Yenisei's ears.
别斯米尔忧虑而无奈的话语，在小叶尼塞耳边阵阵作响。

Yenisei: ...
小叶尼塞：……

Yenisei: Fine. I'll do it.
小叶尼塞：好，我来。

Yenisei: I will find the direction through divination, verify if the water is running, and check if anything's wrong.
小叶尼塞：我会占卜方向，验证活水，确定是否异常。

The girl takes a step forward and walks toward the strange babbling stream that seems to have come from nowhere.
女孩迈步，走向似乎凭空出现的潺潺河流。

Yenisei walks barefoot into the river.
小叶尼塞赤足步入河流中。

Flowing water on a temperate plateau like this should naturally be cold. It gently laps at her, just beneath her calves.
温带高原上理应冰冷的流水，没过小腿，轻柔拍打着。

She closes her eyes, trying to make herself unaware of the temperature.
她闭上眼，仿佛对温度丝毫没有察觉。

Yenisei: *Sacred water, please flow and flow ...*
小叶尼塞：——神圣之水，请您奔涌，奔涌——

Yenisei: *May your love and care drift far away with the flowing foam.*
小叶尼塞：请令您慈爱的轻抚，随奔涌的泡沫漂向远方。

Yenisei: *May you water the roots, moisten the grass, and sweeten the souls.*
小叶尼塞：沿途您可灌溉根系，湿润草地，泼洒灵魂的蜜。

Yenisei: *Like lifting a current from a reef where waves are breaking.*
小叶尼塞：就像从海浪扑打的礁岸捧起一个潺潺流淌的尽头。

The light spots gather and gradually fill the empty glass bottle.
光点汇集，逐渐充盈空落的玻璃瓶。

Yenisei: *And I ...*
小叶尼塞：而我——

Yenisei: *I will go to that current.*
小叶尼塞：我将走上那个尽头。

Yenisei: *Everything will be as I said.*
小叶尼塞：一切都将如我所说那般成为现实。

Yenisei: ...
小叶尼塞：……

Yenisei: Southeast.
小叶尼塞：东南。

The empty glass bottle falls from her loosened grip.
空玻璃瓶从松开的手中坠落。

The girl looks dazed as she picks up her damp and heavy feet from the water, heading to the southeast.
女孩神色恍惚，从水中拾起潮湿沉重的脚步，向着东南迈去。

Bessmert: ...
别斯米尔：——

Bessmert: HEY!
别斯米尔：——嘿——

Bessmert: Where are you going?
别斯米尔：——你要去哪儿?

Yenisei: Hmm ...
小叶尼塞：嗯……

Yenisei: Mmm? I ...
小叶尼塞：……嗯？我——

Half of her mind is still in the realm of delirium. The sounds she hears are fragmented into pieces that she can only attempt to fit together.
她的精神仍有一半处于谵妄的地界。恍惚中听见的声音都碎成数片，难以拼凑。

Yet, through the difficulty of her present state of mind, she tries her best to make sense of what Bessmert is saying.
要听清旁人实在有些困难，但她仍然努力着。

Yenisei: Mmm ...
小叶尼塞：呃……

Bessmert: You've found something, haven't you?
别斯米尔：有结果，对吗?

Yenisei: I, emm ...
小叶尼塞：我，唔……

Bessmert: Easy, Yeni, take your time.
别斯米尔：孩子，你慢慢说。

Yenisei: Yes.
小叶尼塞：……是的。

Yenisei: Yes. The sign has come out.
小叶尼塞：是的。有结果了。

Yenisei: I asked the river to show me the place with the strongest arcane energy. Then, it pointed at the southeast among all the other directions.
小叶尼塞：这条河在诸多道路中，选择了东南。我请它指向的是神秘术气息最浓厚的地方……

Yenisei: That is probably the direction we are looking for.
小叶尼塞：它很可能就是我们所想要寻找的方位。

Yenisei: And yes, this river is real running water. It is flowing with vitality.
小叶尼塞：……嗯，这的确是活水，它很有生命力。

Bessmert: Alright. Perhaps I was wrong.
别斯米尔：好吧。也许是我判断失误。

Yenisei: It's never wrong to consider all the possibilities, Madam.
小叶尼塞：考虑多种可能性总是没错的，女士。

Yenisei: Please wait here. I will mark the direction and inform everyone of it.
小叶尼塞：请在此等候吧。我去做标记，然后通知其他人。

Bessmert: Sure.
别斯米尔：……好。

6#1
6#1

俯身旷野
Strange Horses NS-04

The spring scenery of the steppes stretches out to the edge of the horizon.
草原的春色一路延展。

The expedition team continues to trek in the direction indicated by the river.
考察小队沿着河流所指方向前行，继续跋涉。

As they do, they scarcely notice as the terrain beneath them changes. Until the party at last finds themselves walking across bare rock.
地形逐渐变化，众人已经不知不觉在裸露的山石中穿行许久。

The uneven green rocks merge with grayish and purple granite, rough and jagged. In spots, tumbleweed and sand rice plants pierce through the jagged stone, billowing and cascading, and then plummeting down the cliff.
高低不平的绿岩衔接着灰紫色斑岩，崎岖嶙峋。风滚草和沙蓬从中间洞穿，翻卷过去，再直直坠下峭壁。

The travelers also feel as though they are moving downward. As the surrounding peculiarities increase, so too does their breathing, which becomes increasingly restricted.
人们也感觉自己在向下。随着周围异样的增加，呼吸却越来越被收紧。

Yenisei: *pants*
小叶尼塞：呼……

Krolik: You proved yourself right by ... finding running water for us ...
克罗利克：你们先前……已经证明了自己，带我们找到了活水……

Krolik: So, I'm not ... judging you ... this time, but ...
克罗利克：所以，我不愿总是成为提出质疑的那个。但是——

Krolik: Are we going the wrong way?
克罗利克：我们是不是走错路了？

Yenisei: No. This is the right direction.
小叶尼塞：是这个方向没错。

Krolik: But it's getting harder and harder to breathe, even if we are going down the mountain.
克罗利克：可我觉得呼吸越来越困难了，就算这分明——分明是在下山。

Yenisei: What about you, Madam? Are you feeling alright?
小叶尼塞：女士，您呢？您感觉还好吗？

Bessmert: I feel fine. Perhaps because I'm used to climbing mountains.
别斯米尔：或许是我常常登山的缘故，还没有什么感觉。

Bessmert: But we are definitely 3000 meters above the sea level now. It's normal if you're feeling unwell at this height. If only we still had alcohol ...
别斯米尔：但这地方的海拔绝对超过 3000 米了，你们或许是不适应这种高度。如果我们还有酒精……

Bessmert: Well, it's just a thought. I wouldn't have gathered enough courage to climb up that slope if I hadn't taken the last few sips.
别斯米尔：好吧，只是想想。如果没有那几口酒，我甚至可能爬不上刚才那道窄坡。

Bessmert shakes her head, dispelling unnecessary thoughts, and instead pursues another possibility.
别斯米尔摇头，驱散了多余的想法，改为追寻另一种可能。

Bessmert: But, child, are you sure we are on the right path?
别斯米尔：只是……孩子，你确定我们的方向是对的吗?

Yenisei: I don't think it's wrong. The clearer the sign, the higher the accuracy.
小叶尼塞：我认为不会有错。占卜的指向越清晰，准确性就越高。

Yenisei: And the sign I just saw happened to be exceptionally clear.
小叶尼塞：这次的指向，恰好明晰得十分少见。

Bessmert: What about the others? Are you feeling alright? Shall we stop and take a short break?
别斯米尔：其他人有没有出现身体不适？我们是否需要停下来暂时休整?

Krolik: I have a bad feeling. Instead of a break, we need a new direction. Back home, for example.
克罗利克：感觉不太对劲。比起休整，我们更需要改变方向。比如往回走。

Jurien: Before we do anything, can we have some rest? My head has been pounding for a while. I thought it was common in the mountains and you all felt the same.
尤利恩：或者，能不能至少先休整一下？我已经头痛有一阵子了，还以为这是在高原上的通常情况。

Bessmert: Yes, headache is a common altitude sickness, Sir.
别斯米尔：是的，头痛在高原是常见情况，先生。

Yenisei: Wait, is that tumbleweed?! I don't think it belongs here.
小叶尼塞：等等，那些是刺蓟吗？刺蓟好像不应该出现在这种地方。

Yenisei finally notices a large bundle trundling on not far away.
小叶尼塞终于留意到了不远处滚动的巨大物体。

Bessmert: I hear ... Are they rolling nearby? Are you sure?
别斯米尔：我听到的……就是它们在翻滚的声音？你确定吗?

Bessmert: This is not the right season for them to roll and spread seeds.
别斯米尔：可现在不是它们播种的季节。

Yenisei: I'm not seeing things, I guess, but I don't know why they are here. And those flowers ...
小叶尼塞：我应该没有看错，但是我不明白。还有那些花——

The team members at the end of their procession stop in their tracks. The others beside him also stop as a result.
缀在队伍末尾的队员停下了脚步。于是他身旁的其他人也一起停下了。

Until the entire team comes to a standstill.
队伍彻底陷入了停滞。

Team Member I: Something's wrong.
考察队员 I：这不对劲。

Team Member II: Hey you ... where are you taking us?
考察队员 II：——嘿，你们……你们究竟想把我们带去哪儿?

Team Member II: Haven't you noticed the rocks around us? Their color is abnormal. I've never seen anything like this, not even in books ...
考察队员 II： 你们难道一点也看不见周围这些岩石吗？这些奇怪的颜色，我从没见过，也不在任何的资料记录里……

Team Member II: And look at the holes in the rocks! They were made by water erosion! And that's not supposed to happen in this climate!
考察队员 II： 那些石头上的水蚀洞也绝对不是这个气候应该出现的！

Yenisei: Calm down, Sir. Perhaps we have reached somewhere beyond other adventurers' records, but that's all ...
小叶尼塞： 先生，请冷静。也许我们只是走到了不存在于其他旅行者记录上的地方——

Team Member II: What about this?! How are you going to explain it?!
考察队员 II： 那这个呢！这个要怎么解释?

Team Member II: Another one of your stupid arcane skill tricks?
考察队员 II： 用你们那该死的神秘术吗?

Yenisei lowers her head to look at what seem to be ordinary yellow flowers.
小叶尼塞低头看去，只看到貌似普通的黄色花束。

But these flowers wither almost immediately after blooming. It would be difficult to describe such a scene as anything less than a miracle or a curse.
但这鲜花却自盛开后便立刻枯萎，要说不是神迹，就实在难以描述这样的情景。

Yenisei: What? This is ...
小叶尼塞： 什么？这……这是……

Bessmert: What is it? Explain what?
别斯米尔： 怎么了？解释什么?

Yenisei: I don't know what species it is. It looks like a mini sunflower, but ...
小叶尼塞： ……我不认识这种花，它看起来像迷你的葵花。但是它——

Krolik: Told you we should head back. Something's wrong with this dump.
克罗利克： 我说了，我们应该往回走。这鬼地方不对劲。

Team Member I: Agree. We have a situation now. We should go back while we still can.
考察队员 I： 我支持。遇上异常状况，在退路没有被封死的情况下，我们应该往回走。

Jurien: Ladies, I have to say this is beyond my imagination.
尤利恩： 女士，我得说这确实……有些超出想象了。

Yenisei: ...
小叶尼塞： ……

Bessmert: It's just a flower, yes? Why are you all so scared? I can't see, but ...
别斯米尔： 只是花，怎么都像被吓到了一样？我看不见，但是——

Bessmert reaches out to grasp the flowers again, but the petals wither beneath her fingertips. Now more puzzled, she tries touching a complete cluster, but only ends up with a handful of withered husks.
别斯米尔茫然地伸手握住花朵，花瓣也在她指尖迅速干枯。即使试图继续往前触摸完整的花簇，却都只能捉到一撮枯尽的碎末。

The scent of these withered fragments turns rotten as their sweet fragrance disappears, leaving her having captured only the base note of their "perfume."
枯萎的气息在清香消失后都接近腐烂，人所能做的，仅是捕捉这“香味”的后调。

Bessmert: Emm? The smell ...
别斯米尔：嗯？这是……

Krolik: Everything is wrong here. The fog is not supposed to form at this latitude, the terrain is strange, and the plants ... they wither in an instant!
克罗利克：这一切都违反常理……根本不应该出现在这个纬度的湿雾、怪异的地貌，还有这转瞬即逝的植物——！

Team Member I: I don't want to say this, but this place seems to be cursed.
考察队员 I：我不想这么说，但是，这里就像是遭到了诅咒。

Team Member I: These phenomena make no sense. We have to go back now.
考察队员 I：这些东西……说不通。这次我们必须得往回走了。

The voice of the young man is more resolute than ever before.
青年男人的声音比以往的所有时候都更加不可撼动。

Faced with such a bizarre situation, escape is unarguably the most rational choice.
面对这样不合常理的情况，“逃走”的确是最为理性的选择。

Yenisei: You heard them, Madam. What do you say? Things are indeed weird.
小叶尼塞：别斯米尔女士，他们说往回走，您觉得应该怎么办？现在的情况确实很奇怪——

Bessmert: No, we are not returning. We have made it through the thunderstorm. What could be more dangerous than that?
别斯米尔：不，不是的。我们连草原风暴都熬过了，这不会是什么比自然灾害更加危在旦夕的情况。

Bessmert: Perhaps we are getting close, like those merchants said, there will be a "price" we must pay for the Ask and Acquire. Mr. Jurien, you also asked me about it, don't you remember?
别斯米尔：也许我们就快到了，这是那些商人说过的，实现“所求必应”的考验……对，尤利恩先生，您当时还向我提问了，您也不记得了吗?

Jurien: On the contrary, Madam, I remember it clearly. I have also told you my suspicion—it could be an exchange made between the arcanists and nature.
尤利恩：正好相反，女士。我记得，记得清清楚楚……后来我也告诉了你，我认为那是神秘学家与自然进行某种交易的仪式。

Bessmert: What? Of course not.
别斯米尔：什么？那当然不是——

Jurien: Look around you—all these bizarre phenomena! You know I wasn't making things up. You set out to pursue that arcane skill, yet we ended up here ...
尤利恩：看看现在周围这些异象，我的猜想难道不是确有其事吗？你追逐着神秘术，却带我们来到了这种地方……

Krolik: I don't know what your next plan is, but count me out.
克罗利克：我不知道你们还有什么谋划，总之我不会继续参与了。

Agitated by this abnormal phenomenon and talk of a possible sacrifice, the young man pushes Bessmert aside and stands with the others at the back of the group.
受到异常与“献祭仪式”猜想刺激的年轻人毫不犹豫地推开别斯米尔，去与队伍后面的其他人站到一起。

A previous scene of division and opposition repeats itself.
一幕先前对立的重演。

Bessmert: No, I swear on my life, that is not my intention!
别斯米尔：不，我发誓，我绝对没有那样的想法!

Yenisei: Madam Bessmert would never do that.
小叶尼塞：别斯米尔女士不会那样做的。

Yenisei: The point is, the compass doesn't work here. You will get lost on the way back without me.
小叶尼塞：而且，没有我，也没有指南针，你们不会辨别中途的方向。

Krolik: There's no doubt this is part of your scheme.
克罗利克：这当然也是你们算计的一环。

Yenisei: Excuse me?
小叶尼塞：你说什么？

Krolik: Mr. Jurien already told us about your secret arcane skill. It's our last hope of getting home in this plight.
克罗利克：尤利恩先生早就告诉我们了，你那遮遮掩掩的神秘术——却是指南针失效之后，唯一能带我们往回赶路的方法。

Bessmert: ...
别斯米尔：……

Krolik: We trust him. That being the case, you must come with us.
克罗利克：我们相信他的判断，既然是这样，那你就必须跟我们走了。

Yenisei: No. I came here with Madam Bessmert. I'm not leaving without her.
小叶尼塞：不。我是同别斯米尔女士一起来的，她不回去，我也不会走。

Yenisei also expresses her intentions clearly. Never having been one to be swayed by external forces, unless ...
小叶尼塞也清晰地表达了自己的选择。她从来不是一个容易被外力改变的人，除非——

Bessmert: Let's ...
别斯米尔：我们……

Yenisei: It's fine, Madam. We can keep going on our own ...
小叶尼塞：女士，没关系，我们自己继续前进——

Bessmert: Let's go back.
别斯米尔：我们往回走吧。

Yenisei: ...?!
小叶尼塞：——?!

... Unless the person she is supporting lowers her head first.
——除非她所支持的人先一步低头。

Bessmert: It's alright. Though I can't see, I can imagine how shocking it must be to make you so uneasy.
别斯米尔：没关系，虽然我看不见，但我可以想象眼前的景象有多么令人惊讶。

Bessmert: When we get back to the pastureland ...
别斯米尔：等我们回到牧区——

Krolik: I'm sorry, Madam. We are not taking you.
克罗利克：不，女士，很遗憾，我们不能带上你。

Krolik: I don't think we have enough supplies for everyone to make it back, so certainly someone must be abandoned.
克罗利克：我认为物资已经不足以支撑我们所有人顺利返回，当然有人需要被放弃。

Yenisei takes a step closer until she is completely blocking the depressed Bessmert's path.
小叶尼塞往前更近一步，直到将失魂落魄的别斯米尔完全挡住。

Yenisei: Then, allow me to say no. I will not show you the way without Madam Bessmert in the team.
小叶尼塞：那么，请允许我拒绝。如果不带上别斯米尔女士，我是不会为你们指路的。

Bessmert: No, Yeni. You're going with them.
别斯米尔：……不，孩子。你要和他们走。

Yenisei: But they are leaving you behind!
小叶尼塞：可他们要抛下您！

Krolik: Looks like your assistant has made her own decision. Sorry, but I never thought it would end up like this ...
克罗利克：看来您的助手有自己的决断。真可惜，原本我还希望我们不会走到这一步——

Team Member I: Enough with the talking. My apologies, ladies.
考察队员Ⅰ：不必多说。抱歉了，女士们。

Yenisei: What ... What are you doing?!
小叶尼塞：你们——你们要做什么?!

They are now facing each other, seeming to have decided to end their dispute through force.
人们对峙着，决定将争执以武力压制作结。

They are acutely aware that sacrificing one might save the many.
他们显然都清楚放弃一个能拯救更多。

It is a simple matter of arithmetic.
简单的算术题。

Standing upright is a phenomenon exclusive to humans. It is a miracle born of a desire to break free from the earth and move upward towards the sky.
直立是人所专属的行为，它是人们摆脱大地，执着朝向天空而诞生的奇迹。

The outcome unfolds quite apart from everyone's expectations.
变故发生于所有人的意料之外。

Yenisei: What?
小叶尼塞：……什么?

Striped Horse?: *neighs*
斑纹马?：咴咴——咴——

Yenisei: I-I don't understand. What is ... What is going on?!
小叶尼塞：我不理解，你们、你们这是——发生了什么?!

Even though they acknowledge the untimely nature of their dispute, they are left to witness all hope of reconciliation disintegrate before them.
而即使人们已经意识到内斗的不合时宜，却也只能目睹和解的可能在瞬间化为乌有。

Yenisei receives no answer, as the people standing in front of her now have lost the ability to reply.
小叶尼塞得不到回答，是因为眼前的人们已经失去用言语回答的能力。

6#1
6#1

巴别塔消融
Language Barrier NS-05

Striped Horse?: *neighs*
斑纹马?: ——咴——咴——

Yenisei: No way ...
小叶尼塞: ……为什么……

Turning around, she finds that her companion has transformed in an instant from a human on two feet to a strange hoofed animal on all fours.
转过身去，却发现同行者从双脚站立的人类，突然变成四肢着地的奇蹄目动物。

As the only person to have witnessed the entire process in detail, with every aspect too difficult to comprehend, she can only turn her puzzled gaze toward her elder.
作为唯一清楚地目睹了全程的人，她却感到现状实在难以理解，只能把疑惑的目光投向年长者。

But Bessmert is also in the dark.
但别斯米尔也浑然不觉。

Bessmert: What's this noise? Mr. Krolik?
别斯米尔: 这是什么声音？……克罗利克先生?

The only answer she receives is the impatient stirring of the odd-toed ungulate as it tramples the grass.
回答她的只有奇蹄目踩踏草皮的不耐烦动静。

Bessmert: Mr. Jurien?
别斯米尔: 尤利恩先生?

Striped Horse?: *neighs*
斑纹马?: 咴——

Bessmert: Strange. I heard animals. What happened?
别斯米尔: 不对。我听到了动物的声音。有什么东西出现了?

Yenisei: Emm ...
小叶尼塞: ……这……

Bessmert: Yenisei, I can't see. I need your help.
别斯米尔: 小叶尼塞，我看不见。我需要你的帮助。

Yenisei: Oh dear, give me a minute ... Emm, looks like they turned into ... I don't know, striped horses?
小叶尼塞: 天啊，让、让我想想……呃，看起来，尤利恩先生他们变成了——斑纹马?

Yenisei: I ... Sorry, I'm not sure. I've only seen similar animals in books.
小叶尼塞: 抱歉，我不知道。我只在画册上见过这些动物。

Yenisei: They look a bit smaller than horses, but taller and bigger than donkeys. And they have yellow stripes on their skin.
小叶尼塞: 它们看起来比马要小一些，又比驴的体型更大、更高，身上有一些黄色的斑纹。

Bessmert: Perhaps some local species on the temperate steppe? Are you certain they're transformed from Mr. Jurien and others? Not the livestock of nearby herders?
别斯米尔: 也许是某种温带草原上特有的动物……你确定是尤利恩先生他们自行变成了马，而不是附近出现了牧民?

Bessmert: I didn't cast any violent arcane skills on them, nor did you. Besides, I didn't sense any fluctuations of arcane energy ...
别斯米尔：我刚才并没有采取过激的举措，你也没有。而且，我并没有感受到神秘术的波动——

Yenisei: I'm sorry, Madam. I have no idea.
小叶尼塞：对不起，女士，我也毫无头绪。

Bessmert: I think ... if this wasn't because of us, there must be someone else around.
别斯米尔：我想，如果不是因为我们的行动，就说明这地方可能还有其他人。

Bessmert: Stay close to me.
别斯米尔：你靠近我，不要走散。

The importance of rallying together and remaining vigilant has already been proven to them.
事实证明，迅速地聚拢且时刻保持警惕是必要的。

The sound of raptor wings rapidly slicing through the air rushes towards the two travelers and their horses.
猛禽翅膀急速划破空气的声音，朝着两人与马群所在方向直直冲来。

Bessmert: It's here. Watch out!
别斯米尔：来了，当心！

Yenisei: What is it?!
小叶尼塞：天哪，那是什么——

Bessmert: Some bird of prey? It's fast, judging from the flapping sound of its wings. We must go up front to protect Mr. Jurien and the others. They might be its target ...
别斯米尔：是不是某种猛禽？它翅膀的振幅剧烈，说明速度很快。我们得站到尤利恩先生他们前面去，动物袭击的目标很可能是他们……

Bessmert: Oh, yes, the flint! Take out the flint! Kindle the sand rice to drive it away!
别斯米尔：对了，火石，把火石拿出来！然后找团沙蓬点燃来驱赶它！

Yenisei: No, wait ...
小叶尼塞：不，等等……

Yenisei: I don't think that's a bird of prey, but a human with wings!
小叶尼塞：我觉得那看起来像是一个长着翅膀的人，而不是普通的猛禽！

Yenisei: And it's not coming any closer?
小叶尼塞：……而且它也没有继续前进？

The girl hesitates upon hearing the sound of music.
女孩犹豫是因为乐声。

The music had been playing for only a short while. When those huge wings stirred the air into a violent storm, it was totally drowned out.
起初也有乐声。只是巨大翅膀搅动空气震颤更响，更剧烈，乐声就理所当然地被遮盖了。

It wasn't until it gave up on advancing that the slow flapping of wings was covered up by the music.
等到它并没有打算继续向前，逐渐缓慢的振翅声才被乐声所覆盖。

But the tune of the music is unknown to all present.
——被某种乐声覆盖，可音色却并不被此地任何人所知。

The music starts from the bird and spreads around, like a torrential rain, enveloping the restless brown animals on the ground below.
音乐声从人耳能够捕捉到振翅声音的方位开始蔓延，像急雨一样，笼罩了地面不安的棕色动物。

The horses look up in search of the source of this melody, as do the two other listeners.
马群随旋律抬头，和剩下的两人一样都在聆听着。

It is a simple and repetitive melody, but more than enough to consume Bessmert's full attention.
分明是简单的重复旋律，却似乎攥住了别斯米尔全部的注意力。

???: ...
???: ——

Yenisei: Madam! That thing is a creature with a human's head and a bird's body ...!
小叶尼塞：女士——！那是……！

The fierce steppe winds carry off her cries.
草原上的风吹散了她的呼喊。

Bessmert: What? What did you say? I can't hear ...
别斯米尔：——什么？你说什么？我听不清——

Yenisei: I said, that thing looks like a human with wings!
小叶尼塞：我说，那看起来像是一个长着翅膀的人！

Bessmert: A human? You mean it has the face of a human? Is the music also coming from it?
别斯米尔：人？你是指人面？音乐声是从它那边传出来的？

Yenisei: Yes!
小叶尼塞：是的！

Bessmert: The music-playing winged creature with a human's face. Sounds familiar, don't you think?
别斯米尔：会奏乐，人面的带翅生物。听起来相当耳熟，不是吗？

Yenisei: ... An angel?! You are not serious!
小叶尼塞：……天使?！您在开玩笑吗？

Yenisei: But angels blow trumpets! That stick it uses to play music—I'm not sure whether it's a wand or some instrument.
小叶尼塞：可天使吹奏的是号角！而且那个正在发出声音的，究竟是一根术杖还是某种乐器？

The girl's voice cannot conceal her doubt. She grabs Bessmert, wishing to step back, but remembers not to stray too far from the horses.
女孩的声音藏不住疑惑。她拉住别斯米尔，想要向后退去，却又牢记不能离开马群太远。

This conflict between her instinct and reason is revealed in her fragmented words.
对本能与理智两种选择的犹豫，在她话语里显露得支离破碎。

She tries to understand the current situation, but finds it strangely difficult.
她努力理解现状，可这实在有些困难。

Yenisei: Madam, we, I, we ...
小叶尼塞：女士，我……我们——

Bessmert: Calm down, child.
别斯米尔：——冷静，孩子。

Bessmert: Look closer and tell me. What does it look like? What about its wand?
别斯米尔：你再瞧仔细些，然后告诉我：它和那个术杖都长什么样子？

Yenisei: It ... It has a human's head, dressed in gray, with black wings instead of arms. Looks ... looks like a huge bird of prey ...
小叶尼塞：它……它长着人的脑袋，披着衣服，看起来灰扑扑的，但双手却是黑色的猛禽翅膀，像是某种——某种巨大的鸟类……

Yenisei: While the wand, I don't know how to describe it ...
小叶尼塞：至于那个术杖，我不知道。

The girl hurriedly lifts her head again to confirm, and add a supplementary defense to that which she still cannot clearly express.
女孩又匆忙抬起头确认，好为自己表述不清的部分增加抗辩似的补充。

Yenisei: But that thing is not even holding it! It's making the sound in mid-air.
小叶尼塞： 它甚至没用手抓着它！那东西似乎是隔空在发出声音。

Bessmert: Sounds like a Harpy, if there wasn't a wand.
别斯米尔： 抛开术杖的部分，听起来像鹰身女妖。

Yenisei: But it doesn't quite fit the descriptions in the book ... Neither the color of its feathers nor the environment does.
小叶尼塞： 可它羽毛的颜色，和这里的环境……和书上说的不一样。

As they're trying to figure out what's going on, the horses, effecting a brisk piaffe, look up to the source of the sound.
地上的两人还在尝试解读变故，几匹棕色的斑纹马早已从草地上抬头，轻快地原地迈步，都列队望向声音的来源。

After a brief moment, the "Harpy" turns around, flapping its wings and slowly flying away, with the horses following closely behind as if compelled.
片刻后，“鹰身女妖”转身，扇动翅膀缓缓飞离，马群就仿佛受到感召一般紧随其后。

Yenisei: Mr. Jurien ... They are leaving after that thing!
小叶尼塞： 他们——他们跟着它走了！

Bessmert: Stay calm, Yenisei.
别斯米尔： ……冷静，孩子。

Bessmert: They must be under its control, but I'm not sure if ... if a Harpy can manipulate its subjects from a distance.
别斯米尔： 他们一定被控制了，但我不确定——不确定鹰身女妖是不是有这种隔空操纵行为的能力。

Bessmert strains to extract something useful from her mind, hoping to find anything that might explain the absurdities before her.
别斯米尔努力从脑海中挖掘着信息，希望能找到一点可用的东西，好解释眼前荒唐的变故。

In the end, she gains nothing, and the doubt strikes at her head again like a well-paced hammer.
结果是，她毫无收获，疑问仍然像一把铁锤一样敲打着脑袋。

Bessmert: Err, alright, let's hope that ...
别斯米尔： 呃，好吧，让我们祈祷……

Yenisei: Hope that "Harpy" doesn't eat horses? Madam, we can't just stand here and hope ...
小叶尼塞： 祈祷他们不会被吃掉？女士，我们不能坐以待毙——

Bessmert: Nonsense. Hope that this is just a mind-controlling arcane skill, and they're just affected by it.
别斯米尔： 当然不是！是祈祷这是某种可以控制思维的神秘术，他们都是被控制了……

Bessmert: That's right. We must follow that creature and break the spell on them.
别斯米尔： 对，没错。我们需要追上去，打断施术者的行动。

Bessmert: Now you need to ...
别斯米尔： 所以你先——

Bessmert grabs Yenisei, while her other hand points firmly upstream toward the herd of horses.
别斯米尔抓住小叶尼塞，另一手则坚定地指向马群奔向的上游。

Yenisei takes only a moment to understand her intentions and calms down.
小叶尼塞几乎立刻理解了她的意思，逐渐镇定下来。

Yenisei: Alright. I see what you mean.
小叶尼塞：……好，我明白了。

Yenisei: I'll go first. Please listen carefully to my footsteps and find us as soon as possible.
小叶尼塞：我先追上去。请您留意我的脚步声，尽快赶上来。

Unfortunately ...
然而，很遗憾。

They quickly realize the creature doesn't need to look back to know what's going on behind it. It merely raises its talons to deftly parry Yenisei's attacks.
它似乎不用回头就知道身后发生的事，只需抬手就能接下小叶尼塞所有的攻击。

That is to say, they realize soon enough that its power is far beyond what the two of them had imagined.
换句话说，它的力量超出了两人的想象。

Yenisei: Hold there! What on earth do you want!
小叶尼塞：——停下！你到底要做什么！

Yenisei: Answer me!
小叶尼塞：回答我！

???: ...
???: ……

Perhaps it is because of this disparity in strength that the "Harpy" seems not to feel any need to pay attention. It whirls around in midair.
或许是力量实在悬殊，不必放在眼里，“鹰身女妖”在天上回过身来。

However, Yenisei struggles to see any discernible expression on its human face.
但小叶尼塞很难看清它那张酷似人形的脸上有任何的表情。

???: Turn thee back.
???: 归去。

???: Seek what thou desire elsewhere.
???: 此处并无尔等所寻之物。

Yenisei: What?
小叶尼塞：什么?

???: Turn thee back, there is naught to find here.
???: 既如此，不如归去。

Bessmert: What is this sound? Speaking or singing? Sounds like a young man, how so?
别斯米尔：这声音是它在说话，还是在唱歌？为什么听起来更像青年男子的音色?

Bessmert: Well, at least it's definitely not a Harpy.
别斯米尔：不过，也许可以认为它不是鹰身女妖了。

Yenisei: Perhaps it's talking, but the tone sounds strange. I've never heard any language like this.
小叶尼塞：也许它是在说话。可声调很奇怪，我从没听过这种语言。

Yenisei tries in vain to continue forward, but the "giant bird" shakes its head in the air as though issuing a warning.
小叶尼塞徒劳地想要继续上前，直到“巨鸟”警告似的在空中摇晃脑袋。

???: Thine pursuit will cost thee greatly, and yet little will be thy reward.
???: 若执着于此……便是光阴蹉跎，前程惘然。

???: Tread not one step more.
???: 勿要上前了。

As the wings of the "giant bird" rise and heave, in addition to the strange instrument, the horses also turn around.
随“巨鸟”翅膀抬起而动作的，除了那古怪的乐器，还有蓦然回头的马群。

Their unhinged companions stand in the way as the music suddenly shifts from a melodious tone to a piercing frenzy.
失去控制的同伴拦在路中，乐声也陡然由悠扬转向尖锐。

It paints the scene of a hopeless conflict.
它谱了一出无奈的冲突。

The striped horses are driven by the giant bird, turning their heads to block her path.
同伴变作的斑纹马被“巨鸟”驱遣着，掉转头来挡住她的去路。

Yenisei can only lift her hands against the encirclement and continue launching her attacks upward.
小叶尼塞只能在围堵中抬起手来，继续向上发动攻击。

Striped Horse?: *neighs angrily*
斑纹马?: *愤怒的叫声*

Yenisei: Ugh!
小叶尼塞: 呃！

Yenisei: Ugh ... Gentlemen ... Get out of the way. Out!
小叶尼塞: 呃……你们……让开。让开！

Yenisei: And you, hey, the flying one! You can talk, right? I don't know your language, but ...
小叶尼塞: 还有你，天上的那个！你会说话，是吗？虽然我听不明白——

Yenisei: If you are going to eat them, you'd better think twice.
小叶尼塞: 但你如果坚持要选他们做食物的话，我建议你还是好好考虑一下。

Yenisei: Horse meat has a bad smell.
小叶尼塞: 马肉的味道很腥。

???: ...
???: ……

The bird remains silent. Yenisei notices a slender, white stick poking out from his feathers.
巨鸟没再出声。小叶尼塞留意到一枚细长白色的短杖自它身上飞出。

Like a bone, but yet also like a wand.
像骨头，也像术杖。

Yenisei: No ... Madam, watch out!
小叶尼塞: 不……女士，快躲开！

Bessmert: What? I don't sense any hostility ...
别斯米尔: 什么？我没有感觉到攻击性——

This "attack" indicates that it is, in fact, a wand.
这“攻击”显示，它是术杖。

However, the two individuals supposedly subjected to this attack seem unchanged. Both physically and mentally, they are exactly as they were before.
然而理应受到“攻击”的两人，看上去毫无变化。无论身体或精神，都与先前如出一辙。

Yenisei: Hmm?
小叶尼塞: ……嗯?

Bessmert: Don't worry. I'm fine. It wasn't an attack.
别斯米尔：没事。我没事，这不是一次攻击。

As the two of them begin to explore their uncertainty, the figure flapping its wings in the air speaks once again.
就在两人惊疑不定时，空中挥舞着翅膀的人却再次开口了。

This time, though, something is different.
这一次，有什么东西不一样了。

???: Those whom you chase are no longer related to you once they walked in here and moistened their throats with the flowing water.
???：你们所寻之人……自走入此地，饮下流水起，就已与你们无关。

???: They are the Zhící's concern.
???：此事需交由职祠处理。

???: No more chasing.
???：休要再追。

Yenisei: What is a Zhící? I don't understand ...
小叶尼塞：职祠是什么？我实在难以理解你说的……

Yenisei: No, wait, I-I understand his words now. What?
小叶尼塞：啊，不对，我、我能听懂了？

Yenisei: But ... What is happening? Am I seeing illusions again?
小叶尼塞：可是——这——发生了什么？难道是我产生了幻觉？

Yenisei: Madam, what about ...
小叶尼塞：女士，你——

Bessmert: No, it's not an illusion. I can understand it, too.
别斯米尔：不，不是幻觉，我也能听懂。

Yenisei: Unbelievable. Is he able to speak different languages, or can he learn from our conversation in no time?
小叶尼塞：太奇怪了。是他能使用多种语言，还是说，他能快速学习我们说的话——

Bessmert: The "attack" he just made could be his arcane skill.
别斯米尔：刚才我们以为的“攻击”，应该是他的神秘术。

Bessmert: I can sense the fluctuation of his arcane energy. It's a wondrous power that allows people to communicate.
别斯米尔：我能感觉到神秘术波动的气息。如果是真的，那这个术相当奇特。它似乎能使人语言相通……

???: Speculation is unhelpful to your situation. Go back ...
???：揣测是无用的。回去吧。

???: ... To where you came from.
???：回来处去。

This time, its meaning is clear. But neither these words of advice nor its tone of refusal can shake their resolve.
此时语义清晰。但无论是劝告的话语，还是拒绝的语气，都无法动摇两人执着的念头。

Turning back had never been a consideration before, so of course, they wouldn't consider it now.
之前她们不考虑回头，此时当然也不会答应。

Yenisei: No.
小叶尼塞：不。

Yenisei: First, you must turn them back. Second, to go back or not is our decision to make, not yours.
小叶尼塞：你需要把他们变回来。回不回去，是我们之间的事，与你无关。

???: That was not my doing.
???：……此事非我之祸。

Yenisei attempts to understand the true meaning hidden in the giant bird's words. Her mind spins rapidly, and countless questions clamber up, desperate to leap from her tongue.
小叶尼塞试图理解这只巨鸟话中潜藏的真实含义。她的头脑飞速转动起来，无数个问题要争先跳出舌苔。

Yenisei: You stopped here and cast that arcane skill for us to talk, which means you think communication is an available choice between us.
小叶尼塞：你停了下来，而且对我们使用了能通人言的神秘术，这代表你默认了沟通选择的存在。

Yenisei: You just mentioned "the flowing water." Do you mean the river we passed by?
小叶尼塞：你刚才说的“饮下流水”，是指我们先前路过的河流吗?

Yenisei: And you said these striped horses are "Zhící's concern." I need to know where that place is because they are my teammates.
小叶尼塞：而且，这些斑纹马是我们的同伴。你说要将他们带到“职祠”处去，我需要知道那儿究竟是哪里。

Yenisei: Besides ... who on earth are you?
小叶尼塞：还有……你究竟是谁?

???: ...
???：……

???: What you ask, I have no answer.
???：你所问，皆非我所能答。

Yenisei: Then what do you know?
小叶尼塞：……那你能回答什么?

???: The Four Books and Five Classics, Geomancy and Feng Shui, Chen-Wei Divination.
???：四书五经，堪舆风水，谶纬天地。

Yenisei: What are you talking about?!
小叶尼塞：那都是什么东西?!

???: Mm? The answers to many questions, naturally.
???：嗯？自然是解惑之道。

The doubt in his tone seems to come straight from the bottom of his heart.
他语气里的疑惑听起来竟然是发自内心的真诚。

Bessmert: Yenisei, listen to me. We might be asking the wrong questions.
别斯米尔：孩子，听我说。我们也许不应该这样向他提问。

Yenisei: But we need to collect more information or buy more time. Whatever we are going to do, we can't just let him go.
小叶尼塞：可我们总得知道些什么，或者拖延时间，总之——总之不能就这样让他离开。

Yenisei: He will take Mr. Jurien and the team away from us!
小叶尼塞：他会带走尤利恩先生他们!

Bessmert: But clearly, he is reluctant to answer these questions.
别斯米尔：可他听起来，显然也不愿正面回答这些问题。

Bessmert: Perhaps he'd be willing to exchange them for our supplies?
别斯米尔：也许我们应该考虑，能不能用物资和他交换我们的同伴?

Bessmert: He is trying to take them away, perhaps because they are carrying the supplies he needs.
别斯米尔：他要带走马群，更有可能是因为现在的尤利恩先生他们身上，有他想要的东西。

Yenisei: You mean food, or what? Let's ...
小叶尼塞：食物？还是什么？那我们——

???: Stop, there's nothing else for you here.
???：既无所问，两位这便留步罢。

???: And I need nothing ...
???：毕竟……

???: What I yearn for is beyond even my own grasp.
???：我所欲，渺然远矣，不知亦不可追。

Bessmert: Wait, good sir ...!
别斯米尔：等等，先生——

The bird turns around and flaps its wings, flying away much faster than before.
巨鸟回身振翅，比先前更快地飞远了。

This time, there is no music. Yet the odd creatures follow closely in the wake of the wind raised by the motion of its wings.
而这次甚至没有了乐声。奇蹄目在翅膀挥舞所带动的风声中，仍然紧跟其后。

Yenisei: Hey!
小叶尼塞：你——

Yenisei: Darn. He flew away!
小叶尼塞：该死，他又飞走了！

Bessmert: ... Did I say anything wrong?
别斯米尔：……是我说错了什么吗?

Yenisei: Don't blame yourself, Madam. He appeared to be the unpredictable type.
小叶尼塞：不是您的错，女士。他看起来就是个反复无常的家伙。

Yenisei: Do you still have the strength to walk? We need to hurry up and go after him ...
小叶尼塞：您还能走吗？我们得快点追上去——

Bessmert grabs Yenisei's arm and quickly chases after the piercing sound of the wind.
别斯米尔挽住小叶尼塞的手臂，快步朝着凛冽的风声追去。

6#1
6#1

黄沙道
The Yellow Sand Road NS-06

In the battle between two legs and four, they find themselves on the back foot from the beginning.
两足在与四足的追逐战中，一开始就落了下风。

The burdenless horses gallop wildly as the giant bird flies further and further, leaving exhausted Bessmert and Yenisei far behind.
不必负重的斑纹马在草原上狂奔，巨鸟也在更远的空中逐渐缩小成一个断续变化的点。 早已疲倦的两人很快就因体力不支而被甩在后方。

Yenisei: *pants*
小叶尼塞：……呼……哈……

Yenisei: Madam ...
小叶尼塞：别斯米尔……女士……

Their stamina slips away faster than it did before on the plains.
力气比先前在平原上时更快地从周身溜走。

Their actions become increasingly labored, and their steps slow to a plodding halt.
两人的行动愈发艰难，脚步也逐渐停滞。

Bessmert: Are we going upstream?
别斯米尔：我们是向着河水上游跑吗?

Bessmert: If we are, he must be taking his preys back to his nest. Is-Is there a forest there?
别斯米尔：如果是上游，那么他要带猎物回到栖息地……难道、难道上游有森林?!

Yenisei: I'm sorry, Madam. I can't ... I can't think right now.
小叶尼塞：对不起，女士，我的脑子——转不动。

Yenisei: I can't see ... anything. Only ... stars ...
小叶尼塞：我的眼前……只有重影，什么也……看不清。

Yenisei: *exhales*
小叶尼塞：……呼……

The girl suddenly realizes that she can no longer pull Bessmert along.
女孩突然发现，自己再也拉不动年长者。

With her energy dwindling, the sudden pause only leaves her more flustered.
一泄力，突然的停顿只让她陷入迷惑。

Yenisei: Huh?
小叶尼塞：唔……?

Yenisei: Why ... *pants* ... Why stop?
小叶尼塞：您为什么……呃……为什么停下了?

Yenisei: *pants*
小叶尼塞：呼，呼……

Bessmert: ...
别斯米尔：……

Bessmert: I hear horses, right in front of us.
别斯米尔：马的声音，就在前面。

Bessmert: And people.
别斯米尔：……还有许多人的声音。

And not just people.
不仅是单纯的人声。

The clamor of commerce, a melody in the trundling of carriages, rolling wheels on the ground, and the sound of footsteps on the soil and stones soon follow ...
市集的吵嚷，旋律的铮鸣，马车负重，滚轮碾地，土石上的踢踏声随之而来……

No matter what lies ahead ...
无论那上面究竟是什么——

Bessmert: No. It's not a forest.
别斯米尔：——不。上游不是森林。

Yenisei: There are walls and people ... I-I don't understand. Wait ... Could it be ...
小叶尼塞：这些墙、这些人……我、我不明白，等等……难道是……

Hard city walls made of earth and stone, and a soaring gate tower, the likes of which they have never seen before, encompass the bustling town and the vivid figures within.
——土石组成的坚硬城墙和结构前所未见的高耸门楼，将人影绰绰的热闹城镇囊括其中。

The gate is opened wide. Pedestrians pass under it, as guards wearing silver armor stand at the entrance to the city.
大门洞开，行人往来，身着银盔的守卫伫立在城门的入口。

Yenisei: Emm, is it ... a supply station?
小叶尼塞：……呃，这里是……补给站?

Yenisei: No, no ...
小叶尼塞：……不，不是……

Yenisei: Where ... Where on earth are we?!
小叶尼塞：我们——我们究竟在哪儿?!

Bessmert: Child, please tell me where we are.
别斯米尔：孩子，现在我需要你告诉我，我们大概走到什么地方了。

Bessmert: I can't hear the rustling of the sand rice anymore, but there are other noises. I'm thinking ... is this a settlement?
别斯米尔：我听不到沙蓬翻滚，但有一些其他的声响。我在想，我们是不是走到有人聚居的地方了?

The girl shakes her head, failing to answer Bessmert's question.
女孩晃了晃脑袋，没有马上回答别斯米尔的问题。

Having never seen such a place before, she is naturally apprehensive of all that stands before her.
她从未见过，也因此对眼前的一切产生怀疑。

Yenisei: No. At least it doesn't look like one. Not like any towns or villages we've seen.
小叶尼塞：不是……至少，它看起来不像。它看起来不像任何我们见过的，那些城镇、村庄……

Yenisei: I-I think I'm seeing another illusion. I see a desert, some plants, and a wooden pavilion on the yellow walls.
小叶尼塞：我，我觉得我出现了幻觉。我看到——荒漠植被和黄色的城墙，还有城墙上木头做的阁楼。

Yenisei: The roof of the pavilion looks like bird wings, and the people down the walls are quite different from us ...
小叶尼塞：阁楼的屋顶就像鸟的翅膀，城墙下面的那些人看上去也不一样——

Bessmert: Walls and people, right? Only a city has walls around it. I also hear those noises. It's not an illusion.
别斯米尔：有城墙，也有人，是吗？那么城墙之后，就应该是城镇，这与我听到的人声环境一致，也许并不是你的幻觉。

Yenisei: No, you don't understand. Those yellow walls and the gates don't look real at all!
小叶尼塞：不，请听我说，不是那样的。那些黄色的城墙和门，看上去根本不像真的!

Yenisei: I've never seen any buildings like this. A pavilion on the stone walls with four pointy tips around the roof. They seem to be flying in the mid-air ...
小叶尼塞：我从来没见过这样的建筑，在土石城墙上建起阁楼，四角就像飞在半空里一样……

Bessmert: Perhaps it's just a foreign architectural style.
别斯米尔：听起来，也可能只是另一种文明的建筑方式。

Yenisei: Besides, we couldn't have gone far enough to reach a city, unless ... unless it's a fake one.
小叶尼塞：而且，就算这是城镇，我们也不可能走了那么远。除非——除非这是假的。

Yenisei: We must not go there rashly.
小叶尼塞：我们不能贸然过去。

Bessmert: We've lost track of the giant bird and the others long before we heard the noises of this city. The last thing I can recall is that the flapping of the huge wings disappeared in the south.
别斯米尔： 但是，甚至早在前头的人声出现之前，我们就已经跟丢了那个巨鸟和尤利恩先生他们，只知道扇动翅膀的声音，最后出现在正南方。

The girl tightly clasps Bessmert's sleeve, realizing that things are sliding in a direction beyond her control.
女孩紧紧抓住了年长者的衣袖，她发觉事情正在滑向自己完全无法控制的方向。

Bessmert: The city wall before you is also to the south, is it not?
别斯米尔： 而你眼前的城墙就在正南方，对吗?

Bessmert quietly turns her face toward Yenisei. Even though the girl knows her eyes are covered by fabric and are unable to see a thing, this gesture still possesses the power of a gaze.
别斯米尔安静地以面庞朝向小叶尼塞。即使对方知道那被布料遮住的眼睛看不清任何东西，这个动作也具备了凝视应有的力量。

A kind of soothing, stable, but at the same time questioning power.
那种安抚、稳定，却同时代表了执着叩问的力量。

Yenisei: Madam ... you are doing it again. You never listen to me.
小叶尼塞： 您……您总是这样。您一定不会听我的意见了。

Bessmert: Child, we are standing in the right place.
别斯米尔： 孩子，我们已经在这里了。

Bessmert: Behind these walls, our teammates might be suffering due to my misjudgment.
别斯米尔： 并且尤利恩先生他们，极有可能是因为我们的选择，才遭受了这样的灾难。

Yenisei pauses a brief moment, before she makes up her mind.
小叶尼塞沉默了。片刻后，她做出了一个决定。

Yenisei: The gate is open. I can see the people in the city.
小叶尼塞： ……城门的确开着，能看到里面的人影。

Yenisei: But there are guards patrolling around. They are holding some spear-like weapons, and the one in the front looks ...
小叶尼塞： 可门口有守卫，拿着一些矛一样的冷兵器。最前面的那个人看起来……

Yenisei: Quite different from us.
小叶尼塞： 和我们很不一样。

Yenisei: I don't think they understand our language, even if we ask them to let us in ... Remember those herders? Almost impossible to communicate with them without an interpreter!
小叶尼塞： 即使我们想进去，他们也不一定能听懂我们说的话……还记得那些牧民吗？没有来自当地的翻译，通常很难沟通。

Bessmert: Hope our "travel documents" can get us through that gate.
别斯米尔： ……那就希望我们的“通关文书”能派上用场吧。

6#1
6#1

远来是客
The Guests From Afar NS-07

Gate
城门前

According to Yenisei's description, the peculiar-looking city defenders are all clad in silver armor and bear sharp weapons in their hands.
据小叶尼塞描述，样貌奇特的守城者都穿着银色的盔甲，手中握有锐利的冷兵器。

It sounds like a scene from the medieval era. Having passed every barrier smoothly all the way from Omsk, they think the garrison here is also a piece of cake.
乍一听像中世纪的光景。由于已经从鄂木斯克一路过来，别斯米尔以为这样的守备力量比起她们顺利通过的那些严苛关隘，应该是不足看的。

But as it becomes clear, they are wrong to underestimate them.
但很显然，她们错了。

Even though both sides miraculously understand each other's words, the passes here are still well-guarded.
即使双方都奇迹般地仍然能够听懂彼此语义，这里的关卡仍然死守严防。

Yenisei: ...
小叶尼塞：……

Gate Keeper: Please show me your Pass.
城门郎：请出示过所。

Yenisei: You have all our documents.
小叶尼塞：我们所有的通行文书都已经给你了。

Gate Keeper: This is not a Pass.
城门郎：这不是过所。

Bessmert: Sir, you have the documents. Please, take a closer look at them.
别斯米尔：先生，文书就在您的手上，请再看看吧。

Gate Keeper: I'm not a Sir.
城门郎：我不是先生。

Gate Keeper: Please show me the right Pass, which shows where you come from and where you are going.
城门郎：烦请出示准确过所，上面会写清楚你从哪里来，要到哪里去。

Yenisei: I wouldn't have been here if I knew the answers.
小叶尼塞：……如果我知道这个问题的答案，我就不会在这里了。

Gate Keeper: No Pass, no entry.
城门郎：没有过所不能进城。

The problem seems to lie in both parties failing in the art of effective communication.
问题似乎出在双方旗鼓相当的鸡同鸭讲身上。

This bickering back and forth over useless technical pitfalls undoubtedly wastes everyone's time.
在毫无用处的嘴仗上“打得有来有回”，无疑浪费着所有人的时间。

Bessmert: *sighs* I think it has been clearly stated on our documents.
别斯米尔：唉。我认为这张通行证上都写得很清楚了。

Bessmert: The documents were issued by the association. They worked in all the borders in the North. What makes the difference here?
别斯米尔：您瞧，协会印发的过关文书，在北边的周边关隘都适用，没有理由在您这里不行。

Gate Keeper: It's not verified. I don't know which pass let you pass with this Pass, let alone the writing and the seal on it cannot be recognized.
城门郎：它不行。我不知道你用这个经过了哪里的关卡，况且这上面的记录，无论文字还是印章都不合规制。

Gate Keeper: If I let you in, it would be my negligence.
城门郎：我不能放你们进去，这是玩忽职守。

Yenisei: Can we talk to someone else? You don't understand what we are talking about.
小叶尼塞：能不能换个人来跟我们说？你听不懂我们的话。

Gate Keeper: I understand every word you say.
城门郎：我明白你们在说什么。

Bessmert: Very well, if you do, friend, this is what happened:
别斯米尔：好吧，如果你的确能听懂，事情实际上是这样的，朋友。

Bessmert: Our teammates were transformed into "horses" and taken away by a winged man. We think they might have been brought here, so we need to get into the city to find them.
别斯米尔：我们的同伴被变成了马一样的动物，又被一个长着翅膀的人带走了。我们怀疑他们进了城，所以才需要进去找到他们。

Bessmert: This is urgent. I hope you can understand ...
别斯米尔：这很紧急，希望你能理解——

Gate Keeper: I've been on duty for over six hours. There was no such thing as a "winged man."
城门郎：我今日值守此门已逾三个时辰，从没见过什么长着翅膀的人。

Gate Keeper: You can't fool me with your stupid story. I've seen too many of these little tricks.
城门郎：编故事是无用的。像你们这样想要浑水摸鱼的家伙，我见过太多了。

Gate Keeper: The rule is, no Pass, no entry.
城门郎：规矩就是，没有过所不能进城。

The defender in silver armor looks like a wall of iron from whichever angle he's seen.
身着银盔的守城者无论从哪个角度打量都像是一堵铁墙。

Yenisei looks up and sees the wooden eaves above the masonry, rising straight into the sky to cast a shadow over the ground. She remembers the "giant bird" and suddenly wishes she too had wings.
小叶尼塞抬头，看到砖石之上木制的屋檐，往天空直直翘起，给地面投下一片阴影。她想起那只“巨鸟”，突然希望自己也生有翅膀。

Yenisei: Fine. This man understands our language, but he won't buy it.
小叶尼塞：……好吧，看来这家伙是听得懂，但听不进去。

Bessmert: Yeni?
别斯米尔：小叶尼塞?

Unfortunately, she doesn't have wings, and so she must find some other way to deal with their predicament.
可惜她没有翅膀，只能尝试一些别的办法。

Yenisei: Then I'll see if we can make it in without this Pass.
小叶尼塞：我要试试，没有你说的这东西，究竟能不能进去。

Gate Keeper: Trying to break in? You're overestimating yourself.
城门郎：……你们要强行闯关？这是不自量力。

Yenisei: Just trying, because we are not given any choices, Sir.
小叶尼塞：我只是要试一试，因为我们也没有别的办法了，先生。

Bessmert: Wait, Yenisei ...!
别斯米尔：等等，小叶尼塞——！

Emptying the glass bottles one by one, Yenisei's "weapons" are quickly depleted.
玻璃瓶逐个空掉，小叶尼塞身上能用的“武器”已经很快见底。

Across from them, the dry iron wall—the poor guard—has become a wet iron wall.
两人对面，一堵干燥的铁墙变成了一堵湿淋淋的铁墙。

Gate Keeper: ...
城门郎：——

Gate Keeper: Warning! Intruders!
城门郎：——报——有人正试图强行闯入——

Gate Keeper: Close the gate!!
城门郎：关城门——！

The guards on the wall above the city gates respond in a quick and rhythmic step.
城门墙楼上的卫兵立即响应，极富节奏地奔跑起来。

Below, those within the city gates scuff the sand, as the gates' heavy cables are twisted in reply, held tightly in expectant hands awaiting their next command.
下方，城门内的脚步声蹭动沙地，门上沉重的缆索被规整而迅速地收绞，在手中挽紧，只等一声令下。

Bessmert: They are closing the gate!
别斯米尔：他们要关门了！

Bessmert: This is bad! We, we have to get in, or how are we going to get them back? We can't just leave them here ...
别斯米尔：糟了，我们、我们得进去，否则再也找不到尤利恩先生他们了！我们不能把他们丢在里面——

Bessmert: Neither can I just turn away from the clues to the Dùshuò Festival and the mysterious Eastern arcane power ...
别斯米尔：还有、还有那些“度朔节”与东方神秘术的线索……

Bessmert: Sir, I beg of you!
别斯米尔：先生，我请求您！

Bessmert rushes forward, attempting to pull back the guards and city gates with all her might.
别斯米尔冲上前去，试图以一己之力拉住正在后退的守卫与缓缓关闭的城门。

But her lack of sight impedes her, unable to detect the hidden dangers on the uneven, packed-sand road.
可她什么也看不见，当然也发现不了不平的沙土道路上隐藏的危险。

—A loose stone is enough to trip her, and despite the demands of the moment, it takes her time to get back up again.
——一颗石头也足以绊倒她，令她摔下去，甚至一时之间难以再次爬起。

Gate Keeper: Don't get any closer.
城门郎：……不要上前了。

Yenisei: Madam! Are you alright?!
小叶尼塞：别斯米尔女士！您怎么样了！

She anxiously helps Bessmert to her feet, with her other hand tightly gripping an empty glass bottle.
她着急地搀扶起别斯米尔，另一只手，紧紧攥着那枚空掉的玻璃瓶。

They've had countless unpredictable mishaps along the way, enough to write an adventure story few would believe, and experienced more than enough to exhaust the will of any explorer.
这一路上经历的不可测的事故已数不胜数，足以撰写出一部荒诞的冒险小说，更足以击倒任何一位经验丰富探险家的意志。

Perhaps simply allowing the city gates to close is a safer and more appropriate approach.
也许，就这样任由城门关闭，的确是更为妥当与安全的做法。

Yenisei: Maybe we should just give up, Madam ... I'm even thinking if all these things we've been through are just illusions.
小叶尼塞：女士，我们或许真的该放弃了……我甚至怀疑，这一切是否只是一场可耻的幻觉。

Yenisei: The unusual terrains, the teammates turned into striped horses, and now this nonsense ...
小叶尼塞：那些怪异的地貌，那些变成斑纹马的队友，还有眼前这、这些……

Yenisei: I won't let you go in there and risk your life!
小叶尼塞：我不能眼睁睁地看着您用自己的安危去冒险……！

Bessmert cannot see her companion's expression, but can hear the hesitation in her voice. It proves enough to add to her struggle to get up again.
别斯米尔看不见对方的表情，却能从声音中读出那种犹豫。于是她挣扎着起身。

Bessmert: No, on the contrary, child.
别斯米尔：不，恰恰相反，我的孩子。

Bessmert: The unknown people, the uncharted city ... We are very close to what we've been chasing. We were born to run after these exciting and amazing things.
别斯米尔：这些闻所未闻的风土人情，距离我们所追寻的东西已经非常接近了——那些我们生来便要追寻的新奇而伟大的事物。

Bessmert: You're also looking for an answer from Ask and Acquire, right?
别斯米尔：而且，你不也有问题，期望着“所求必应”能够给出答案吗?

Bessmert: Besides, we have no idea how Mr. Jurien and the others are doing ... There is more to consider other than our own safety.
别斯米尔：更不必说还有尤利恩先生他们不明的去向……与这些相比，我们的安全简直不值一提。

???: Well said. Speaking of which ...
???：说得好。若论安全……

???: The city is much safer than the wild. You have my word.
???：城内应比城外安全许多。我可以向两位保证。

Lizheng: As for me, I am the Lǐzhèng of the biggest merchants hub in this city. You can address me by my title. *Lǐzhèng: A low-ranking government official responsible for taxation and household registrations.*
里正：至于我……我在这城中最大的金市任里正一职，两位称呼我为里正即可。

Yenisei: Lǐzhèng ...?
小叶尼塞：里正……?

Bessmert: He sounds like a decent gentleman.
别斯米尔：听起来是一位体面的先生。

Gate Keeper: Lǐzhèng, they are the intruders!
城门郎：里正，这两人要强行冲关入城。

Lizheng: Noted. The situation is under control. No need to close the gate. The ladies look like foreign merchants. Their business is within my purview.
里正：我已知悉，情况可控，不必关城门了。这两位似是胡商，正在我职责范围之内。

Lizheng: Besides, it's holiday time. They could be here for the celebration. Don't be so harsh on them.
里正：况且正值节日，亦或许只是前来参加庆典的人。不必如此严苛。

Gate Keeper: Understood.
城门郎：……喏。

The guard holds his hands in front of him and makes a gesture that Yenisei cannot understand before retreating to one side.
守城者把两只手往身前一抱，做了个小叶尼塞看不懂的手势，就退回一边了。

A glimmer of expectation is reignited in the hearts of Yenisei and Bessmert, as if their misfortune might have at last dissipated.
似是厄运散去，小叶尼塞与别斯米尔心中重新燃起了微微的期望。

Lizheng: If I'm correct, you have lost your Pass, right?
里正：我瞧两位，似乎丢了过所文书?

Bessmert: We do have a Pass, but it seems it doesn't work here.
别斯米尔：我们有文书，只是好像不能在这里使用。

Lizheng: Well, just an understandable mistake for people from afar.
里正：远道而来，难免错漏。

Lizheng: However, either for business or the Dùshuò Festival, it is troublesome without a proper Pass.
里正：不过，即使两位来此或为经商，或为度朔节，这缺了过所，却仍是麻烦。

Bessmert: Dùshuò Festival? Is it taking place now?
别斯米尔：度朔节？您是说，现在就是度朔节期间吗?

Lizheng: That's what I said. I thought that is why you're here in Pèi City.
里正：正是？我还以为你们是清楚这一点，才来到沛城。

Bessmert: Uh, yes! We were told of it, but we've never been to one. We are not sure.
别斯米尔：啊，是的！我们知道，但我们从来没有真正参与过，所以不了解，也不确定。

Bessmert: We all heard of the legend about it.
别斯米尔：我们只是听过这个传说。

Lizheng: Hmm. So, is the festival sung as a nursery rhyme in your tribe?
里正：哦？度朔节，难道在你们的部族当中被当作童谣传唱了?

Bessmert: Uh, "tribe"? We are not tribal people. We come from the North.
别斯米尔：啊，“部族”。不是那样的，我们来自……北方。

Lizheng: Northerners? Oh, I mistook you for the descendants of the Wūsūn from the westward.
里正：北人？我还以为，两位都是西边乌孙族的后人。

Lizheng: It is said that they have migrated outside the Zhéluómàn Mountain. No one has ever met them until now. Your clothes also have a unique style. I should apologize for my mistake.
里正：我听闻他们早已失落于折罗漫关外，此前都无人得见……加之你们的服饰也相当奇特，这才贸然猜测了，实在抱歉。

Lizheng: What's more, this lady by your side has red hair, green eyes, and a fair complexion. The features match the records in history books ...
里正：况且，您的同伴红发碧眼，貌色白皙，恰好符合史书上的记载……

Bessmert: History books? Mr. Lǐzhèng, in your history books, do you have ...
别斯米尔：史书？里正先生，你们的史书上——

Lizheng: Like I said, you may just call me Lǐzhèng.
里正：我说过了，称我为“里正”即可。

Lizheng: The book says, "Wūsūn, one of the tribes in the Western Regions, has the most unusual appearance. The present foreigners are their descendants with features of green eyes, red hair, and the looks of macaque monkeys."
里正：书中有言：“乌孙于西域诸戎其形最异。今之胡人青眼、赤须，状类猕猴者，本其种也。”

Yenisei: M-Monkeys ...
小叶尼塞：猴、猴子吗……

Lizheng: Heh heh ... Maybe we can't believe every word in the book. No matter.
里正：哈哈……或许书中所言也不可尽信，两位听过便罢。

Lizheng: Where were we just now? Was it ...
里正：至于先前，我们说到何处了？是否……

Bessmert: Dùshuò Festival. We are here for the festival.
别斯米尔：度朔节。我们是为度朔节来的。

Lizheng: Oh, right. Exactly!
里正：哦，正是！

The old man in front of her seems to be full of interest, and with his hands clasped, he resumes his topic.
眼前老者貌似兴致盎然，双手一合就拾起了刚才的话题。

Lizheng: The Pèi City is famous for its grand celebration and joyful spirit during the festival. It attracts countless travelers from far away every year.
里正：沛城度朔节的氛围与仪典，曾经最鼎盛时，每年都能吸引许多不远万里赶来的人。

Lizheng: I could only imagine how hard it was for you to arrive here. Well done.
里正：想必两位自北而来，路途遥远，亦是如此。辛苦了。

Lizheng: However, forgive me for being offensive. It seems you have lost sight in both eyes ...?
里正：不过，我尚有最后一问。你这眼，是双目皆盲?

Bessmert: Yes. Would that be a problem?
别斯米尔：嗯，您说的没错……请问，这会有什么影响吗?

Lizheng: Under this city's caring policy, you have the privilege of traveling without a Pass.
里正：对缺少过所文书的旅人来说，身有疾残或许并非坏事。

Lizheng: The gate guard is new here. I sincerely apologize for his offense.
里正：今日当值的城门郎新才到任，或有冒犯之处，还请两位海涵。

He bows slightly, implying a subtle apology, and leads the two toward the city proper.
他微微鞠躬，略表歉意，将二人向城内引去。

Lizheng: Come, follow me. It's not safe to stay outside of the city.
里正：这便随我来吧，逗留城外并不安全。

Lizheng: There have been many missing persons cases recently. We intensified the patrol, in case someone is blocked out of the city and goes missing.
里正：最近人口失踪案频发，须得四方走动巡查，才能确保不会有人因被拦在门外而失踪。

Yenisei: Missing persons cases ...
小叶尼塞：失踪案……

Between further topics of conversation, the two follow Lǐzhèng's guidance and, at last, pass through the city gates.
更多交谈的话题间，两人跟随里正的指引，身影没入城门之中。

6#1
6#1

十万个问答
Questions and Answers NS-08

Tower
城楼内

Lǐzhèng leads the two of them up the city wall to a connected inner chamber.
里正引着两人登上城墙，来到阁楼中的一处内室。

Yenisei cannot shake the notion that her next step will land on thin air, until they at last enter the room, and she can let go.
小叶尼塞一路都怀揣着下一步就将踏空的不真实感，直到进入房间之内才放下心来。

From the city gate to the room, the scenery is completely different from outside the city. Though it's a short distance, she is very impressed.
即使与先前城外的景象全然不同，这短暂路途也足以使人印象再度深刻。

Yenisei: Emm ...
小叶尼塞：……请问……

Lizheng: Have a seat.
里正：都先坐下来吧。

Bessmert: Thank you.
别斯米尔：好。

Yenisei: Here, Madam.
小叶尼塞：女士，在这边。

Bessmert: I don't feel any chairs around me. How am I going to ...
别斯米尔：我没有摸到座椅，要怎么……

Yenisei: It seems the people here sit on their heels. Here, cushion.
小叶尼塞：似乎是跪坐的方式。来，这里有软垫。

Lizheng: Just make yourself comfortable.
里正：两位随心坐下即可。

The two of them hobble onward, imitating the old man's unfamiliar posture as he kneels down beside a low table.
两人磕磕绊绊地学着老者的样子，在矮桌边跪坐下来。

Lizheng: You ladies look better now. What were you going to ask?
里正：小娘子面色好些了。方才想问什么？

There are many fears and doubts in their hearts that beg expression. However, the first to break the silence is nothing more than an odd query.
疑问自然有很多。不过最先溜出口的，却是这样一句冷不丁的话。

Yenisei: Your walls ... Won't they collapse?
小叶尼塞：我想问，你们的城墙……难道不会塌下来吗？

Lizheng: Hmm? Why do you think that?
里正：嗯？为什么这么说？

Yenisei: Because they seem to be made of only earth and stone. I don't think these materials can stand the weathering ...
小叶尼塞：因为，我看见城墙似乎是黄色的纯土石结构。它们应该经不起雨水冲刷和大风侵蚀……

Yenisei: Not to mention the wooden pavilion on the walls.
小叶尼塞：更不用说，上面还有用木头架起来的阁楼。

Lizheng: Haha. You draw the conclusion only by its appearance. In fact, the stakes are deeply driven into the ground and stand firmly. No need to worry about the peeling bricks and clay. It's just the sign of the city's longevity.
里正：哈哈。你独见其外，不知其中木桩已沉沉嵌入大地，土石仅为依凭与外壳。无需担忧，即使墙砖剥落，它也存在久矣，与整座城的年岁相仿。

Yenisei: The city's longevity. So how old is this city?
小叶尼塞：与整座城的年岁相仿……那这座城，存在多久了？

Lizheng: As I recall, hundreds of years. Its annals take up most of the library. Each volume records a decade. Considering the large quantity, "hundreds" may not be the best quantifier.
里正：据我所知，数百年。县志占据了书库的一整片书架，十载为一本，数百年是一个比实际更轻描淡写的概括。

Lizheng: There are many historical sites in the city. You may take your mother for a sight tour.
里正：城中多有历史遗迹，或许之后可带令慈前去游赏。

Yenisei: Madam Bessmert is not my mother.
小叶尼塞：别斯米尔女士不是我的母亲。

Lizheng: Ms. Be- ... Oh, I apologize. I forgot about her sight ...
里正：别女士——？哦，抱歉。我还忘了她的眼疾。

Between his words, Lǐzhèng instinctively casts an apologetic glance in Bessmert's direction.
话语间，里正下意识朝别斯米尔所在的方向投去饱含歉意的一眼。

Though she cannot see, she seems to feel something and turns her head towards his voice.
她看不见，但似有所感，转过头来。

Bessmert: That's alright. People often mistake me for having good eyesight because I walk around freely like others.
别斯米尔：没关系。也许是因为我看上去行动太过自如，人们常常忽略这一点。

Lizheng: The silver lining is, we have a caring policy in this regard. We're here to help, whether you need assistance or not.
里正：宽心些，此事亦有好的一面。即使你行动无碍，我们依然会施以援手。

Bessmert: You keep talking about my eyesight. May I ask why?
别斯米尔：我可以问一下，这是为什么吗？对于我是盲人这件事，你们似乎很在意。

Lizheng: The government is obliged to provide help to people with severe impairments, including those who have lost their sights in both eyes. Isn't it the same with the Northerners?
里正：双目失明为笃疾，残疾者受官府庇护。北人没有这样的惯例么？

Lizheng: Oh, if my question is offensive ...
里正：啊，这问题若令你感到冒犯——

Bessmert: No. That's fine. More than fine, actually ...
别斯米尔：不，这很好。不如说，相当好……

Bessmert: In the North, I have to do more to be treated like an ordinary person.
别斯米尔：在北方，我需要付出更多才能得到和寻常人一样的待遇。

Lizheng: I see. I've heard that people in the North idolize the strong and pay little attention to the weak. Little did I know the disabled enjoy no privilege.
里正：竟是如此……北边弱肉强食，我有所耳闻。却不成想连疾残者也得不到应有庇护。

Lizheng: But now you're here with us in Pèi City. Please rest at ease.
里正：既然今日，你们已经来到沛城，就放下心来吧。

Lizheng: Moreover, you speak fluent Hanese. I'm sure your stay here will go swimmingly.
里正：而且，两位的汉话听起来十分流利，这会令你们在城中方便许多。

Yenisei: ...! You mean we are speaking the "Hanese" right now?
小叶尼塞：……！您指的是，我们现在说的正是“汉话”么?

Yenisei feels her hand being pressed lightly by Bessmert's own.
小叶尼塞感到自己的手被别斯米尔轻轻按了一下。

Lizheng: Are you not? It's interesting you ask. According to the records of the hub, most of the foreign merchants with fluent Hanese have lived a long time in the Central Plains. **Central Plains: the name given to China by the ancient Chinese.*
里正：自然？小娘子此言，倒是当真有趣。在金市记册中，言语流利的胡人多数都在中原生活已久。

Lizheng: While you are obviously not one of them, neither have you paid frequent visits here, otherwise ...
里正：而你们看上去，显然并非如此。并且也没有频繁地出入中原，否则——

Lizheng: You wouldn't have forgotten a proper Pass.
里正：就不会连过所也忘记了。

This somewhat insightful witticism surprises Bessmert.
这句不知是否别有深意的玩笑话，令别斯米尔的心头一惊。

Bessmert: You're a man of sharp wit, I have to say.
别斯米尔：我得说，您猜得没错。

Bessmert: Back where we are from, merchants come and go, including those who speak your tongue. We've dealt with them a lot throughout the years.
别斯米尔：我们在家乡时，常年与那些会讲“汉话”的商人打交道。正如您说的那样，他们总是日夜兼程，穿梭于不同的城乡之间。

Bessmert: If it weren't for their advice, we wouldn't have made it this far on our first journey as a new caravan.
别斯米尔：如果不是有他们分享给我们的经验，像我们这样首次出行的商队，恐怕还会遭遇更大的危机。

Lizheng: I see. Foreign merchants are well-informed and welcomed by the citizens in Pèi City. Oh, there are other foreign merchants in the hub. If you have no place to stay, the caravanserai there might be a good choice ...
里正：嗯。胡商见多识广，沛城也一向乐于与他们贸易往来。哦，对了，金市之中有些胡商，若无落脚处，也可去那边寻个旅店……

As he speaks, Lǐzhèng takes out a sheet of paper from a large stack.
话语间，里正从厚实的书简纸堆中取出了其中一张。

Lizheng: Take this with you. It is the Pass to verify your identities.
里正：那么，还需此物。两位需备齐此类过所文书，以作身份证明。

Lizheng: You can enjoy your stay here with it, or you might end up being expelled.
里正：由此才好在城中行走，否则，仍有可能被驱逐出去。

Bessmert: Thank you. Then how are we going to ...
别斯米尔：好的，那请问我们要怎么……

Lizheng: Please show me the documents you have now.
里正：请两位将现下携有的文书予我一观。

Bessmert: Certainly. Let me just ...
别斯米尔：没问题，让我翻翻那东西在哪儿……

Yenisei: I have them. I always have them with me, Madam.
小叶尼塞：在我这里。一直都在我这里，女士。

Bessmert: Oh. Thank you. You are reliable as always, child.
别斯米尔：噢，可靠的好孩子。

They hand over a document in a brown paper envelope.
她们递去一份牛皮纸信封袋装着的文书。

Lizheng: Thank you. I will take a look.
里正：好，我来看看。

Lizheng: Hold on a second.
里正：稍等。

Lizheng: ...
里正：……

On this "document," besides a drawn red seal that roughly illustrates its purpose, the remaining descriptive handwriting looks like scrawled symbols, with the beginnings and ends of sentences connected hastily without leaving any gaps.
“文书”之上，除开一枚图样红章能勉强看出用途以外，剩下的表述性字迹都像鬼画符一般，句句之间首尾相连，仓促而不留一丝空隙。

The embarrassment between reader and writer grows like a bubble waiting to pop.
这实在有些令人为难。

Lizheng: Er ...
里正：呃……

Lizheng: Looks like it's written in Turkic. Is it Turkic?
里正：它们看起来像突厥文。这是突厥文吗?

Yenisei: What? No ...
小叶尼塞：什么？不——

Bessmert makes a move before Yenisei finishes speaking. She pats the girl's back and gestures for her to allow her to explain.
年长的女性抢在小叶尼塞能够说完之前有了动作。她拍拍女孩的背，示意下面由自己来说。

Despite her doubts, the girl habitually follows her lead.
尽管疑惑，女孩还是习惯性地听从了。

Bessmert: Yes, a variation of it. This is the written language in the North.
别斯米尔：是的，可以说它是突厥文。我们北方也使用这种文字。

Yenisei: ...
小叶尼塞：……

Bessmert: Yeni, this is the written language in your hometown, also known as Yeniseic, isn't it?
别斯米尔：孩子，这是你家乡的文字，也叫叶尼塞文，不是吗?

Yenisei is almost certain that her companion is winking at her, despite her eyes being covered.
小叶尼塞怀疑自己是否真的看见对方眨了两下眼睛，毕竟那是被遮住的部分。

Or perhaps it is just her own intuition prompting her. She realizes then, in a moment of enlightenment, that in their precarious situation, she may well need to learn how to quickly accommodate these occasional lies.
又或许只是一种感应和提醒，她随即福至心灵地意识到。在目前尚且不明状况的险境中，也许她需要学会迅速接受这些偶尔的谎言。

Yenisei: Oh, yes. That's right.
小叶尼塞：……哦，是的。没错。

Bessmert: My apologies. I should have known that our language is a rare kind in the Central Plains.
别斯米尔：抱歉，我们应该考虑到这种文字在“中原”不那么常见。

Lizheng: I understand. It's alright, but I'm afraid you have to write it down yourself, including where you came from.
里正：我了解了。无妨，只是需得两位自己写出来历了。

Lizheng: Please take this file as a reference.
里正：具体行文，参见此书。

Yenisei: Thank you. I'll do it.
小叶尼塞：好的，我来写。

Yenisei: ...
小叶尼塞：……

Yenisei: Emm, sorry, but I don't think I can read it.
小叶尼塞：呃，不好意思，我好像也不认识这上面的字。

Lizheng: Hmm?
里正：嗯?

Lizheng: Oh, my mistake. I should have realized the paper work is much harder than oral communication.
里正：哦，是我考虑不周。汉话读写，的确比听说更困难。

Lizheng: But the servant is not here today ...
里正：小童今日不在……

Lizheng: Alright, you can tell me, and I'll write it down. Like ... this one. What did you come to the city for?
里正：既如此，那便你们说，我来写，例如……此处。两位入城，所为何事?

Bessmert: For business.
别斯米尔：经商。

Lizheng: How many of you are there in the team?
里正：商队几人?

Bessmert: Seven, including us.
别斯米尔：算我们在内，七个人。

Yenisei: There WERE seven of us.
小叶尼塞：原本有七个人。

Lizheng: Were? Where are they now?
里正：原本？他们现在何处?

Bessmert: This is also what we are trying to find out.
别斯米尔：这也是我们想要知道的。

Bessmert: On our way here, they were transformed into "horses" and taken away by a giant bird.
别斯米尔：在来到这里的路上，他们变成了马一样的动物，然后被一只巨鸟带走了。

Lizheng: Transformed into horses? Um ... Then how come you didn't get transformed?
里正：被变成了马？这……那两位如何幸免于难？

Yenisei: We have no idea. Perhaps because Madam Bessmert and I are arcanists, while the others are humans.
小叶尼塞：我不知道。也许因为别斯米尔女士与我是神秘学家，而他们是人类。

Lizheng: What do you mean?
里正：何出此言？

Lizheng: Does the giant bird only attack humans? Then how does he identify them?
里正：难道巨鸟只袭击人类？可他又如何分辨呢？

Lizheng: There is no huge difference between humans and arcanists, after all.
里正：毕竟，人类与神秘学家并无太大分别。

Yenisei: What? Emm ...
小叶尼塞：什么？这……

Bessmert: No huge difference?
别斯米尔：……没有太大区别？

This is an answer they had never considered before.
这是她们从未设想过的回答。

Or rather, it was a premise that seemed so distant to their own views that it defied being considered.
或者说，能这样自然以为的前提，在两人的认知中，从未存在。

As if saying a diamond was no different from a clump of soil.
钻石与泥土如何等同？人类与神秘学家又如何等同？

Lizheng: Is that a problem?
里正：怎么？

Bessmert: No, not at all.
别斯米尔：不，没事。

Bessmert: Let's go back to the difference between humans and arcanists later.
别斯米尔：先不论……神秘学家与人类的区别。

Bessmert: My guess is, there might be something wrong with the water.
别斯米尔：我认为，问题也有可能出在水上。

Bessmert: We found a river when crossing the steppe. Our teammates were too thirsty and drank the water in haste. Then we realized something was wrong.
别斯米尔：穿越草原时，我们发现了一条活水河流。当时其他人由于长途跋涉的疲累，在我们发现异常之前，就喝下了那条河中的水。

Yenisei: Yes. It came from the northwest. Not a big one, but quite clean.
小叶尼塞：是的，那是一条在草原上自西北方延伸出来的河。流量不大，但很清澈。

Lizheng: That might be the main river of Pèi City, called Pèilín River.
里正：你们所见的河流，也许是我们的母亲河，沛霖川。

Lizheng: But it has been shrinking these past years. Also, there are no cases of people drinking it and turning into horses ... What were the features of that giant bird?
里正：但近来她已经濒临枯竭，也不会导致这般变化……那巨鸟长什么模样？

Yenisei: He has black or brown wings, red tail feathers, and a man's face.
小叶尼塞：黑色或棕色的翅膀，红色的尾羽。面目像人。

Bessmert: Also, as I recall it, he has the voice of a young man.
别斯米尔：还有，在我的回忆中，那位巨鸟具有青年男子的嗓音。

Lizheng: A giant bird with a man's face. A feather man. Did he play a musical instrument?
里正： 人面鸟身，那么，便是羽人。他能否奏乐?

Yenisei: He played a stick-like instrument. His music could lead the horses to where he went.
小叶尼塞： 他使用一种能发出声音的长条形乐器，还能用那乐器奏乐来控制动物随它前进。

Lizheng: Was there a bone-like wand with him?
里正： 他是否还带着像骨头的短杖?

Yenisei: Could be, but I'm not sure. He was so far away from us.
小叶尼塞： 有相似的东西，但我不确定。当时他与我们的距离实在是太远了。

Lizheng: I have a rough idea now.
里正： 既如此，我大约知晓这羽人身份了。

Lizheng: ...
里正： ……

Lizheng: If that's what I think it is, even though he is not a Xiángruì, I have to say ... *sighs*
里正： 若真如我所想，即使他本就并非“祥瑞”，这也实在——唉!

He seems to be overcome with regret.
他似乎感到万分遗憾。

Bessmert demurely adjusts her kneeling position, keenly sensing a new development.
别斯米尔轻轻地调整跪坐的姿势。她敏锐地感知到，新的进展似乎出现了。

Bessmert: Sounds like something happened when you last met.
别斯米尔： 听起来，似乎还发生过什么事情。

Lizheng: The giant bird, or the feather man, as we say, was considered the Xiángruì by some citizens. It is because he looks like the legendary Gōumáng.
里正： 你们所见巨鸟，或为我们城中所传的羽人。他曾被城中少许居民视为“祥瑞”，皆因其大致身形，与传说中的句芒相似。

Bessmert: What is this Xiángruì? Is it some kind of guardian?
别斯米尔： “祥瑞”是一种类似“保护神”的存在吗?

Lizheng: Not exactly. In most cases, Xiángruì is just Yāo, but in the good way. They are benevolent, using their power to help people and bless the area.
里正： 不，并非如此。“祥瑞”多为妖类，但常与人为善，施术解难，福佑天地。

Lizheng: Before your report, there was someone else witnessing a feather man with a bone wand. He once brought some animals to the Zhící and claimed they were transformed from humans.
里正： 在你们来报之前，城中亦有人侧面目击过持有骨杖的羽人。据传他曾将动物牵引至职祠，声称所带动物实则为人所变。

Bessmert: This ... this is exactly what happened to our teammates.
别斯米尔： 这……这和我们同伴的遭遇，是一样的。

Lizheng: If these two are the same feather man, then he is very likely involved in these missing persons cases.
里正： 假使确为同一人所为，那便足以怀疑他与城内失踪案有关了。

Yenisei: Oh, the cases you mentioned ... I see.
小叶尼塞： 原来之前说的失踪案……是这件事。

Lizheng: Too bad, that witness couldn't remember anything, even the slightest feature, for us to draw a picture. Since no one could provide other evidence, her word was considered nonsense.
里正： 可惜，我们那位侧面目击者，甚至无法凭记忆给出一张画像，此后也无人佐证她的说法，自然被当作是胡言乱语了。

Lizheng: The Fǎcáo thought she was "possessed" and suggested she take a break in her hometown during the holiday.
里正：为此，法曹甚至以为她中了邪，建议她趁节日回乡歇去。

Bessmert: We want to pay her a visit. Will she come back?
别斯米尔：我们还能找到她吗？

Lǐzhèng waves his hand. There is little value to be gleamed from such a faulty clue.
里正摆了摆手。好不容易找到的线索，显然是断了。

Lizheng: I'm afraid not. She worked as the Zhílǐ in the Zhící. It's not a crucial position, but clearly not suitable for a possessed person. There is someone filling in for her now.
里正：她是于职祠工作的执礼，虽非官府要人，可这年节里也不能出现这样的差错。现下是其他人在职祠帮忙。

Yenisei grips the fabric on her knee. She is as persistent as a soldier when executing orders, and this time is no different.
小叶尼塞捏紧了膝上的布料。她总是像个执行命令的士兵般执着，而这次也是一样。

Yenisei: What if ... What if I can offer a drawing of the feather man?
小叶尼塞：如果，如果——我还能给出羽人的画像呢？

Yenisei: He was far away in mid-air at the time. I couldn't see the details, but I remember his outline and the color of his wings. Besides, I have experience in making sketches and maps.
小叶尼塞：虽然他当时飞在半空，看不清细节，只记得廓形和翅膀的颜色。但我学过素描！而且有画地图的经验。

Yenisei: I can totally make a drawing of him.
小叶尼塞：我能画出来。

Lizheng: Sketch? Map? Hmm ... But we can only attach your drawing to the wanted poster for the moment. We can't put him in prison without solid evidence. Everything is yet to be confirmed by the court.
里正：素描？地图……唔……即使你能画出来，我们也只能暂且发令通缉，捉不得他下狱。一切还需得等到当庭对质才行。

Lizheng: But a drawing is better than nothing. Please give it a try.
里正：不过，既然你能画，便试试吧。

Lizheng: Here is the brush and the ink. Help yourself.
里正：此处有毛笔与砚台。请。

Yenisei approaches the table and picks up the brush that was used to write just moments ago.
小叶尼塞靠近桌前，拿起刚才里正记录用过的笔状物。

Yenisei: This is the same long pen you just used?
小叶尼塞：这是刚才您用的那种很长的笔，对吗？

Lizheng: That's right.
里正：是。

Yenisei: And this is ... the ink? But it won't adhere to the pen.
小叶尼塞：这上面的，就是墨水？可我似乎蘸不起来。

Lizheng: To get the liquid ink, you need to rub the ink stick on the ink stone first. It's fine. I'll rub it for you. You can focus on the drawing.
里正：……墨需得新研后蘸取。罢了，我来替你研磨，你尽管画。

The old man rolls up his sleeves and deftly grinds out some ink for Yenisei to dip the brush in.
老人挽起袖口，利落地研出一些墨汁来，让小叶尼塞能够蘸取。

And the girl does not hesitate to write—
而女孩落笔确实也毫不迟疑——

Yenisei: Huh? The lines it draws are really heavy ...
小叶尼塞：咦？这个笔落在纸上，笔迹怎么这么粗……

Yenisei: And do we only have the black ink?
小叶尼塞：而且这个墨水，只有黑色吗?

Lizheng: ...
里正：……

Lizheng: No, there are different colors.
里正：不，旁的颜色也是有的。

Yenisei: May I have the red one?
小叶尼塞：红色可以吗?

Lizheng: Please hold on. I'll get it for you.
里正：……稍等，我去取。

The slow and steady footsteps gradually move away.
缓慢而稳定的脚步声逐渐远离。

6#1
6#1

街市狂澜
Chaos on Streets NS-09

Lizheng: This is great. With your drawing, we can issue wanted posters to find the feather man.
里正：如此甚好。有这画像，我们尽可以通缉羽人了。

Yenisei: ...
小叶尼塞：……

Lizheng: You stay silent. Any questions or concerns?
里正：小娘子沉默不语，可是还有其他顾虑?

Yenisei: You mentioned a former employee of the Zhící ... Or should I call her the Zhílǐ?
小叶尼塞：您先前，提到职祠有一位已经离开的工作人员……或者说，“执礼”?

Yenisei: You said she had seen the feather man and the animals he brought. Then maybe he will come again today. If he shows up with our horse teammates ...
小叶尼塞：您说那位执礼曾经见到了羽人，和他带来的动物。那也许他今天也会来，如果他带着我们同伴变成的那些斑纹马——

Lizheng: That is to say, the feather man she saw is the same person you met.
里正：……意味着前任执礼目击的羽人，与你们所见，确为同一人。

The old man follows his train of thought to its destination, frowns and ponders, before taking the brush from its holder yet again.
老者很快跟上思路，皱眉思索间，从笔架上再次取下了毛笔。

He neatly spreads out a new piece of paper, rubs an ink stick on the slab, and begins to write with a calm and swift hand.
他利落地铺开一张白纸，研墨落笔，从容而迅速。

Lizheng: In this case, a visit to the Zhící might be a good choice for you.
里正：那么，或许两位应去一趟职祠。

Lizheng: I will write a letter for you. Please take it to the Zhící and show it to Jiǔ Niángzǐ, the current Zhílǐ. If the feather man has been there, you can take over the animals he brought to her.
里正：我修书一封，劳两位带去职祠，交予现在的执礼曲娘。若是真有羽人来过，你们也好接手那些被他带来的动物。

Lizheng: Even if he hasn't, you can still proceed with the letter, since Jiǔ Niángzǐ is very warm-hearted. She should be in the Zhící right now. You can find her there.
里正：假使没来，两位也能将信转交，请新任执礼多多留意。曲娘是个热心的孩子，此刻约莫正在职祠，两位自去寻她便是。

Yenisei: Thank you.
小叶尼塞：……好。

With this glimmer of hope, the turbulent emotions of these two strangers in a strange land find themselves anchored, temporarily at least.
少许希望的出现，终于暂时锚定了两人初入异域的动荡心情。

Street, Inside the City
城中街上

After receiving their pass, they are finally permitted into the city. Colorful silks hanging between pointed eaves. People bustle around, taking no notice of the extraordinary beauty around them.
领了书信，异域的来客才终于真正去到城中。只见彩色的绸缎高悬于指向天空的飞檐间，东方面孔的人们视若无睹地穿行其下。

On both sides of the street, there is a silver or copper charcoal pot in front of every house, crackling subtly and bringing spots of warmth to the cold day.
而道路两旁……各户门前或银或铜的炭盆里有着更细微的爆裂声。一团团无光的火，在寒日里捧起热切的温度。

Yenisei: ...
小叶尼塞：……

Bessmert: We should go, Yeni.
别斯米尔：走吧，孩子。

They walk in the direction indicated by Lǐzhèng, from the silent neighborhood, to the dusty and bustling market.
两人向着里正所指方向，从石砖铺就的寂寥门前，走向沙石翻飞，人语与噼啪声齐响的热闹街市。

The peddlers and street performers lay a steady claim to their spaces, forming eddies in the stream of pedestrians that flows toward the center of the main boulevard.
摊贩与表演者岿然不动地占去部分空间，流动的行人都被逐渐收拢至干道中央。

The more people flow toward that intersection, the more crowded it becomes. Until it becomes a slow-moving throng, impeding anyone wishing to move through it.
汇聚到交集路口的行人越多，便越拥挤。这显然滞缓了急于行路者的速度。

Yenisei: This is going to take forever if we have to follow the crowd.
小叶尼塞：如果这样一直推挤着彼此前进，就太慢了……

Yenisei: Madam, do you think we can take the gaps between the houses? Or find a shortcut. That'd be even better ...
小叶尼塞：女士，我们能不能从房屋与房屋之间穿过去？当然，如果能问到更快的路径会更好——

Citizen I: Ahh!
城中居民 I：——啊！

Insisting on politeness in a crowded space like this can often lead to such accidents.
要在拥挤人群中强求面对面说话的礼貌，就会发生这样的事故。

Bessmert: Careful. What's wrong?
别斯米尔：小心。怎么了？

Yenisei: Sorry, we were in a hurry. Are you alright?
小叶尼塞：抱歉……我们急着赶路——您还好吗？

Citizen I: No problem. Don't worry about the bumping. Oh, aren't you the foreigners? I've never seen any red hair in the city. It's pretty.
城中居民 I：无妨，不过略微磕碰罢了。两位是胡人吧？还从没在城中见过你这头发色式的，真是漂亮。

Citizen I: It's holiday time. It's fine to stumble into people. But what's with the rush? Where are you going?
城中居民 I：现下各处都在过节，摩擦是常有的，不过你们这样着急，是要去哪里呢？

Yenisei: We are going to the Zhící.
小叶尼塞：我们是要去职祠。

Citizen I: Oh. But the way there is crowded with visitors. Maybe you can take the other road.
城中居民 I：原来如此……可现在去职祠的路上游人却是太多了。或许，两位能从别的路过去——

The gaudily-dressed woman frowns, clearly pondering how to describe it, but is just as soon distracted by a commotion.
衣着艳丽的女子皱起了眉，似乎思考着如何描述，却很快被喧哗声转移了注意力。

A group of strange black creatures appear from somewhere nearby, dragging their long tails before soaring into the air.
只见一群黑色奇异生物，拖着长尾自不远处腾空而起。

Citizen I: Huh? They are ... Oh no, they are Zhúyès! What are they doing in the street during the daytime?!
城中居民 I：——嗯？那是——天哪，烛夜怎么会白日里出现在大街上?！

Yenisei: Zhúyè? What's that? Some kind of critter?
小叶尼塞：烛夜是什么？一种魔精吗？

Zhuye the Monster?: Squeak ... Coo ... Squeak!
烛夜?：吱……咕叽……吱吱！

They jump down from the eaves, flapping their sticky little wings and violently raising a wave of flying dust accompanied by strangely fragrant drops of water.
它们自屋檐跃下，挥动潮湿的小翅膀卖力掀起一阵飞扬尘土，连带着洒落香味莫名的水点。

Bessmert: Umm, an extraordinary smell. Like liquor.
别斯米尔：唔，好香啊。我似乎闻到了一股酒香味儿。

The travelers on the street run away, harangued by the creatures flapping their wings at them everywhere they turn.
街上的游人则连连奔逃，被那四处振翅的动物折腾得不轻。

Citizen II: Why are they here? Oh! I smell liquor. A lot of liquor!
城中居民 II：这儿哪儿来的烛夜！好大的一股酒味儿！

Citizen II: Who broke the liquor jar and attracted them here?!
城中居民 II：谁家的酒坛子翻了招的烛夜！

???: People! A Zhúyè in the street during daytime is a sign of auspiciousness. Stay calm!
???：——诸位！烛夜白日跃市，乃喜兆也，勿要惊慌！

Yenisei: It's coming our way! Watch out, Madam!
小叶尼塞：……它朝我们来了，别斯米尔女士，小心！

It seems as though the ringleader's movements are even more exaggerated than the others, perhaps realizing that it is being underestimated.
似乎是因为发觉了自己被轻视的现实，闹剧元凶扑腾的动作看上去愈发有分量。

It flies straight toward the center of the crowd, readying its talons.
它径直地朝人群中心飞扑而来，扬起了钩爪。

Zhuye the Monster: Coo!
烛夜：咕——！！！

Zhuye the Monster: Coo! Squeak! Squeak!
烛夜：咕咕咕！吱！！

The Zhúyè's ambition to dominate the street is ended by the sudden intrusion of rampaging livestock that burst into the scene.
烛夜的称霸之路被一群突然闯入的牲畜所终结。

The milieu of beasts, pedestrians, and fliers soon becomes so entirely chaotic, that no one present seems to have any grasp of what is happening beyond the end of their nose.
或许是这景象看起来太过混乱，以至于几乎所有人都没能反应过来究竟发生了什么。

???: Um ... S-sorry!
???：呃——抱……抱歉！

???: You ... You guys! COME BACK!
???：你们……你们——给我——回来——！

???: Bad boys and girls!
???：坏东西！

Zhuye the Monster: Coo coo! Coo! Coo!
烛夜：咕咕——咕——咕！

Bessmert: What's going on? All this shouting and running about ...?!
别斯米尔：——怎么了？吵嚷声好像不仅没有减弱，反而越发纷扰了。

Bessmert: I smell liquor and dust. What happened?
别斯米尔：我闻到了酒，还有尘土扬起的呛人气。发生什么事了？

Yenisei: A kind of local animal named Zhúyè popped up in the street. Maybe they are arcane creatures? I don't know. I've never seen one in books. The liquor smell probably comes from them.
小叶尼塞：路上突然出现了一种被称为“烛夜”的当地神秘学动物，我不知道——图鉴上没有那样的东西。它似乎身带酒香。

Yenisei: And ... I think a herd of livestock rushed out of the fence over there, but I can't see it clearly.
小叶尼塞：还有……更远处似乎是冲进来了一群牲畜，但我没能看清。

Yenisei: Sorry, Madam. We are not supposed to stop here.
小叶尼塞：抱歉，女士，我们本来不该停在这里的。

Ignoring the chaos around them, the two travelers decide to leave before even more commotion starts.
顾不上眼前的闹剧，两人决定在人越聚越多之前离开。

This bizarre scene of animals, critters and people leaping every which way and everywhere was never part of their plan.
围观鸡飞狗跳的混乱场面从不在她们的计划列表中。

Citizen I: We are already having enough trouble with the Zhúyè. Who let out these Festive Animals now?
城中居民 I：烛夜就算了，这会儿又是谁家的年节动物跑出来了——

It seems life has seen fit to frustrate their plans yet again.
除非计划的确赶不上变化。

Citizen I: Wait ...
城中居民 I： 等等……

Citizen I: Jiǔ Niángzǐ?!
城中居民 I： 这不是曲娘吗?!

—The familiar name hums in Yenisei's mind.
——熟悉的名字在小叶尼塞脑中嗡的一声响起。

Citizen I: Jiǔ Niángzǐ, aren't you supposed to be in the Zhící during work hours? What are you ...
城中居民 I： 曲娘，你、你不应该在职祠吗——你这是……?

Jiu Niangzi: Um ... I ...
曲娘： ……呃……我现在……

Jiu Niangzi: No time for explaining!
曲娘： 没法解释！

Jiu Niangzi: Anyway ... They're escaping!
曲娘： 总之——它们——跑了……！

Jiu Niangzi: And I'm ... I'm losing them!!
曲娘： ……而且我要……我要拽不住啦！

Yenisei: Jiǔ Niángzǐ? That's the one Lǐzhèng told us to talk to, isn't it?
小叶尼塞： “曲娘”？这不是里正让我们去找的那个人吗?

The girl named Jiǔ Niángzǐ tries to sound as relaxed as possible in reply, but the scene before her is one obviously and rapidly spiraling out of her control.
被称为“曲娘”的女孩努力使自己的话听起来轻松，但眼前的景象显然逐渐要脱离她的控制。

A panicked sweat drips down her forehead.
她额角沁下汗珠，越发地惊慌失措起来。

If she lets go now, these wild creatures will wreak havoc on the market street and everyone on it.
如果这时候放手，这些得到自由以至于癫狂的动物们，将会是市集道路上所有人的灾难。

Yenisei: Madam, I ...
小叶尼塞： 女士，我……

Yenisei's instincts tell her to step forward. She looks toward the Zhící, still out-of-sight in the distance, then turns back to look at Bessmert.
小叶尼塞下意识想要上前去。她望了望远处还看不见的职祠，又回头看着别斯米尔。

Bessmert can feel her gaze and nods gently.
年长者能感受到她的视线，轻轻地点头。

Bessmert: Go. I will wait here.
别斯米尔： 去吧，我会在这里等你。

Jiu Niangzi: Er ...
曲娘： 呃……

Two of the horses suddenly bolt forward, as if testing the strength of the people behind them.
其中两匹马突然狠狠地往前蹿去，似乎试探着身后人的力气。

Jiu Niangzi: Whoa!
曲娘： ——呀！

Jiu Niangzi: Please, please, guys ... I can't hold on anymore!
曲娘：拜托、拜托大家……我这次真的要，拽不住啦！

The girl in the center of the crowd strains to keep her eyes fixed on the horde of animals more than outmatching her strength.
位于人群视线中心的女孩，继续试图牵住那一大群明显超过她力气大小的动物。

Her obviously waning control does nothing to contain the chaos. All she can do is twist the hemp rope tightly in her hand, winding it one hoop after another, until it is so tight that rough-edged rope cuts into her hand.
力气不断流失，让牵制这件事变得越发困难。她只能把麻绳用力在掌心绞紧，一圈，又一圈，紧到虎口都渗出血来。

Citizen IV: Oh, let me help!
城中居民 IV：……哦，我来帮你！

Citizen II: Yeah! I'll help, too!
城中居民 II：呀！我来，我也来帮帮忙！

Citizen II: I wonder how these animals got out ...
城中居民 II：不过，这些家伙怎么跑出来的……

It is at this moment that finally—heeding the call to come to their senses, the crowd begins to rush forward to assist.
到此刻终于——在第一个回过神来的居民的呼吁下，人们逐渐开始涌上前去。

Jiu Niangzi: Thank you! Thanks ... everyone ...
曲娘：——谢谢、谢谢……大家！

Jiu Niangzi: Please ... help me ... pull harder!
曲娘：劳烦……再帮我……牵紧一些……！

Jiu Niangzi: Hold on!
曲娘：拽住呀——

Jiu Niangzi: You all get a drink on the house!
曲娘：我会请你们喝酒的！

After a short while, with help from the other streetgoers, she manages to get the rampaging, if festively decorated, animals back under control.
片刻后，在围观者的帮助下，她终于将扎着彩带奔逃而出的节庆动物们控制住了。

She deftly ties the quelled animals to the flagpole, then, breathing a well-earned sigh of relief, lets the rope finally slack down from her hands.
绿衣女孩手脚利索地把冷静下来的动物都拴在了彩旗柱子上，又将多出来的末端握在手中，才终于松出一口气。

Jiu Niangzi: Oh dear, thank you so much ...
曲娘：天呀，谢谢你们——

Jiu Niangzi: I couldn't do this without you ... Making so much trouble on the first day of work ...
曲娘：要不然，我可真不知道该怎么办……上任第一天就出这么大的岔子！

She pants heavily, still recovering from her battle—a battle to defend her hometown.
她气喘吁吁的，如同经过一场浩大的战役——保卫家乡的战役。

Citizen I: Where were you, Jiǔ Niángzǐ? I didn't see you in the tavern.
城中居民 I：曲娘打哪儿来呀，早些时候在酒坊没瞧见你。

Jiu Niangzi: Me? I was in the Zhící.
曲娘：我？我就在那边，在职祠里。

Citizen III: What were you doing there?
城中居民 III： 曲娘在职祠做什么?

Citizen I: Oh, Mr. Liǔ, did you forget again? The former Zhílǐ went back to her hometown. Jiǔ Niángzǐ is the new Zhílǐ now.
城中居民 I： 哎，柳郎，你又忘啦？原先的执礼回乡去了。现在呀，曲娘已是新的执礼了。

Jiu Niangzi: No, no, that's not it. I'm just, um, covering for her! I was counting the Festive Animals, and then I heard the noise outside ...
曲娘： 不不，不是的，我只是，呃，代班！我刚才清点节庆动物的数量时，听到了外面的动静……

Citizen II: Haha, you must have been distracted by the Storyteller, huh? He was telling the end of the story today, so you would never miss it.
城中居民 II： 哈哈哈，是听到了说书先生的声音吧？今日是他最后一讲，你定是不会错过。

Jiu Niangzi: Well, yeah. I thought he might tell the story of Xiángruì, so I hurried out and forgot to lock the fence. Hmm ...
曲娘： 是啊，我想着，他可能会讲祥瑞的故事，才着急出来。兴许是没有关好围栏的门，唔……

Citizen I: You're talking about Xiángruì again. People would think you were another Storyteller if they didn't know you just really like these tales.
城中居民 I： 总是惦记着“祥瑞”、“祥瑞”的，不晓得的，还以为你是要写书呢。

Citizen III: Are your palms bruised? Go to my clinic for medicine if it hurts.
城中居民 III： 也看看手掌有无擦伤，若是有恙，一会儿可随我去医馆取药。

Citizen II: Remember the drinks on the house!
城中居民 II： 晚些时候还要请大伙喝酒～

Jiu Niangzi: Of course, I will! Thank you so so much!
曲娘： 好的呀，那是一定的！真是谢谢你们啦！

She speaks with warm familiarity to the other residents, but keeps an eye in the direction of the tea house—as though anxious to confirm whether the Storyteller from before is still there.
她熟络地与居民叙话，却又不住地向茶馆的方向张望——似乎想确认之前那位说书先生是否还在原地。

After seeing his swaying figure in the distance, a look of joy lightens up her face.
当看到远处那摇头晃脑的身影后，她终于露出释然和欢欣的神色。

Yenisei: ...
小叶尼塞： ……

Yenisei quietly observes the scene and retreats, turning around to walk toward Bessmert. The conversations among the locals flow into her ears, allowing her to confirm a crucial fact.
小叶尼塞安静观察，慢慢退后，转身朝别斯米尔走去。刚才人们的对话流进她的耳朵，使她确定了一个事实。

Yenisei: Please follow me, Madam. That lady must be the "Zhílǐ" that Lǐzhèng mentioned.
小叶尼塞： 女士，请跟我来。那位应该就是……里正所说的“执礼”。

Yenisei: Please mind your steps, as we are walking in a mess now. We need to follow the crowd and see if we will have a chance to talk to her.
小叶尼塞： 请您留神脚下，现在地面上有些乱糟糟的。我们得继续跟上去看看，或许能与她搭上话。

Storyteller: Let's put aside the Zhúyè for now ...
说书先生： ——先不论——烛夜如何——

Yenisei: ...?
小叶尼塞： ……?

Little sooner than they reach the tea house, do they notice the crowd rushing toward a stone platform, filling up every nearby space before they have a chance to find a seat.
两人一走到茶馆前，没等拾到一个好位置，便发现人潮都追着石台上的声音向前涌去。

The crowd fills the tea house tightly. The surge of people pushes Bessmert and Yenisei right in front of the Storyteller.
他们更紧地聚拢在茶店前的空地，以至于身在其中的两人也被裹挟到那人面前。

Storyteller: ... And talk about Emperor Yáo. He had seen strange beasts like this many times ...
说书先生：且说那帝尧，亦是多见此类异兽——

He speaks with eloquence, as if possessing some strange magic that naturally attracts even those who didn't go there to hear him.
他的声音娓娓道来，的确带着某种奇异的魔力，连并不为此而来的人都自然被吸引。

Storyteller: It was the seventh year of his reign. Yáo granted an audience to an envoy offering a treasure from the Jiéxiōng Kingdom. The envoy had a strange face and a bulgy chest. He claimed to have come from somewhere millions of miles away from the Yùmén Pass.
说书先生：其在位日久，及至七年。有使者前来献宝。此使乃结匈国人，样貌精奇，胸脯尖削，自称从玉门关外万万里处来。

Storyteller: "This bird is born with the talent for human languages and the phoenix's voice. Our people see it as a Xiángruì, and I am here to offer it to you, Your Majesty!"
说书先生：“有鸟生来即通人言，鸣若凤啸，吾人引以为祥瑞，特此献上人主！”

Storyteller: Then Yáo and his people saw a real giant bird. It was as huge as a mountain and as dazzling as a phoenix. It had an azure body and red tail feathers!
说书先生：帝尧诸臣见证，结匈使者所献宝物果真为一巨鸟。其貌壮如山峦，有凤凰之姿，青身红尾，神貌不凡！

Citizen II: Was it really a phoenix?
城中居民 II：难道真的是凤凰?

Storyteller: Oh no, no. The bird was called Mièméng. It was said to be able to read one's bones, change their fate, and even remove misfortune!
说书先生：哎，非也，非也。此鸟唤作灭蒙鸟，云是能勘骨相，改命貌，禳异灾！

Storyteller: Yáo was pleased with the gift and kept the bird in Dùshuò Mountain. Naturally, that very bird was the ancestor of all the Mièmégs nowadays.
说书先生：于是帝尧甚悦，故另辟山头饲之。今人所见灭蒙，盖度朔山始祖之后也。

The envy in the eyes of the girl clad in green matches her attire completely.
先前那位绿衣姑娘眼中盈满了艳羡的神色。

Jiu Niangzi: H-have you seen a Mièméng with your own eyes?
曲娘：您、您有亲眼见过灭蒙鸟吗?

Storyteller: Be patient and listen. Mièmégs tend to inhabit silent and clean environments, so since the ancient times, the people have always cleaned their yards carefully from time to time, hoping the Xiángruìs will gather and stay beside them. It may not work immediately, but it makes things possible in the long term.
说书先生：莫急莫急。灭蒙鸟生性喜静好洁，古今之人常将门前扫净，盼望祥瑞禽鸟停留聚集。虽时不定，长此以往，或可见之。

Citizen III: So that's why we have the tradition of cleaning the yards on Shuòrì?
城中居民 III：我们朔日需得扫门，原是这么个道理?

Storyteller: Exactly. Some even make Mièméng statues with jewelry and use them to decorate their homes, hoping the Mièméngs will bless the family. Remember the "chicken" statues on your roof? Actually, they are not chickens but Mièméngs, so are those birds you see in the paper-cutouts on the doors.
说书先生：正是。亦有人将金玉珠宝刻成灭蒙模样，装点家宅以求平安。是以诸位仰头望去，今日屋头檐上所刻时夜，其非时夜也，其真灭蒙也，家户所裁门笺亦是。

After saying this, he lifts a piece of red paper, carved in the shape of a peculiarly familiar bird.
说罢，他举起一张红色的门笺，上面剪刻了某种鸟类的形状。

Storyteller: Look, everyone. This is the Mièméng.
说书先生：此鸟即为——灭蒙鸟。

The crowd expresses an underwhelmed disappointment.
众人露出了失望的神色。

Jiu Niangzi: Hmm. But this looks like a normal chicken ...
曲娘：唔。可这个，看起来像普通的鸡……

Yenisei: More like a capercaillie to me.
小叶尼塞：这看起来像松鸡。

Yenisei: And like the bird I just drew, isn't it?
小叶尼塞：……也像我刚才画的巨鸟?

Bessmert: The way he is speaking is interesting, rhythmic, like singing. It would be great if there was some music to accompany him. Something is missing in his story without the music.
别斯米尔：他说话的方式和语调很有韵律感，像是在唱歌。只可惜没有伴奏，清唱似乎令这些歌词失去了一些味道。

Bessmert: If he could ...
别斯米尔：如果他能——

Before Bessmert can finish speaking, the red paper instantly ignites in the hands of the Storyteller, and before touching his fingers, it becomes ashes and falls onto the stone platform.
别斯米尔话音未落，红色的纸张瞬间在灰衣男子手中自燃，又于触到手指之前尽数化为灰烬，簌簌落到石台之上。

The little boy standing beside him stands on his tiptoes, quickly taking the initiative to sweep the ashes into the charcoal pot below.
一旁侍立的小童则登时踮起脚来，利落地接手，将那些灰烬扫进了下方的炭盆中。

Storyteller: Among the Five Elements, Mièméng belongs to the Fire. That's why people set fire in spring to drive away misfortunes. Speaking of ...
说书先生：灭蒙属火，庭燎燃春，此即为喻。而话又说回——

Yenisei's attention is diverted. She witnesses the child's movements, but doesn't yet understand the meaning behind them, choosing to stare ahead until a crackling sound explodes behind her.
小叶尼塞的注意力被转移了。她目睹小童那一切动作，却不明白其中的含义，只是注视，直到噼啪的爆炸声在身后响起。

Bessmert: What is this noise?
别斯米尔：这是——什么声音——?

It seems no one cares about the noise of the cracker. Only Jiǔ Niángzǐ, who had previously worked so hard to restore order to the bustling city, turns around with the two of them.
然而几乎身边所有人都对这动静见怪不怪，以至于此时与两人一同回过头去的，只有先前在闹市中力挽狂澜的曲娘。

As she turns around, she seems to remember something and shows a remorseful look.
她回头时，一种突然记起早前遗忘之事的懊恼神色，也逐渐浮现在她脸上。

Jiu Niangzi: The cracker ... Shoot. I almost forgot!
曲娘：庭燎爆竿……糟了。天哪，我差点忘了正事！

Jiu Niangzi: Sorry, excuse me! Please let me go out ...
曲娘：抱歉、抱歉！请让开一下，我得出去——

Citizen II: You won't listen to the rest? It's still early. Oh, are you going back to the tavern to make our drinks?
城中居民 II：这就不继续听啦？时辰还早着呢，急着回去酿酒吗？

Jiu Niangzi: Not drinks, but other stuff! Oh, and "drinks on the house" tomorrow!
曲娘：不是酿酒，但也还有事呢……明天，明天一定请你们喝酒！

Everyone chuckles warmly, making way for Jiǔ Niángzǐ. Yenisei holds onto Bessmert to prevent her from falling behind.
人们低声调笑着，为曲娘让开一条小道来。小叶尼塞也牵住别斯米尔，以防跟过去时，她落在了身后。

This time, they follow her without incident. Despite the strangers' otherwise eye-catching hair, everyone's attention seems focused intently on the Storyteller telling the legend.
她们这回很轻易地跟上去了。无人对发色醒目的异乡人投以别样注视，所有人的注意力都集中在这位讲述传奇的“歌唱家”身上。

6#1
6#1

异乡人关怀
Treat Them Right NS-10

Not far away, Jiǔ Niángzǐ can be seen stopping near the post where the animals were tied, vaguely moving as if whispering something to them.
不远处，能大致瞧见曲娘在先前拴动物的桩子前停了下来，仿佛对它们私语着什么。

Jiu Niangzi: Um, can you understand me?
曲娘：嗯，你们能听懂我说的话吗……？

Jiu Niangzi: Can you tell me where you are from?
曲娘：可不可以告诉我，你们是从哪里来的？

Yenisei: Hello ...
小叶尼塞：请问……

Yenisei waits for a moment before walking forward and attempting to pat her shoulder.
小叶尼塞等待了片刻才走上前去，试着拍了拍她的肩膀。

The girl turns around to reveal her young and eager face.
而后少女回过头来，展露一副年轻而热切的面庞。

Jiu Niangzi: Hmm? What's wrong? I don't know you. Have we met before?
曲娘：咦？怎么啦？娘子面生，我们从前见过吗？

Yenisei: I don't think so. We just arrived here.
小叶尼塞：……应该没有。我们才到城里。

Jiu Niangzi: Really? Oh, welcome to Pèi City!
曲娘：真的吗？天哪，欢迎你们来沛城玩！

Yenisei cannot help but hold her eyes on the bundled hemp rope the girl is holding in her hand, and the many animals now tied at the end of it.
小叶尼塞没忍住，用余光看了眼这女孩手里拽住的一把麻绳，和麻绳尽头的许多动物。

Jiǔ Niángzǐ blinks, then blinks again, as though realizing what the other girl is staring at.
被称作“曲娘”的女孩眨眼，又眨眼，似乎终于发现了对方正在看着什么。

A blush quickly rises to her cheeks like two sunset clouds.
红晕很快像两朵火烧云一样浮上她的脸颊。

Jiu Niangzi: Oh ... Y-you were on the street, weren't you?
曲娘：……啊，你们……你们刚才也在街上吗?

Jiu Niangzi: I am so sorry. I didn't mean to make such a scene there. I promise, it was just an accident!
曲娘：真不好意思……一来就让你们看见这种混乱的情况。我保证，这只是一场意外！

Bessmert: I can imagine. You reacted quickly and saved us from more trouble.
别斯米尔：可以想象的意外。您的反应很及时，避免了一场灾难的发生。

Jiu Niangzi: No, no, no, it was my responsibility. And the people on the street also gave me a hand there!
曲娘：没有没有，都是我应该做的。而且大家也帮了很多忙。

Jiu Niangzi: How can I help you? Please feel free to let me know.
曲娘：你们找我是有什么事情吗？如果有什么能帮上忙的，请尽管告诉我。

She seems to be a warm-hearted type.
看来是一位相当好说话的姑娘。

Yenisei: Here's the case: The people call you Jiǔ Niángzǐ, and you work in the Zhící, right?
小叶尼塞：是这样的。我先前听见他们叫你“曲娘”，你是曲娘，在职祠工作，是吗?

Jiu Niangzi: Ng, ng. Yes!
曲娘：嗯，是的！

Yenisei: Lǐzhèng told us to find you, and we happened to hear your conversation on the street.
小叶尼塞：我们从里正那里过来，之前恰好听见了你们在街上的对话……

Yenisei: So did the feather man come here today?
小叶尼塞：请问羽人今日来过职祠了吗?

Jiu Niangzi: Feather man? You mean the Xiángruì out of the city? Um, I heard that he had been here. As for today, I have no idea.
曲娘：羽人？你说城外那位“祥瑞”？唔，我听说他以前好像来过，今天就不知道了。

Yenisei: What about the animals in the fence? Any new ones?
小叶尼塞：……那职祠有没有今天才新送到的动物?

Jiu Niangzi: I-I'm not sure about that either. When I arrived at the Zhící this morning, there were already many Festive Animals in the fence.
曲娘：这，我也不清楚……今天我到职祠点卯的时候，围栏里就已经有很多年节动物了。

Jiu Niangzi: They're getting more and more ... How weird is that!
曲娘：真奇怪啊，为什么越来越多了呢……

Jiǔ Niángzǐ mutters inaudibly before turning around, pointing out the culprits who caused her so much trouble earlier with her index finger.
曲娘嘟囔着转过身去，以食指将先前闹事的那些罪魁祸首指给两人瞧。

Yenisei inspects the creatures briefly but doesn't seem to notice any difference. It seems to be a show for common livestock, where various cattle, sheep, and horses might compete to show their worth.
小叶尼塞顺眼望去，的确没看出来什么不同。这里几乎是一个常见牲畜的博览会，各种牛羊马都争相露出个脸来。

Jiu Niangzi: See, they all look alike. I can't tell which of them were brought here today. Counting is troublesome as well. I always think, "where am I?"
曲娘：你看，它们都长得差不多，我不知道哪些是今天送到的。清点的时候也很麻烦，经常忘记自己刚才数到哪里了。

Jiu Niangzi: If only I could read and write. You write them down, then you won't miscount.
曲娘：如果我识字就好了。能写下来，就不会算错。

Yenisei: Our teammates have been turned into striped horses, like these.
小叶尼塞：……我们的同伴就变成了这种有斑纹的马。

Yenisei: Actually, we are a team of merchants. When we reached the outskirts of the city, our teammates were turned into horses and brought away by a giant bird.
小叶尼塞：是这样的，我们原本是一支商队，走到城外的时候，同伴被变成了马，还被一只巨鸟带走了。

Yenisei: Lǐzhèng said that bird was probably the feather man they've been looking for, and he appeared around the Zhící once.
小叶尼塞：里正告诉我们，那只巨鸟很可能就是他们正在追寻的羽人，而他曾经在职祠附近出没过。

Yenisei: That's why we are here to ask for help.
小叶尼塞：所以，我们想来职祠寻求帮助。

Jiu Niangzi: They're-They're not horses, I suppose.
曲娘：它们……它们应该不是马。

Jiǔ Niángzǐ seems hesitant to say anything further.
曲娘似乎有些欲言又止。

Jiu Niangzi: But-but how is that possible? Are you saying that the feather man can turn people into ... into horses ...?
曲娘：但是——怎么可能呢？你们的意思好像是说，羽人能把人变成……变成马？

Jiu Niangzi: I don't understand. How did he get this power? Is it because he is the Xiángruì?
曲娘：我不明白。难道因为他是“祥瑞”，就会有这样的能力吗？

Upon hearing the word "Xiángruì" again, Bessmert's interest is immediately captured.
再次听到“祥瑞”这个词，别斯米尔燃起了兴趣。

Bessmert: We've also heard about the Xiángruì from the Storyteller. It does sound like some kind of local guardian.
别斯米尔：我们刚刚也在说书先生那儿听到了关于“祥瑞”的故事，“祥瑞”听起来确实很像具有地域特征的保护神。

Jiu Niangzi: Guardian? Is it the Gods of Shètí we're talking about?
曲娘：什么神？我只知道摄提神。

Bessmert: Oh, yes, the Gods of Shètí. These are the gods you serve.
别斯米尔：噢。是的，摄提神。这应该才是你们供奉的东西。

Bessmert: I guess Xiángruì is closer to a local legend, like a reputed arcanist in this area. The use of arcane skills seems common here. Perhaps there are also many arcanists around.
别斯米尔：我猜“祥瑞”应该更类似一种本地的信仰，传奇的神秘学家之类的。这里神秘术的使用听起来相当常见，或许神秘学家也一样。

Bessmert: But, could you please tell us more about the Gods of Shètí?
别斯米尔： 不过，既然说到这里，您能告诉我，摄提神究竟是什么吗?

Jiu Niangzi: There are 12 ... or 13 of them, I guess? That's all I know. I can't read most of their names.
曲娘： 我只知道摄提神有十二……还是十三位，的样子？但那些名字，很多我都不认识。

Jiu Niangzi: Oh, but I know this year is the year of Zhíxú! We will bring lots of Festive Animals to the broken bridge to worship It.
曲娘： 哦，我知道今年是摄提神执徐的生辰年！我们会请很多的年节动物去断桥供奉祂。

Jiu Niangzi: The Fortune Walk and Bridge Leap are the most fun parts! We go to the broken bridge on the cliff with the animals, count our steps, and swing our bodies, like dancing. And at last, we will try to jump over it!
曲娘： 走吉和跃桥是最有趣的。我们会带着年节动物去到悬崖上的断桥前，一起数着步数摆动身子，像跳舞一样，最后再尝试跳过去——

Yenisei: Jump over a broken bridge on the cliff? It sounds dangerous and quite ... familiar.
小叶尼塞： 跳过悬崖上的断桥？这听起来不仅危险，而且还相当的……耳熟。

Bessmert knows exactly what Yenisei is hinting at. The familiar rule of "Ask and Acquire" resurfaces in their minds, but no one attempts to ask it out loud.
别斯米尔知道小叶尼塞在暗示什么。传闻中“所求必应”的规则不约而同浮现在她们的脑海里，但没有一个人真的问出声来。

So that Jiǔ Niángzǐ's explanation interrupts their thoughts with perfect timing.
而曲娘的解释也及时打断了她们的联想。

Jiu Niangzi: No, no, no, we can't do that. No one has even done that! Even the goats can't do that, let alone humans.
曲娘： 不不不，跳不过去的！还没听说有谁能跳过去呢，连最厉害的山羊都跳不过去，更别说人了。

Jiu Niangzi: We'll also cast arcane skills as safety measures to protect anyone from falling.
曲娘： 我们还会提前用神秘术进行保护，防止真的有人或者动物掉下去。

Jiu Niangzi: The valley is deeeep down there. Once you fall down, you're not coming back.
曲娘： 山谷很深。掉下去，就再也回不来了。

Bessmert: Intriguing. And who's in charge of the safety measures, may I ask?
别斯米尔： 真有意思。那些提前的神秘术设置，都是由什么人负责的?

Jiu Niangzi: The staff in the Zhící. It's the place to manage arcane affairs in the Pèi City.
曲娘： 嗯，就是职祠负责的。职祠是负责管理沛城神秘术事务的地方哦。

Jiu Niangzi: But not me ... I'm new here, filling in for the former Zhílǐ after she went back to her hometown.
曲娘： 不过，我并不负责那些……我只是新来的，在上任执礼回乡后，暂时兼任这个工作而已。

Jiu Niangzi: They told me to take care of Zhící for a couple of days. That's good enough for me!
曲娘： 他们跟我说，我只需要这几天把职祠照看好就可以了！

Her eagerness to be able to help is clear.
她似乎对能帮上忙感到很高兴。

Yenisei: So, simply put, you're a doorkeeper?
小叶尼塞： 所以简单来说，您是看门的。

The barb of her conclusion makes Jiǔ Niángzǐ fluster into a red blush.
预料不到的结论令曲娘惊讶地涨红了脸。

Jiu Niangzi: I-I'm not-I'm not just keeping the door safe! I do stuff too!
曲娘： 我——我不是——我不站在门口呀。我也有其他事要做的。

Jiu Niangzi: Like, um, take good care of those startled by the fire crackers! There is a kind of firecracker enhanced by arcane skill. It can make a huuuge sound! Much more louder than what you heard in the tea house!
曲娘：比如，嗯，我还要安抚那些被爆竿声音吓到的人，有一种被神秘术加强过的爆竿，声音很大的！比刚才茶馆外面的动静，都还要大很多……

Bessmert: Please forgive her. She didn't mean to hurt your feelings. We speak bluntly in the North.
别斯米尔：请您原谅，她并不是对您有恶意，只是我们来自北方，说话都会直率一些。

Jiu Niangzi: Oh, it's alright. I can tell she's a bit anxious.
曲娘：没关系，没关系。我能感觉到，她只是有点着急。

Jiu Niangzi: But it's not getting us anywhere. Like, um, pigs can't learn how to climb in a day ...
曲娘：但现在着急也没用呀。就像，呃，野猪上树？也不是说会就会的……

Yenisei: ...
小叶尼塞：……

Jiu Niangzi: Or, let's think another way. Can you recognize your teammates from these horses?
曲娘：或者，你们能从这些马里面，认出来哪些是你们的同伴吗？

Jiu Niangzi: Let me see, there are one, two, three ... three striped horses. Come see for yourself.
曲娘：我看看，这里有一、二、三……三只“斑纹马”。来，你们也瞧瞧。

Yenisei: I can't. There was little time for me to memorize the difference. Besides, even if they are my teammates, two of them are still missing.
小叶尼塞：……我认不出来，当时太匆忙了，我不记得样貌的差别。而且，即使这几只都是，也还差了两只。

Jiu Niangzi: More than three teammates?
曲娘：你们的同伴比三个还多？

Jiu Niangzi: When three plus two ...
曲娘：三加二——

Jiǔ Niángzǐ counts out the numbers on her fingers, calculating with great care.
曲娘掰着指头就要仔细算来。

Bessmert: How about we wait and see what Lǐzhèng has found out?
别斯米尔：……这样吧，我们先等等里正那边的消息。

Bessmert: That's right, child, didn't Lǐzhèng leave us with a letter?
别斯米尔：对了，小叶尼塞，里正不是给了我们一封书信么？

Yenisei: Oh, right. I almost forgot. Please read this, Ms. Jiǔ Niángzǐ. It may have clues about the feather man.
小叶尼塞：噢，是的，我差点忘记了……来，曲娘小姐，请你看看这个。也许里面有关于羽人的线索。

She produces the letter, offering it to the girl.
她掏出那张信函。

Jiǔ Niángzǐ opens it in front of them without a moment's hesitation, but all Yenisei can see on it are several images.
曲娘接过后，毫不防备地当面打开，但小叶尼塞只看见几枚图画留在上面。

Jiu Niangzi: Um ...
曲娘：唔……

Jiu Niangzi: Make the fence taller ... Get off work earlier and ... go back to the tavern?
曲娘：加高围栏……早些放班……回酒坊……？

Jiu Niangzi: What is he trying to say?
曲娘：什么跟什么呀。

Jiu Niangzi: What do these have to do with the feather man?
曲娘：这些都跟羽人有什么关系？

Yenisei: Hmm?
小叶尼塞：嗯？

Bessmert: ...
别斯米尔：……

Jiǔ Niángzǐ mutters to herself as she stares at the pictures on the letter, before frowning and smoothing it out. She clumsily folds it and clips it to her waist.
曲娘对着满是图画的信件自言自语，皱眉又舒展，半晌才把它乱七八糟地叠好，夹到腰绳上。

Jiu Niangzi: Well, don't worry! I'll pay close attention to the new horses for you!
曲娘：别担心，这几天我会帮你们多多留意新来的马的！

Jiu Niangzi: If there's any good news, I'll ask Lǐzhèng to tell you.
曲娘：一旦有什么好消息，里正一定会转告你们。

Bessmert: You're so kind. But we just got here and haven't decided where to stay for the night. How are we going to keep Lǐzhèng informed once we find a place to rest?
别斯米尔：谢谢您的好意。不过，我们今日才入城，还没有找到住的地方。要怎么才能让里正知道我们在哪里呢？

Jiu Niangzi: Oh ... I see ...
曲娘：啊，这样啊……

An answer leaps to her mind, bursting through and out at the same time.
她很快便想到了答案。

Jiu Niangzi: How about staying in my tavern? I forgot to tell you that I'm the owner of a tavern.
曲娘：对，你们可以住在我的酒坊里！刚才忘了和你们介绍了，我正在经营一家酒坊。

Jiu Niangzi: And I'm doing it well!
曲娘：而且……生意还挺不错的。

She laughs, as though just the saying of it might render it true.
曲娘笑了起来，似乎想到这个，便能令她感到安心。

Jiu Niangzi: It is located in the merchants hub, two streets away from the Zhící. Lǐzhèng will know your whereabouts since he's in charge of the hub.
曲娘：酒坊就在离职祠两坊距离的金市中，里正会知道的。

Jiu Niangzi: I'll take you back to the tavern, also escort these animals back to the Zhící. You can check out other animals there as well!
曲娘：我还可以顺路把这些家伙都送回职祠。你们也去看一看其他的年节动物吧！

Yenisei: Good idea.
小叶尼塞：我赞成。

Bessmert: That'd be great. Saves us from all the trouble sleeping on the streets.
别斯米尔：这太好了，也不必在外面摸索到天黑了。

Jiu Niangzi: Let's go then. Oh, the street looks beautiful later in the night. You can't miss the golden lanterns and bonfires lit on Dùshuò Festival! They light up the sky and the street as if it's daytime.
曲娘：是呀。不过等晚些入夜了，街市上会更好看。度朔节有金灯和庭燎，照得天上和地上都亮堂堂。

Jiu Niangzi: Everything seems brighter at night.
曲娘：在晚上，感觉什么都是特别亮的。

6#1
6#1

廊下夜话
Night Talk NS-11

A breathtaking number of animals lie within the Zhící—a fact that only hinders their efforts to find their companions.
职祠中的动物多得令人眼花缭乱，对她们确认同伴并无帮助。

After weighing their options, they decide to follow Jiǔ Niángzǐ and settle in at the tavern first. The weary travelers are more than eager to relieve their fatigue after journeying non-stop for so long.
权衡之下，两人决定先跟随曲娘到酒坊中落脚，似乎终于得以卸下急行数日的疲惫。

And they've more than earned it, because strange things have indeed happened to them, non-stop for several days.
前提是没有那么多怪异的事情接连发生。

Yard, Tavern
酒坊院中

Yenisei: Madam ...
小叶尼塞：女士……

Yenisei: What do you think about Jiǔ Niángzǐ's words? Could that be "Ask and Acquire"?
小叶尼塞：您觉得白天曲娘说的，有可能是“所求必应”吗?

Bessmert: Jumping over a broken bridge is like "jumping over a canyon or climbing over a mountain." It's a condition that cannot be met, like those merchants said.
别斯米尔：跃过断桥就像跃过悬崖，攀爬高山，就像商人们说的那样，一个不可能达成的条件。

Yenisei: An inevitable price?
小叶尼塞：一种绝对的代价?

Both of them fall silent, lost in thought.
两人都因为陷入思索而沉默。

However, Bessmert's doubts do not seem to have fallen on deaf ears, as Jiǔ Niángzǐ responds while walking out from the tavern.
别斯米尔的疑问却没有因此落在地上，被正从酒坊里走出来的曲娘轻轻拾起。

Jiu Niangzi: Are you talking about the broken bridge outside the city?
曲娘：——你们是在说城外的断桥吗?

Jiu Niangzi: I'm so sorry. The chairs in the lobby have not been cleaned yet. Please take a seat here, just for now.
曲娘：不好意思，大堂里的座椅都还没擦洗，要委屈你们先坐在这里……

Bessmert: Oh, don't worry about it. Thank you for letting us stay here.
别斯米尔：哦，没关系，谢谢您的收留。

Bessmert: As for the broken bridge we talked about ... can you tell me more about it?
别斯米尔：关于我们刚才说的那座断桥……您知道些什么吗?

Jiu Niangzi: Hmm, when I first got here, the bridge was already broken.
曲娘：断桥嘛，反正在我到城里的时候，就已经断掉很久了。

Jiu Niangzi: Beneath that is a deeeep canyon. Across that canyon stands the Yuān Temple. You can't see it from the other side of the bridge. It's surrounded by fog. So, I'm not sure if there really is a temple there or not.
曲娘：在它下面是高高的悬崖，对面是一个叫渊庙的地方，但被雾气遮盖了。所以我也不知道那个庙是不是真的存在。

Yenisei: The Yuān Temple ...
小叶尼塞：渊庙……

Jiu Niangzi: They said you can talk to Zhíxú in the Yuān Temple. Be faithful and ask It. It will answer you.
曲娘：据说在渊庙里，你能和执徐对话。有什么问题，你虔诚地问祂，祂就会回答。

Jiu Niangzi: What did they call this? "The Divination," I think? They also said that the fog was strange. You can't stay there for long, or you'll pass out or get overexcited ... Well, I haven't seen such things so far.
曲娘：他们管这叫什么来着？好像是“问卜”？而且据说那里的雾气有些奇异，不能久留，否则会让人昏迷，或者变得过于兴奋……我是没有见过的。

Bessmert: ...!
别斯米尔：……！

Jiu Niangzi: But even so, people of that time still rushed there and prayed. Doesn't it mean that The Divination is for real? After the bridge was broken, no one's wish was ever granted.
曲娘：就算会这样，以前的人们都还是会去渊庙，就说明问卜确实有效呀。在桥被洪水冲断之后，可就再也没有这样的好事了。

Bessmert: Seems odd. There was already a bridge in the first place. Why wouldn't people rebuild it in all these years?
别斯米尔：这是有些奇怪。按理说，如果最开始这座桥能修建起来，那就没有道理不能重建。

Jiu Niangzi: I can answer this one! The river dried out. People couldn't swim across, and the cliffs between the mountains were too dangerous to jump over.
曲娘：这个我知道！是因为水变少了，人们不能游过去到对岸，也没办法跳过去，因为山和山之间的悬崖很高，很危险。

Jiu Niangzi: But, if one can be the new Xiángruì, the problem will be solved.
曲娘：人跳不过去，不过，如果能成为新的“祥瑞”，或许就能跳过去了。

Jiu Niangzi: The Xiángruìs are awesome! They protect the city, help the people ... There's nothing they can't do ...
曲娘：它们是很厉害的，八面威风，还能守护一方，为众人排忧解难，什么事情都能做到……

As she speaks, she sinks into her own personal contemplation.
说着说着，她自顾自地陷入了低落的沉思。

Yenisei: Never mind. We'll check the striped horses in the Zhící again tomorrow.
小叶尼塞：没关系。明天，明天我们再去职祠看看那些斑纹马。

Jiu Niangzi: Alright, I'll go with you! It's time to rest now. I got the rooms cleaned for you upstairs.
曲娘：嗯，我和你们一起去！现在就先歇息吧，我在楼上收拾出了房间。

Jiu Niangzi: And here, take the liquor with you. They can help you sleep tight!
曲娘：这里呢，还有助眠的浊酒，能帮你们睡个好觉——

Jiu Niangzi: You got to have some.
曲娘：来一些吧。

Yenisei: Sorry, Ms. Jiǔ Niángzǐ. I don't drink, neither does Madam Bessmert.
小叶尼塞：抱歉，曲娘小姐，我不喝酒……别斯米尔女士也不喝酒。

Jiu Niangzi: Why did you call me "Ms." twice?
曲娘：为什么要叫我“小姐小姐”?

Jiu Niangzi: Um, if you want some water, wait a second, please. The water jars are on the other side of the yard. I'll get it for you.
曲娘：唔，水的话，要等一下。水缸在院子另一头，我去打。

Yenisei: Oh, I can do it myself. You don't have to ...
小叶尼塞：啊。那我自己去，不用麻烦你——

Jiu Niangzi: It's fine. There is no light near the jar. You need to cross a stream. I'm afraid you might get lost ...
曲娘：晚上水缸那边没有点灯，还要过一条小溪，我怕你找不着地方——

Yenisei: Thank you.
小叶尼塞：……好的。

Once the girl's voice and figure are obscured by the night, Yenisei turns to look at Bessmert.
在少女的声音与身形都被黑夜隐没之后，小叶尼塞转头望向年长者。

She seems puzzled, or perhaps, just tired.
似乎疑惑，又似乎只是单纯的疲倦。

Yenisei: There were so many different striped horses in the Zhící. I couldn't recognize them at all.
小叶尼塞：今天在职祠看到的那些斑纹马，花色众多，完全难以分辨……

Yenisei: We are going to get up early tomorrow. Please have some water and go to bed.
小叶尼塞：明天还要早起，您喝些水再去休息吧。

Bessmert: I'm not thirsty, thank you. But I do feel like some rest.
别斯米尔：其实我不渴，只是累了。

Yenisei: Okay. I'll take you to the room.
小叶尼塞：……好。那我扶您去休息。

The girl returns from fetching water, only to find Yenisei alone in the hallway.
少女打水归来，却只在廊下找到另一名少女。

Looking around and not seeing Bessmert, she walks over and naturally sits where Bessmert sat earlier.
四处张望无果，她走过去，自然坐到先前年长女子坐过的地方。

Jiu Niangzi: I didn't see you from there. I thought you went to sleep.
曲娘：远远的，我瞧你们不见，还以为都歇去了呢。

Yenisei: Oh, sorry. Madam Bessmert is tired, so ...
小叶尼塞：……啊，抱歉。别斯米尔女士太累了，所以……

Yenisei: Thank you for helping us.
小叶尼塞：谢谢你帮助我们。

Jiu Niangzi: Don't bother. Here's the water.
曲娘：这些话就不必说啦。喏，这是你要的水。

As she takes up the ceramic cup, Yenisei is slightly surprised.
接过那个陶土材质的杯子时，小叶尼塞有些微的惊讶。

In her mind, a material like this is one of two extremes—crudeness and finesse, one of handmade rough bowls used by the populace, and the latter of delicate treasures owned only by the rich nobles ...
在她的印象中，这种材质一般只与粗糙和精致两种极端关联，前者是一些农家手制的碗盆，后者是贵族专用的珍品——

Yet this cup is a combination of the two extremes—it's used by an ordinary tavern owner, but it is marked by a refined, tasteful aesthetic.
总之都不是眼前这个显然供平民日常使用，还带着良好审美和品味的成熟工艺制品。

Yenisei: ...
小叶尼塞：……

She rubs the side of the cup with her fingers, gently brushing across the painted patterns, as if feeling a fine porcelain vase.
她用手指摩挲杯壁，轻轻擦过那些彩绘的纹路，像感受一枚复活节瓷胎。

Yenisei: The cup ...
小叶尼塞：这个杯子……

Jiu Niangzi: What's wrong?
曲娘：怎么啦?

Yenisei: It looks expensive.
小叶尼塞：它看起来很昂贵。

Jiu Niangzi: It's a gift I received. I don't know how much it costs, but it's delicate, isn't it?
曲娘：啊，这是别人给我的。我不知道它贵不贵，但它很漂亮，是吧。

Yenisei: Yes, it is delicate.
小叶尼塞：是的，它很漂亮。

Yenisei feels compelled to rub the surface of the ceramic cup again, as though she cannot bear to part from it, and loses herself in thought.
小叶尼塞反复摩挲着陶杯的表面，似乎对这触感爱不释手，又似乎若有所思。

Jiu Niangzi: The pattern is a Lùshǔ, also a kind of Xiángruì.
曲娘：上面画的是鹿蜀，一种祥瑞。

Jiu Niangzi: See? It's majestic. The tail is like the sunset clouds. I really like it. I hope you do too.
曲娘：你看，它好雄伟的，尾鬃就像傍晚的云霞一样……我很喜欢它，也希望你会喜欢。

Yenisei: Majestic indeed. And it looks a bit like those striped horses in the Zhící. Both of them are similar to horses.
小叶尼塞：是很威风。仔细看，它和职祠里那些斑纹马还有点相近，或许因为都是马一样的动物吧。

Jiu Niangzi: Hmm ... but people still think they are horses. Don't they?
曲娘：嗯……但大家还是觉得它们是马，不是吗?

Yenisei: Sure, they do. I think this species is native to Pèi City. It's an interesting discovery and will help enrich our travel notes.
小叶尼塞：当然了，我想，它们应该是沛城特有的物种。这很有意思，对我们的风物记录很有帮助。

Jiǔ Niángzǐ lowers her head to look at the cup in her own hand. Yenisei can smell a fermented aroma emanating from within, like kvass, but without the sweet aroma of wheat.
曲娘低头看向她自己手里的杯子。小叶尼塞能够闻到一股发酵的香气从里面散发，就像格瓦斯，却并没有属于小麦的香甜气息。

Jiu Niangzi: She is in bed now. I can only drink it for her.
曲娘：她去睡了，那这杯就只好归我啦。

Yenisei: Your drink smells good. Is this the liquor that helps one sleep tight?
小叶尼塞：你的杯子里很香。这个，就是你说的助眠酒吗?

Jiu Niangzi: Not exactly. It's just unfiltered liquor.
曲娘：不是哦，这就是普通的浊酒。

Yenisei: Sounds like you have a lot of different kinds of liquor here.
小叶尼塞：听起来在你们这里酒有很多的分类。

Jiu Niangzi: Sure, we do. There are a lot of different liquors. The unfiltered ones, the clear ones, the ones made of herbs, the fine ones ... and on and on. Bedtime liquor is made of herbs with Spine Date Seeds.
曲娘：当然呀。酒有很多不同的，有浊酒、清酒、药酒、露酒……好多好多。助眠酒就是一种加了酸枣仁的药酒。

Yenisei: I thought liquor was just liquor. At least there aren't so many types in my hometown.
小叶尼塞：我还以为酒就只是酒而已。至少，在我们那里……没有这么多的分别。

Jiu Niangzi: Well, to be honest, I too have no idea why they are still "liquor," though they have different names.
曲娘：好吧，其实我也不明白，为什么酒有这么多不同的名字，却都还是酒。

Jiu Niangzi: If the color is the standard to classify them, then what am I when I'm wearing different colored clothes? Am I not Jiǔ Niángzǐ anymore?
曲娘：如果是因为它们颜色不同，那我换了一件颜色不一样的衣服，我就不叫曲娘了吗?

Yenisei: Haha.
小叶尼塞：……哈哈。

Shocked, Yenisei cannot help but break into a laugh.
小叶尼塞一愣，忍不住发笑起来。

Seeing the other girl smile, Jiǔ Niángzǐ's eyes begin to sparkle. She nods and decides to go one step further and express her thoughts.
看到对方露出了笑容，曲娘眼睛也变得闪闪发亮。她点点头，决定更进一步地说出自己的想法。

Jiu Niangzi: That is to say, if your teammates are turned into horses or other animals in different colors, are they not your teammates anymore?
曲娘：——没错。如果你的同伴变成了马，或者别的什么颜色的动物，那就不是你的同伴了吗?

Yenisei: They are, of course ...
小叶尼塞：不是那样的，他们当然……

Yenisei stops talking. This childish conversation might have caused her to erupt with laughter, but the weight of the situation is still acute, and her worries swell deep within her.
小叶尼塞止住了话头。这样孩子气的对话能让她短暂地笑出声来，但她仍然清醒着，清醒地感受到内心的忧虑。

The chirping of birds in the cold night gently blankets the sound of her anxious breathing.
寒夜的鸟鸣轻易盖过了呼吸声。

Yenisei: I'm worried, actually.
小叶尼塞：其实我很担心。

Yenisei: Well, maybe not just worried. I don't know.
小叶尼塞：……或者说不仅仅是担忧，我不知道。

Jiu Niangzi: Looks like you really miss your teammates.
曲娘：嗯，你看起来，真的很想念你的同伴。

Yenisei: "Miss" them?
小叶尼塞：“想念”?

Yenisei: I ... I won't use this word to describe my feeling.
小叶尼塞：我……不会这样描述这种心情。

Yenisei: All I'm thinking is, they were turned into animals because I gave them the wrong direction.
小叶尼塞：我只是认为，他们会被变成动物，都是由于我指错了方向。

Yenisei: What if ... What if they can't turn back to who they really are ...
小叶尼塞：如果——如果他们再也变不回来了，那……

The frankness of her own inquiry unmasks the long unease Yenisei had been harboring since entering this strange city.
这叩问将小叶尼塞自进入这座奇异城市以来的不安，全部表露无遗。

After speaking, she holds her breath and controls the impulse to turn back and look toward Bessmert. For a moment she is no longer even sure of where she is.
说完，她就屏住呼吸，控制回头去看别斯米尔所在方向的冲动。话语吐露后有一瞬间，她甚至不确定自己身在何处。

Jiu Niangzi: But I don't think that will happen! Things won't get any worse.
曲娘：唔。我觉得，不会这样的，事情一定不会变得更糟糕。

Yenisei: Hmm?
小叶尼塞：嗯?

Jiu Niangzi: There must be a way. I promise!
曲娘：——我觉得，一定会有办法的!

Jiu Niangzi: Like the clouds turn colorful, pool water gets sweet like liquor ... There are many signs of auspiciousness. They just need time.
曲娘：就像天空出现彩色的云朵，池水变得如醇酒般甘美一样……天地之间，还有许多吉祥的征兆没有显现。

Jiu Niangzi: Think about it, what if the story about the Yuān Temple is real? Maybe, maybe there will be another way for you to recognize your teammates.
曲娘：你想想，也许渊庙是真的呢？也许，也许会有别的办法，让你能认出你的同伴……

Jiu Niangzi: Even if the feather man is not a Xiángruì, there are other Xiángruìs in the city.
曲娘：而且，就算羽人不是祥瑞，这城里却还有别的祥瑞。

Jiu Niangzi: All in all ...
曲娘：总之——

Jiǔ Niángzǐ racks her brain to find another way to persuade Yenisei, but is stopped by the other girl before she can begin.
曲娘试图找到更多的角度来劝说小叶尼塞，却被对方打住。

Despite the cultural differences between the two of them, Yenisei feels a surge of warmth from her brief trembling words.
尽管双方文化并不相通，但小叶尼塞已从她战栗、短促的话语中感受到一股热流。

Yenisei: Thank you, Ms. ... No, Jiǔ Niángzǐ.
小叶尼塞：……谢谢你，曲娘小姐……曲娘。

Yenisei: I see what you mean. I really do.
小叶尼塞：我明白，我明白。

Yenisei takes a deep breath and exhales both calm emotions and words together, so that like a light white smoke they soon drift away.
小叶尼塞深吸一口气，然后让松动的心情与话语一同呼出，变成一股白烟飘散。

Yenisei: Thank you.
小叶尼塞：谢谢你。

Jiu Niangzi: It's nothing! I will definitely help you!
曲娘：这有什么！我一定会帮你们的！

Jiu Niangzi: Oh, here are some other Spine Date seeds. Drink the water, and I'll go make you a cup of tea with the seeds. It also helps you sleep ...
曲娘：哦，我口袋里还有一些干酸枣仁。你快把水喝掉，我去给你泡酸枣水，也有助眠效果——

Jiǔ Niángzǐ shoots up to immediately rummage around in the bag beside her as she urges Yenisei to drain what is left in her cup.
曲娘忙忙碌碌地站起来，在身侧的袋子里不停往外掏着什么，一边催促着小叶尼塞赶快喝掉手中的水。

Yenisei drinks down all of the cold, sweet water and hands the still-compelling cup back to her ...
小叶尼塞于是饮尽了冰凉但甘甜的清水，将漂亮杯子递还——

She then watches Jiǔ Niángzǐ step onto the porch and run back into the hall at a trot.
然后注视曲娘踩上门廊，小步跑着回到大厅里去了。

Yenisei: *exhales*
小叶尼塞：……呼……

She takes a long breath and turns to look at the arid night sky.
她长舒一口气，回头望向干燥的夜空。

It seems even in a strange city like this, she can enjoy the same bright moonlight as the steppes.
即使陌生的城市也与草原享有同一片月色。

6#ı
6#1

倾杯舞
Dancing Dolls NS-12

The curtain of night has already fallen, but even after drinking another cup of tea promised to induce drowsiness, Yenisei finds that sleep evades her.
夜幕早已沉沉地降下，即使喝下了据说有助眠功效的茶水，小叶尼塞也始终没能睡着。

In theory, someone so heavily fatigued, should fall fast asleep the very moment the opportunity presents itself. But not for her.
按理说，常人在她们先前那样累重的疲倦之下，得到机会便迅速入睡，几乎是一种本能。可对她来说却并非如此。

On the contrary, her mind, so sick with worries, seems to run faster now than ever in the stillness of night.
相反，她满怀心事，在黑暗中不需费力就保持着清醒。

Yenisei: ...
小叶尼塞：……

Bessmert: ...
别斯米尔：……

Yenisei: *sighs*
小叶尼塞：呼……

She stands up, steps away from the couch, and treads lightly down the stairs.
她起身，离开榻上，轻手轻脚地走向楼下。

Unwelcome in even her own dreams, she wanders around without direction.
因为连梦境也不收留，除了游荡之外，她无处可去。

Yenisei: The yard ... Go downstairs and through the main hall ...
小叶尼塞：花园在……下楼后，穿过主厅……

Groping around for the railing in the darkness, she walks up and then down the steps.
她在黑暗中摸索着栏杆，踩上下楼的阶梯。

One step, another step ... As she descends, a rustling sound envelops her in the darkness, like an indelible point that demands her whole focus.
一级，一级。随她向下的，还有悉窣的响动，如同挥之不去的清醒一样在黑夜里包裹了她。

Yenisei: Hmm? What's that sound ...
小叶尼塞：……嗯？有声音……

Yenisei: Where does it come from?
小叶尼塞：在哪里——

???: **By the flowers in the snow, raise a toast and don't say no.**
???: **两岸山花——似雪开——家家春酒——满银杯——**

Yenisei: ...
小叶尼塞：……

Yenisei: Who is it? Someone's ...
小叶尼塞：那是……？谁在——

Yenisei: ... singing?
小叶尼塞：……唱歌?

Without realizing it, she departs the second floor and follows the sound into the spacious hall of the tavern.
不知不觉间，她离开二楼，循着声音踏进了整洁而空旷的酒坊大堂。

With the cascading moonlight and melodious singing, the scene laid out before her is one that defies description.
月光扑撒，歌声悠然，而眼前真正是从未想象过的一幕。

Yenisei: What ...
小叶尼塞：……什么……

Yenisei: The striped horses—how come they are ... glowing?!
小叶尼塞：——这些斑纹马，怎么会……在发光?!

Yenisei: What ...
小叶尼塞：……这……

Yenisei: What on earth is happening?!
小叶尼塞：这都是什么东西?!

Yenisei: I ...
小叶尼塞：我——

Yenisei: Gosh!
小叶尼塞：天哪。

With its red mane and luminous stripes, the "horse" stands there in the courtyard and turns gently toward her.
那有着红色鬃毛与发光斑纹的“马”站在院中，向她回过头来。

The singing continues, almost freezing Yenisei in place. She turns around sharply, trying to escape the sound, only to realize that she has already been surrounded ...
歌声仍在持续，把小叶尼塞几乎凝滞在原地。她用力转身，想要逃离声音的包围，才发觉自己早已受到了围困。

... by the group of wooden dolls who were in her cup earlier.
——被一群刚才还在酒碗中的木头小人。

Wooden Dolls: **By the flowers in the snow, raise a toast and don't say no.**
木头小人群：**家家春酒——满银杯——**

Yenisei: ...?
小叶尼塞：——?

Wooden Dolls: **Fill your cup, fill your cup!**
木头小人群：**请满上，请满上！**

Yenisei: Are they ... asking me to drink?
小叶尼塞：它们这是……邀请我喝酒……?

Yenisei: Jiǔ Niángzǐ! Where are you?
小叶尼塞：……曲娘——曲娘在哪儿??

Yenisei: Is she ...
小叶尼塞：她会不会——

Now, the wooden dolls, originally submerged in the stream in the courtyard, have begun to climb up the bank.
现在，就连原本浸在院外河水中的木头小人也缓缓地爬上了岸。

They surround her, spinning, singing, and contorting, with bodies clearly possessing a flexibility beyond what wood should possess.
它们围着她，转圈，欢唱，扭动，身体明显有着木头不应拥有的柔软程度。

Using this odd flexibility, they repeatedly lift their full cups toward Yenisei.
依靠着这种柔软，它们不断向小叶尼塞举起手中满盈的杯盏。

Wooden Dolls: **No turning down, no turning down!**
木头小人群：**莫辞，莫辞！**

Yenisei: No ...
小叶尼塞：不——

This invitation, perhaps initially hospitable, turns increasingly creepy in the dark night.
本应热情的邀请，在这样的浓夜中越发显露出它的不合时宜。

Making a choice now requires next to no thought. Yenisei jumps out from their enclosure and runs toward the other end of the yard—toward the water jar.
做出选择几乎不用太多思考，小叶尼塞跳出包围圈，向着院子另一头，也向着水缸的所在跑去。

Fortunately, she clearly remembered the location pointed out by Jiǔ Niángzǐ.
好在，她的确清晰记得曲娘指过的位置。

Yenisei: I can't go back to my room. Need to lead them away.
小叶尼塞：不能回楼上去，得引开它们——

The wooden dolls still sing happily, as if they are only playing a game of tag.
木头小人们依然欢唱，以为这是一场追逐的游戏。

Yenisei: Ugh!
小叶尼塞：——呃！

The wooden dolls stage a disorganized offensive, with a piercing song that twists Yenisei's perception of her surroundings.
木头小人的攻击毫无章法，歌声刺耳，屡次带偏小叶尼塞对周围环境的准确感知。

She can only stand by the water jar, in a constant retreat, consciously nearing a dead end.
她只能站在水缸周围，不断后退，几乎已经被逼至绝路。

Wooden Dolls: *sound of wood rubbing*
木头小人群：咯——咯——

Wooden Dolls: Clack. Clack. Clack.
木头小人群：咚、咚、咚。

Yenisei: No ...
小叶尼塞：……不……

Yenisei: Can't stop here. I must go ... farther.
小叶尼塞：不行，还要——还要再远。

Yenisei: Come here! This way!
小叶尼塞：……过来！来这边！

The wooden figures have no ears, so it seems unlikely they hear or understand her.
木头没有耳朵，自然听不见，也听不懂。

Nonetheless, they are lured in, leaping forward with strange enthusiasm.
所幸，它们的确受到吸引，继续向前跳动。

Never tiring. Just like those cups, always lifted high, constantly spilling and overflowing.
永不疲倦，充满热情。如同它们始终被高高举起，不停洒出又重新满溢的杯盏。

Wooden Dolls: *sound of wood rubbing*
木头小人群：咯——咯咯——

???: ...
???: ——

It seems these crude wooden creations are quick to be alert to sudden interlopers.
看似粗糙的木头造物比人更早警觉第三者的介入。

They immediately stop their siege of Yenisei and abruptly turn toward the tall trees in the courtyard.
它们立刻停止对小叶尼塞的围攻，突兀地转投院中树木伫立的方向。

Yenisei: Hmm? Where are they going?
小叶尼塞：……嗯？它们是要……去哪儿？

Wooden Dolls: Clack! Clack!
木头小人群：咚！咚！

Wooden Dolls: Clack! Clack!
木头小人群：咚咚！咚咚！

The coercive rhythm plays heavier and faster than before, as they jump a few more hops toward the bottom of the tree—
逼迫的节奏比先前走得更重更急，它们几步蹦跳，去往树下——

???: Be off!
???: ……退！

A wand of bone flies out from the darkness, scattering liquor and shattering the wooden figures into pieces.
骨杖飞出，酒水泼散，木头小人应声破碎成块。

???: ...
???: ……

Serenity comes back to the scene, the end coming as swiftly as its beginning.
一切似乎就这样归于平静，结束得如同转机出现一般突然。

???: They are conjured ...
???: 这造物……

???: ... so feebly.
???: 竟如此羸弱。

Yenisei: Who ... Who is it?!
小叶尼塞: 谁——是谁?!

???: Hmm?
???: ……嗯?

???: It's you?
???: 只你一人?

Yenisei: You? The feather man who stole our horses!
小叶尼塞: ……是你？你是偷走我们马匹的羽人——

???: No matter. You're leaving with me.
???: 罢了，也须得与我走。

Yenisei: Leave me alone! What is going on?
小叶尼塞: 别过来！这到底是怎么回事——

???: Silence. It's dangerous here, and words are no help to us.
???: 噤声。此地危险，多说无益。

Without hesitation, the giant bird grabs Yenisei's arms quickly, lifting her up and away from the courtyard.
不由分说，巨鸟将小叶尼塞的双臂抓起，飞快带离了院落。

Her struggle proves futile in the howling wind.
她的挣扎在呼啸的天空下愈发徒劳无功。

Yenisei: Aaaah!
小叶尼塞: 啊——!

The sound of flapping wings punctuated by the shrieking girl gradually fades in the distance, leaving only a disordered mess as evidence in the courtyard.
振翅的响动与尖叫逐渐远离，只留下此处院中一片狼藉。

In the morning, Jiǔ Niángzǐ walks into the shambolic scene.
清晨，曲娘迈入院子里的狼藉中。

A still-intact wooden doll bounces around, gathering the remains of its kind into a ball.
一个完整的木头小人正蹦跳着，将它同类的残骸拢作一团。

Wooden Doll: **Alas, alas. An arm is missing. Can't put them together, anymore.**
木头小人: **——兄兄，缺了一只手，拼不回来了。**

Jiu Niangzi: ...
曲娘: ……

Wooden Doll: **Late. You are late.**
木头小人: **来晚了，你。**

Jiu Niangzi: What's going on?
曲娘: 怎么回事?

Jiu Niangzi: I told you to keep the house, not to tear it down.
曲娘：是让你们看家，不是让你们拆家。

Wooden Doll: **Being, a, good host. Offering, a drink.**
木头小人：**只是想尽地主之谊，请喝酒。**

Jiu Niangzi: Offer a drink to whom?
曲娘：你们要请谁喝?

Jiu Niangzi: Those two ladies should be soundly asleep upstairs.
曲娘：昨天来的两位，还在楼上睡着呀……

Wooden Doll: **One, was downstairs, at night. Bird man, with her.**
木头小人：**一个，晚上在楼下。那个鸟人也在。**

Jiu Niangzi: Bird man ... You mean that feather man? He had been here?!
曲娘：什么鸟人……？你是说羽人？他来过了?!

Jiu Niangzi: What was he doing here? He's not even a Xiángruì, nor is he doing anything good. Do not offer a drink to him!
曲娘：他来做什么？他都不是祥瑞，也没有在做好事。不许你们请他喝酒！

Jiu Niangzi: Humph. If I were the one treating him, I would ...
曲娘：哼，要让我见到他，我一定——

Wooden Doll: **He took one, with him.**
木头小人：**他把一个带走了。**

Jiu Niangzi: I would ... I, wait, what?
曲娘：——等等，什么?

Jiu Niangzi: Took whom with him??
曲娘：谁被他带走了??

Wooden Doll: **The scarlet. The brown, took away, the scarlet.**
木头小人：**绛色的。茶色带走了绛色。**

Jiu Niangzi: Brown? Scarlet? What color is that?
曲娘：什么茶色和……绛色？什么颜色?

Jiu Niangzi: *sighs* You're just confusing me. I'll make you one more mouth next time. What on earth are you talking about.
曲娘：唉，我怎么越听越糊涂了。下次我一定给你们多做一张嘴，你看看，这都是在说什么呀——

Bessmert: Hiss ...
别斯米尔：嘶……

Jiǔ Niángzǐ turns around to see Bessmert fall over the threshold.
曲娘闻声回头，看见年长的女性跌倒在门槛上。

She quickly approaches with her skirt held up, and the wooden doll jumping up and down, hiding behind her.
她赶紧提着裙角迎过去，木头小人正好蹦跳着，躲进她身后。

Jiu Niangzi: Be careful! I'll help you.
曲娘：请小心一些！来，我扶你。

Bessmert: Thank you. Thank you so much.
别斯米尔：谢谢，谢谢您。

Bessmert: Where's Yenisei? Did you see her upstairs or in the yard?
别斯米尔：小叶尼塞，她不在楼上，也不在院子里吗?

Jiu Niangzi: Are you talking about your red-haired friend? Did she go out?
曲娘：是你红头发的朋友吗？我没看见她。她是不是先出门了？

Bessmert: No, not very likely. She would have told me if she was going out. Or at least ask someone to pass on the message.
别斯米尔：不，不会的。她如果要出门去，一定会告诉我。或者至少通过您告诉我。

Bessmert: Did you really not see her today?
别斯米尔：您真的没有见到她吗？

Jiǔ Niángzǐ racks her brain, her voice coming out serious and resolute.
曲娘绞尽脑汁地回忆了一下，声音更加认真而坚定。

Jiu Niangzi: No, not this morning, no.
曲娘：没有，早上真的没有呀。

Bessmert: ...
别斯米尔：……

Bessmert: The missing persons cases! Is this how they happened?!
别斯米尔：失踪案。城里的失踪案，是不是也都是这样的情况？

Jiu Niangzi: I-I don't know. Lǐzhèng didn't make it in time to tell me the details ...
曲娘：我、我不知道，里正没有和我讲过……

Bessmert falls into silence. This is a loss that she finds difficult to accept.
别斯米尔陷入了沉默。这是她难以接受的损失。

Bessmert: If—I'm only saying—if this is another missing case, there must be a clue or two telling us what happened.
别斯米尔：如果，只是如果，这就是所谓的失踪案，那也一定会留下什么蛛丝马迹。

Bessmert: Could you please look around and see if she has left anything in the yard? She must have been taken from there, or I would have definitely heard the noises.
别斯米尔：请您帮忙看一看，院子里有没有留下什么东西？她不是在二楼被掠走的，否则我不会一点声音也没听见。

Bessmert anxiously grasps Jiǔ Niángzǐ's hands. Their hands are equally coarse—one pair exposed to age and sun, and the other exposed to grueling work.
别斯米尔着急地握住了曲娘的手。那是两双略有风霜的手，一双曾饱经日晒，另一双，兴许做过不少手工活儿。

Jiu Niangzi: Stay calm. Let's go ask Lǐzhèng.
曲娘：你先别急，我们可以去找里正——

Bessmert: Wait ...
别斯米尔：等等……

Jiu Niangzi: What's wrong?
曲娘：怎么了？

Bessmert: I sense an arcane energy. Someone cast a skill in the yard.
别斯米尔：神秘术。这院子里有使用过神秘术的痕迹。

Bessmert: Follow me.
别斯米尔：跟着我。

Jiu Niangzi: Where are you going? You can't see! Just tell me. I'll take you there.
曲娘：你要去哪儿？你看不见呀，你告诉我，我带你去。

Bessmert: No, please follow me.
别斯米尔：不，请跟着我就好。

Jiu Niangzi: You're heading toward the water jar. I was here last night to get water.
曲娘：再往前走就是水缸了，昨晚我来这里打过水。

Bessmert: It's somewhere close to the water jar. I sense it clearly.
别斯米尔：就在水缸的附近。我能很清晰地感受到。

Bessmert wades through the stream and stops in front of the water jar. She crouches down to find something among the scattered leaves in front of her.
别斯米尔蹚过溪水，在水缸斜前方停住。她蹲下身，在面前地上散落的树叶中，准确地摸出一样东西。

Jiu Niangzi: Is this a bone?
曲娘：这是……一根骨头?

Bessmert: That makes sense. Lǐzhèng told us that the feather man uses a bone wand. Yenisei also saw something similar in that giant bird's hand when we faced him outside the city.
别斯米尔：那就对了。里正说，羽人也拿着像骨头的术杖。而小叶尼塞看见巨鸟也有这样的东西。

Jiu Niangzi: I knew it! Now, we have the proof, we can ...
曲娘：我就知道！这下我们有证据了，我们可以——

Bessmert: No, it's not enough. And Yenisei is missing.
别斯米尔：这不够。而且小叶尼塞失踪了。

Jiu Niangzi: Why not enough? He left his bone wand, which means he was here before. And your friend is missing! Still not enough to prove his guilt?
曲娘：为什么？我觉得这就够了呀，羽人的骨杖都掉在这里了，这说明他来过，而且你的同伴不见了，那不就说明是他干的吗?

Bessmert: But only Yenisei knows what the giant bird looks like. She also drew the picture of that bird.
别斯米尔：但只有小叶尼塞先前亲眼看见了巨鸟，巨鸟的画像也是她提供的。

Bessmert: Without her, we cannot confirm that the feather man and the giant bird are the same creature.
别斯米尔：没有她，我们依然无法证明，巨鸟与羽人就是同一人……

Jiu Niangzi: I don't understand. You're saying that, even if we have his bone wand, we can't prove anything?
曲娘：我听不懂……是说就算我们找到了他的骨头，也不能用这个证明任何东西吗?

Bessmert: Exactly.
别斯米尔：……是的，没错。

Jiu Niangzi: But, I think you're overthinking.
曲娘：但是，我觉得不需要想这么多。

Bessmert raises her head slightly, conveying her confusion in unsubtle movements.
别斯米尔稍微抬起头来，用动作传达茫然。

Jiu Niangzi: I-I mean, whether enough or not, it's not up to us, right?
曲娘：就是——就是这个证据够不够，能不能证明，不是我们说了算的。

Jiu Niangzi: I know nothing about the law. It ... it just doesn't feel right.
曲娘：我也不懂，但感觉，这样不对……

The girl's voice quietens down, giving rise to her own hesitation.
女孩的声音渐渐小了下去，终于也生出一点不确定的犹疑。

Jiu Niangzi: I'm just thinking ... we should do something, because you are sad.
曲娘：……我只是觉得，我们应该做些什么。因为你很难过。

But Bessmert already understands.
但别斯米尔已经明白了。

Bessmert: ...
别斯米尔：……

Bessmert: You have a point. Then we ...
别斯米尔：您说得对。那我们——

Jiu Niangzi: Let's go to the Zhící now! Lǐzhèng will be there today. He is supposed to tell me something about the Dùshuò Festival.
曲娘：嗯！我们先去职祠吧，今天里正也会在，他要跟我说些度朔节的事……

Jiu Niangzi: Let's tell him what happened today. He will know what to do!
曲娘：我们正好可以告诉他。里正会有办法的！

Bessmert: Sure.
别斯米尔：……好。

They decided to head towards the Zhící. Bessmert puts away the bone wand and follows Jiǔ Niángzǐ's footsteps carefully, one at a time.
她们决定离开酒坊，前往职祠。别斯米尔收好骨杖，亦步亦趋地跟随曲娘的脚步。

They leave the wooden doll standing in place, a sentinel atop the rest of the debris.
留下木头小人伫立原地，与另一些残骸一起。

6#1
6#1

葛生
Gesheng NS-13

Zhici
职祠室内

Lǐzhèng is flipping through annual expense account records from previous years, worries written on his heart and wizened face.
里正翻阅着往年的年节用度账册，心下踌躇。

Jiǔ Niángzǐ is sure to report for duty on time, and he must have a decision ready before she does.
曲娘会准时过来点卯，而他需要在对方到达之前，做出一个决定。

Lizheng: In past years, the Festive Animals used in the Fortune Walk and the Bridge Leap were less than three.
里正：……往年走吉与跃桥，所用年节动物，皆不超过三只。

Lizheng: "A cow, a goat, and a donkey. Without exception."
里正：“一牛，一羊，一驴，未有例外。”

Lizheng: The poorer the harvest, the less food for the animals and less well-fed donkeys, so people had to use horses instead. However ...
里正：收成愈差，城内少有可用的青壮成驴，以至于用马代替。可现今——

Lizheng: Aren't there too many Festive Animals this time? Even if it is for celebrating the birth of Zhíxú? Not to mention some of them are transformed from humans! We shall act prudently.
里正：即使庆贺执徐生辰，职祠之内的年节动物也过多了。其中还有为人所变，断不可一视同仁。

Lizheng: If we have to cancel the ceremony, we must make the decision before New Year's Eve ...
里正：若要取消跃桥之仪，岁除后便是朔日，须得尽早决断……

He writes the words "Fortune Walk" and "Bridge Leap" into a blank space on the account records in his hand, then circles them in red ink to serve as his reminder.
他在手中账册的空白处，写上“走吉”、“跃桥”几字，又洗墨沾红，轻轻用圈勾住。一个提醒。

As he does, he ponders and shifts his gaze nearby to the portrait of a giant bird.
写下这些，里正思索着，将视线移向一旁的“巨鸟画像”。

Lizheng: ...
里正：……

Lizheng: A giant bird ... a feather man ...
里正：巨鸟……羽人……

Lizheng: *sighs* There is always trouble around New Years.
里正：偏生是在这年节关头……烦扰从来都接踵而至。

Suddenly, there comes a loud fluttering of wings. This sound is not like one of common birds flapping, but is rather a droning hazardous sound the kind of a titanic bird of prey approaching.
这一声并非常见鸟雀扑扇翅膀，而是真正庞大的野外猛禽旋临的声响。

Lizheng: Hmm?
里正：……嗯?

A winged shadow covers the portrait on the desk.
一个长着翅膀的影子，覆盖了桌面的画像。

Lǐzhèng turns his head to see the visitor clearly, meeting it with a look of shock and heart-shaking doubt on his face.
里正转头看清来者，面上只剩下愕然与发自内心的疑惑。

Lizheng: You?!
里正：是你……?!

The visitor is no less than the very giant bird or feathered man depicted in that portrait.
来者正是画像上的巨鸟，或者说羽人。

He glides in as smoothly and naturally as if he were entering an open glade. It seems as though the guards of the Zhící were unaware of his arrival entirely.
他飞进来的动作，若入无人之境一般流畅自然，就连职祠的护卫也未被惊动。

???: You ... Are you responsible for this place?
???: 你便是……掌事之人?

???: It was ... someone else when I last visited.
???: 可上次我所见的明明是……另一人……

???: *sighs*
???: ……唉。

???: No matter. I have an urgent matter to discuss, or it will be too late.
???: 罢了，我有要事相告。若是再不阻止，万事休矣。

Without waiting for Lǐzhèng to react, a bizarre horse, or something like it, rushes in behind him.
不待里正反应，一只模样前所未见的马就跟在他身后闯进来了。

The horse's mane and tail are both red, and it bears a tiger-stripe pattern along its body, the combination of which produces a truly incomparable sight.
这马的鬃毛与尾巴都是红色，身上亦有虎皮一样的纹路，颇为罕见。

Striped Horse?: *neighs*
斑纹马?: 咴——

It steps forward, allowing Lǐzhèng to see it clearly. It suggests a great sort of intelligence in its movements.
它踏步上前，使里正能够更清楚地看见自己，动作间似乎有着某种灵性。

As for the feather man—he simply folds his wings and lands. The narrow space forces him to pinch himself tightly into the cramped room.
而羽人——羽人只是并拢翅膀降落。狭窄的方室令他颇有些无处伸展的感觉。

Lǐzhèng notices a hint of embarrassment in his visitor as a result.
里正也因此觉察到对方的一丝局促。

Getian: I'm Gětiān, and I'm here to advise caution. The lady owner of the tavern can turn people into Lùshǔ. She needs to be stopped, or more people will suffer.
葛天：我乃葛天。此行是为告知，那酒坊娘子以术法使人变为鹿蜀形貌，需得尽快阻止，以免贻害更广。

Getian: She has extremely light bones, which means she's still in the stage of development. She might be unstable, hence a danger to keep in the city.
葛天：她骨相过轻，形状尚在生长，也因此作为不定，恐为祸患。

Lizheng: You are referring to ... Jiǔ Niángzǐ?
里正：——你指的，难道是曲娘?

Getian: Precisely.
葛天：正是。

Lizheng: Bones ... Are you the Goddess of Lí Mountain that can read one's bones? But you don't look like her at all ...
里正：骨相……难道，你是可识骨相的骊山姥？但你的身形，分明不似黎山老母……

Getian: ...
葛天：……

The brief silence conveys Gětiān's astonishment at the unexpected change in topic.
短暂的沉默表示了葛天对话题转变速度预计不足的错愕。

Getian: I am no Goddess of Lí Mountain.
葛天：我自然并非骊山姥。

Lizheng: Then your words have no weight at all. You should have claimed to be her.
里正：那这些言辞从你口中说来，岂不无人相信。你还不若声称自己是骊山姥。

Lizheng: Besides, "Goddess of Lí Mountain," take a look around you.
里正：而且……“骊山姥”啊，且看看周围吧。

Though puzzled, Gětiān looks around as advised, only to find some paper with the same bird totems painted on it. Some of the papers even bear ink stains yet to dry, indicating their recentness.
虽然疑惑，葛天还是依言环视四周，只看到了一些画了相同鸟类图腾的纸张。部分纸张上面甚至墨迹未干，显然是新落的手笔。

Getian: You mean ... these paper-cutouts?
葛天：你说的是……这些门笺?

Getian: A man-faced bird with a red tail. You're drawing me ...
葛天：人面，鸟身，红尾。你们画这些——

Even though he recognizes the image in the painting, the idea of being "worshipped" through such artwork comes across as quite unnecessary.
就算辨认出画上的形象，他也并不认为这些图画的“供奉”有任何必要。

Striped Horse?: *neighs*
斑纹马?: 咴?

Horseshoes impatiently clank on the ground, seeming to urge a sense of haste. This prompting though goes unnoticed.
马蹄不耐地点了点地，似乎急急催促着两人的对话。只可惜此刻无人在意。

Getian: But I'm not a Xiángruì. These paper-cuts won't send me your prayers and wishes.
葛天: 我并非祥瑞，此类筹措或祈祷，毫无必要。

Lizheng: They're not paper-cutouts for worshiping the Xiángruì, but wanted posters, and you are wanted.
里正: ……这些并非向祥瑞祈愿的门笺，而是你的通缉令。

Gětiān is stunned for a moment, as if unable to understand Lǐzhèng's words. Whether paper cuttings or wanted notices, they are complex things found only in the world of the mundane.
葛天怔愣一瞬，似乎不能理解里正的话。门笺也好，通缉令也罢，皆是人世间才有的繁杂之物。

As such, he opts to ignore them for now and continue on with the purpose of his journey.
所以他决定简单地跳过，继续自己此行的目的。

Getian: The most important thing is to find Jiǔ Niángzǐ. She's the culprit of the missing persons cases in the city.
葛天: 无论如何，现在捉拿曲娘最为要紧。正是她造成了城中的这些失踪案件。

Lizheng: Humph.
里正: 呵。

Lizheng: I thought you came here to confess or make peace, but it seems not.
里正: 我还猜想，你是前来自首或交涉。如今看来，却是我想多了。

Lizheng: You come to defame Jiǔ Niángzǐ, while being ignorant of the fact that you're the top suspect.
里正: 主动前来攀咬曲娘，你是全然不知，自己才是头号疑犯啊。

Upon learning that the culprit is not in fact the one he identified as Jiǔ Niángzǐ, Gětiān falls into an even deeper confusion.
得知真正被怀疑的对象并非自己指认的曲娘，葛天陷入了更深的疑惑。

Many things outside the mountains are beyond his understanding.
人世的许多事情都超出了他的理解范围。

Getian: How am I related to this?
葛天: 这与我何干?

Lizheng: Every time a disappearance was reported, you were witnessed bringing animals to the Zhící.
里正: 我们数次收到人口失踪上报，次次与你现身于城内，携动物来到职祠的时日关联。

Getian: No, the nature of my visit has been taken wrongly. The Zhílǐ there knew what I came for.
葛天: 不，这是污蔑。当时那位执礼应知晓我的来意。

Lizheng: Humph. When we arrived at the Zhící, you had already fled without a trace.
里正: 呵，当我们赶往职祠时，你早已只身离去，不见踪影。

Lizheng: No one could testify in front of the Fǎcáo for her, so her words were considered nonsense. Now, she has returned to her hometown.
里正: 无人为她作证，她自是被法曹视为胡言乱语，现已回乡去也。

Upon hearing this, Gětiān breathes a sigh of relief.
听到此处，葛天反而认为事情明了，舒出一口气来。

Getian: I wouldn't have shown up in the city if not for the urgent matters. What's the purpose of lingering around when my business is done here?
葛天：若非此事突然，我本就不会来到城中，自然没有久留的道理。

Getian: Besides, the Zhící allowed arcane skills to be cast without restrictions in the city, so it is your responsibility to bear the consequences of such negligence.
葛天：况且，咽下神秘术随性施为的苦果，本应是职祠之责。

Lizheng: You're very articulate ...
里正：好啊，你伶牙俐齿……

Lizheng: But how can you explain the testimony provided by the two foreign merchants?
里正：昨日正有两位胡商来到沛城，向我们提供了一些线索。

Lizheng: All roads are leading to you.
里正：而这些线索，都指向你。

Getian: ...
葛天：……

Getian: Yes. The two foreigners.
葛天：是，正是那两位胡人。

Lizheng: ... Do you confess?
里正：……你认罪了?

Getian: They are the other reason why I'm here.
葛天：这是我此行要告知你的另一件事。

Getian: One of the two is here with us. She can explain to you.
葛天：那两人其中之一，现下就在此处。她可以向你解释。

Gětiān leans over and asks the red-maned horse beside him to signal to Lǐzhèng.
葛天侧身，让出身旁的红鬃马驹，示意给里正。

Striped Horse?: *neighs*
斑纹马?：咴咴——

The strange horse, after being ignored for a long time, seems to acknowledge that it can now finally make itself useful and steps forward on proud hooves.
被冷落许久的奇异马驹，好像知道自己终于能够派上用场一般，迈开蹄子走上前去。

Lizheng: Wait, you mean she is ...
里正：等等，你说它是谁?

Before Lǐzhèng can react, Gětiān flaps his wings, causing the tea on the table to flip onto the ground.
不等里正反应，葛天便挥动翅膀，将案上茶水掀翻在地。

The red-maned horse takes another step forward and turns to the spot where the stone bricks have been wetted.
红鬃的马驹闻声再次迈步，转向石砖被打湿的位置。

The tea seeps out over the interior stone, forming a pool in a small indentation. There the reflection of the horse appears in a flash.
浑浊的茶水很快滑入室内石砖的缝隙之中，马驹的倒影在水渍汇集最多的部分闪现。

Getian: I ask for your patience. Please look at the water on the floor.
葛天：稍待，请看这茶水泼过的地方。

Lizheng: Hmm?
里正：嗯?

Lǐzhèng looks towards the spot Gětiān's line of sight indicates, where the fading reflection remains.
里正也看向葛天视线所在的地方。那里仍然是地砖与逐渐消失的马驹倒影。

But the liquid drains out along the low-lying and uneven floor, and eventually disappears into the crevices of the stone bricks.
水痕只是更快向室内低洼不平的位置汇集，最后隐没在石砖下方。

The tea, it seems, is just tea.
显然，茶水只是茶水。

Getian: ...
葛天：……

Lizheng: What is this for?
里正：……这是何意?

Lizheng: Is this a demonstration of your discontent, because I didn't treat you as a guest, offer you a seat, and give you a cup of tea?
里正：难道因为我没有恭敬待你，邀你坐下，再向你奉茶?

Getian: No ...
葛天：不是……

Getian: This should not be.
葛天：这不应当。

He appears to murmur to himself and turns to the red-tailed horse beside him, his words muddled with confusion.
他几乎是喃喃自语着转向身边的红尾马驹，语带疑惑。

Getian: Why ... why didn't your arcane skill work this time?
葛天：为何——为何你未像先前那样，使出神秘术来?

Getian: Or must it be clean water to reflect it?
葛天：……不。还是说，需得干净的水才行?

Getian: No. The water in the river was no cleaner. How did you do it earlier?
葛天：可河水不洁，应当没有这样的限制。你之前究竟是怎样做到的?

Having now weathered this series of absurd confrontations to his limits, the cultured manner of Lǐzhèng breaks along with his patience.
经历了先前的一系列荒诞对峙，即使是见识广博如里正也已完全失去耐心。

Lizheng: ...
里正：……

Lizheng: Guards!
里正：来人——

Lizheng: Catch him!
里正：将他拿下!

Gětiān is startled by the sudden and rapid footsteps, and immediately flies upward.
葛天被突如其来迅速的脚步声吓得立刻飞了起来。

Within the narrow chamber, the shadow of his wings appears unusually large, and even the red-haired horse retreats beyond the shadow's range.
狭窄的方室之中，他翅膀的影子显得异常庞大，连红鬃的马驹也向阴影范围之外退去。

Getian: What is the meaning of this?!
葛天：你这是何意!

Lizheng: You're a suspect. That's ...
里正：你是疑犯。因此——

Getian: What I know, I told you truthfully. Why are you troubling me instead of going after Jiǔ Niángzǐ?
葛天：我所知，已倾数相告，你们不去捉拿曲娘，反而在这里纠缠于我？

Getian: Find some clean water. I will prove it to you ...
葛天：找干净的水来，我再证明给你——

Lizheng: That's enough. Surrender now.
里正：不必。束手就擒即可。

Getian: I will not fight you. But neither will you have me.
葛天：……我不会同你们动手，但你们也抓不得我。

Lizheng: *sighs*
里正：唉。

Lizheng: Be careful not to hurt that horse. It might be one of the victims.
里正：注意保护那红尾的马，那可能是受害者。

Gětiān flaps his wings and flies out, escaping to the courtyard.
葛天振翅飞出，逃到院中。

He does not leave immediately, instead deftly avoiding the attacks of the guards as he flits around the courtyard. Despite the fact that this brief conflict has already left him injured.
但他并未直接离开，而是不断躲避着攻击，在院中徘徊。即使这冲突已经令他负伤。

Lizheng: Your strength will eventually run out.
里正：你的力气总会耗尽的。

Getian: Is this necessary?
葛天：何须走到这一步？

Getian: Find me the clean water, and I will show you what Jiǔ Niángzǐ has done.
葛天：仅仅找来清水与我，我就能向你证明曲娘的过错。

Lizheng: How will I know if you're using your arcane skill to fake the result?
里正：我又如何知道，你的“证明”，不是你用神秘术伪造的结果呢？

Lizheng: The truth is, we know the girl very well, but nothing about you.
里正：说到底，我们了解你指认的“罪魁”曲娘，却对你一无所知。

Getian: ...
葛天：……

Lizheng: No one had gone missing in Pèi City before you showed up.
里正：甚至于在城内有人失踪前，你都未曾入过沛城。

Lizheng: So how can we trust you or your "proof"?
里正：我们又要从何处判断你的话语，真实与否？

Gětiān gently shakes his head and lowers his wings.
葛天轻轻摇头，垂下了翅膀。

Lizheng: And you have denied that you're a Xiángruì ...
里正：更何况，你说自己并非祥瑞——

Getian: *sighs*
葛天：……呼。

Getian: It is true that I am not a Xiángruì, nor have I ever visited here.
葛天：的确，我并非祥瑞，此前也从未来到城中。

Getian: I never wanted to leave the mountain.
葛天：因为我本就不愿下山。

His movements make the wounds on his wings visible. His stance is low and reverent, suggesting his willingness to discuss a truce.
他的动作令翅膀上的伤痕被明确地展示。一种代表休战相谈的姿态。

Lǐzhèng hesitates and, as a result, raises his hand to stop the storming advance of the guards.
里正也因这动作而犹疑，抬手叫停了涌上来的职祠护卫。

Lizheng: But you still left.
里正：你却还是做了这样的事。

Getian: I really shouldn't have come to the human world.
葛天：为何我一定要来到人世当中呢?

Lizheng: What do you mean?
里正：……你这话是什么意思?

Getian: My people have left the mountain and come to help you. They renounced their names, families, and even lives for you ...
葛天：我的那些同族都已下过山了。为了你们，放弃姓名，放弃族人，放弃性命，放弃……

Getian: They gave up everything so that you would have gods to worship. They became symbols, totems ... except themselves.
葛天：放弃一切，成为一个符号，一个图腾。变得谁也不是。

Lizheng: What are you talking about, feather man?
里正：羽人，你究竟在说什么?

Getian: I told you my name. I'm not a "feather man."
葛天：我告知过，可以怎样称呼我。“羽人”并非我的名字。

Lizheng: ...
里正：……

Getian: "This feather man is not one of us. No need to call him by name."
葛天：“眼前羽人或许非我族类，并无以名相称之必需。”

It isn't any sort of prescience. It's only that the answer is a simple deduction.
不是读心，只是答案很容易便能猜想。

Lizheng: !
里正：——!

Getian: ... Seems like my people have been long forgotten.
葛天：……看来尔等确乎忘矣。

Getian: You forgot the Gětiāns who left the mountain, the city-builders, the bridge-masters, the flood-fighters ... They all faded into oblivion. You only remember the Gods of Shètí, who never answered to your prayers!
葛天：忘了过去那些下山的葛天氏，亦曾是建城之人、筑桥之人、抵御洪水之人……只记得一个久不存在，从未回应的摄提神。

Getian: That's why I'm discouraged ...
葛天：所以我不愿……

Getian: ... by the idea of leaving the mountain like my people. I don't want to face such suspicion and disbelief after giving you all the help.
葛天：不愿下山。不愿相助之后，却又这样被猜忌或忘却。

Lizheng: Who-who are you?
里正：——你、你究竟是谁?

Getian: Now that I see it, the destruction of the bridge was inevitable. It was bound to happen, like I was bound to be left in the mountain and be the last of us.
葛天：现今看来，桥断，乃是必然，一如在我之后再无葛天。

Lizheng: The bridge? Did you have something to do with the broken bridge? Feather man, tell us!
里正：“桥断”？你与断桥又有何关联——羽人，你说清楚！

Getian: Question no more. You can have me, if that's what you want.
葛天：就这样罢。你们尽可以来擒住我了。

The message conveyed by Gětiān's words and actions forces those present to hold their breath.
葛天话语和动作传递出的信息，一时之间，令在场所有人都屏住了呼吸。

He gives up his resistance and sees the connection between the broken bridge and this vague allegation.
他放弃了反抗，在以一段语焉不详的指控，勾连出断桥的过往后。

Though the onlookers wonder whether this might be merely a stalling tactic.
每个人都在怀疑：这是否只是缓兵之计?

Jiu Niangzi: Lǐzhèng!
曲娘：——里正！

The two who set off from the tavern, heading toward the Zhící, arrive in time to witness the end of the standoff.
而先前从酒坊出发，向职祠前进的另外两人，此刻正要迎面赶上一场对峙的终结。

Bessmert had been following Jiǔ Niángzǐ closely all the way, but now stops just short of the Zhící's gates.
别斯米尔原本一路紧跟曲娘，却在职祠门前停下了脚步。

Bessmert: Ms. Jiǔ Niángzǐ, please wait.
别斯米尔：……曲娘小姐，先不要过去。

Even without the ability to see it, she stops to analyze the tense atmosphere ahead.
她的确看不见。之所以停下来，只是敏锐地察觉到前方紧绷的气氛。

Lizheng: Come no further!
里正：不要过来！

Jiu Niangzi: Huh?
曲娘：咦?

Getian: ...
葛天：……

The gaze of almost everyone in the courtyard converges now on Gětiān, wary of any possible movement.
No one present believes that he would just surrender like this.
几乎所有人的目光都汇集到院中的葛天身上，警惕着他可能还会有的反应。
没有人相信他会真的就这样束手就擒。

And in an unnoticed corner, the red-tailed horse deftly bypasses them all before running off in agitation.
而在无人注意的角落，红尾马驹灵巧地绕过所有人，一路狂奔——

Striped Horse?: *neighs*
斑纹马?: 咴——！

The horse that had rushed into the crowd then just as immediately weaves back out, seeming to aim to snatch Bessmert out from behind Jiǔ Niángzǐ.
马驹飞快地窜进人群，又迅速窜出，目的竟是将别斯米尔从曲娘的身后掠走。

Bessmert: Ah!
别斯米尔: ……啊！

And it succeeds.
并且它成功了。

6#1
6#1

往日鎏金
The Old Days NS-14

Jiu Niangzi: What, what just ran out of there?
曲娘: 什么……刚才跑出去的是什么?

Jiu Niangzi: That "thing" took away the lady. What's going on?!
曲娘: 那东西还带走了和我一起来的那位娘子，这——

Jiǔ Niángzǐ's words dissipate in the air without stirring a response. The eyes of all stare at Gětiān in the center of the courtyard. Most of these are filled with doubt, suspicion, and fear.
曲娘话音落下，众人都齐齐望向院子中央的葛天。多数目光都饱含质疑、猜忌和恐惧。

As the strange horse and its unwilling rider disappear in the distance, the communication arcane skill cast by the bone wand also seems to dissipate.
伴随城外异客的身影远去，那骨杖所带来的神秘术似乎也逐渐消散。

Lizheng: Now we lost another witness. Did you plan this?
里正: 现在我们又失去了一名证人。难道这也在你的计划之中?

Getian: I left my wand in her tavern yesterday. Ask her. You will know.
葛天: 我的术杖，昨日便已遗落在她的酒坊。你一问便知。

Lizheng: Jiǔ Niángzǐ, is that so?
里正: 曲娘? 是这样吗?

Jiu Niangzi: We did find a bone in the yard, but it's with that foreign lady now.
曲娘: 在院子里是发现了一根骨头，但那东西现在正在被掳走的胡人娘子身上。

Lizheng: ...
里正: ……

Lizheng: Tie him up first. Do you have more to say?
里正: 先把他捆起来。你还有什么要说的?

Getian: Everything I need to tell you, I have spoken it all. Catch her now, or even a real Xiángruì cannot save you from the disaster.
葛天: 该说的，我都已说了。若再不制止，便是真的祥瑞来了也无力回天。

Lizheng: Why are you so obsessed with calling Jiǔ Niángzǐ the "culprit"?
里正：你究竟为何执着于指认曲娘为凶手?

Jiu Niangzi: What? You ...? I ...? I am the culprit?!
曲娘：什么？你——我——我是凶手?

Jiu Niangzi: What kind of culprit am I?
曲娘：我是什么凶手?

Lizheng: It's fine, Jiǔ Niángzǐ. We all know you have nothing to do with the missing persons cases ...
里正：曲娘，无妨。我们都知道，你与失踪案无关……

Jiu Niangzi: And he said ... said that ... "Even a real Xiángruì cannot save you." He is more of a fake one to me!
曲娘：而且他还说什么——什么真祥瑞也没办法……我看他才是假的!

Jiǔ Niángzǐ rushes angrily toward Gětiān, striding forward until she stands just before him, but in her rush of emotion, she loses her ability to speak.
曲娘气愤地冲向葛天，三步并作两步来到他跟前，临了却又丢失了言语的能力。

Jiu Niangzi: You ...
曲娘：你——

Getian: ...
葛天：……

Lizheng: Stay calm. We will hold him in detention in Zhící for now. I'll report this to the Fǎcáo.
里正：曲娘，不必激动。现下只能暂且将他关押在职祠，我自去告知法曹。

Lizheng: The first thing to do is catch up with the horse and the foreign lady ...
里正：现在要紧的，是派人去追回马和那位胡人娘子……

Lizheng: And find his wand to figure out his arcane skill.
里正：需得找到他的术杖，才可溯源。

The crowd quickly moves according to Lǐzhèng's command and exits the courtyard in an orderly fashion.
人群依着里正的指挥快速行动起来，逐渐离开了中庭。

Only a few scattered guards remain in the courtyard, along with the three figures located in the center.
院中只剩下一些零星的护卫，与位于中央，静默的三人。

At this point, it would seem obvious that Gětiān must be taken away, but as Lǐzhèng has not yet ordered anything to that effect, no one dares step forward. For though subdued, his huge wings and claws still serve as effective deterrents.
葛天原本也应被带走，却由于里正并未直接发话，没有人敢上前。即使已经束手就擒，他巨大的翅膀与趾爪看上去仍然有着相当的威慑力。

Lizheng: Take him away. Everyone else dismissed.
里正：……把他也带下去吧。其它人都散了。

Lizheng: Jiǔ Niángzǐ, follow me. There is something we need to talk about.
里正：曲娘，你随我来。我有事与你商议。

Jiu Niangzi: What do you want, feather man?
曲娘：羽人，你到底想做什么?

Lizheng: Jiǔ Niángzǐ?
里正：曲娘?

Jiu Niangzi: You look like a decent Xiángruì. Why did you say something like that?
曲娘：你明明看上去就像祥瑞，为什么要说这样的话?

Jiu Niangzi: Even-even if you're not, aren't you afraid that ... the real Xiángruì will blame you for doing the wrong thing?
曲娘：而且，就算你不是祥瑞，你难道——难道不怕……不怕真的祥瑞降责于你吗?

The girl appears as though she has not heard Lǐzhèng's words. The doubt in her questions is conveyed in an almost whispered tone.
对于里正的话语，少女看上去恍若未闻。她问句中的疑惑透过近乎呢喃的语气传递出来。

Gětiān doesn't even lift his head. He remains motionless, like a statue.
而葛天连头也没抬。一动不动，仿佛一尊兀然的塑像。

Getian: ...
葛天：……

Lizheng: Jiǔ Niángzǐ. It is true that he is not the Xiángruì of our city. The Xiángruì, who once protected our city, has been long lost.
里正：曲娘。须知他早前未与我们有所接触，的确并非此地祥瑞，城中也已失庇护久矣。

Jiǔ Niángzǐ turns her head, failing to connect the logic behind Lǐzhèng's statement.
曲娘蓦地转过头来，似乎并不理解里正这一论断的逻辑。

Jiu Niangzi: BUT! But everyone thinks the feather man on the mountain is the Xiángruì! Just, just look at him! How could people not take him as a Xiángruì by his look?
曲娘：可是——可是大家都以为，山上的羽人就是祥瑞！单单是他的样貌，就能让旁的人觉得他是祥瑞。

Jiu Niangzi: The former Zhílǐ told me that the feather man looks like a Gōumáng, just like what was depicted in a picture book. *Gōumáng: the God of Spring in ancient Chinese mythology, in charge of agriculture, with wings and claws.*
曲娘：执礼离开前跟我说过，羽人长得像“句芒”，就像画册里走出来的一样，好像这能解释一切。

Jiu Niangzi: A Gōumáng is a confirmed Xiángruì recorded in a book!
曲娘：句芒可是画在书上的祥瑞啊!

Lizheng: Jiǔ Niángzǐ.
里正：曲娘……

Jiu Niangzi: But this man? Of course, he is not a Xiángruì! He isn't like the Gōumáng nor the Mièméng ... He doesn't even understand the saying of, um, "One can remove the footsteps, but not the path one walketh on."
曲娘：但他当然不是祥瑞了，不像句芒，或者灭蒙鸟……他连，呃，“绝迹易，无行地难”的道理都不明白。

Lizheng: ...
里正：……

Lizheng: "One can remove the footsteps, but not the path one walketh on." ... That's fair. One cannot commit wrongdoing without leaving a trace.
里正：“绝迹易，无行地难。”唉，道理确是如此。只要做错了事，必然会留下痕迹。

Lizheng: However, we can't convict him without definitive evidence, such as witnesses and his wand.
里正：即使他试图嫁祸于你，我们在尚未找到术杖和证人之前，也不能轻易假定他为凶手。

Lizheng: The trace he left is yet to be found.
里正：我们还没有找到足够确证的“痕迹”，曲娘。

Jiǔ Niángzǐ squats down in front of Gětiān in a sudden inexplicable movement. Then stares unwaveringly into his eyes as she speaks, as if she is to judge the authenticity of his words and expressions by doing so.
曲娘蓦然，在葛天的身前蹲下来。她执着于去看着对方的眼睛说话，似乎这样就能从中判断话语与感情的真伪。

Jiu Niangzi: Feather man. Do you know what is a "real Xiángruì"? Do you know where it is?
曲娘：羽人……什么叫作“真的祥瑞”？你知道它在哪里？

Jiu Niangzi: Why did you take people's friends away and accuse me of being the culprit?
曲娘：你又为什么要带走别人的同伴，却来这里指认我？

But Gětiān seems to have made up his mind to remain silent. He lowers his head, taking a feigned interest in observing the blood dripping from his wounds. An act of passive resistance.
但葛天似乎已经打定主意沉默。他低着头，好像突然对观察伤口上的血珠有了兴趣。——一种消极的抵抗。

Getian: ...
葛天：……

A drop of blood seeps into his feathers, the moment passes long enough for the girl to organize her words and continue her barrage of questions.
一滴血渗入羽毛的时间已足够女孩整理措辞，继续提问。

Jiu Niangzi: You, um, your appearance is given by heaven. So you should not act against the nature of your look just because of your personal preference.
曲娘：你……这样的形貌……嗯，是天道赋予的，就不应该因为自身的好恶得失而偏离了这形貌应有的本性。

Jiu Niangzi: You could have become a much-loved spirit, like in the stories and picture books ... as everyone expects you to be.
曲娘：你明明可以变得像说书先生说的、像画册上画的那样好，那样受人们喜爱……就像大家所期望的那样。

Jiu Niangzi: But you ... when you took away that foreign lady's teammates, you didn't care about their feelings. They didn't want to be separated.
曲娘：但你……你把胡人小娘子，和她的同伴带走的时候，都没有考虑过人们的心情。那不是他们想要分离的时刻。

Jiu Niangzi: You disappointed people. That's not what a Xiángruì should do.
曲娘：你令人伤心了，这不是祥瑞该做的事。

Lizheng: Alright, Jiǔ Niángzǐ. That's enough.
里正：……好了，曲娘。就到这里吧。

Lizheng: Take him away.
里正：你们先把他带下去。

Jiu Niangzi: I ...
曲娘：我……

Jiǔ Niángzǐ watches coldly as Gětiān is taken away.
曲娘眼瞧着葛天被带走的方向。

Jiu Niangzi: He didn't tell me anything. Nor did he tell anyone.
曲娘：他也什么都没有告诉我。大家都是一样的。

Lizheng: I know you're chasing after anything that could be a Xiángruì, but the feather man has clearly claimed that he is not one.
里正：虽然，我知晓你一直以来都对“祥瑞”十分着迷，但羽人今日来到职祠，言语中已经透露了他实则并非祥瑞的事实。

Lizheng: To be honest, judging from his attitude, he has never had the intention to be one.
里正：甚至，我以为他的态度，更像是说他自身并非祥瑞，也从未想过要成为祥瑞。

Jiu Niangzi: I don't understand ... How could he not want to be one?
曲娘：我不明白……他怎么能不想呢?

Lizheng: Not everyone is so interested in the legend of Xiángruì.
里正：并非人人都对祥瑞的传说如此趋之若鹜。

Lizheng: The Pèi City did have a good era under the protection of the Xiángruìs. But after all these years, no one can recall that time without the help of mythologies and history books. Even I can't be sure if there is a real Xiángruì.
里正：沛城的确曾在祥瑞的庇护下有过不错的时光。但此去经年，那段旧日只能在神话典籍中查阅。甚至我也不敢论断，真正的祥瑞是否还存在。

Lizheng: But, Jiǔ Niángzǐ, you should know that we don't need a Xiángruì anymore.
里正：但是曲娘，你应该知道。现在，我们也已不需要祥瑞了。

Jiu Niangzi: We don't need it?
曲娘：……我们不需要吗?

Lizheng: With no Xiángruì, no Divination, we cannot arrive at the Yuān Temple, but this is still an orderly city.
里正：现在没有祥瑞，甚至也没有了行之有效的问卜。但你看，我们失去了与渊庙的沟通，城中依然秩序井然……

Lizheng: The Dùshuò Festival is as vibrant as ever. You can tell that a Xiángruì is not necessary for a city to prosper.
里正：度朔节也依然热闹非凡，可见祥瑞并不是一城立足之必需。

Jiu Niangzi: Is that so ...
曲娘：是这样吗……

Jiǔ Niángzǐ grasps the small bag she carries with her. The bag is embroidered with a peculiar combination of love poems. Though, she has never really understood the meaning of the words, in some way, they now mirror her own confused mind.
曲娘捏住了随身携带的小包。包上绣着搭配奇特的艳诗，她不懂那些字的意思，此刻却正如自己被搅乱的心情。

Lizheng: By the way, turns out you can read, can't you?
里正：不过，今日看来，原来你是识字的?

Jiu Niangzi: Hmm? You know that I can't, Lǐzhèng.
曲娘：嗯？你知道我不会写字的，里正。

Lizheng: "One can remove the footsteps, but not the path one walketh on."
里正：“绝迹易，无行地难”——

Jiu Niangzi: Oh, that's not what it seems to be. I heard it from the Daoist countless times, so I remembered it.
曲娘：哦！不，不是的。我只是听道士说过太多次，所以记住了。

Lizheng: Which Daoist? In the city?
里正：哪位道士？是城中的道人吗?

Jiǔ Niángzǐ shakes her head to refute Lǐzhèng's assumptions.
曲娘摇摇头，否认了里正的猜想。

Jiu Niangzi: No. It was a Daoist I traveled with before I came to Pèi City. The Daoist said many different things over and over again. I couldn't understand, but I remembered them.
曲娘：是我来到城里之前，曾经与一个道士同行过一段时日。他会重复一些话，我总是听不明白，但心里牢牢地记着。

Lizheng: Sounds like you had a distinguished teacher. Since you came here, you've been treating people nice and kindly, exactly the opposite of what Gětiān has done.
里正：听起来，你曾有一位贤师。毕竟你入城以后，一向与人为善，走上了一条与葛天不同的道路。

Jiu Niangzi: Ah, so his name is Gětiān.
曲娘：啊，原来他叫葛天。

Lizheng: Yes, Gětiān ... You said too many things to him.
里正：是啊，葛天……但你刚才还是同他说得太多了。

Lizheng: He is not the Xiángruì you're looking for.
里正：他并不是你一直在寻找，心中所向往的祥瑞。

Lizheng: A real Xiángruì would never be so rude. It is very possible that he is only a ... Yāo that has been living on the mountain for too long.
里正：真正的祥瑞不会毫无理由做出这样冒犯的事，他或许只是一个……久居山上的大妖。

Her head lowers, seeming to find it difficult to accept such a change in thought.
她低着头，似乎很难接受这样的变故。

Jiu Niangzi: But why did he accuse me like that? I-I don't get it. Did I do something wrong?
曲娘：可他究竟为什么要指认我呢？我……我不明白。是我做错了什么吗？

Lizheng: Because you're the Zhílǐ.
里正：可以想见，因为你是执礼。

Jiǔ Niángzǐ looks at Lǐzhèng, her face caught between doubt and curiosity.
曲娘茫然地望向里正，脸上写满了疑惑和探寻。

Having presented his point of view, the old man rubs his beard and laughs, knowingly helpless to influence the girl's reaction.
提出观点的老者则摸着胡子笑起来，仿佛对女孩的反应感到无奈。

Lizheng: The former Zhílǐ left because of what he said and did. Now he wants to play the same trick on you.
里正：前任执礼已因他之故，回乡去了。他见此法奏效，或是想要故伎重施。

Lizheng: What's more, when he got here and saw me but not you, he acted quite surprised. You can tell from the details.
里正：况且，今日他闯入职祠时，见我似乎相当惊讶。由此不难推断一二。

Jiu Niangzi: Hmm ...
曲娘：……唔……

The thoughts behind her eyes grow more muddled, such deceitful scheming felt too complicated for her to comprehend.
她的眼神越发困惑，这样的心机处事，于她而言似乎太过复杂。

Jiu Niangzi: Oh, and that captured foreign lady, she ...
曲娘：啊，对了！还有那被掳走的胡人娘子，她——

Lizheng: Don't worry. There are people searching for them now. As for us, we should confirm the details for tomorrow's Fortune Walk and Bridge Leap.
里正：放下心吧，已派人出去搜寻了。我们现在也该去商定一下明早走吉与跃桥的事项。

Jiu Niangzi: Right, Bridge Leap, I almost forgot ... If only the broken bridge could be fixed, and we wouldn't need those Festive Animals, nor to jump over the bridge ...
曲娘：噢，跃桥。是的，还有这件事……要是断桥能够修复就好了，就不用年节动物，也不用跳桥了。

Jiu Niangzi: During Gětiān's silence, I was thinking that ...
曲娘：刚才我问葛天，可是他什么都不回答的时候，我就在想……

Jiu Niangzi: What if I can go to the Yuān Temple and ask Zhíxú the Guardian?
曲娘：如果我能直接问执徐呢？去渊庙。

Jiu Niangzi: If the legend of The Divination is real, then whatever the question is, Zhíxú will answer me, right?
曲娘：如果是真正的问卜，那我想了解的事情，也一定会有答案吧。

Lizheng: I guess so.
里正：……是啊。

The two of them walk indoors, their conversation disappearing from the courtyard under the sound of footsteps on hard stone.
两人向室内走去，交谈的话音伴随脚步声，逐渐消失在庭院中。

Government Office
官府室内

Within the pristine government office, two figures exchange information from their past few days so they might agree on their next step course of action.
齐整的官府室内，两道身影交换着连日来的信息，以商定下一步行动。

Lizheng: That is the whole story. Gětiān is now detained in Zhící's dungeon. Jiǔ Niángzǐ is there as well.
里正：……事情就是这样，葛天现下暂时收押在职祠地牢，曲娘也还在那边。

Lizheng: Four hours ago, after discussing with the new Zhílǐ, we decided to keep the ceremonies of Fortune Walk and Bridge Leap.
里正：两个时辰前，我与执礼曲娘商议后，决定保留走吉与跃桥的仪式。

Lizheng: But no colored animals are used this time. The number of animals will be less than those in previous years of Zhíxú.
里正：只是那些生有异色的动物，确实不便再用，规模相较以往执徐值年，有所缩减。

Lizheng: Here is the list of ceremony members and funds. I've asked people to deliver the copies to all the streets.
里正：此为人员名录与各类筹措明细，我令人摹写了几份，已经送到各坊去了。

Lǐzhèng picks up a stack of papers from the desk and hands them out dutifully.
里正从案上抄起一叠纸页递出去。

???: Thank you, Sir.
???：您辛苦。

Lizheng: This is my duty. As for Gětiān, we shall put him on hold untill after the Dùshuò Festival according to the law.
里正：应当的。还有葛天一事，按照法规，需得度朔节后再升堂会审。

???: One more thing. Have we found the horse and the proof?
???：我还有一问。证据追回来了没有?

Lizheng: Not yet. The horse taking that foreign lady away might still be under the control of Gětiān. There was no trace of them when our people chased them out of the city.
里正：……尚未追回。掠走胡人娘子的红尾马驹，大抵还是受了葛天的控制，等我们的人追到郊外，已经在雨中消失得无影无踪。

???: I understand, given the road conditions in the morning rain. Looks like we will have to continue with the search after it stops.
???: 辰时郊外急雨，行路困难，可以理解。只能等此次雨停后再行搜索了。

???: But I don't think a horse carrying a blind woman can go far enough to escape. I'll lead the search squad myself next time.
???: 不过，一马驹携一盲眼女子，应当走不出太远。待到雨停，我会亲自带队前去。

Lizheng: Thank you, Fǎcáo.
里正：劳烦法曹。

The imposing figure, with his back to the entryway, habitually presses down on the short sword at his waist, adjusting the position of the blade. Then waves his hand again to show that he doesn't need to concern himself with such matters.
背对门厅的威武身影，习惯性压下腰间的短剑，调整了别剑姿势，才又一挥手表示不必在意。

Facao: I'm only doing my job. Where is the Zhílǐ?
法曹：分内事罢了。执礼呢?

Lizheng: Are you referring to Jiǔ Niángzǐ, or the former one?
里正：嗯？法曹是问曲娘，还是先前的那位?

Facao: The one who went back to her hometown.
法曹：回乡的那位。

Lizheng: We haven't heard anything from her yet. Perhaps it will come after the Dùshuò Festival.
里正：大概需得等到度朔节后，才有消息。我尚未收到她的回信。

Facao: Noted. Jiǔ Niángzǐ is still green, so please help me take care of the Zhící before the former one comes back.
法曹：好。曲娘毕竟年轻，在回乡那位执礼传来消息之前，还需得您多多看着职祠些。

Lizheng: I will. She is kind-hearted. That's why I recommended her for this position. It will be my responsibility if she makes any mistakes.
里正：她足够良善，也正因此我才会向职祠贸然举荐。若曲娘行事出了差池，自然也是我的责任。

Facao: Well, there are so many things to do before the New Year. It's fine, even if she makes a mistake or two. Don't push her too hard.
法曹：话虽如此，年节事项繁多，难免有所疏漏，也不必太过苛责。

Lizheng: That's what I thought. If you find any evidence or the two foreigners, please let me know.
里正：正是。若你寻回了证据和那两位胡商，也劳烦派人知会一声。

Fǎcáo rises nimbly while folding the documents, as he prepares to bid his farewell, he is stopped by Lǐzhèng's raised hand.
法曹一边将文书折叠一边利落起身，预备告辞，却被里正抬手拦下。

Lizheng: Oh, another thing, the New Year's Feast tonight. You're welcome to Jiǔ Niángzǐ's tavern with your relatives.
里正：稍待，还有一事，是今夜岁除宴。法曹若是愿意，可携亲眷来曲娘的酒坊度过。

Facao: The tavern? Are the people around the merchants hub going too?
法曹：酒坊？那可是金市街坊都去?

Lizheng: Yes. She is hosting a feast for the neighbors.
里正：是啊。她宴请乡邻，理由也不难猜。

Lizheng: It is the New Year's Eve Vigil, followed by the first day of Dùshuò Festival.
里正：岁除守夜。翻过年去，便是度朔节的第一天。

Lizheng: It is an annual tradition at the tavern.
里正：往年酒坊也是设宴的。

Facao: Shuòrì, the New Year ...
法曹：朔日，新年……

Lizheng: Right, another year of the Zhíxú ...
里正：是啊，新的一年，又是执徐生辰……

Lizheng: Hopefully, the Yuān Temple, which worships the Zhíxú, will bring us good news.
里正：希望供奉着执徐的渊庙，亦能传来好消息。

Having said his piece, leaving only a moment of silence. The two of them look out the window, toward the eaves of the broken bridge and the temple flickering in the misty rain.
话音落下，仅余一阵沉默。两人望向窗外，断桥与渊庙的飞檐，在雨中蒙雾里忽隐忽现。

6#1
6#1

空心眼
Hollow Eyed NS-15

The striped horse with its red mane charges through the pouring rain, carrying Bessmert.
红鬃的“斑纹马”驮着别斯米尔冲进急雨。

All the way, it runs with wild abandon, as if afraid of possible pursuers behind them, and perhaps to prevent the person on its back from jumping off should it slow down.
它一路狂奔，似乎恐惧于身后可能的追捕，也为了防止背上的人在减速中跳下去。

Bessmert: Halt ... Halt!
别斯米尔：停——停下——！

Bessmert: Do you hear me?
别斯米尔：——你能听见吗?

The horse runs onward still, even striding several shallow depressions with ease before continuing forward.
马只是继续向前奔跑。它甚至轻松地越过几处凹陷的浅滩，继续往前。

Seeing her words taking little effect, Bessmert attempts to slow it down using her prior experience with horses.
人的语言无用，别斯米尔试图按照驯马的方式让它减速。

Bessmert: *deep breaths*
别斯米尔：呼……呼……

As she releases her breath, she lets go of the mane and replaces one hand in front of the creature's neck, while the other hand caresses the fur on both sides, adjusting to match the rhythm of its gallop.
深呼吸之后，她松开一开始就紧紧抓住的，作为着力点的鬃毛，改为一只手扶在颈脖之前，另一只手则在奔跑的节奏中一下一下抚摸它两旁的皮毛。

Bessmert: Easy ... easy now ...
别斯米尔：放松……放松……

Bessmert: Good child ...
别斯米尔：好孩子……

Bessmert: *deep breaths*
别斯米尔：呼——呼——

After taking another deep breath, she seizes the opportunity to vault herself off the horse and tumble down in a quick movement.
深呼吸之后，她抓住这机会从马背上翻身，摔了下来。

Bessmert falls into the shallows, just as she intended.
别斯米尔“如愿”跌在浅滩里。

Bessmert: Ugh!
别斯米尔：呃！

Striped Horse?: *neighs*
斑纹马?：咴——！

Bessmert: Hiss ...
别斯米尔：嘶呃……

Striped Horse?: *neighs*
斑纹马?：咴！咴！

The horse stops not far from where she lands and turns back.
马停在了不远处，而且正在掉头回来。

Ignoring the accumulated pain of new and old injuries, Bessmert clambers out of the water, but her hands sink into the soft mud along the shallow shore.
顾不上新伤旧伤叠加，别斯米尔从水泊中爬起来，手却陷入了浅滩柔软的泥土里。

Though not as sticky as the swamp, for a while, she finds it impossible to stand.
不像沼泽那般黏着，也同样让她一时无法站立。

Striped Horse?: Madam!
斑纹马?：别斯米尔女士！

Bessmert: What ...
别斯米尔：……什么……

Bessmert: Is it you, Yenisei?
别斯米尔：是你吗？小叶尼塞?

Bessmert: Where are you?
别斯米尔：你在哪儿?

The familiar voice is certainly within earshot, but Bessmert cannot place its direction, no matter how hard she strains.
熟悉的声音近在咫尺，别斯米尔却无论如何也摸索不到准确的方向。

She struggles to lift herself out of the mud and falls again.
她努力将自己从泥地中撑起，又再次跌下去。

Yenisei: I'm sorry. Are you hurt?
小叶尼塞：对不起，您摔伤了吗?

Yenisei: I was so anxious. We must not let them catch us ...
小叶尼塞：是我太着急了，我们不能被追上……

Bessmert: I'm alright. I'm good ... How did you ...
别斯米尔：还好。还好——你是怎么——

Yenisei: I am talking to you through the water. Please hurry up and get back on me!
小叶尼塞：我现在是在水里和您说话，您快回到我的背上来。

Bessmert: You've turned into a striped horse, too?!
别斯米尔：……你也变成了斑纹马?!

Bessmert: Or, is this your arcane skill? ...
别斯米尔：难道说，这是你的神秘术……

Yenisei: I am not a striped horse, Madam. I'm a Lùshǔ! Both of them are arcane creatures, but not the same kind ... And yes, that's my arcane skill.
小叶尼塞：女士，这不是斑纹马，这是鹿蜀！虽然都是神秘动物，但不一样——哦，是的，这是我的神秘术。

Yenisei: I can show images and diffuse sounds through water. I cast it once when we passed by the swamp in Tula, remember?
小叶尼塞：我能通过水中显影传声，经过图拉的沼泽时，您曾经见过的，记得吗?

Bessmert: What about the "Lùshǔ"? What are they? Did Gětiān take you away and turn you into this?
别斯米尔：那“鹿蜀”呢？鹿蜀是什么？是“葛天”把你带走了，变成这样——

That strange term she heard before all this began suddenly reappears in her mind. Bessmert quickly associates it with her current situation.
被带走前听到的陌生名词突兀地出现在脑海中，别斯米尔很快将它与现状关联起来。

Yenisei: The rain is making too much noise. I can't hear you or the surroundings ...
小叶尼塞：雨太大了，我听不见后面的声音，也听不清您——

Yenisei: Get on my back! I'm not sure how far they are from us.
小叶尼塞：您快上来吧！我不确定他们离这儿还有多远。

Bessmert: ...
别斯米尔：……

Bessmert: I don't hear any footsteps from grown men. Come here, child. Help me up.
别斯米尔：我还没有听见成年人的脚步声。孩子，你得过来些，拉我一把。

Yenisei then steps closer and scoops Bessmert out of the sinking shallows.
小叶尼塞于是跨得更近过去，把别斯米尔从下陷的浅滩中拱出来。

Bessmert: Thank you. So ... What happened? The situation is getting trickier and trickier.
别斯米尔：谢谢。所以究竟发生了什么……？我们遇到的情况似乎越来越复杂了。

Yenisei: We made a mistake. Gětiān didn't turn me into a horse. On the contrary, he saved my life.
小叶尼塞：我们弄错了。葛天并没有对我下手，与此相反，恰恰是他救了我。

Bessmert: Then who was it? Who did this to you?
别斯米尔：那是谁？是谁能把你变成这样?

Yenisei: You didn't drink any water last night, did you? But I did, quite a lot. After you went into the room, Jiǔ Niángzǐ and I had a chat downstairs, and she gave me the water.
小叶尼塞：……昨晚您没有喝水，对吗？在您上楼之后，我与曲娘在楼下闲谈，还喝了不少她赠予的水。

Yenisei: This is the difference. Gětiān said her arcane skill was cast through liquids like water and liquor.
小叶尼塞：这就是差别。葛天说曲娘的神秘术就在酒或者水这类液体之中。

Bessmert: My poor child ...
别斯米尔：天哪，孩子……

Yenisei: I went upstairs after the chat. You must have been too tired to notice me at the time. I stayed in the room but couldn't sleep at all, so I went downstairs again.
小叶尼塞：在那之后，我也来到楼上。您大概是累极了，睡得很安稳，可我却一点也睡不着，只好再次下楼。

Yenisei: That was when I heard someone singing.
小叶尼塞：就在下楼的途中，我听见了歌声。

Yenisei: That song ... I'd never heard it before, and I had no idea what the lyrics were about. All I remember is that the melody was soft and a bit unusual ...
小叶尼塞：那是一首……我从没听过的歌。歌词我也无法理解，只记得旋律轻柔，还有些奇特——

Yenisei: Then I found that "someone" was a group of wooden dolls. They were small and would melt when they touched liquor.
小叶尼塞：直到我发现这首歌是一群木头人在唱。那是一群很小的，会融化在酒水中的木头人。

Yenisei extracts the frightening journey from her mind, trying as best she can to narrate it back in a calm tone.
小叶尼塞把那段惊吓的旅程从头脑中掘起，又努力用平静的语气讲述。

Yenisei: And there were horses in the yard, also humming the melody. They had red manes and red tails, just like what I look like now.
小叶尼塞：而且，院子里的马，好像也在随木头人哼唱旋律。它有红色的鬃毛和尾巴，就像我现在的样子。

Yenisei: I didn't know they were Lùshǔs until now. Their stripes glowed under the moon.
小叶尼塞：现在我知道，原来那就是鹿蜀。它的斑纹，会在月光下泛着银光。

Bessmert: But didn't you have a closer look at the Lùshǔ last night?
别斯米尔：可是，昨晚你们在楼下时，你没有看到那只鹿蜀长什么样吗?

Yenisei: I had no time to see it clearly, to be honest. Anyway, that chat I had with Jiǔ Niángzǐ was ... quite good. Everything felt so comforting at the time, so I don't understand ...
小叶尼塞：说实话，我没有仔细看。上楼之前，我和曲娘甚至聊得……聊得很好。当时一切都很让人安心，我不明白……

Bessmert: Then, why are you different from the animals turned from Mr. Jurien and the others? You told me they only have stripes on them, right?
别斯米尔：那为什么——为什么尤利恩先生他们变成的动物，和你不一样？你只说过他们有斑纹不是吗?

Yenisei: Yes. I have an assumption about that, but I can't verify it now.
小叶尼塞：的确不一样。关于这个，我有一些猜想，但现在还没办法确证。

Bessmert: What is it?
别斯米尔：什么样的猜想?

Yenisei falls into silent reflection for a moment before answering Bessmert.
倒影中的小叶尼塞也沉默了，片刻后才回答了别斯米尔。

Yenisei: Remember the river our team found? Perhaps that was the lower course of the main river, and it included Jiǔ Niángzǐ's arcane power because the stream across her yard is near one of its branches. The running water might have diluted the arcane power in there.
小叶尼塞：曲娘后院打水的地方，正靠近城内母河的支流。或许我们遇上的，是它的下游，活水又分割了滞留其中的神秘术。

Yenisei: Usually, a stream of running water is like an independent settlement. It rejects outsiders by nature. Even I have been rejected more than once.
小叶尼塞：通常情况下，活水就像自足的聚落，会自发排斥外来者的痕迹，就连我也被拒斥过许多次。

Yenisei: The striped horses our teammates turned into could be an accident caused by an incomplete arcane skill.
小叶尼塞：尤利恩先生他们的情况，或许只是神秘术施展不完全而导致的意外。

Bessmert: Those other striped horses in the Zhící, are they too ...
别斯米尔：那职祠中那些其他的斑纹马，难道也是——

Yenisei: Perhaps Jiǔ Niángzǐ had no idea at all that she somehow leaked her arcane skill into the river.
小叶尼塞：……也许曲娘根本就没有意识到，她所释放的神秘术，以残余的形态流入了河中。

Yenisei: As for the water I had, she must have made it on purpose ...
小叶尼塞：而我饮用的，则是她亲手所制的……

Both of them sink into a silence made awkward by the revelation.
两人都陷入了难堪的沉默。

Bessmert: *sighs* Then, how did Gětiān get involved in all this?
别斯米尔：唉……那么葛天又是怎样出现的呢?

Yenisei: Last night, after he saved me from the wooden dolls ...
小叶尼塞：就在昨晚，在他打退突然开始围攻我的木头小人之后。

The topic of their recollections, only just resumed, is again interrupted, this time by the sudden stopping of the rain. Yenisei looks up as if to confirm it has really ended.
重新拾起的回忆话题，被急雨骤停打断，小叶尼塞抬起头去确认落雨的情况。

If the rain has stopped for good, this also means they'll need to keep moving to avoid being found.
雨真的停了。这也意味着她们需要去往其他地方，以免被找到。

Yenisei: The rain has stopped.
小叶尼塞：雨停了。

Yenisei: We need to find shelter, Madam.
小叶尼塞：女士，我们得换个安全的地方。

Bessmert: No, child. I don't see why he had to take you away. What if I was there with you?
别斯米尔：不，孩子，我不明白葛天为什么唯独把你带走。如果当时我也在那里呢?

Yenisei: All I know is, he was there to take us out of the danger.
小叶尼塞：我只知道，他当时就是为了来带走我们两个，他是来救我们的。

Yenisei: And he's injured now. When we confronted the people at the Zhící, he didn't fight back at all. I think he didn't hurt them for a reason.
小叶尼塞：而且现在葛天已经负伤了。在职祠时，他一直没有出手还击，我怀疑有什么原因让他不能伤害那些人。

Yenisei: If he really meant to help us, we must go save him.
小叶尼塞：如果这是真的，那我们得去救他。

Bessmert: ... Child.
别斯米尔：……孩子。

Bessmert: All of a sudden, you seem to trust this creature entirely. Did he do anything else for you?
别斯米尔：你突然这样相信他，是不是因为他还做了些什么?

Bessmert: Based on what we know, Gětiān, Lǐzhèng, and Jiǔ Niángzǐ ... they all seem strange.
别斯米尔：按照现在的情况，在我看来，他们全都不对劲。葛天是，里正和曲娘也是。

Yenisei: Please trust me, Madam. I used to think this way, too. "Maybe he's fooling us with a fake rescue."
小叶尼塞：女士，请相信我。我曾经也这样觉得，他或许只是装作救人，实则把我们耍得团团转。

Yenisei: But he's not. He even showed me his arcane skill to win my trust. Yes, he read my bones.
小叶尼塞：但他不是那样的。他为了使我相信，还使用了一种神秘术，就像是……读我的骨头。

Bessmert: ...!
别斯米尔：……！

Yenisei: Can you imagine that? He gained information by reading my bones, and then he actually told me something I didn't even know about myself.
小叶尼塞：您能想象吗？他靠从我骨头上获取的信息，说出了我自己都不确定的事。

6#1
6#1

见我所见
See What I See NS-16

Yenisei: Let me go! Where are you taking me?!
小叶尼塞：——放开我！你带我去哪儿?!

Yenisei: You ...
小叶尼塞：你——

???: If I let go, you will fall, and death will be your end.
???：我现下放开，你摔落便是死路一条。

???: Hold your life dear. You are a lot more vulnerable than you can imagine.
???：惜命些吧。你们比自己能想象的还要脆弱许多。

Yenisei: Quit threatening me. It's a river down there.
小叶尼塞：下面就是一条河，你不用吓唬我。

???: Yes. But you don't know how shallow it is. Even a lantern can't float on it!
???：是。可你不知，这河上甚至无法漂浮河灯。

???: It's dying, unlike the other branches you saw outside the city.
???：它在逐渐死去，与你们在来路上所见支流不同。

Yenisei: So what? Does that explain why you captured me?
小叶尼塞：所以呢？你抓走我，就是为了告诉我这个?

Yenisei: Fine. The river is dying; I'm held by a bird man in mid-air; I'll fall and die if I struggle. There's nothing I can do.
小叶尼塞：好，这条河在死去。而我被一个鸟人抓住，摔下去也会死，什么都做不了。

???: ...
???：……

???: Yes. It's a rare wisdom for a girl of your age to know her limits.
???：是的。自知之明，在少年人身上是种难能可贵的品质。

Yenisei: ...
小叶尼塞：……

???: But I am not a bird man. I'm a Yāo.
???：不过，我并非鸟人，而是妖。

???: My name is Gětiān.
???: 我名为葛天。

Yenisei gives up on her midair struggle, pondering over his name and identity.
小叶尼塞放弃在半空中挣扎，思索着划下一个“等式”。

Yenisei: You can use arcane skills. You're an arcanist.
小叶尼塞: 你会用神秘术。你是一个神秘学家。

Getian: If you say so, then it is so.
葛天: 若你说是，那便是。

Getian: We have gone for miles. I will leave you here. Beyond the ford, you will see the steppe.
葛天: 飞出许多里了，我会在不远处将你放下，此地浅滩之后即是草地。

Gětiān slows down, just as he said he would, and after a moment, he gently places Yenisei on the ground.
葛天如他所言减缓速度，片刻后将小叶尼塞轻轻放到地上。

Given her situation, she had not anticipated such gentle treatment.
小叶尼塞并未预料到这种优待。

Yenisei: I don't understand. What on earth is your purpose?
小叶尼塞: ……我不明白。你到底想做什么?

Yenisei: Why did you turn humans into horses? I believe you can commit much worse crimes if you want to.
小叶尼塞: 为什么要把人变成马？我觉得，你能做比这严重得多的事情。

Yenisei: Are you doing it for fun?
小叶尼塞: 难道你以此为乐吗?

Gětiān stops to the side of a curved tree growing like a bridge over the vines of a shallow stream, face heavy with a look of contemplation.
葛天停在一旁，一棵弯曲生长，像桥一样架过了浅溪的树藤上，神情似乎思索。

Getian: The more you ask, the more mistakes you make.
葛天: 多问多错。

Yenisei: There's no such thing as a wrong question.
小叶尼塞: 问题哪来的对错?

Getian: I will answer one of the questions, regarding ... why I turned people into horses.
葛天: ……但我会答你一问。关于……我为何要将人，变为马。

Getian: The answer is, I didn't do it. Neither did I have that intention.
葛天: 答：我未有此举，亦未有此意。

Yenisei: Hah, interesting. Who did it then?
小叶尼塞: 哈。真有意思，那谁能做到?

Getian: The lady owner of the tavern.
葛天: 酒坊娘子。

Yenisei: Jiǔ Niángzǐ?
小叶尼塞: 曲娘?

Getian: Precisely.
葛天: 正是。

Yenisei shakes her head, not believing his words.
小叶尼塞摇了摇头，显然并不轻信。

Yenisei: If that's the case, why did you leave Madam Bessmert there alone? Do you really think I would buy your nonsense after I saw you take my teammates away?
小叶尼塞：如果这是真的，你却还让别斯米尔女士留在那里——你指望我在亲眼看见你带走被变形的人之后，还能草率相信你口说无凭的指认吗?

Getian: You saw the "horse" in the yard, with the red tail and the red mane. Did you not?
葛天：你方才见了院中那红尾红鬃的“马”，是也不是?

Yenisei: Yes, I saw ...
小叶尼塞：……是，我看见了。

Getian: It's not a "horse." It's a Lùshǔ, or at least, it looks like one.
葛天：那并非是“马”，而是鹿蜀。至少，它的形貌是。

Yenisei: Lùshǔ ... I have never heard of it before. It sounds like an arcane creature native to the East.
小叶尼塞：鹿蜀……我从来没有听过这种东西。听起来像是东方特有的神秘生物。

Gětiān doesn't respond. He only continues to contribute yet more astonishing information.
葛天并未对此作出回应，而是继续抛出惊人的话题。

Getian: It is a Lùshǔ, and also Jiǔ Niángzǐ herself.
葛天：它是鹿蜀，也是曲娘。

Yenisei: What? That thing is Jiǔ Niángzǐ?!
小叶尼塞：什么？那是曲娘??

Getian: What you saw tonight was not real Lùshǔ. Those "horses" merely resembled half of them.
葛天：你今夜所见，的确并非真正意义上的鹿蜀。它们不过徒有鹿蜀的半分形貌。

Getian: I speak of the fact that Jiǔ Niángzǐ might be a Lùshǔ, a kind of Yāo, or, as you would put it, an arcane creature.
葛天：我言下之意，是说曲娘或为鹿蜀，一种妖。也即你方才所说的神秘生物。

Yenisei: *sighs* Your words sound even more complicated than those in the city.
小叶尼塞：唉，你说的话比这城里其他人还要更难懂。

Yenisei: Is it because you are also an arcane creature like the Lùshǔ? Or, you have a thing only the pure-blooded can understand?
小叶尼塞：难道这是因为你同鹿蜀一样是神秘生物，还是这是某种我不能理解的纯血神秘学家怪癖?

Getian: We are nothing alike. Lùshǔs are Xiángruìs, born with red manes and white faces, covered with tiger's markings.
葛天：……我与她并不相似。鹿蜀天然地是一种瑞兽，红鬃白首，身披虎纹。

Getian: In the books, Lùshǔs are capable of casting an arcane skill named The Shape of Will. It could be the same skill that Jiǔ Niángzǐ uses to turn others into Lùshǔs.
葛天：总之，据载，古时鹿蜀会役使名为“存想”的神秘术。曲娘也正是经由此术，才可将其他人变为鹿蜀。

Getian: Do you understand?
葛天：如此解释，能使你明白吗?

Yenisei: Yes ... I'll try.
小叶尼塞：哈。我试着理解吧。

Getian: The Shape of Will is a dangerous and secret skill, as written in the books. The Lùshǔs use it to transform blood into fire and stone into gold.
葛天：记载中，“存想”之术隐秘而危险。鹿蜀炼血为火，点石成金，皆依靠此术。

Yenisei: So ... it's like alchemy?
小叶尼塞：也许……就像是炼金术?

Getian: I'm unfamiliar with what you said, but ...
葛天： 我并不了解你所说的“炼金术”，不过……

Getian: Jiǔ Niángzǐ's power seems to be restricted. She cannot fully transform into a Lùshǔ like a Yāo could, nor does she possess great power. She's closer to a Half Yāo.
葛天： 曲娘似乎受到了其他术法的限制，她无法像真正的鹿蜀般俯身为妖，身负伟力。与其说她是鹿蜀，更不如说她是天生的半妖。

Getian: Unlike other Lùshǔs, she requires a certain medium to cast her skill, The Shape of Will. This is also why people did not recognize her. She's harder to identify.
葛天： 她的“存想”，需要通过一定媒介才可施展，并不如记载中的鹿蜀那般直截、高效。由此，她相较于真正的鹿蜀，更为难辨。

Yenisei: Jiǔ Niángzǐ ... "Half Yāo" ... Is that another name for the mixed-blood?
小叶尼塞： 曲娘……半妖……“半妖”难道是指拥有不纯神秘血统的神秘学家?

Yenisei: Anyway, even if you're telling the truth, how did you know that?
小叶尼塞： 不过，假设你说的都是真的，但这些信息，你又是怎么知道的?

Getian: It is within my bloodline. Like you find your direction through the water, I read people through their bones.
葛天： 天赋而已。就像你以水为媒卜出前路，我亦读骨识人。

Yenisei: ...! How did you know my ...
小叶尼塞： ……！你怎么知道我——

Yenisei: Wait, you mean you can read people through their bones? That makes no sense. What can one's physical condition tell you?
小叶尼塞： 等等，你说你能看骨头辨识人？这太离奇了，从生理结构上又能看出什么?

Getian: Many. Many stories, many sounds. Even if I was never there with them.
葛天： 许多。许多见识，许多音声。即使我并不曾亲身历经。

Getian: Such as you. The markings on your bones resemble an open net, yet it captures nothing. You are away from the waterless land where you once lived, and to this day you're still wandering.
葛天： 例如你。你骨纹织缠，形似漏网，一方兜首，三面延伸，是自曾经栖居的无水之地离开，迄今为止仍在游荡。

Yenisei: What ...
小叶尼塞： 什么……

The girl's eyes widen with astonished disbelief.
少女瞪大了眼睛，显然是不可置信。

Getian: You will travel far many times in life and turn homeward, like the migratory birds.
葛天： 你此后一生，也将有无数出走与无数归回，譬如……鹘鸠。

Getian: Until you find your lake.
葛天： 直至寻到属于你的水域。

Yenisei: What on earth are you talking about ...
小叶尼塞： 你究竟在说什么——

Getian: Have I mistaken anything? I should hope not.
葛天： 我所言有误？应当不会……

Getian: Forgive me. I have long since stopped reading others' bones and put them into words.
葛天： 抱歉，我已久未读过他人骨相，且诉诸言语了。

Getian: Perhaps I did not tell it in the most precise way, but it should be generally accurate.
葛天： 或许白口讲来，与所见有些微偏差，但大体上应是没错。

Yenisei: Alright, stop.
小叶尼塞：好，停。

Getian: Hmm?
葛天：嗯？

Yenisei: I need ...
小叶尼塞：我需要……

Yenisei: I need some time to digest your words ...
小叶尼塞：我需要一些时间，来理解你刚才说的……

A bizarre spectral sound cuts off Yenisei's reply.
一阵影绰的响动很快就夺走了小叶尼塞的话头。

Getian: Careful!
葛天：——当心！

Strange creatures that resemble balls dragging long tails suddenly leap out from the trees behind the two of them.
圆球一样拖着长尾的生物，自两人身后的林中猛然蹿出。

They shriek and charge towards Yenisei, who is most evidently their target.
它们尖叫着，目标明确地冲向小叶尼塞。

Zhuye the Monster: Squeak!
烛夜：咕吱——吱——

Zhuye the Monster: Squeak! Squeak! Squeak!
烛夜：吱吱吱！

Yenisei: Ugh!
小叶尼塞：呃！

Yenisei: These things again ... They already attacked me once in the street!
小叶尼塞：——又是这些东西——我曾经在闹市上见过它们！

Zhuye the Monster: Squeak!!
烛夜：吱——吱吱！！

Yenisei: *sighs* These stupid birds!
小叶尼塞：唉，这群奇形怪状的鸟！

Following closely behind is a mysterious creature markedly different from the other feathered balls.
紧随其后的，还有一只与其他圆球有着显著不同的神秘生物。

Yenisei: This one is shining bright! Get out of my way, out!
小叶尼塞：……怎么还有一只这么亮！别围着我转了，走开！

It is indeed exceptionally bright and long, illuminating the shallow stream in front of them on both sides.
它通体明亮异常，形态颀长，几乎照亮了眼前整片浅溪的水面。

Gětiān stares in the direction the scattered Zhúyè ran off, his mind burdened with thought.
葛天注视着被打散的烛夜们奔命逃窜的方向，心下有了一些考量。

Getian: Have you drunk the liquor ... offered by Jiǔ Niángzǐ?
葛天：你是否……喝过曲娘给你的酒？

Yenisei: No, but I had the water from her. Why?
小叶尼塞：没有，我只喝过她给我的水。为什么这么问？

Getian: These Zhúyè might be attracted here by the scent of liquor. They feed on the flowers of Zhúyè, which can be used to make liquor and smell of lees.
葛天：这些烛夜，或许是闻酒香而来。它们以烛夜花为食，此花可酿酒，其蕊气如酒糟。

Getian: They could be here because they smelt the liquor. But you only had the water. What else could attract them?
葛天：因此，酒香也会吸引它们。可若你未曾饮酒……它们又是如何会缠上你?

Yenisei thinks back to the preceding events.
小叶尼塞冥思苦想。

Yenisei: If they were attracted by the scent of liquor, I think it was the wooden dolls' fault. They soaked themselves in the liquor before they attacked me. I might have gotten their scent during the battle.
小叶尼塞：如果是酒，那或许是因为那群木头小人。我看见它们泡在酒碗里，后来又攻击了我，也许是在我躲避时不小心沾上了它们的气味。

Getian: The scent of liquor stains is not strong enough to attract them here. It would have taken a proper consumption of liquor for them to notice.
葛天：若真如此，仅身上沾上一些，未曾流入脾胃，应当不会有事。

Getian: I worry that liquor is the medium for her transformation skill, but that is only my speculation. If the water you drank also exerts the same effect on you ...
葛天：在我来看，那酒水恐怕正是使人变为鹿蜀的媒介。当然，这仅是我的预估，除非你所饮下那水，亦有此作用——

As though his words hold the power of execution, the change happens the very moment he speaks.
似乎言出法随，变故就在他话语落下的时刻发生。

Yenisei: Emm ...
小叶尼塞：呃……

Getian: What? You ...
葛天：怎么，你——

Yenisei kneels down and her body transforms, just as her companions transformed on the steppes before her.
小叶尼塞跪了下去，身体逐渐发生变化，一如她的同胞们先前在草原上的境况。

Getian: How so ...!
葛天：怎会如此——!

Although Gětiān had already anticipated this moment, he cannot help but be startled by this strange process and flaps his wings involuntarily.
尽管葛天可以说是对此刻早已有所预料，却仍被这奇异的转变过程惊得振翅飞起。

His instincts tell him to flee.
本能令他想要离开。

Night falls. The rain has stopped, and the riverbank is moist and soft.
入夜，雨停，河滩湿润而柔软。

Fǎcáo leads his team in search of the red-haired horse's trail, finally arriving at the edge of the river.
法曹带队，搜寻着红鬃马驹与胡人娘子的踪迹，终于来到郊外靠近河边的地界。

The exact spot where Gětiān and Yenisei stayed the night before.
而此地正是前一夜葛天与小叶尼塞曾经停留的地方。

Guard: ...
巡防兵：……

Facao: Find anything?
法曹：结果如何?

Guard: Someone was here. Seems like a horse, with a female, tall and thin.
巡防兵：有人来过，足迹似一高挑女子，与一匹马。

Facao: Not a horse, but a foal. Look carefully. The footsteps are smaller and shallower than a horse's.
法曹：不是马，是马驹。脚印还要更浅更小，且看仔细些。

Facao: Where are the ends of the tracks?
法曹：这些脚印消失在何处?

Guard: The river beach ahead. The tracks stopped three meters away. We couldn't tell where they went.
巡防兵：前方浅滩，从这里数过去十尺之后就没有痕迹了，无从知晓他们离开的方向。

Facao: That can't be.
法曹：……不应当。

Fǎcáo strides over to inspect the traces near where the trail of footprints ends.
法曹大步过去，仔细观察着脚印最后出现地点的残余痕迹。

Guard: It rained a couple of times. The rain could have washed away the footprints.
巡防兵：如果是说脚印消失，急雨接连几场，是有可能冲刷了河滩的。

Facao: If that's the case, there shouldn't be other tracks here.
法曹：不。这里不应当还有其他痕迹。

Facao: Like this. A bird's claw marks at the edge of the rotten wood.
法曹：例如此处。树藤的边缘，禽类爪印。

Facao: It was a bird of prey. And judging from the size and the sharpness, it's quite strong.
法曹：猛禽，相当有力的趾爪大小，和甲尖的锋锐程度。更早的时候曾在此落脚。

Guard: It's true ...
巡防兵：真的……

Guard: Hey, I found another two sets of footprints!
巡防兵：啊，这附近还有两组脚印!

Guard: They are shallow and narrow, possibly from the same person, a young woman.
巡防兵：浅而窄，是年轻女子的脚印。

Facao: The wood lies on the ground near the river. It's not a good spot for birds of prey to roost on.
法曹：此处，如此低矮，靠近河面的中空树藤，通常不是普通禽类的理想落脚点。

Facao: What stopped here was something even bigger.
法曹：来过的，是更大的东西。

Facao: A young woman met a huge bird of prey here, yet there is no bloodstain at all.
法曹：……年轻女子，与如此庞大的猛禽狭路相逢，四周却没有血迹。

Facao: Perhaps the truth behind the foreign merchant's disappearance is different from the feather man's statement.
法曹：也许那失踪胡商的真相，与羽人所说仍有偏差。

Facao: We need to go back to the Zhící.
法曹：我们须得回去一趟职祠。

On the steppes, a Lùshǔ stands in place of a girl. The fright of this transformation sends Gětiān up into the air.
草地上，一只鹿蜀替代了原本站立于此的少女，甚至连葛天也因为受到惊吓而飞上了半空。

Lushu: *neighs*
鹿蜀： 咴——！

Getian: Too late.
葛天： ……来不及了。

Getian: So it seems her tea can also transform people. I must report this to the authorities.
葛天： 如此看来，即使仅饮下那娘子所予茶水也会发生异变，需得报给官府。

Getian: Stay here.
葛天： 你就在此处，不要走动。

Yenisei: No, no. You must not leave!
小叶尼塞： 不。不，你不能走！

Getian: You ... can speak through the water?
葛天： 你——你能在水中说话?

Yenisei: You know what my arcane skill can do! But I can't maintain it for long. I spent too much energy fighting the Zhúyès ...
小叶尼塞： 你知道我的神秘术！但我维持不了太久了，刚才驱散烛夜已经耗费了我太多的力气——

Getian: I must take leave.
葛天： ……我须得走了。

Yenisei: Where are you going? You need to save Madam Bessmert!
小叶尼塞： 你去哪儿？你要去救别斯米尔女士！

Yenisei: Please, please, I'm begging you! Please save her. She can't see, and she's still alone in the tavern. She must be in great danger now ...
小叶尼塞： 不，我请求您！我请求您去救她。她看不见，一个人在酒坊，非常危险……

Getian: I have thought about it, given that my wand was also left in that tavern. But should I return, Jiǔ Niángzǐ might be alerted.
葛天： 我曾想过的，我的术杖也遗落在了酒坊。但若此时再去，必将打草惊蛇。

Getian: I sense kindness in that girl. She hasn't done anything evil except for turning people into Lùshǔs. Your friend should be safe with her for the moment.
葛天： 我观曲娘其人，本性非恶，除将他人变为鹿蜀以外，再无旁的行迹。你的友人应该暂时安全。

Getian: The more urgent matter is to spread the word before she further repeats her mistake.
葛天： 现下更要紧的是，在曲娘能够有所应对之前，揭穿她。

Getian: I must go find someone to handle this properly.
葛天： 我须得去找能够全权处理此事之人。

Yenisei: Please take me with you.
小叶尼塞： 您一定得带上我。

Yenisei: They believe you are the one behind the missing persons cases now. You'll be turning yourself in if you go alone.
小叶尼塞： 他们现在认为你是失踪案的凶手，你这样过去简直就是自首。

Gětiān is startled, having never thought such an outcome might occur.
葛天一愣，似乎从未料想过这样的情状。

Getian: I see. The world outside the mountains is indeed not meant for me to step into.
葛天： ……原是如此。我实在不应下山的。

Yenisei: But you are already involved. Besides, we gave Lǐzhèng a drawing of you when I was not clear of the truth ...
小叶尼塞： 但你已经在了。而且——而且我们因为先前不知道详情的缘故，已经向里正指认了你……

Getian: No matter. I will reason with him.
葛天： 无妨，我自会与他分辩清楚。

Yenisei: Even so, you will need me there. Look at my arcane skill. It will be the best proof, right?
小叶尼塞： 那你也要带我去。我的神秘术，你看，这不就是最好的证明吗?

Yenisei: So they will know that Jiǔ Niángzǐ is the real culprit who turned the people into horses, I mean, "Lùshǔs."
小叶尼塞： 证明曲娘才是把人变成斑马，变成“鹿蜀”的元凶。

Getian: Is that really needed?
葛天： 还需这般复杂吗?

Yenisei: You need to know that you are a suspect! Even though I know you are innocent, you need something absolutely persuasive to prove it.
小叶尼塞： 你已经被怀疑了！如果你真的没做那些事，就还必须用有百倍说服力的证据，证明给他们看。

Yenisei: All in all, you must take me with you. My arcane skill will vindicate you.
小叶尼塞： 所以，你需要带我去。我的神秘术可以为你证明。

6#1
6#1

舍玉求石
Jade or Stone NS-17

Street, Inside the City - Night
城中街上-夜

Only vagrants and outsiders wander the streets on the eve of the Dùshuò Festival.
会在岁除的夜晚游荡于街市之上的，只有无家可归者与异乡人。

In front of each threshold, sparking fires burn below colorful decorations laid out in the dark night, peering out at each other from across sandy gravel roads that have not yet dried from the rain.
各户门前，燃着火星的庭燎与黑夜中张开的结彩，隔着落雨后尚未干燥的沙石道路遥遥相望。

Bessmert and Yenisei continue their advance toward the Zhící in the quiet, gentle light.
别斯米尔与小叶尼塞，就在这样寂静柔和的光亮中，继续向职祠前进着。

Bessmert: This place ...
别斯米尔： 这里……

Bessmert: ... looks so different than it does in the daytime. It's so quiet and empty.
别斯米尔： 和白天不一样，街上几乎没有人，没有声音。

Bessmert: As if it's waiting for us.
别斯米尔： ……简直就像正等着我们过去一样。

Yenisei stops to cast her reflection into a puddle of water, attempting to comfort Bessmert.
小叶尼塞停下来，在一处水泊中显影，试图安抚年长者。

Yenisei: It's nighttime now. They have lit the braziers. There is cloth of different colors around them.
小叶尼塞： 现在是晚上，他们至少还点燃了火盆。那些彩色的布匹被照得发亮。

Yenisei: Remember our New Years? We put up tar barrels and made festive fires. There were also decorations on the houses.
小叶尼塞： 就像我们在新年时也点燃柏油桶，在房子上做各种装饰。您记得吗?

Bessmert: Yes, I remember that.
别斯米尔：是的，我记得。

Bessmert: Perhaps people here also stay with their families at this time of year, like we do on New Year's Eve.
别斯米尔：也许，在这样的夜晚，人们都呆在家中，就像我们会在一年当中的最后一天晚上，与家人共同度过一样?

Bessmert: A heartwarming custom.
别斯米尔：就像是一种习惯，一种温暖的常态。

Yenisei: Yeah ...
小叶尼塞：是啊……

Bessmert: Shush, quiet.
别斯米尔：嘘，不要出声。

Bessmert stops to listen carefully to the sound. A moment later, a line of night patrolmen pass by from the corner ahead.
别斯米尔停住脚步，仔细听着声响。片刻后，一列巡夜兵从前面拐角处走过。

They march at ease without stopping, clearly ready for their shift change and the chance to get home.
他们面上松快，脚步不停，显然是正要换班回家的一批人。

It isn't until they disappear completely that Yenisei's figure reappears in the puddle.
等到他们的身影完全消失，小叶尼塞的身影才再次从水洼中显现。

Yenisei: The guards here are more reliable than ours in the empire. At least they don't get drunk on New Year's Eve.
小叶尼塞：这些守卫倒是比新年的近卫军要更尽责，至少他们没有在这个时候就醉醺醺的。

Yenisei: Madam, we are close to the Zhící.
小叶尼塞：别斯米尔女士，职祠就在前面了——

Bessmert: We didn't prepare anything other than these bottles. Don't cast any skills for now. You need to rest. We don't know what's ahead of us ...
别斯米尔：除了这些瓶子，我们什么准备也没有。你现在暂时不要使用神秘术了，保存些精力。一会儿说不定还会遇上些什么——

Bessmert: Hold on. I heard something.
别斯米尔：等等。又有脚步声。

Unlike the neat footsteps of the previous patrol, the distant sound they hear this time is of slower and wearier footsteps.
与先前巡防兵整齐的步履不同，这次从远处响起的，是更缓慢、疲惫的脚步声。

The woman and the Lùshǔ hurriedly dart into the shadow of the nearby eaves.
一人一鹿蜀都匆匆闪入一旁屋檐的荫蔽下。

Bessmert: Staggering footsteps, almost limping. Sounds like this person just tripped and fell, or drunk.
别斯米尔：脚步声很不均衡，一深一浅，没有固定的节奏。像是刚刚摔过跤，或喝多了酒的醉汉。

Yenisei follows the sound described by Bessmert and looks around.
小叶尼塞循着别斯米尔描述的声音所在望去。

Yenisei: Jiǔ Niángzǐ? What is she doing here?
小叶尼塞：……奇怪，怎么会是曲娘?

Not far from them, Jiǔ Niángzǐ hobbles along. She takes one step, then pauses, two steps, then pauses, and finally stops as she prepares to turn down a narrow alley.
不远处，正是曲娘在跌跌撞撞地走着。一步一顿，两步一顿，最终在即将拐入狭窄巷中时停下。

She looks completely broken down, as though she has just been in a fight, or perhaps she's just drunk.
她形容落魄，看上去像是与人刚刚打过一架，又或许只是真的醉了酒。

Jiu Niangzi: Why ...
曲娘：……为什……

They can hear her talking to herself in the darkness, her voice echoing intermittently against the silently festive street.
暗处两人都能听到的自言自语，断续话音回响在空旷的除夜街道上。

Jiu Niangzi: Why ... no answers for me ...
曲娘：为什么……总是没有答案……

Jiu Niangzi: How long do I have to wait ... before I ...
曲娘：……要等到什么时候……才能……

Yenisei: What is she saying? I don't understand at all. Madam, what about you ...
小叶尼塞：她在说什么？我听不懂，女士，您能——

Bessmert: Shh.
别斯米尔：嘘。

Jiu Niangzi: *sobbing*
曲娘：呜……

They cannot see whether she's crying or not, but there is a soft sobbing that comes out like a whisper.
看不清是否落泪，只能听见近似呢喃的哭声。

Even so, she clenches her fists, as if tightly gripping something.
即使如此，她还是手中握拳，似乎紧紧攥着什么东西。

Jiu Niangzi: Is this ...
曲娘：是不是……

Jiu Niangzi: ... a mistake?
曲娘：错了……?

Jiu Niangzi: ...
曲娘：……

Amid her silent sobbing, Jiǔ Niángzǐ relaxes her hand. A long object falls from it and into a puddle on the ground.
默然的泣音中，曲娘垂手。一个长条形的物件自她手中坠落，落入地面水洼。

Yenisei: Oh ... She dropped something and left.
小叶尼塞：啊……她扔下了一个东西。然后走了。

Bessmert: Where did she go?
别斯米尔：去了哪里?

Yenisei: I don't know if she's going to the tavern, but she has left the port. That's for sure. We should go find out what she dropped.
小叶尼塞：我分辨不出她是不是往酒坊的方向，但确实已经离开了巷口。我们得去看看她究竟丢下了什么。

Yenisei's figure disappears from the puddle. She takes two steps, turns around and bites on Bessmert's hem, half dragging, half guiding her toward the corner of the alley's entrance, where the light and darkness intersect.
小叶尼塞的身影从水泊中消失。她迈出两步，回头咬住别斯米尔的衣角，半是拖拽地引导她，朝巷子入口拐角的明暗交界处走去。

Approaching the water, she finally lets go of Bessmert and goes around to the other side. Yenisei then lowers her head as though to drink from the puddle, and deftly removes a piece of wood from it.
走近水泊，她才放开别斯米尔，绕到另一边。小叶尼塞低下头以饮水的姿势，从水坑里准确地叼出一根木片。

She shakes the water off the wooden slab and leans toward Bessmert's hand until her friend can grasp it.
她把木片上的水甩干，凑向别斯米尔手边，直至这东西被她握住。

Bessmert: It is ... a wooden chip. Rough surface, and some carvings on it. Is this an inscribed text?
别斯米尔：这是……一根木头长片。有些粗糙，上面还有刻痕。是写了字吗?

Yenisei: Maybe. Please hold it. I'll check the other side.
小叶尼塞：也许是。请您拿好，让我看看另一面。

Yenisei: Starting from the round end, there is a ... mmm ... a person, I guess, at the top; then there is another person holding a bowl in the middle ...
小叶尼塞：从圆的那头开始，最上面刻着一个——唔——像是一个人。中间是一个人拿着碗，下面……

Yenisei: Hmm ...
小叶尼塞：……唔……

Bessmert: A person holding a bowl in the middle, and ... and then?
别斯米尔：中间是一个人拿着碗，然后呢?

Yenisei: Then there is a striped ... horse? At the bottom?
小叶尼塞：最下面刻着一匹看上去有纹路的……马?

Yenisei: What does it mean?
小叶尼塞：……这是什么意思?

Bessmert: A striped horse ...
别斯米尔：有纹路的马……

Bessmert: Gětiān once said that a Lùshǔ has a red mane and the markings of a tiger.
别斯米尔：还记得葛天告诉你，鹿蜀有红色的鬃毛，老虎的纹路。

Yenisei: You mean this is a Lùshǔ? But it has no colors.
小叶尼塞：您是想说，这上面画的是鹿蜀？上面可看不出颜色。

Yenisei: Even if it is a Lùshǔ, why was she crying?
小叶尼塞：不过……就算真的是鹿蜀，她又为什么要哭泣呢?

Yenisei: From my perspective, Jiǔ Niángzǐ is not a bad person. I think she did all these things for a reason—some kind of burden only known to herself.
小叶尼塞：就我个人与她的接触来说……曲娘本性并不坏，只是她似乎一直背负着某种不为人知的枷锁。

Bessmert: Burden?
别斯米尔：枷锁?

Yenisei: I'm only guessing. Since we didn't catch her words clearly, there is no conclusion, Madam.
小叶尼塞：感觉而已。鉴于我们都没有听清她在说什么，或许怎么猜都是错的，女士。

That being said, the two of them fall into a shared silence. Since entering the city, the dark cloud of their uncertain future has followed them like a shadow.
话音落下，两人几乎一同沉默下来。自从入城，前途未卜的乌云就如影随形。

Bessmert: Well, there's no easy answer to any question here. We should meet with Mr. Gětiān before making any further arrangements.
别斯米尔：唉，不明白的事总是存在。我们还是先找到葛天先生，再做打算吧。

Yenisei: Sure.
小叶尼塞：……嗯。

The woman and the Lùshǔ walk forward at pace.
一人与一鹿蜀，都快步向前走去。

The two increase their speed, arriving outside the gray walls of the Zhící courtyard before they might be discovered by another team of night patrollers.
两人加快速度，在被另一队巡夜兵发现之前，抵达职祠灰色的院墙之外。

The streets in this area are built with high walls surrounding their homes on all sides, so that people walking by can see nothing but stacked bricks.
这地方的街道，院墙四面总是修得较高，从旁走过去的人，除了院墙与墙砖之外，什么也看不见。

Bessmert: Stop here. I hear ...
别斯米尔：停。我听见了——

It is at this moment that Gětiān flies over the Zhící courtyard's walls.
葛天就是在这个时候从职祠的院墙中飞出来的。

His wings flutter lighter—lighter than the previous few times, and he has no intention of stopping until he notices the figure at the foot of the wall.
他的翅膀挥动的方式比前几次更轻，更轻，并且在发现墙脚下的人影之前，并没有打算停留。

Bessmert: ...!
别斯米尔：——!

Bessmert: Mr. Gětiān?
别斯米尔：葛天先生?

Or perhaps, he had no intention of staying until he heard Bessmert's voice.
或者说，他原本没有打算停留，直到听见了别斯米尔的声音。

Getian: It's you?
葛天：……是你?

Gětiān perches on a tree by the roadside, tightly clutching branches bearing leaves that have only just begun to wither. The tree's shadow sways. But he goes silent, only stopping as he recognizes the two figures below.
葛天落到路旁的树上，抓紧了才生出些寒叶的枝杈。树影晃动，他没有出声，却因为认出了两人而停留。

The ground nearby is flat and long dried. Without a puddle, Yenisei can only grab hold of Bessmert's hem and tug on it lightly to confirm her guess.
附近地面平坦，缺少水洼。小叶尼塞只能衔住别斯米尔的衣角轻拽，确认她的猜想。

Bessmert, though, quickly understands. She listens to the sound and walks forward and to one side, eagerly reaching around beneath the tree.
别斯米尔于是理解了。她听着声音向侧前方走去，急切地来到树下。

Bessmert: Mr. Gětiān ...
别斯米尔：葛天先生——

Getian: Why are you here?
葛天： 你们为何来此?

Bessmert: Did they let you go? Have you seen Jiǔ Niángzǐ? She was on the street just now ...
别斯米尔： 您被放出来了？那曲娘呢？刚才她还在街上——

Getian: Whatever speculation you are making, I am leaving.
葛天： 无论你的猜测如何，我都会离开。

Bessmert: Leaving? Are you going after her?
别斯米尔： 您说要走，是要去找曲娘对峙吗?

Getian: No. I was not meant to be here in the first place. It's only natural that I should return to the mountain.
葛天： 不。我本就不应下山，如今回去，也只是顺势而为。

Bessmert: Return? But we're not done with Jiǔ Niángzǐ yet. Yenisei and the others are still in the shape of Lùshǔ ...
别斯米尔： 回去？但是曲娘的事还没得到解决，还有小叶尼塞，她和其他人都仍然是鹿蜀……

Bessmert: She was turned into a Lùshǔ in front of you. Are you going to just let her be?
别斯米尔： 您难道不是看着她变成鹿蜀的吗?

Getian: She has told you everything.
葛天： 她已全数告知与你。

Bessmert: Yes, she did! Now you're the only one who can persuade others to go after Jiǔ Niángzǐ ... We are foreigners here. People won't listen to us.
别斯米尔： 当然！现在只有您能说服其他人，追究曲娘……我们两个，作为异乡人，是做不到这点的。

Getian: I am left with no other options. Today, at the Zhící, none of us would have gotten away if I hadn't surrendered.
葛天： ……我亦无可奈何。就连今日职祠之事，是我自愿被俘，你们才得以逃走。

This is a fact that, as an observer of the entire scene, Yenisei cannot deny.
这是事实，小叶尼塞作为全程的旁观者，是无法否认的。

Getian: They will only see me as a greater threat if I insist on raising doubts about her.
葛天： 我若仍固执与那娘子为难，除被他们视作更大威胁之外，毫无用处。

Getian: They have known her for a long time but know nothing about me. My words have no greater effect than yours, for I'm also ...
葛天： 而这一切，只因这些人都与曲娘相识已久。意即在此前提下，我与你们并无不同，都只是……

Getian: A foreigner here.
葛天： 异乡人。

His voice is light, but as gloomy as the night.
他的声音很轻，像夜色一样晦暗。

Bessmert: Still, you're going to just give it all up before exhausting every possible way to end this?
别斯米尔： 即使是这样，您还没有用尽办法，就要放弃吗?

A wave of swaying tree shadows causes Gětiān to fly up on alert. He seems to have finally made up his mind to leave.
一阵树影的晃动，是葛天防备地飞了起来。他似乎真的打定主意离开。

Getian: You need not prick my pride. Gětiāns and Mièméngs are never meant to get involved in this.
葛天： ……不必激我。无论葛天氏，抑或灭蒙鸟，都不欠你们任何东西。

Before a response is issued, the sound of rhythmic footsteps sounds, one after another.
不待反应，整齐的脚步声就纷至沓来。

Whether it is the patrol or some other city personnel, it is enough to immediately alert the vigilant trio.
无论来的是巡防兵还是其余人员，都足以令在场者立刻警惕。

Yenisei: ...!
小叶尼塞：——！

Gětiān though, does not leave. His actions are seemingly not in line with his tongue.
葛天却并未一走了之，表现更是与他的“口舌之快”不相符合。

Getian: There are people coming. You ...
葛天：有人来了。你们——

???: I knew it.
???：果真如此。

A bold and imposing voice sounds out from the spot the footsteps had been moving toward.
一个威严的声音在人群牵头的地方响起。

Facao: You two are in it together. The merchant identity was only an excuse you made up to enter the city.
法曹：你们原本就是一伙的，胡商不过是进城的托词。

Facao: Isn't that so?
法曹：是也不是?

Bessmert: No, please listen to me ...
别斯米尔：不，不是这样——

Facao: The stories you told Lǐzhèng made no sense at all. How dare you come back like you did nothing and break into the jail?!
法曹：你两人告给里正的说法，本就漏洞百出，现在竟然还敢堂而皇之，前来劫狱。

Getian: You go first.
葛天：……你们先行一步。

Bessmert: Mr. Gětiān!
别斯米尔：葛天先生！

Bessmert intuits that she shouldn't just run away. At that moment, the only one who can help her confirm her assumption is Gětiān.
别斯米尔直觉自己不应就这样逃走，此时唯一能助她确认决定的只剩下葛天。

The one being sought for help does not make a sound. He dives from the tree, spreading his wings to cast an immense shadow over the scene.
被求助的对象却并未出声。他从树上俯冲下来，展开翅膀就像是给猎物覆下一片巨大的阴影。

He flies between the patrol and Bessmert, turning his back to them, then spreads his wings even wider until they completely block the view of those behind him.
他飞至巡防兵与别斯米尔中间，背对她们，双翅伸展更开，直到完全挡住了身后人的视野。

At this moment, he truly seems like a bird of prey.
在这种时刻，他才真正好似猛禽。

Getian: Lùshǔs are fleet-footed creatures. Get on her back and leave. I will join you shortly.
葛天：鹿蜀日行千里。先骑上她，快些走，我随后赶来。

Getian: Go!
葛天：——走！

Facao: Don't you run! Catch them!
法曹：哪里逃——抓住他们！

Thanks to Gětiān's cover, the two successfully run from the neighborhood and arrive at the shallow shore on the city outskirts, where Yenisei has now stopped twice before.
得益于葛天的殿后，两人成功跑出坊市，来到小叶尼塞曾两次驻足的郊外浅滩处。

At this moment, the night seems to have become even darker, without a single star to light the sky, and only faint moonlight trails scattered across the riverbank.
此刻夜色更浓，天幕之中没有半点星子，只有微弱的月光散落河滩。

Yenisei: It's been quite a while. Is he ...
小叶尼塞：……感觉已经很久了，他不会——

Yenisei cannot help but think of Gětiān's experience at the Zhící that same morning.
小叶尼塞显然是想起了葛天早上在职祠的遭遇。

Bessmert: Have faith in him, child. He is able to defend himself, since he managed to escape without others' help.
别斯米尔：相信他吧，孩子。既然能够自己出逃，就说明他并非毫无抵抗之力。

Bessmert: I believe ...
别斯米尔：甚至或许……

Bessmert: I believe he is not aggressive. He left his wand behind when he tried to save you.
别斯米尔：先前他为了解救你，连武器都可以抛掷，或许只是不愿意动武而已。

A long period of waiting, pregnant with anxiety, is finally broken by the sound of flapping wings.
惴惴的等待中，一阵挥动翅膀的声音终于逐渐靠近。

Bessmert: ...!
别斯米尔：……！

Yenisei: Madam!
小叶尼塞：女士——！

Gětiān crosses over them and stops along the twisted vines, folding his wings and tightly gripping the edges of the tree with his talons.
葛天越过她们，停在扭曲生长的树藤上，收拢翅膀，趾爪紧紧扣住树木边缘。

The garment on his head must have split during his fight, and now fully reveals his previously covered expression, one both baffled and tense.
他头上的披挂一定在先前的冲突中散开过，才会在此刻让那下面原本被遮盖的，不解而紧绷的表情，完全显露出来。

Bessmert: You're here!
别斯米尔：先生，您来了！

Bessmert: You seem fine. Do you still intend to leave? Or, have you changed your mind?
别斯米尔：您听起来没事——您还是要走吗？或者说，您改变主意了——

Bessmert follows the sound of movement, turning her head toward where Gětiān landed.
别斯米尔循着动静，朝葛天落下的方向殷切地转过头去。

Getian: No. I'm here for one last thing.
葛天：……并非如此。我来，是为着最后一事。

Getian: When I was imprisoned in Zhící, I heard that Jiǔ Niángzǐ would hold a banquet at the tavern tonight, and the Fǎcáo was also invited.
葛天：在职祠牢中时，我听闻今夜曲娘设宴，那法曹亦会到场。

Getian: I'll take the opportunity and get those half Lùshǔs out of there.
葛天：趁此机会，我可将那些不完全的鹿蜀都从职祠带出，交还你们——

Bessmert: Please wait a second, Sir.
别斯米尔：等等，请等一下，先生。

Getian: Yes?
葛天：怎么？

Bessmert: We're not going anywhere. We must release them from the arcane skill and bring them back.
别斯米尔：我们不会走的。他们都还没有变回来，我们至少还需要尝试去解除这个神秘术。

Getian: If you don't flee tonight, I'm afraid there will be no better chance for you to leave.
葛天：……你们若再不离开，怕是今夜之后，就再也来不及了。

Getian: Though her true intention is beyond my speculation, I fear the consequences of her action will be severe.
葛天：尽管我不知她究竟意欲何为，但仅是顺理推断的结果也足够可怖。

Bessmert: You know full well the consequences.
别斯米尔：这些事您都明白。

Getian: Mm? Certainly.
葛天：嗯？我自然明白。

Bessmert: But you won't help us stop her.
别斯米尔：可您不愿阻止曲娘。

Getian: That is not my problem to address. I have done my part.
葛天：非我之祸，我已仁至义尽了。

Bessmert: Then why did you help us get rid of the soldiers and offer to help again?
别斯米尔：那您为什么刚才要救我们，还提出要帮我们最后一件事？

This question surprises Gětiān. He had never thought about it until that moment. He lifts his wings, forming a posture similar to cupping his face, sinking into contemplation.
这话令葛天讶然，似乎从没想过。他抬起翅膀，形成一个类似人们掩面的姿势，又仿佛沉思。

After a moment, he conjures up an explanation.
片刻之后，他才思忖出解释。

Getian: It doesn't suggest my further involvement in this matter.
葛天：……我救人，不代表仍会继续参与此事。

Bessmert: You are contradicting your own words, Sir.
别斯米尔：说实在的，您的行为与您的话语相矛盾了，先生。

Gětiān lowers his head and looks towards the drying earth near the embankment out across the river's calm surface.
葛天低头望向逐渐干涸的浅滩，和一片平静的河面。

Getian: Very well. I will put it differently. Look at the street. It is empty tonight.
葛天：好，不若这样说吧。你们应当留意到，今夜街市之上行人寥寥。

Getian: There was a time when people sent lanterns down the river on New Year's Eve. Even the simplest lantern would glow like the moon on the water.
葛天：曾几何时，城中之人还会于除夜漂河灯祈愿。即使最朴实的圆灯，也相当明亮。

Getian: Those lanterns, carrying people's wishes, floated down the river. The further they went, the more wishes were granted.
葛天：承载心愿的河灯，沿水带，顺水流，一路朝前。漂去愈远，愿望成真的希望便愈多。

Getian: Some would cast arcane skills on their lanterns to keep them from getting wet. But most of the lanterns still disappeared in the depths of the mountains or at the waterfalls.
葛天：但即使上方附着了能在激流之中卫护烛火的神秘术，多数河灯，都仍会在地形高差变化间失去踪迹。

Getian: I used to look down at the city from the mountain top, watching those lanterns float down the streams and merge into a light belt in the dark.
葛天：当我……仍在山上时，岁岁自山顶下望，最终如愿汇入下游与支流的那些河灯，在黑夜中如同光带一般醒目。

Getian: They were more brilliant and vibrant than the bonfires that were lit up all night in this city.
葛天：它们较这城中所谓彻夜通明的庭燎更亮，更具生命力。

Bessmert: ...
别斯米尔：……

The Lùshǔ follows Gětiān's gaze and looks towards the river, only to see the bare and narrowing "river" looking more and more like a stream in her eyes.
鹿蜀也顺着葛天的目光，向河面看去，入目只有光秃狭窄，仿佛溪涧一样的“河水”。

This sad reality of the present makes it difficult to imagine the scene described in Gětiān's words, despite the nostalgia overflowing from his tone.
这现实令她难以想象葛天话语里那样的光景，即使怀念已经几乎自他的语气中满溢。

Bessmert feels it too, but the safety of her companions remains a constant concern in her mind.
别斯米尔也感受到了，但同伴的安危还始终牵系着她。

Bessmert: I'm sorry. I don't understand what you mean. Time is against us ...
别斯米尔：对不起，我不知道您究竟想说什么，我们的时间已经不多了——

Getian: Now, the river has dried up, and the water no longer has vitality. Rainfall is getting scarce, accelerating the dying process.
葛天：如今……河流干涸，活水失活。降雨却始终短暂急促，难以扭转水源的消逝。

Getian: What was given does not compensate for what was lost. So, people no longer show up by the river and send their wishes at night.
葛天：所得不偿所失，自然无人放灯，河灯之俗废弛，成为必然。

Getian: And I have lost my opportunity to watch the light belt.
葛天：我亦许久不曾得见那样的光带。

Getian: Even so, to this day, I haven't fully understood why I was impelled to leave the mountain. I once thought I couldn't bear the sight of those humans being turned into other creatures.
葛天：且事已至此，我却仍未悟得此身下山的缘由。也曾以为是因目睹途经山下之人，遭逢变形这等无妄之灾……

Bessmert: And now you think it's no longer worth the effort to put things back in order?
别斯米尔：而您现在却觉得这个理由还不够，是吗?

Getian: Yes. You people are no more than passengers in my life, drifting past me like those lanterns in the river.
葛天：是。你们毕竟仅仅经过，如同河灯，有或无，皆与我无关。

Getian: What's more, what is my purpose here if the Gods of Shètí they serve don't intend to intervene?
葛天：更何况，若此事连他们所奉的摄提神都不关切，纵使我有再多作为，岂不都是多余?

Gětiān's words are so full of perplexity that they are almost painful. He poses questions like cutting meat to feed a tiger, knowing that there will be no reward after throwing them out, but still he insists.
葛天的话语听上去竟然疑惑到近乎痛苦。他提问如同割肉饲虎，明知抛出之后不会有任何回报，却仍然坚持。

Yenisei, who has been silent on one side for a long time, seems to understand his feelings. And so she continues to remain silent, only looking at the pitch-black surface of the river.
一旁，沉默已久的小叶尼塞似乎理解这样的心情。于是她继续沉默，只去注视漆黑的河面。

The river too looks back with its own quieting babble.
河面也以寂静回望。

Getian: The lights in the river are gone, and there will be no more in the future.
葛天：况且，无论如何，那光亮都不再有了。

Yenisei gazes at her reflection of Lùshǔ.
小叶尼塞注视着自己属于鹿蜀的倒影。

It isn't until Gětiān says "there will be no more" that she suddenly lifts her hooves and steps into the silent river.
直到葛天说完“不再有”一句，她才突然抬起蹄子，踏进死寂的河水中。

Getian: Mm? What is she doing?
葛天：——嗯？她要做什么？

Of course, Bessmert can also hear the sound of her entering the water, but she only shakes her head.
别斯米尔当然也听见了声音，但她只摇了摇头。

She knows what the girl is going to do. The moment has arrived for her to offer her assistance.
她知道那女孩要做些什么。这恰好是她能够帮忙的时刻。

Getian: Even shallow water could also be dangerous. She ...
葛天：即使水浅亦有危险，这——

Bessmert: Trust her. She knows what she's doing.
别斯米尔：相信她吧。这孩子知道自己在做什么。

The water begins to engulf half of Yenisei's body. At the same time, her song begins.
水位逐渐吞没了小叶尼塞的半个身子。同时，歌声响起。

Getian: What is this?
葛天：她究竟要做什么？

Colorful dots of light suddenly ignited in the narrow river in front of them, burning like intense flames along the water's surface.
灯彩一般的光点从眼前狭窄如同溪流的河上蓦地燃起，像烈烈的火焰烧灼水面。

Then, the dots of light meandered to the soft riverbank, drifting with the song, like travelers on the long river, journeying without end.
而后，与这歌声一起，光点沿柔软的河滩一路蜿蜒，如同时间长河上匆匆旅人，步履不停。

The place where the light passes through now shines brighter than all the decorations in the city streets, more than many years worth of river lanterns that had passed through the mountains.
这光所经之处，比坊市的结彩，比数年经过山下的河灯，都要更亮。

Bessmert: There are river lanterns, yes? I can't see them, but I can feel the light.
别斯米尔：您瞧，河灯。虽然我无法清晰地看到色彩，但我能感觉到它的明亮。

Bessmert: Are you appreciating them with your own eyes?
别斯米尔：而您能真切地看到这一切，不是吗?

Getian: I ... don't ...
葛天：……我，不……

Faced with such a scene, Gětiān is struck dumb. He can sense Yenisei's arcanist origins in her bones, but he cannot even begin to imagine what is happening at this moment.
在这样的景象面前，葛天已经近乎哑然。他从骨相上能读出小叶尼塞的神秘术渊源，却无法想象现在这一幕的发生。

Bessmert: Mr. Gětiān ...
别斯米尔：葛天先生……

Bessmert: The fact is ... you've seen too many people and grown attached to too many things since you left the mountain.
别斯米尔：真正的既成事实是……因为您已经下山，已经见过了那些原本不必留意的人。

Bessmert: They float in your mind, glistening like the river lanterns.
别斯米尔：他们停留在您的心中，就像那些您曾经见过的，耀眼的河灯。

Bessmert: And you're saddened by the idea that they will be gone one day, like the lanterns drifting away from your sight.
别斯米尔：而您不愿像再也看不见河灯的光亮一样，再也看不见他们。

Getian: ...!
葛天：——!

Bessmert: But have you thought that those bright, agile, and hope-rising flakes of light would gleam once again?
别斯米尔：但您从来没有想过，那些绚丽的，灵动的，带着企盼的光，是可以再亮起来的。

Bessmert: The path of destiny is not always a dead end.
别斯米尔：命运从来不是一成不变的。

Getian: ...
葛天：……

Bessmert: It's too soon to give up, Mr. Gětiān.
别斯米尔：现在放弃，还太早了，葛天先生。

Bessmert: Here ... It is your wand. Put it away, and please give this another thought.
别斯米尔：以及……这是您的骨杖。请您收好，且再考虑一下吧。

6#1
6#1

除夜宴
New Year's Eve NS-18

In the tavern courtyard at night, the sky is still gloomy with the promise of rain yet to fall, and mist shrouds the heads of all present.
入夜的酒坊院中，天色仍是有雨将落未落的低沉，雾气缭绕在所有人头顶。

But the festive atmosphere of the banquet seems unaffected, and the damp mist is easily dispersed by the clamor and high spirits.
但欢庆的酒宴氛围似乎并未受到影响，湿润的水雾轻易被喧嚷人气冲散。

Jiu Niangzi: ...
曲娘：……

Citizen I: Oh, Jiǔ Niángzǐ, you are welcoming us at the door this year.
城中居民 I： 呀，曲娘。今年知道要在门口迎了。

Jiu Niangzi: Because Lǐzhèng said ... Oh, welcome, guys! You're all here.
曲娘： 因为里正说过……啊！欢迎，欢迎，你们都来啦。

Citizen I: What's going on? You seem absent-minded.
城中居民 I： 怎么了？瞧着魂不守舍的。

Citizen I: Here, Zhúyè flower seeds. I know this is the only flower you would use to make liquor.
城中居民 I： 给，这是烛夜花苗。想着若是你，定不要别家酿的酒。

Citizen I: And here are two festoons with auspicious deer patterns. Not a fancy kind, but I made the pattern myself. Put it on the wall if you want. It would look as lovely as the horse paper-cutouts you gave me last year.
城中居民 I： 这儿呢，还有我自己绣的结彩——两匹不多，对鹿纹，好不好也寻个地方挂起来，不比去岁你送的纸马差。

Jiu Niangzi: Oh, dear, this is too much. I'll hang them up right away!
曲娘： 呀，当然！这……这太贵重了，我马上去挂起来——

Jiu Niangzi: Thank you so much!
曲娘： 谢谢你们！

Citizen I: Don't worry! To be honest, I didn't see that you would be welcoming us at the door. I thought I could sneak in and empty the jars before you showed up.
城中居民 I： 哪里的话。你这就知道站在门口迎客了，我还想着偷偷地来，喝光酒再同你打招呼呢。

Most had intended to spend the festival at home, but now they gather here at the generous invitation of Jiǔ Niángzǐ. The golden colors of the courtyard displayed for all to see, punctuated by the delicacies and fine liquor on offer.
本应在各自家中守岁的邻里，在曲娘的盛情邀请下，都会聚在这摆上了庭燎金彩与珍馐美酒的一方院落中。

Almost every corner is filled with people, who scattered about like sand in the desert, with status and age set aside and all notions of formality cast to the wind.
几乎各处都坐满了人，像戈壁上的石砾一样散落。抛开身份，抛开年纪，毫不拘礼。

Jiu Niangzi: One, two, three, four ...
曲娘： 一个，两个，三个，四个……

Lizheng: Jiǔ Niángzǐ.
里正： 曲娘。

Jiu Niangzi: Seven, eight, nine ... Huh, hmm?
曲娘：七个，八个，九个……啊，啊?

Lizheng: Everyone is here.
里正：大家都入座了。

Jiu Niangzi: I'm not sure about that. I haven't counted them up yet.
曲娘：也许还有人没到……我还没数清楚呢。

Lizheng: That might be Fǎcáo. His family is here, without him.
里正：那么，也许是法曹未到。他的妻儿早已落座，只是尚未得见他本人。

Jiu Niangzi: Is he still patrolling? This late? Is he still looking for the foreign ladies?
曲娘：这么晚了，他还在巡逻吗？是不是还在寻找胡人娘子她们?

Lizheng: Perhaps. But it is not polite to keep other guests waiting.
里正：应当是。我们就这样让其他人等着，不大妥当。

Jiu Niangzi: I see ... Then, let's start the party first. I'll save him his liquor.
曲娘：这样……那，那我们先开始吧。我会给他留酒的。

Lizheng: Alright, everyone!
里正：好，诸位——

Lizheng: The hostess has a toast to make. Please pay attention.
里正：主人家有祝酒辞要唱，烦请听过。

Jiu Niangzi: Thank you.
曲娘：感谢您。

Jiǔ Niángzǐ stands up above the crowd, hoping that everyone can see her.
曲娘在人群中站起来，以期能让大家都瞧见自己。

Although her mind begins blank, some heartfelt words bubble up, brought to the fore by the encouraging gazes below.
尽管头脑中仍是一片空白，有些心里话却在底下殷殷的眼神鼓舞之中，自然流露。

Jiu Niangzi: A-ahem! Everyone here knows that I can't read and can't say some sweet words like toasting ...
曲娘：咳……咳！大家都知道，我不识字，也说不出来什么子丑寅卯。

Citizen V: Just say whatever you want!
城中居民 Ⅴ：随便说点吧！

Citizen IV: Don't interrupt her, you imbecile!
城中居民 Ⅳ：死相，别打断人家！

Jiu Niangzi: Oh, alright? Well, haha, where was I ...
曲娘：哦，嗯？好，哈哈，我刚才说到哪里了……

Lizheng: A toast.
里正：祝酒辞。

Jiu Niangzi: Right. A toast! But I can't do it myself, so I copied a line from the book at the place where I work now. I like how it sounds!
曲娘：嗯，对。祝酒辞！我哪会自己写呀，所以只好从职祠的书上看了一句，我觉得很好听，是叫——

Jiu Niangzi: "I bid thee all to drink and be merry, do not stay thy hand from thine cup."
曲娘：“劝君金屈卮，满酌不须辞。”

Jiu Niangzi: Hope I didn't pronounce it wrong. It means ... people should drink, and drink more, so you shouldn't say no to it!
曲娘：希望我没有念错，“劝君金屈卮，满酌不须辞”……是说劝大家喝酒，有更多的酒喝，不许推辞！

Citizen III: Is that so?
城中居民 Ⅲ：真是这个意思吗?

Jiu Niangzi: Well, whatever! Anyhow ...
曲娘：——哎，不管啦！总之……

Without waiting for everyone present to react, she looks up and drinks her bowl dry in a single gulp.
不待在座各人有所反应，她仰头，将自己碗中的东西一饮而尽。

Her bowl is now slightly tilted, indicating that it has been emptied. Jiǔ Niángzǐ's gaze glides over each face, one by one, and finally she laughs with glee.
酒碗微倾，表示已经空掉。曲娘的目光从每个人脸上一一滑过，最后快活地笑了起来。

Jiu Niangzi: Bottoms up, and fill your cups. Cheers!
曲娘：满酌不辞，再卷白波，会饮千岁！

Soon, the cry of "cheers" begins to echo through the courtyard, one after another, rising wave by wave, until even the festoons on the eaves are shaking.
很快，“千岁”应和声连连响起，节节拔高，似乎连屋檐上的结彩都被震动。

Crowd: Cheers!
人群：千岁！！

Jiu Niangzi: You've always been nice and warm to me since I came here. I can't do anything in return but host this feast.
曲娘：打从我入城起，乡邻们待我就很好，很亲切。除夜设宴是我能为大家做的为数不多的好事情。

Jiu Niangzi: Hope you enjoy the liquor and the dinner. I wish you a Peaceful New Year's Eve. May all of your wishes come true in the coming Shuòrì.
曲娘：愿大家畅饮美酒，除夜平安，朔日……心想事成。

Jiu Niangzi: Er, Lǐzhèng, do you have anything else to say?
曲娘：呃，里正，您要不要再说些什么?

Lizheng: A "Peaceful New Year's Eve" would be enough.
里正：我这老人家，今日只需说一句“除夜平安”，就够了。

Citizen V: Peaceful New Year's Eve ...
城中居民 Ⅴ：除夜平安——

Citizen II: Peaceful New Year's Eve!
城中居民 Ⅱ：除夜平安！

Citizen III: Peaceful New Year's Eve.
城中居民 Ⅲ：除夜平安。

Lǐzhèng sits among them, like a kindly old man from their neighborhood, rather than an imposing governor.
里正坐在人群中，就像一位普通的老者一样。

The crowd loosens up once again shortly after he finishes speaking, the sound of clinking cups and tapping chopsticks continuing to rise and fall.
人群在他发言后的片刻便再次松散下来，碰杯拈筷的声音此起彼伏。

Citizen IV: You did a good job with the toast, Jiǔ Niángzǐ. Looks like you've learned something from those love poems. You must have read them unconsciously after you stuck them on the wall ...
城中居民 IV： 曲娘，这说得不是挺好吗，看来把人家写给你的情诗粘在墙上，朝夕相对还是有些耳濡目染的用处——

Citizen I: Oh, please, that custom is no longer popular in our neighborhood!
城中居民 I： 瞧你说的，我们金市早就不兴贴诗在墙上啦！

Citizen I: I'd rather transfer the poem onto a kerchief and make a purse out of it, just like Jiǔ Niángzǐ did. It draws so much attention on the street!
城中居民 I： 不如说，现今都学曲娘把诗铰成帕子做包，但凡带着出门，人人都羡慕好奇呢！

Jiu Niangzi: Actually, I still can't read what they write on the purse. But the characters seem beautiful!
曲娘： 其实，他们写的东西，我还是看不懂……但字都是很好看的。

Citizen V: What about the one you recited during the toast? You sounded really fluent. Who taught that to you?
城中居民 V： 那今天这几句，说得这么流利，谁教你的呀?

Jiu Niangzi: Oh, haha, that's from the former Zhílǐ, the one who went back to her hometown. She taught me that.
曲娘： 噢，哈哈，是前任执礼教的！就是回乡去的那位执礼，她教给我的。

Citizen III: Speaking of her, is she going to come back?
城中居民 III： 说到这儿，她还回来吗?

Jiu Niangzi: I didn't know any better ... But by now, she should be at home, having New Year's Eve dinner.
曲娘： 我不知道呀……不过她这会儿，应该也已经在家乡吃上除夜饭了吧。

Citizen I: Did you hear from her? If she doesn't come back, you'll have to work as the official Zhílǐ. Who will take care of the tavern by then?
城中居民 I： 曲娘得了她的信？这若是不回来了，你真做执礼，那酒坊要怎么办?

Citizen I: The tavern has never had a reliable owner before you. It would have still been run down if you hadn't taken over it.
城中居民 I： 这酒坊主人隔些日子就换来换去，要不是你来了，完全是个烂摊子。

Lizheng: Jiǔ Niángzǐ is kind and warm-hearted. Such a girl of integrity can perform well in both running a tavern and being a Zhílǐ.
里正： 曲娘为人正直，识大体，有仁善之心。这样的心性，无论做酒坊主人，还是做执礼，都应付得来。

Citizen I: You have a high regard for her, Lǐzhèng. Are you telling the truth or showing partiality?
城中居民 I： 评价这样高，不是偏心，就是确有其事。

Lizheng: The truth, of course. What she said in the Zhící a few hours ago is still vivid in my mind.
里正： 自然是确有其事。几个时辰前，她在职祠的一番话，仍使我记忆犹新。

Lizheng: I once again realized that it's never too late to learn.
里正： 学无止境，大抵如此。

Jiu Niangzi: No, no, no, I'm not as good as you say.
曲娘： 没有，没有你说的那样好，里正。

Citizen I: What did she say?
城中居民 I： 什么话?

Lizheng: Things like "One can remove the footsteps, but not the path one walketh on," "Act not against the nature of thy flesh, for through it all things were made." ... She made it sound easy.
里正：什么“绝迹易，无行地难”，“道与之貌，天与之形，无以好恶内伤其身”……手到拈来的引用。

The crowd erupts in a series of alarmed cries.
人群发出了一阵子大惊小怪的呼声。

Citizen V: Really?
城中居民 V：真有这事?

Lizheng: Absolutely. She is indeed illiterate, but she keeps learning and interprets the classic sayings in her own way.
里正：自然。曲娘即使不识字，也一直在摸索着修习，对典籍名句，亦有自己的理解。

Lizheng: Even if there were other scholars, they would be convinced by her powerful speech. Sadly, the one she confronted was not a human but a Yāo.
里正：当时若有旁的书生在，也一定会为她的话语所撼动，挑不出错处来。只可惜，当时她面对的是妖，而非人。

Citizen I: Confronted a Yāo in the Zhící ... Was that the feather man?
城中居民 I：在职祠，面对妖……莫非，曲娘与那羽人对峙了?

Lizheng: She thought the feather man was Xiángruì and asked him some questions.
里正：她以为那羽人是祥瑞，所以问了些问题。

Citizen V: You actually asked him questions?! He could have turned you into another striped horse!
城中居民 V：你竟然还问他话！你就不怕他将你也变成有斑纹的怪马吗?

Jiu Niangzi: Um, I didn't think of that back then ... This is the first time I've ever been so close to a Yāo. He looks so similar to the ones in the books! So I ...
曲娘：呃，我当时，想不了那么多……我第一次见到形貌那么像画上祥瑞的妖，所以就——

Facao: Jiǔ Niángzǐ ...
法曹：曲娘——

Facao: Jiǔ Niángzǐ, where are you?
法曹：曲娘，曲娘在何处?

The rapid sound of footsteps approaches, and their leader's figure steps into the tavern in several broad and forceful steps.
一阵急促的脚步声踏来，为首的身影两三步便跨进了酒坊中。

The abrupt sound severs the excitement in the courtyard.
粗嘎而匆忙的声音将院中的热闹直接掐断。

Jiu Niangzi: Wh-what happened?
曲娘：什么——怎么了?

Citizen I: What is ...?
城中居民 I：这是……?

Facao: Where is Jiǔ Niángzǐ?
法曹：曲娘在何处?

Jiu Niangzi: Here, I'm here! What's happening?
曲娘：这儿，我在这儿！这是怎么啦?

Facao: Turns out those foreign ladies have been in league with Gětiān the whole time. They helped him break out of jail and hid themselves in the wild with their arcane skills.
法曹：那两个胡人原来与葛天早有勾结。她们助葛天越狱，现已用神秘术躲进了郊外。

Facao: I'm sure it will rain again soon and it will be dangerous to stay in the wild. By then, they will come to you.
法曹：假使不久还要落雨，河边滩险，她们不在外面久留，一定会过来找你。

Facao: Because you are the feather man's target.
法曹：因为你正是那羽人的目标。

In the courtyard, the crowd's gaze follows Fǎcáo closely, while Fǎcáo's own eyes are fixed on Jiǔ Niángzǐ. They realize now that some word of resistance is on her tongue.
院中，人群的视线对法曹紧追不放，而法曹的眼睛则直盯曲娘，似乎知道有些拒绝的话，此刻就在她的舌苔底下。

Lizheng: What ... Jiǔ Niángzǐ, you ...
里正：这——曲娘，你——

Lizheng: You must leave here. You can't stay in the tavern.
里正：——你须得离开这里，不可留在酒坊。

Jiu Niangzi: But it's-it's my tavern! Why am I leaving my own place?
曲娘：酒坊——酒坊是我的酒坊！我为什么要离开这里？

Facao: You are in danger. Since Gětiān was able to break out of jail, he'll for sure be able to break into the Zhící. For your safety, I will have my soldiers escort you to the government office.
法曹：你现在处于危险之中，为了保证你的安全，须得随巡防兵移步官府。既然葛天能够越狱，职祠亦不可靠。

Facao: That's the only safe place now.
法曹：我们只剩下官府一个选择。

Jiu Niangzi: No, I'm not leaving. He is neither a Xiángruì nor a strong Yāo ...
曲娘：不，我不能走。他既不是祥瑞，也不是什么大妖……

Jiu Niangzi: Why are we afraid of him?
曲娘：我们不用怕他呀！

The sound of wings cutting through the air overlaps the end of Jiǔ Niángzǐ's question.
翅膀划破空气的声响将曲娘话音的末尾覆盖。

The new arrival spreads his wings, like a dark cloud blanketing the courtyard's colorful decorations and dazzling lights.
来者展翅，如同阴云遮盖了满院结彩与庭燎光华。

Citizen III: Watch out!
城中居民 Ⅲ：当心！

Citizen I: Waaah!
城中居民 Ⅰ：啊！

Getian: She's right.
葛天：的确如此。

Getian: You need not fear me. This lady owner of the tavern is the bigger concern here.
葛天：因为你们更需要惧怕的，是酿酒的这娘子。

Facao: Formation One!
法曹：列队——！

The well-trained guards surround the tavern, and the sound of running, trampling feet echoes through the courtyard.
巡防兵训练有素地将酒坊包围，跑走踢踏的声音响彻院落。

Facao: I knew you would come for her.
法曹：我就知道你会来找她。

Facao: Where are your accomplices? Are you the vanguard of the team?
法曹：你的同伙呢，她们让你来打前锋?

Getian: Jiǔ Niángzǐ, it's not too late for you to stop.
葛天：曲娘，你现在悔改，仍有机会。

Getian: No more turning people into a Lùshǔ. Too many people have gone missing because of you.
葛天：不要再将人变为鹿蜀了，失踪者已是太多。

This information, unknown present, hits like a stone cast into water.
对多数人来说尚算新鲜的信息，像石子投进水中一样在人群中泛起阵阵涟漪。

Questions and whispers begin to circulate through the crowd like ripples in a pond.
一些窃窃的疑问与私语。

Citizen V: Turn people into a Lùshǔ? But the wanted poster says those are striped horses.
城中居民 V：人变成鹿蜀？通缉令上不是说，失踪者变成的是斑纹怪马吗?

Citizen IV: What is he talking about?
城中居民 IV：他究竟在说什么?

Jiǔ Niángzǐ looks up into the air and stares straight at the looming figure of Gětiān above her.
曲娘抬头望向空中，坦然直视着居高临下的葛天。

Jiu Niangzi: What are you talking about?
曲娘：你在说什么?

Jiu Niangzi: You know nothing about Lùshǔs. Besides, what do I have to do with the missing people?
曲娘：你根本不了解鹿蜀。而且，失踪者和我有什么关系?

Citizen I: He's talking nonsense, right, Jiǔ Niángzǐ?
城中居民 I：曲娘……他在胡说，是不是?

Facao: Save the talk.
法曹：不必与他多说。

Facao: Catch him first.
法曹：先捉住他。

6#1
6#1

如愿
A Wish Come True NS-19

The uninvited guest is not willing to attack, even in his own defense. So a one-sided battle ensues. It is only natural that the side resigned to only evading will eventually lose.
不速之客并不愿出手攻击民众。一场单方面的较量，仅仅躲避的一方会落败，简直再自然不过。

Facao: Surrender, and dispel your arcane skill. Turn the victims back to who they were.
法曹：认输吧，然后解除你的神秘术，将失踪者变回来。

At this moment, Bessmert and Yenisei rush to the edge of the encirclement. The communication arcane skill that Gětiān cast on them earlier is quietly translating the words for people.
此时，异乡人也赶到了包围圈之外。她们携带的神秘术使落到耳中的话语，再次悄然改变。

Facao: We will put an end to it before the Shuòrì.
法曹：让我们在朔日前了结此事。

Getian: But I don't possess the power to transform people from one shape to another, and thus, cannot turn them back.
葛天：可我并不能使人变形，自然也无法……解除它。

Getian: You're asking the wrong one.
葛天：能应许你所求者，另有其人。

Gětiān struggles to hold on and rests on the eaves, still looking directly at Jiǔ Niángzǐ with some hidden meaning.
葛天勉力支撑，堪堪停在檐上，依然意有所指地望向曲娘。

But Jiǔ Niángzǐ shows no hint of understanding, simply looking back with a placid anger. Her look is so forceful that it is almost a glare.
但曲娘全不在意，只是坦然而愤怒地回望。那一眼用力到几乎是在瞪着了。

Jiu Niangzi: Why do you have to blame this on me? I've never met those missing people. And I have no idea what you're talking about!
曲娘：你究竟为什么这么执着于栽赃给我？我从没有见过那些失踪的人……我真的不明白你在说什么！

Jiu Niangzi: Is-is this because ... Did you have a grudge against me or something?
曲娘：难道、难道我以前……曾经和你结过什么仇吗？

Getian: Nothing of that sort. I'm here only to prevent an unwanted escalation.
葛天：无仇无怨。我此行，只为阻止事态更加恶化。

Getian: I could have just walked away, and there's nothing you can do. I could have gone to other mountains, and life would have continued as it has always been. But for those who have been turned into half Lùshǔs ...
葛天：毕竟，今夜我若就此离去，你们亦无可奈何。于我自身，更是毫无损失，左不过换一地栖息。只是那些被变成残缺鹿蜀之人……

Getian: No one can get them out of this trouble.
葛天：就当真回天乏力了。

Jiǔ Niángzǐ stands stunned before him. After a moment, she struggles out an accusatory remark, but her voice trembles slightly.
曲娘在他眼前怔住，片刻后才挣扎出一些疑问的词句，声音却微微颤抖了。

Jiu Niangzi: "Been turned into half Lùshǔs"? Are you saying that the animals in my backyard, and those in the Zhící ...
曲娘：残缺——残缺鹿蜀？你的意思是……我后院里，职祠内的……

Jiu Niangzi: Are they all the missing people?
曲娘：——它们，都是失踪者吗……？

Jiu Niangzi: But, but I thought they were just Lùshǔs. The first time I saw them, it was clear that we were alike. We're just some ...
曲娘：可是，它们只是鹿蜀。我很清楚，我从遇到它们第一眼，我就知道——它们和我很像，是……

Jiu Niangzi: ... half divine beasts.
曲娘：有残缺的瑞兽。

The crowd is thrown into a commotion. She turns a deaf ear to them and once again stares blankly at Gětiān.
人群哗然。她充耳不闻，只是愣愣地望着葛天。

Jiu Niangzi: So they must not be humans! I've done nothing to-to transform them!
曲娘：它们不可能是人。我也从来没有对它们做过任何——任何能让它们变形的事情！

Jiu Niangzi: I'm just taking good care of them, so that they can tell me where they're from, and if they can ... take me home.
曲娘：我只是很好地照料它们，想知道它们都从哪里来……以及能不能带我……回家。

Her trembling words usher in a silence. Gětiān, who knows she has already begun to waver, can only sigh. It seems he is starting to see the whole picture for what it is.
震颤的尾音落下，了解她已经有所动摇的葛天只能叹息。他似乎已经开始看清事情的全貌了。

Getian: ...
葛天：……

Getian: "The Niǔyáng Mountain shelters the beasts. The beasts have white heads, red tails, the bodies of horses, and the markings of tigers. When they neigh, the sound becomes music. The name is Lùshǔ."
葛天：“杻阳之山，有兽焉，其状如马而白首，其文如虎而赤尾，其音如谣，其名曰鹿蜀。”

Getian: The "striped horses" you keep in the yard are half Lùshǔs. They look like what's told in the tales, and they cry like humming songs in the moonlight.
葛天：你院中那些身带斑纹的“马”，即为残缺的鹿蜀。在月色下，火光中，它们哀叫声同歌谣，毛色也一如传说。

Getian: And the wooden dolls infuse your arcane skill, The Shape of Will, into the liquor, which turns people into Lùshǔs, or, half Lùshǔs. As for the dolls, they were once soaked in the water of Pèilín River, were they not?
葛天：你亲手所制的木人，能附酒水以“存想”之力，将人变为鹿蜀，或残缺的鹿蜀。而那些木人——曾在沛霖川支流中浸泡过，是也不是?

Jiu Niangzi: The stream runs through the backyard ...
曲娘：……后院的河……

Jiu Niangzi: No, no way! They went there just for fun or a bath! They should not ... should not ...
曲娘：不——不可能！它们只是会去那里玩耍，仅仅只是浸泡……不应该，会……

Beyond the encirclement formed by patrolling troops, Bessmert judges the course of events through the sound of people's voices.
在巡防兵组成的包围圈外，别斯米尔透过声音判断着进程。

Jiǔ Niángzǐ falls silent. The seeds of suspicion have been planted, and it is now time for witnesses to take the stand.
曲娘沉默了。怀疑的种子已经种下，证人也是时候走入舞台。

Striped Horse?: *neighs*
斑纹马?：咴——

Hidden in the crowd, Yenisei crashes into the soldiers on both sides of her.
藏于人群之中的小叶尼塞猛地撞开两旁的士兵。

Sharp swords and spears brush over her Lùshǔ skin, but she seems completely unfazed, charging straight toward the direction of the water jar.
剑戟的锋锐从她属于鹿蜀的皮肉上划过，但她仿佛全然未觉，径直冲向水缸所在的方向。

Facao: What ... Who let it in?
法曹：什——谁放它进来的?

Facao: Catch it!
法曹：逮住它——

The water leaking from the jar creates puddles in the crevices of the courtyard. Although it isn't much, it is still enough to buy some time.
缸中漏出的水，在庭院里深浅不一的地面积起块块水洼。虽然不多，但也足够支撑片刻。

Yenisei: Wait!
小叶尼塞： 停下！

Lizheng: It's you?!
里正： ——是你?!

Lǐzhèng immediately looks up at Gětiān, as though wishing to catch a glimpse of the arcane skill cast from his still figure, only to find nothing there.
里正立即抬头望向葛天，似乎要从他静止的身形上看出刚刚释放神秘术的痕迹，只一无所获。

Facao: The markings of a tiger and a red mane ... Exactly what the feather man said. But its reflection is a woman.
法曹： 老虎的斑纹，红色的鬃毛……与羽人的描述一致，可倒影里却是人。

A gasp sounds out from the crowd.
人群里发出一阵倒吸凉气的声音。

Citizen I: Oh my, that reflection. Is that the foreign lady from the street earlier?
城中居民 I： 天哪，那倒影里的，不是前日街上那位小娘子吗?

Jiǔ Niángzǐ also casts a bewildered gaze toward Yenisei.
曲娘望向小叶尼塞的眼神中亦是不解。

Jiu Niangzi: You-you are a Lùshǔ. You're a real Lùshǔ now. This ... is what a Lùshǔ should be.
曲娘： 你是——你是鹿蜀。你现在真的已经是鹿蜀了。这才是……鹿蜀。

Jiu Niangzi: But, but why are you still here?
曲娘： ……可为什么，你还在这里?

Yenisei: I don't see what you mean, Ms. Jiǔ Niángzǐ.
小叶尼塞： 我不明白你的意思，曲娘小姐。

Jiu Niangzi: You're hurt. And you shouldn't be here. It's not right.
曲娘： 你受伤了。而且你不应该在这里的，这不对。

She lightly taps the pool of water with her hand, as if soothing the invisible reflection of herself.
她轻轻用手点了一下水泊，仿佛在安抚一个看不见的自己的倒影。

Jiu Niangzi: I thought you were able to recognize your teammates and had already left here.
曲娘： 我以为，你已经能认出自己的同伴，早就和他们一起离开了。

Yenisei: Wait, what ... GOSH!
小叶尼塞： 噢，天哪。

Yenisei: I ... I get it!
小叶尼塞： ——我、我明白了。

Even Yenisei's reflection in the water ripples in response to this sudden realization.
就连小叶尼塞在水中的倒影，也因这恍然大悟而波动了。

Yenisei: Jiǔ Niángzǐ, you turned me into a Lùshǔ because you thought that would help me find my teammates, didn't you? Last night, you said you would help me, so this is how you ...
小叶尼塞： 曲娘，你以为让我变成鹿蜀，就能从那些动物里认出我的同伴了，是吗？那晚你说过，你想帮我，你会帮我。原来是这样……

Yenisei: But I was not asking for help! I was only being emotional or pouring out my troubles. Anyway, I was not asking for anything from you.
小叶尼塞：可那并不是在向你求助，只是某种感慨，或者倾述，总之——我当时并不想从你身上得到什么。

Yenisei: From the talk, I could feel the sincerity from the bottom of your heart. It was too real to be fake.
小叶尼塞：那个晚上……我能感受到你是发自内心地待我。你很恳切，那不会是作假的。

Yenisei: I understand you were trying to help, and that was enough.
小叶尼塞：这就足够了，我能理解的。

Jiu Niangzi: But-but I don't understand!
曲娘：可是——可是我不理解啊！

Jiu Niangzi: The Daoist said, "The one who can protect and benefit the people shall be a Xiángruì." If you can, but you don't, that would be wrong.
曲娘：……道士说过，能够造福一方的，保护一方之民的，才是祥瑞。如果你有能力，却不这样做，那就是错的。

Jiu Niangzi: I've done a terrible job. I'm not that majestic, nor do I look like any Xiángruìs in the book ... I can't even turn into a real Lùshǔ! How is that enough?
曲娘：我一直做得都不好。我不像那样威风，也全没有画册上祥瑞的形貌……我甚至无法变成一只真正的鹿蜀！这怎么可能就足够了呢?

She shakes her head and takes two steps back, until she can retreat no longer and collides with a motionless patrol guard.
她猛地摇头后退两步，直到退无可退地撞上纹丝不动的巡防兵。

Lizheng: Jiǔ Niángzǐ, I think you need to tell us everything.
里正：……曲娘，我认为你需要将来龙去脉说清。

Lǐzhèng, who has been standing nearby, now speaks, his tone intensifying as he goes on.
而一直伫立于不远处的里正，语气正逐渐冷凝。

Lizheng: Have you ever transformed people into Lùshǔs?
里正：你是否真的将人变为鹿蜀，有过这样的行径?

Jiǔ Niángzǐ turns her head, only to find that everyone's gaze has now shifted toward her, needling her with probing eyes.
曲娘转过头去，却只发觉所有人的视线都是刀刃调转，朝着自己刺来。

Lizheng: Answer us!
里正：回答我们！

Jiu Niangzi: I-I swear, I was trying to help ...
曲娘：我——我发誓，我是在帮你们……

Jiu Niangzi: ... to help everyone get what they want. Just like the former Zhílǐ—she wanted to go back to her hometown, so I offered her a drink and sent her back.
曲娘：为了让所有人得到他们想要的。就像执礼想要回乡，我就请她喝酒，送她回去了那样。

Facao: Jiǔ Niángzǐ, do you understand what you are saying?
法曹：曲娘，你可明白你所说的话，都是什么意思吗?

Jiu Niangzi: I understand every word I say!!
曲娘：每一句话我都清楚！

Her reaction says more than any confession.
她的反应早已胜过任何直接的承认。

Every sentence. Every sentence is a declaration—every sentence is an interrogation.
每一句。每一句都是陈述，每一句也都像是疑问。

Lizheng: Jiǔ Niángzǐ, what have you done?
里正：……曲娘，你到底做了什么？

Getian: You should have asked this a lot earlier.
葛天：你该早些问出这句话来。

Lizheng: What did you do to the Zhílǐ?!
里正：你对执礼做了什么??

Jiu Niangzi: I ...
曲娘：我……

With Lǐzhèng, who had always trusted her, turning on her in anger, Jiǔ Niángzǐ's reaction is to grab her own arm tightly as if for protection.
面对从来信任自己的里正，表现出这样前所未有的愤怒，曲娘的反应是抓紧自己的手臂。

She wants to step back again, to keep herself away from the intense emotion, but there is nowhere left for her to go.
她想要再次后退，令自己远离那种激烈的情感，却没有地方能让她离开。

All she can do now is answer.
她只能回答。

Jiu Niangzi: She-she came to my tavern and complained that you didn't understand her at all, and that she was considering going back to her hometown.
曲娘：她……她先前来到酒坊，同我抱怨，说自己的话不被你们理解，在考虑是不是应该接受意见，回乡休息。

Jiu Niangzi: But it seemed far away from Pèi City. She looked sad and tired, and didn't know what to do.
曲娘：可她口中的家乡，离沛城好像很远，她又那样难过和疲惫，不知道该怎么选择。

Lizheng: So, so you ...
里正：所以你——所以你就——

Jiu Niangzi: I must grant her wish, mustn't I?
曲娘：我必须回应她的心愿，不是吗……

Jiu Niangzi: The Daoist said, a Lùshǔ can easily go a thousand miles within a day. If they start running, go faster, that will be over ten thousand miles.
曲娘：道士说过，鹿蜀可以轻松日行千里。若是快些，再快些，日行万里也不在话下。

Jiu Niangzi: If that's how I can help her, I should definitely do that!
曲娘：如果我能帮助她，当然就要这样做啊！

Lizheng: You ...
里正：你——

Jiǔ Niángzǐ lowers her eyes, trying to find more suitable words for her confession, but in the end, only a knot of confused sadness fills her throat.
曲娘垂下眼睛，试图为这剖白寻找更合适的词句，可不解与难过毕竟能轻易哽住咽喉。

Jiu Niangzi: Just like-like now. If the Pèilín River dries out, you have nowhere to go ...
曲娘：就像——就像现在。若是沛霖川干涸，你们无处可去……

Jiu Niangzi: Just turn into Lùshǔs, and then you won't suffer. Lùshǔs can go anywhere they want. To the north, to the south, wherever they want.
曲娘：如果都能变成鹿蜀，就不会这样了。鹿蜀想去哪里都可以。去北方，去南方，无论哪里。

Jiu Niangzi: I can grant your wish differently, even if I can't recover the river from drought. I was thinking going away freely might be a good choice. But, in the end ...
曲娘：就算我没办法让沛霖川的水重新涨起，也能换个方法，完成你们的愿望。我想，自由自在的远走是个不错的选择，可结果……

Jiu Niangzi: But, in the end, in the end, what I'm doing is ... wrong?
曲娘：……结果，这是不好的吗?

For a moment, almost everyone is at a loss for how to deal with this revelation. Every sentence seems to them to be absurdly wrong, but the tone with which she speaks is completely sincere.
一时间，几乎所有人都不知道怎样应对这样的剖白。每一句似乎都错得离谱，但每一句话被说出时的语气又那样恳切。

Yet no matter what explanation she might offer, it only reveals that the true culprit of the disappearances was in fact Jiǔ Niángzǐ herself.
无论怎样的剖白都只昭告着，失踪案的罪魁祸首竟然真是曲娘。

Lizheng: Jiǔ Niángzǐ, you ...
里正：……曲娘，你……

No one familiar with Jiǔ Niángzǐ anticipated this moment. That on the eve of the festival, a time of joy and reunion, they had to come to grips with a colossal disaster caused by such a simple act of childishness.
所有熟识曲娘的人都理应无法料到此刻。在合该属于团圆与欢乐的岁除夜，发觉曲娘竟真的以小兽般的稚气闯下大祸。

Jiu Niangzi: But if not by doing this, then ... what else can I do?
曲娘：如果不这样做，那我又应该……怎么办呢。

This matter is too chilling and heartbreaking for an early spring night.
这事实在早春的夜里这样令人胆寒，也这样令人心碎。

Yenisei, who has remained silent for a long time, takes a step forward.
许久不作声的小叶尼塞向前迈了一步。

Yenisei: Jiǔ Niángzǐ, remember what you said to me last night?
小叶尼塞：曲娘，还记得昨晚你和我说过的话吗?

Yenisei: Liquor has many different names, but they are still "liquor."
小叶尼塞：酒有那样多的名字，却都还是酒。

Yenisei: You can put on many different clothes, but you will still be the same Jiǔ Niángzǐ.
小叶尼塞：即使你换了一件颜色不一样的衣服，你也仍然是曲娘。

Yenisei: Likewise, whether you turn me into a horse, a donkey, or a Lùshǔ, I will still be the same Yenisei.
小叶尼塞：无论你把我变成马，变成驴，还是变成鹿蜀……我都只是小叶尼塞而已。

Yenisei: You don't have to force yourself to become the people's Xiángruì. I think it's only an unreachable symbol.
小叶尼塞：你并不需要……强求自己变成人们想象中的祥瑞，我认为那只是一个缥缈的符号。

Yenisei: What matters is that the Jiǔ Niángzǐ I know would do whatever she could to help others. That's just what a Xiángruì does, as far as I know. Even though some results turned out to be not so satisfying, your sincerity is as valuable as the Xiángruì itself.
小叶尼塞：我能看到的，是竭尽所能地为所有人排忧解难的曲娘。尽管它的结果不如人意，但你的初衷，和我来到这里了解到的祥瑞，已经没有差别。

Yenisei: So now, you just need to turn us all back.
小叶尼塞：所以现在……你只需要把大家变回来就好。

Getian: Yes. So turn back, when no path lies before you. It's never too late to return.
葛天：的确如此。穷途孑立，亦可回返。在尚可挽回时，挽回即可。

Seeing Lǐzhèng, who has been silent for a while now, nodding, Jiǔ Niángzǐ's worried expression begins to stifle a few beams of hope.
见一旁失语已久的里正也点头，曲娘脸上惴惴的神色才逐渐焕发希望。

Jiu Niangzi: I-I will. I will do my best!
曲娘：好……我会努力的——我会尽我的全力……！

Jiǔ Niángzǐ turns around and whistles. Immediately after, the sound of wooden footsteps follows and gradually echoes around the courtyard. They circle in and silently jump around her.
曲娘回身吹了一声哨。紧接着，木头的踢踏声就接续哨声末尾，逐渐在院落四周响起。它们围了过来，沉默不语地在曲娘身旁蹦跳。

Jiu Niangzi: Alright! You can talk now. It's okay ...
曲娘：好了，你们现在可以说话了，没关系——

Wooden Doll: **They, trapped you.**
木头小人：**困住你，他们。**

Wooden Doll: **We, save you.**
木头小人：**我们会救你。**

Jiu Niangzi: What?
曲娘：什——

Lizheng: These handicrafts are able to talk ...
里正：……人造物件，却会言语……

Lizheng: How could you be manipulated by them, Jiǔ Niángzǐ.
里正：曲娘，你竟是为它们所操纵。

Wooden Dolls: **Save you. Save you!**
木头小人群：**救你，救你——！**

Jiu Niangzi: No-no! You're getting it wrong! Don't save me!
曲娘：不是，不是的！不用救我！你们误会了！

Jiu Niangzi: Lǐzhèng, I'm not manipulated! They're just wood! Well, they're indeed my friends ... No, no, no, that's not for now ...
曲娘：里正，我没有被操纵，它们、它只是木头！虽然也是我的朋友——不，这不是我想说的，但——

Jiu Niangzi: They just talk like that! That's not what they mean!
曲娘：它说话一直都断断续续的，不是完整的意思！

The elder's patience teeters now on the verge of exhaustion, yet his responsibilities force him to stay calm and wait patiently for the end of this farce.
长者的耐心早已濒临耗尽，背负的责任迫使他沉下心来等待这场闹剧的结尾。

Lizheng: This shall be the last time I put my trust in you. Ask them how to transform people back.
里正：……我便，最后信你一次。询问它们将人复原的方法吧，我且等着。

Lizheng: But if you can't ...
里正：若是不能……

Jiǔ Niángzǐ knows that there can be no "can't" allowed at this juncture.
曲娘知道，此刻已经没有“不能”这个选项。

She turns her head to look at the patrolmen surrounding the entire courtyard, and the locals with their fearful faces. Finally, she shakes her head to clear her mind of any unnecessary emotions and focuses on just one thing.
她转头看向包围着整个院落的巡防兵，与面有惧色的邻里，最后晃晃脑袋，好将多余的情绪都清出脑海，专注于一件事。

Jiu Niangzi: You-you heard him. Now, please tell me how to turn them back into humans, will you?
曲娘：你们……都听见了吧？现在，我想知道怎样让他们都变回去。可以告诉我方法吗？

Jiu Niangzi: If it requires liquor, I'll get it for you ...
曲娘：如果也需要你们跳进酒里，那我现在去找酒来——

Wooden Doll: **Way. No way. Once turned, no turning back.**
木头小人：**方法，没有。酒，起效。收回，无效。**

Wooden Doll: **The white-haired Daoist. The yellow drawing, on forehead. You forgot.**
木头小人：**白毛道士和花黄，你忘了。**

Jiu Niangzi: The Daoist? I didn't forget anything! And you ...
曲娘：道士？我没有忘！而且，你……

Jiu Niangzi: I see. You must be messing with me, because I treated you badly this morning. This is your revenge, right? It's not the time for it. I really need you to ...
曲娘：对，你在捉弄我，报复我，因为今天早上我讲话的态度不好，是吗？可现在不是耍脾气的时候了，我真的很需要——

Wooden Doll: **No way.**
木头小人：**没有。**

Jiu Niangzi: No, no! There must be a way! I must-I must be able to dispel my own craft ...
曲娘：不可能没有，不会的！我不可能……不可能连解术都做不到……

At the end of her somewhat lackluster speech, her voice weakens to a whimper—an acknowledgment that there is no way out.
苍白的言语到了最后，声音渐渐弱了下去。一种意识到无路可走的标志。

Facao: You must come to the Zhící with me, Jiǔ Niángzǐ. We'll see what we can do.
法曹：看来……曲娘，你随我回职祠。我们再看如何解决这件事。

He signals to the patrol soldiers to come forward and take her away. At this moment, Jiǔ Niángzǐ no longer seems willing to cooperate and instead takes another step back.
他示意巡防兵上前，要将曲娘带走。曲娘此刻却不再配合，反而再次后退了一步。

Jiu Niangzi: I'm sorry. I'm sorry. But I must fix it. I can fix it! This is all because of me. I need to ...
曲娘：对不起，对不起。但是，我要……我能解决这件事。这是我闯下的大祸，我必须要……

She makes a ritual gesture, attempting one final desperate act of self-salvation.
她做出了一个术法手势，试图最后再尝试一次。

Jiu Niangzi: I, um, I will think carefully, think of what I did before ...
曲娘：我——呃——会好好想一想，之前是怎么做的——

Jiu Niangzi: I can do it. I can do it without them ...
曲娘：我能做到的。不需要它们，我也能做到……

Wooden Doll: **No. It hurts. Very. Writhing pain.**
木头小人：**不，不。很疼。会疼。刀剜在骨头上。**

Jiu Niangzi: Urgh!!
曲娘：……呃啊！

A dim light emanates from her forehead, like moonlight or the silver stripes on the Lùshǔ's skin in the dead of night.
她的额头上散出一道幽暗的光，像月色，也像夜半时分，鹿蜀身上泛起的银纹。

Wooden Dolls: **Save you! We save you!**
木头小人群：**救你——我们救你！**

Wooden Dolls: **SAVE YOU!**
木头小人群：**——救你！**

The sound of more wooden dolls leaping wildly rings out. They emerge from various corners of the courtyard, breaking through the encirclement of patrol soldiers and locals with unexpected force, heading straight toward Jiǔ Niángzǐ.
更多木头人狂乱跳动的声音响起。它们自院中各处角落里涌现，以意想不到的力道撞开巡防兵与居民组成的包围圈，向着曲娘直直奔去。

The miniature wooden creations begin to grow rapidly in a twisted transformation before Jiǔ Niángzǐ, who is now overwhelmed by a sudden burst of pain.
小小的，低矮的木头造物，终于在因突然爆发的痛苦而委顿下去的曲娘面前，开始以扭曲的方式迅速成长。

They shift from a human form into strange, enormous beasts. To this point, everything has proceeded almost exactly like the prophecy.
——自人形，变为了奇异而巨大的兽类。此前种种，几如谶语。

Jiǔ Niángzǐ sits slumped in the debris of the wooden dolls smashed through everyone's joint efforts, the pain fading from her face leaves only a desperate look of despair.
曲娘瘫坐在木头人被众人合力击碎的残骸中，痛苦已从她脸上褪去，仅余颓然。

She holds the fragments of wood, helpless—as though she were that weak and panicked girl in the bustling marketplace once more.
她捧着木头的碎片，无助得好像又是闹市上那个柔弱而慌张的女孩儿了。

Jiu Niangzi: Seems what they said is true. I can't do it.
曲娘：……看来，它们说的是真的。我做不到。

Jiu Niangzi: I just want everything to be back to normal. Is that too much?
曲娘：我只是想回去，让一切都变回去。就连这样也不可以吗？

Getian: There should have been ways to undo it. But now even I am confounded.
葛天：有施术，就应当有解术。可如今的情况，却是连我也看不明晰了。

Getian: Your pain is real. Then ...
葛天：你这痛苦，亦不似作伪，那究竟是……

Bessmert: ...
别斯米尔：……

Beside the broken water jar, Yenisei looks toward Bessmert, who seems to feel something and gently breaks free from the stupefied patrol soldiers.
破碎的水缸旁，小叶尼塞望向别斯米尔。女人似有所感，从呆滞的巡防兵手下轻轻挣脱出来。

This static courtyard is like a frozen scene, and Bessmert is the only actor walking freely on stage.
这静止的院落就像一场沉默的戏剧，别斯米尔是在台上随意行走的唯一一人。

Not being able to see the danger gives her an unworldly calm.
她什么也看不见，或许也因此才更加坦然。

Bessmert: You said you "can't do it," not that you "don't want to." Right?
别斯米尔：是“做不到”，而不是不能做，不愿做。对不对？

Bessmert: The arcane skill with conditions cannot be taken back once it is cast.
别斯米尔：有所限制的神秘术，仅能释放，不可收回。

Bessmert: Just like the irretrievable curses and vows in Siberian shamanism.
别斯米尔：就像在萨满仪式中已经说出口的诅咒与誓言。

Getian: I can see some markings on this girl's skull, like an unknown seal. I've been speculating about what caused the limitation of her power.
葛天：……我观此女，头骨上确有后天刻印的纹路，图样乃是某种镇符，不可溯源。关于她“存想”能力之限，此前我亦有所猜测。

Getian: This may be the reason why she is in pain. A seal powerful enough to change one's marking on the bones is not to be easily broken.
葛天：或许，这也是为何方才她看上去那样痛苦。能够改变骨纹的永久封印，即使短暂挣脱也并非易事。

Jiu Niangzi: Skull ...?
曲娘：头骨……?

Jiǔ Niángzǐ raises her hand and touches her forehead.
曲娘抬手，摸了摸自己的额头。

The yellow drawing upon it should have been swept away by this sudden movement, forming a colorful mark, or something else, but it doesn't.
上面的花黄理应被潦草的动作擦去一块，变成一道彩色的印记，或者别的什么，可它却没有。

Jiu Niangzi: I don't know what you're talking about ...
曲娘：我不知道你们在说什么……

Her exploration bearing no fruit, Jiǔ Niángzǐ wearily withdraws her hand and gives up her investigation.
摸索无果，曲娘疲惫地收回手，放弃了深究与挣扎。

Jiu Niangzi: I can't. I can turn them into Lùshǔs, but not the opposite way.
曲娘：我做不到。我能将他们变成鹿蜀，但却不能将他们变回人。

Jiu Niangzi: Maybe-maybe I can't be a Xiángruì at all. I'm not qualified.
曲娘：或许，我根本就不能成为祥瑞，没有那样的本领。

At this point, the story has entered an unsolvable impasse.
故事至此，走进了无解的死胡同。

Bessmert: Alright. There's one more question that seems to be overlooked by us all.
别斯米尔：……好吧。那么，还有一个被忽略的问题。

Bessmert: How many people have drunk Jiǔ Niángzǐ's liquor ...
别斯米尔：在场的人，有多少已经喝了曲娘的酒——

Bessmert: ... in the merry festival spirit?
别斯米尔：——在节日氛围的鼓动之下?

6#1
6#1

别春山
Farewell to the Past NS-20

When the voice of this outsider fades, the fated hour also arrives. Those among the crowd who drank the liquor undergo a transformation amidst chaotic screams, as each and every one of them becomes a Lùshǔ.
异乡人话音落下，时辰亦至。饮下酒的众人，在混乱的嘶鸣与尖叫中脱胎换骨，尽数变成了鹿蜀。

As Jiǔ Niángzǐ watches this irreversible scene, she is unaware that tears are already flowing down her face.
曲娘眼看这无可挽回的一幕，毫无觉察间，泪水已经簌簌落下。

She has made no progress at all. Everything is no different now than it was a few years ago, when she was even more reckless and naive.
……自己竟然从来没有太大的长进，一切都与莽撞无教的数年前别无二致。

Jiu Niangzi: The Daoist told me that my mother was the ninth Lùshǔ from the very beginning of time.
曲娘：道士告诉我，我的母亲是从古至今第九只鹿蜀。

Jiu Niangzi: Great, though, distant.
曲娘：似乎很伟大，却也很遥远。

Jiu Niangzi: After all, except for the moment she turned from a human into a Yāo when she was leaving ...
曲娘：毕竟，除了她离开时从人变回妖模样的那瞬间之外——

Jiu Niangzi: I don't quite remember her.
曲娘：我不太记得她。

Daoist: Your mother was the Xiángruì, the people's guardian.
道士：你母亲，是庇护一方的祥瑞。

Jiu Niangzi (Child): What is a Xiángruì?
小曲娘：什么是祥瑞?

Daoist: The spirit of auspiciousness, the great Yāo who protects and benefits people, like your mother once did.
道士：生而有灵，选择造福一方，保护一方之民的大妖。就像你的母亲。

Daoist: But a Xiángruì is not supposed to have any personal feelings. She fell because of you, because of the personal feeling. Remember that.
道士：但祥瑞不应有私情。因这私情，她为你而陨落。你须得记住。

Jiu Niangzi (Child): What is a "personal feeling"?
小曲娘：“私情”又是什么?

Daoist: It's something she shouldn't have had, for you, either.
道士：她不应有的东西，你也不需要了解。

Daoist: But you shall keep to the path she left.
道士：但……她没能走下去的路，你却应当继续走。

Jiu Niangzi (Child): What path?
小曲娘：什么路?

Jiu Niangzi (Child): Is it like the dirt path we're walking on, or, or the stone path around the house?
小曲娘：是这样的泥土路，还是像那些房子外面的石板路?

Daoist: Neither.
道士：都不是。

Daoist: Stay in this city. Be their guardian. Be a Xiángruì.
道士：留在城里，成为他们的庇护者，成为祥瑞。

Daoist: You shall understand when the day comes.
道士：终有一日，你会知晓。

Jiu Niangzi: The Daoist brought me here, and left me here.
曲娘：……道士带走我，却又离开我。

Jiu Niangzi: That's exactly what my mother, the former Xiángruì, did to me as well. So I took departure as the price of living in the human world.
曲娘：曾是祥瑞的母亲也同样如此，于是我以为，分离是步入人间必须付出的代价。

Jiu Niangzi: Before I came into Pèi City, the Daoist guaranteed me that ...
曲娘：将我关入沛城前，道士也曾经允诺我——

Jiu Niangzi: "Be a Xiángruì, and then you will understand her."
曲娘：“成为祥瑞，便能理解她，触及她。”

Jiu Niangzi: How alluring was that! That's why I chose to stay here.
曲娘：这话很诱人，于是我就留了下来。

Jiu Niangzi: At first, I couldn't stop thinking about what the Daoist said, but I had no idea how.
曲娘：起初，我日夜不停地咀嚼这句话，却实在不知道应该怎么做。

Jiu Niangzi: Because I was never taught how by anyone.
曲娘：因为道士也从未指点我应该怎么做。

Jiu Niangzi: I didn't have any other choice, so ...
曲娘：可我也没有其他的选择，于是……

Jiu Niangzi: So I started to recall my mother by piecing together the scattered words and descriptions from books and legends, to recall what a Xiángruì is.
曲娘：于是我开始从那些散落的话语，从不同的画册里，从不可触及的传奇中，试着拼凑起一个母亲，一个祥瑞。

Jiu Niangzi: I tried to be her, tried to replace her.
曲娘：然后学着成为它，学着取代它。

Jiu Niangzi: Just to meet her, once again.
曲娘：——却也是为了再次见到她。

Jiu Niangzi: If I got to meet her, I would ask her, "What was on your mind?"
曲娘：我想问问她，你是怎样想的呢?

Jiu Niangzi: If only you could see me doing such a great job as a Xiángruì, would you feel even the slightest twinge of guilt? For deserting me, for leaving me alone.
曲娘：若是知道我这祥瑞，做得这样好，会不会有哪怕一点的后悔呢？后悔离开我，后悔将我一人留下。

Jiu Niangzi: Well.
曲娘：……好吧。

Jiu Niangzi: Looks like I've neither truly understood her, nor a Xiángruì.
曲娘：现在看来，我其实从未真正理解过她，也没有真正理解过“祥瑞”。

Between the two people standing in the courtyard walkway in the silent rain, a decision is made.
院中廊下站立着两人。在沉默的雨幕中，一个抉择已经被定下。

Facao: Jiǔ Niángzǐ, are you really going to ...
法曹：曲娘，你难道真的要……

As someone who has always been steadfast in his will, he rarely hesitates. He doesn't know which words to use to emphasize the danger of this matter to the person in front of him, or whether all words are powerless before her final choice.
作为一个从来意志坚定的人，他难得犹疑了，不知应该摘撷何种词句才能向眼前人强调此事的危险，又或是一切言语在她的选择前都显得苍白。

And so, ultimately, he remains silent.
所以他最终还是沉默了。

Jiu Niangzi: It's fine. I know there's no one who could jump over it. In order to stop me, Lǐzhèng even told me some stories, and they were ... not very suitable for children.
曲娘：我知道，从来都没有人真的跳过去了。里正为了告诫我，还讲过许多故事。一些不适合用来告诫孩童的故事。

Jiu Niangzi: But I have to, because there is no other way ...
曲娘：可我一定得去。因为只有这个方法了。

Jiu Niangzi: Only The Divination.
曲娘：只有问卜——

Jiu Niangzi: Well, you can't talk about Shuòrì without The Divination, right?
曲娘：而且，朔日本就应该有问卜。

Jiu Niangzi: ...
曲娘：……

Jiu Niangzi: Thank you for letting me go. You even brought me the clothes. But the Zhílǐ is not here. I'm not sure if I'm wearing it right ...
曲娘：谢谢您愿意放我走，甚至还替我取来了衣服。虽然执礼不在，我都不知道怎么穿它才对……

Jiu Niangzi: But it's ok. Even if it's wrong, it still looks new and colorful.
曲娘：但没关系。新衣服始终是新衣服，不会因为我穿得不好，就变了味道。

She pats the hem of her skirt aimlessly, then folds the cuffs, and finally folds back the silk drapes once more. When she cannot find anything else to fix, her farewell rises to the tip of her tongue.
她毫无目的地拍了拍裙边，又翻折了一下袖口，最后将披帛重新拢起来。直至再也找不到可以做的事，道别的话也正好走到舌尖。

Jiu Niangzi: Thank you. Thank you so very much. I-er, I ...
曲娘：……谢谢，真的谢谢您。那我这就——

Jiu Niangzi: I'm leaving, then.
曲娘：嗯，我走了。

Jiǔ Niángzǐ steps back and places her hands beneath her forehead, palm to back. She bows farewell to Fǎcáo in the hallway and the Lùshǔ turned from Lǐzhèng.
说完，曲娘后退两步，将双手以掌心贴手背的方式交叠，置于额下。她向此刻站在廊下的法曹，和已经变为鹿蜀的里正鞠躬告别。

A gesture of gratitude and an apology. She has never performed such a ritual before—this will be the first and last time.
是感谢，也是歉意。她从来没有行过这样的礼，这是第一次也是最后一次。

Facao: Perhaps we will find another way. You don't have to ...
法曹：……也许，我们会找到其他法子。你不必——

He doesn't finish. Because anything he wants to say would be untrue, an example of unwarranted comfort from a survivor toward their aggressor.
他没有说完。因为这显然并非实话，甚至是幸存者对元凶不必要的宽慰。

And so, Jiǔ Niángzǐ says nothing. She shakes her head as if she hadn't even heard his proposal, retreating into the rain, and then turns around and walks towards the outside of the Zhící.
所以曲娘也没有说话。她摇了摇头，仿佛没有听到这个提议一般后退，退进雨中，然后转身向着职祠之外迈去。

Her footsteps have never been so relaxed before, with each step becoming faster and faster, almost evolving into a sprint toward the end.
她的脚步从未如此松快，步子越走越急，到最后几乎变为了奔跑。

She runs toward the outside of the city, but not to escape.
——她向着城外奔去，却并不是为了逃离这里。

Broken Bridge, Outside the City
城外断桥

The rain has not stopped since the previous night.
这雨从昨夜起就再没停下过。

Outside the city, Bessmert and Yenisei stand at the end of the broken bridge, gazing at the misty bank opposite to them.
城外，别斯米尔同小叶尼塞站在断桥这头，眺望雾气缭绕的对岸。

Gětiān is perched on the tree above their heads. He has been here all along, arriving earlier than the others.
葛天停在她们头顶的树上。他一直在，来得比所有人都要早。

Bessmert: Mr. Gětiān, we ...
别斯米尔：葛天先生，我们……

Bessmert: We are left with only one option, which is to stand here and pray for her, correct?
别斯米尔：我们只能在这里，对着断桥祈祷了，对吗?

Bessmert: Pray that the Ask and Acquire, or The Divination, will answer us and give us what we want in a flash.
别斯米尔：祈祷那个“所求必应”，或者说问卜，能够灵光一闪地实现。

Bessmert: But is it really possible?
别斯米尔：——说实在的，这有可能吗?

Getian: ...
葛天：……

Getian: I think not. We should go.
葛天：并无可能，还是放弃罢。

Bessmert listens to the advancing footsteps around her, emanating from all those who are walking toward the broken bridge, still remembering the auspicious significance of this New Year's Day.
别斯米尔听着周围越来越多的脚步声，来自那些朝断桥走来，仍记挂着朔日走吉的人们。

At first, she tries to distinguish the voices that might be Fǎcáo and the others, but as the rain grows heavier and louder, she finally gives up.
一开始她还尝试去分辨法曹他们可能身处其中的声音，直到雨越来越大，才终于放弃。

Bessmert: I heard today is a special day for the locals, known as "Suìzhāochūn."
别斯米尔：我听见他们说，今天是度朔节的第一天，也是岁朝春。

Bessmert: Mr. Gětiān, what is Suìzhāochūn?
别斯米尔：葛天先生，什么是“岁朝春”?

Bessmert holds her wet fringe to one side, and tilts the oiled umbrella towards Yenisei.
别斯米尔把淋湿的额发别向一边，油伞也朝小叶尼塞倾斜而去。

The Lùshǔ silently approaches and leans against her tightly.
鹿蜀沉默着靠近，使潮湿紧贴着潮湿。

Getian: It comes from an ancient proverb, "Bǎizǎi Nánféng Suìzhāochūn."
葛天：“百载难逢岁朝春。”

Getian: It's the first day of a new year and the first day of spring.
葛天：既是朔日，也是立春。

Getian: Lìchūn, the beginning of spring, corresponds to the lower trigram of Kǎn in the direction of Gèn. It is the season of life.
葛天：立春，艮位坎卦下，应乘春令。

Getian: A time when the weather is clear and Yáng fills the air.
葛天：……气清而温阳。

Bessmert: They are pleasing to the ears.
别斯米尔：听起来很厉害。

Bessmert: But I don't know what to make of it when all these are put together.
别斯米尔：但这些句子合在一起，我什么也没听明白。

Getian: Lìchūn is one of the 24 solar terms. It signifies the beginning of spring.
葛天：……立春是一个节气，表明春季将临。

Getian: Suìzhāochūn is how people would call it when the first day of the Dùshuò Festival and the first day of spring happen to be the same day. It is a once-in-a-century good sign.
葛天：岁朝春则是立春与度朔节第一日重叠，百年不遇，实为难得。

Bessmert: Indeed. It's also the first day of a new year. I like the coincidence.
别斯米尔：听起来是很难得的日子，还是新年的第一天，这很好。

Getian: Do you still find it equally pleasing if your teammates are not coming back?
葛天：但你的同伴，或许都无法变回来了。即使如此，你也认为很好?

Bessmert: Then, I will take them home as they are now and see what I can do.
别斯米尔：那我就这样带他们回去，再做打算。

Getian: ...
葛天：……

Bessmert: I know the words are hidden behind your silence, but this is the best option for now.
别斯米尔：没必要用沉默来回应我。这只是目前看来的最佳选择。

Bessmert: After all, as you just said, prayers are not enough to bring them back.
别斯米尔：毕竟，您也说了，光靠祈祷是不能让他们都变回去的。

Getian: They could, for a time.
葛天：曾经是可以的。

Bessmert: But that's only what happened in the past, as you just said. Good days only exist in our memories.
别斯米尔：但您同时也说了，那是以前。从前总是有好时光的。

Getian: That was before the flood. The aftermath of that disaster lasted longer than I thought.
葛天：是在那场洪水之前……我原以为那洪水造成的破坏，并不会遗留至今。

Getian: I was so wrong to think it was over.
葛天：显然，我错了。

Bessmert looks up. A drop of rain falls right onto the fabric she uses to cover her eyes. Then more falls, and more, gradually wetting the entire weaved surface.
别斯米尔仰起头。一滴雨正好坠在她用以遮盖眼睛的布料上。随后是更多更多，逐渐湿濡了整块纺面。

She listens without intending any comment.
她听着，且不打算发表评价。

Getian: It all began with the unstoppable flood. At first, it was just a few unusual tides that no one noticed.
葛天：……起先是……不可回流到上游的汹涌洪水。少许水波的变化，声音细微，因此无人注意。

Getian: Then the flood came, followed by the destruction of the bridge.
葛天：然后是洪水肆虐后，无可修复的断桥。

Getian: The temple on the mountain thus lost its connection to its pilgrims. The prayers were no longer answered.
葛天：紧接着，才是失去香火的山上渊庙，和无人应答的问卜习俗。

Getian: I do not understand what caused all these things. My people left the mountain to help with the situation, but they never came back.
葛天：关于这些，我无从知晓原因。那些下了山，对这一切施以援手，了解真相的同族，也都没有再回来。

Getian: And now ...
葛天：而现在……

Getian: Even this river beneath us is gone, just like the Yuān Temple, forever lost in the fog.
葛天：连下方这条河，也将如隐入雾气之中的渊庙一般失落了。

Getian: ...
葛天：……

Behind them, the city residents gradually approach and carve words of divination onto the wooden sticks in their hands, just as they had in previous years.
几人身后，逐渐有普通的城中居民走上前来，像往年一样在手中的木签上，刻下问卜之辞。

They are prepared for the fact that there may not be an answer to their questions, but they know nothing of the reason why.
他们对这问卜无人应答的事实早有准备，却对其中原因一无所知。

Bessmert feels the weight of the growing crowd. They gather and write in the rain, working tirelessly for a long time.
别斯米尔望着越来越多的人。他们聚拢去，在雨中刻写，久久做着无用功。

Is it the eternal fate of humans and arcanists to act upon desires they know cannot be realized?
明知不可为而为之，这是人类与神秘学家亘古不变的常态吗?

Getian: It's useless. The god won't hear us, nor will It see us.
葛天：白费力气。祂听不见，也看不到。

Bessmert: Please know that I don't mean to offend you with this question.
别斯米尔：……我不知道这样问，是不是一种冒犯。

Getian: Please.
葛天：请讲。

Bessmert: Can't you take those people to the other end of the bridge?
别斯米尔：难道您不能带着那些人到对岸去吗?

Bessmert: If the condition of The Divination is to go across the broken bridge ...
别斯米尔：如果现在问卜能得偿所愿的条件，是跃过断桥——

Getian: Though we are both outsiders in this place, you're more naive than I am.
葛天：的确，你才是天真的外乡人。

Bessmert: Emm ...?
别斯米尔：嗯……?

Getian: One can only meet the condition by going over the bridge oneself, even if the price is their life.
葛天：自然只有自己走过去，或者跃过去，才可作数，即使那要以付出仅此一次的生命为代价。

Getian: You might think it's cruel. But what good would it do if people were easily given what they asked for without paying a price?
葛天：或许你会揣测，这是否太过残酷。可若真如你所说，祂所求必应，然却随手可得，毋需付出……

Getian: Wouldn't it make others' suffering a joke?
葛天：那此地一切生灵的困苦，不都如同笑话一般吗?

Bessmert: ...
别斯米尔：……

Gětiān lowers his head to look at Bessmert and the quiet Yenisei beside him, thinking that they perhaps do not believe his words.
葛天低头去看别斯米尔，和一旁没有动静的小叶尼塞，认为对方并没有相信自己的话。

He rarely needs to say so much to others in such a short space of time. But since he has already started, he might as well finish.
他很少需要在几日之内与其他人说这么多。但既然已经起了头，不如将对子作完。

Getian: You don't believe me.
葛天：你不信我的话。

Bessmert: I'm ... trying to understand.
别斯米尔：我是……在尝试理解。

Getian: It's all the same. I can take you to the other side of the bridge, but you must not be disappointed if it ends up fruitless.
葛天：并无不同。我能够带你飞往对岸，但你应当做好这毫无用处的准备。

Bessmert: Pardon?
别斯米尔：……什么?

Getian: I can take you there.
葛天：我可以带你飞过去。

Bessmert: Why? Why the change of mind?
别斯米尔：为什么？为什么您突然改变了主意?

Getian: Mm? Haven't I mentioned it before?
葛天：嗯？我从未提起过吗?

Bessmert: Mentioned what?
别斯米尔：提起什么?

Getian: Your bones. Among all the others, you are the only one for whom I do not recognize the markings on your bones.
葛天：你的骨相。你的骨相是我所见之人当中，唯一不可堪识的。

6#1
6#1

天堑亦通途
Another Way Out NS-21

This new discovery swiftly draws Bessmert's attention away from the broken bridge.
一个全新的发现，轻易将别斯米尔的注意力从飞跃断桥上全部吸引过去。

Bessmert: Mm? What is that supposed to mean?
别斯米尔：嗯？这是什么意思?

Getian: Judging from the fact that you have unreadable bones, you're certainly neither a Yāo, nor a human. A grumkin? No.
葛天：从骨相不可识读这点看来，你不是妖，也不是人。精怪？亦不相同。

Bessmert: Oh, I'm also an arcanist.
别斯米尔：噢，我也是一位神秘学家。

Getian: My instinct told me that I should flee to the end of the world the moment I saw you.
葛天：直觉告诉我，应在看到你的那一刻，就逃去天涯海角……

Bessmert: You did run away, along with my poor teammates, who were turned into Lùshǔs.
别斯米尔：我记得，您的确这样做了，带着我那些被变成鹿蜀的，可怜的同伴们。

Getian: ...
葛天：……

Getian: I could not have imagined being around someone with unreadable bones.
葛天：总之，我本难以想象，应当怎样与无法看透骨相之人相处。

Getian: Turns out it wasn't as strange as I thought it would be.
葛天：如今看来，也不过如此而已。

Bessmert: Not much difference, you mean? Like the people here believe that there's no difference between humans and arcanists, which makes me very surprised.
别斯米尔：没有什么区别，对吗？就像我至今还很惊讶，这座城里的人，竟然认为神秘学家与人类并无不同。

Getian: Based on the bones I've seen, they are different. It's just that ...
葛天：就我所见骨相来说，大约确有不同。不过……

Bessmert: Doesn't make a difference, right?
别斯米尔：不重要，是不是?

Bessmert: We are the same when we desire something.
别斯米尔：在有所求，有所问的时候，我们也没有什么不同。

Bessmert turns her face toward where the people are moving.
别斯米尔把脸转向人们走来的方向。

She holds her face as if firmly staring at something, despite her lack of sight.
她明明看不见，却像是在坚定地望着什么。

Bessmert: I wasn't questioning you or the temple when I asked you about flying to the other side.
别斯米尔：……不如说，我刚才提出借助外力，飞跃断桥的那个问题，也并不是为了质疑你，或者你们说的“渊庙”。

Bessmert: I wasn't even questioning the strange condition of this arcane skill.
别斯米尔：甚至也不是在质疑这个古老神秘术的施放条件。

Getian: What do you mean?
葛天：那你是何意?

Bessmert: I was ... running out of options, I guess.
别斯米尔：只是……走投无路。我想。

Bessmert: It was just some futile effort I made when I realized this was a dead end, but I have no idea how it got to this point.
别斯米尔：像所有已经走投无路，却不理解自己究竟是怎样走到这一步的人，都会想做的一些无用功。

Bessmert makes her decision. She lifts the oiled umbrella and sticks it between the branches above her head. Walking out from beneath its cover, heading toward the people carving sticks in the rain.
别斯米尔做了一个决定。她把油伞举起来，卡在头顶的树杈之间，自己则从那下面离开，走向雨中正在刻下问卜木签的人们。

Yenisei does not stop either. She follows behind Bessmert—just as she has been doing since their departure.
小叶尼塞也没有停留。她跟在别斯米尔身后，从最早出发时就是如此，现在也一样。

Getian: Where are you going?
葛天：你往哪里去?

Bessmert: I have questions to ask.
别斯米尔：我也有话想问。

Getian: Even if there're no answers?
葛天：即使没有答案?

Bessmert: Yes. I think ... it is the same for all these people.
别斯米尔：是的。我相信这些人……他们也都知道。

Bessmert: They keep asking, even though they hear no answers.
别斯米尔：没有答案，可他们依然在问。

Bessmert walks forward, almost reaching the broken bridge, until Yenisei grabs her sleeve.
别斯米尔往前走去，几乎都要走上断桥，直到小叶尼塞衔住她的袖子。

Bessmert: It's okay. I know what you're going to say.
别斯米尔：没关系，我明白。

Yenisei reveals her image in the rain. The surface of the water is lightly pattered by raindrops, and her face is rippled by their falling.
小叶尼塞在雨中显影。水泊的表面被雨点打得隐隐绰绰，她的面庞也在其中不断晃动。

Fortunately, her heart is no longer swaying like her reflection.
好在她的内心已经不再如倒影一样摇摆不定。

Yenisei: How are you going to do it? We don't have any wooden chips like that.
小叶尼塞：您想怎么做？我们没有那样的木签。

Bessmert: I will use my finger, mud, and water, on the ground.
别斯米尔：用手指，用泥水，就在地面。

Bessmert: You can ask, too, whatever means you use.
别斯米尔：你也问吧，不必拘泥于形式。

Yenisei: What I want to know ...
小叶尼塞：我的问题……

Bessmert crouches down and pokes her index finger into the soft mud, writing a few Cyrillic letters. Then, others, and then still more.
别斯米尔蹲下身来，以食指戳在松软的泥水中，写下几个西里尔字母。而后是一些和另一些。

By the time she finishes writing the entire question, the first letters have already been eaten by the heavy rain, like seawater washing away etchings on a beach.
当她写完整个问题时，前面的字母已经被大雨冲刷而去，就像海水会卷走沙滩上的所有痕迹。

Bessmert: Child, what's your question? Say it if you like.
别斯米尔：孩子，你的问题呢？你可以说出来的。

Yenisei: I think I will write it down.
小叶尼塞：……我还是写下来吧。

Yenisei doesn't believe that doing so will have any purpose. But she cannot refuse Bessmert.
小叶尼塞并不认为这样做会有任何的意义。但她无法拒绝别斯米尔。

As she gazes at her face in the pool of water, she once again activates her arcane skill and asks the question that has been waiting in her heart.
注视着自己在水泊中的面容，她再次发动了神秘术，同时问出心中一直以来的疑问。

The red-haired girl suddenly disappears from the pool of water in front of her. Instead, a line of Cyrillic letters composed of warm-colored dots appears on the clear water's surface.
很快，眼前的水泊中，红发的女孩消失了。取而代之的是澄澈水面上，由暖色光点组成的一行西里尔字母。

The girl looks at the water and realizes that the line of words doesn't even need to be fully legible.
女孩望着水面，意识到那行字甚至不需要去仔细辨认。

Rain pounds and waves rise. The water trembles with her question.
雨点捶打，波光浮动。水面颤抖出一个问句。

"Where is my water?"
«Где мои воды?»
<“我的水域在哪里?”>

The sudden emergence of more animal footsteps prevents Yenisei from becoming lost in deeper thought.
突然出现的更多动物的脚步声，令小叶尼塞没来得及陷入更深的思索。

The red-haired girl reappears in the water, her tone as unsparing as usual.
红发女孩重新出现在水泊中，语气如往常一样毫不留情。

Yenisei: Are they still going to carry out the Fortune Walk?
小叶尼塞：他们难道还没放弃走吉——

Yenisei turns around.
小叶尼塞猛地回过头去。

These animals, neither Lùshǔs nor striped horses, have left the city's unattended Zhící and coincidentally arrived here.
既不是鹿蜀，也不是斑纹马的人们，从城中无人看管的职祠离开，却不约而同地来到这里。

They are stood there naked and tired, unadorned in any festive decorations.
他们赤裸，疲惫，未被驱赶，也没有穿着任何年节的装饰。

The ribbons and flowers Yenisei had seen on that first day in the bustling market have disappeared. Not suitable for the present situation, after all.
那些第一天小叶尼塞曾从闹市上见过的绸带与花朵都消失了。它们在这里毕竟不合时宜。

Yenisei: ...
小叶尼塞：……

Yenisei: They are ... carrying wooden chips in their mouths ...
小叶尼塞：……他们……衔着木签……

Bessmert: They're all here, right?
别斯米尔：他们都来了，是吗？

Yenisei: Yes.
小叶尼塞：……是的。

Yenisei: With the wooden chips. They are here for The Divination.
小叶尼塞：衔着木签。他们为问卜而来。

Yenisei: But the chips are empty.
小叶尼塞：但那上面是空白的。

Bessmert: They will have to ask in their minds.
别斯米尔：他们只能在心里发问了。

Yenisei: What would you like me to do?
小叶尼塞：您想让我做什么？

Bessmert: ...
别斯米尔：……

Bessmert: You can ...
别斯米尔：你可以——

Bessmert: You can be their mouths, hands, and eyes.
别斯米尔：成为他们的口、手、眼。

Bessmert: You can also do nothing.
别斯米尔：或者什么也不做。

Bessmert: Just like the good sir waiting behind us.
别斯米尔：就像我们后面的那位先生。

Gětiān remains in the tree and thus sees everything.
葛天还留在树上，也因此得见了一切。

His wings have become damp and heavy from the rain, and the cloth on his head is soaked, pressing down heavily as if dragging him back down to the ground, back into the mud, back to the place where the world began.
他的翅膀因淋雨而变得潮湿和沉重，头上的布巾也浸透了雨水，滞重地压着，像是要使他回到地上，回到泥层里，回到世界之初会有的那些地方去。

He doesn't move, silently taking stock of everything that happened under that tree.
他没有动作，沉默着将树下发生的一切纳入眼中。

Yenisei: I see. If they are here for The Divination ...
小叶尼塞：我知道了。如果他们都是来问卜……

Yenisei: I will help.
小叶尼塞：我会帮忙。

There are many puddles on the uneven ground. After a brief flicker of light, faces begin to appear in the water.
不平的地面上有许多水洼。短暂的光点闪烁后，水中逐渐显现出一些形色各异的人的面庞。

They fade again one by one, forming in long or short sentences. Though Yenisei cannot understand them. This is all she can do.
那些面庞很快出现，又很快消失，接连浮现的，是或长或短的方块字句子。小叶尼塞无法读懂。这就是她能做的所有了。

She continues to look for a while, then forces herself to turn around and search for Bessmert.
她继续望了一会儿，选择转头去寻找别斯米尔。

Yenisei: Madam, after we go back ...
小叶尼塞：女士，等回去后——

Bessmert smiles, shakes her head gently, and halts the girl's words.
别斯米尔笑起来，轻轻摇头，止住女孩的话。

Bessmert turns around, seeming to be facing Gětiān's direction, back to the city gates from which everyone came.
年长者转过身去，似乎朝向葛天所在的方向，也像是在对着众人来时城门的位置。

She can sense a steady stream of energy flowing toward some destination.
尽管她什么也看不见，却能察觉到某处有着源源不断的生的气息，正朝此处奔涌而来。

Bessmert: You're wrong. "It" can hear us.
别斯米尔：……你错了。祂能听到的。

Gětiān is in the tree, shaking off his wings like a swallow—shaking off the reasons for making him feel so excessively damp.
葛天在树上，像雨燕那样抖落翅膀上所有会令其过分潮湿的缘由。

He knows that Bessmert must not be talking to him, as the blind arcanist continues to work in vain.
他清楚别斯米尔并非在对着自己说话，盲眼的神秘学家只是继续做着无用功。

But then he is wrong yet again.
——但他又一次错了。

Getian: Who is ... that?
葛天：……那是——何人？

The sound everyone present can hear becomes louder and louder against the breaking silence, accompanied now by nothing but the patter of the rain, to the point where they all turn back in response—
所有在场者都能听见的声音，在除了雨声一无所有的寂静中越发响亮，以至于一切活物都应声回头——

All they see is a red dress swiftly passing over them all.
只见一袭红衣飞快地越过所有人。

It is Jiǔ Niángzǐ.
是曲娘。

Both those familiar and unfamiliar with her quickly realize her identity, despite the change.
那是曲娘，熟知或不熟知的人们都很快意识到。

Why did she do it? Did she really jump over the broken bridge? What could possibly have happened to her after doing so?
她为什么要这样做？她真的跃过断桥了吗？跃过去之后会怎么样？

A myriad of questions hovers in the minds of the confounded witnesses.
无数个问题盘旋在目睹一切之人的脑海中。

Yenisei: ...!
小叶尼塞：——！

Bessmert: It was her. The noise I heard ... It was Jiǔ Niángzǐ, right?
别斯米尔：……是她。刚才的声音……是曲娘，对吗？

Bessmert: It was an unusual disturbance when she jumped over the bridge.
别斯米尔：我听到了非同寻常的动静，就在她跃过去的那一瞬间。

Citizen I: That-that was Jiǔ Niángzǐ?
城中居民 I：刚才那是——是曲娘——?!

Citizen I: Mr. Liǔ, did you see that??
城中居民 Ⅰ： 柳郎，你看见了吗??

Citizen III: Yes! That's her, that's really her. High heaven, she did it, she jumped over!
城中居民 Ⅲ： 是，我看见了。是她——是她。天啊，她居然办到了，她飞过去了……！

In shock, someone hurriedly pokes their head toward the opposite bank of the broken bridge, but stops and withdraws at the cliff's edge.
震惊之中，有人向断桥的对岸急急探出头去，却又在崖边停住收回。

They are seeking a definite answer, but fear the steepness and height of the cliff. Naturally, they never imagined someone might cross it—
他们追求着一个笃定的答案，却仍然畏惧于悬崖的陡峭与高远，自然也想不到——

Citizen I: This ... That ...
城中居民 Ⅰ： 这，这——

Yenisei: That's right. It's Jiǔ Niángzǐ ... I saw her turn into a Lùshǔ ... Madam, she turned into a real Lùshǔ!
小叶尼塞： 没错，没错，是曲娘……我看到她变成了鹿蜀……女士，她真的成为了鹿蜀！

Citizen I: *sobs* The people are back, and the river ...
城中居民 Ⅰ： ——呜呜……马都变回来了，河也——

Citizen V: The river! Ah, the Pèilín River is rising!
城中居民 Ⅴ： 天哪，河水——沛霖川涨水了——！

Beneath the cliff no longer lies a canyon or a low river, but a constantly rising torrent.
悬崖之下已经不再是峡谷和低矮的河水，而是涌动着不断向上的湍流。

Citizen V: Wait, I can talk! My body is ... What's happening?!
城中居民 Ⅴ： 不对，我能说话了，我的身体也……怎么回事！！

The people finally react.
人们终于反应了过来。

They look at each other excitedly, a red light illuminating their faces like the dazzling courtyard fires beneath the festival walkways—or the strip of light that appeared on the river before.
他们奋袂地张望着彼此，脸上浮现着红光，如同除夜廊下耀眼的庭燎，更像是河上曾经的光带。

Their divine wishes have been granted.
问卜应验了。

Yenisei: Wait. I ...
小叶尼塞： 等等，我——

Yenisei: My body is back?
小叶尼塞： 我也变回来了?

Yenisei almost leaps into the air to embrace Bessmert.
小叶尼塞几乎要跳起来拥抱别斯米尔。

Yenisei: Jiǔ Niángzǐ ... She jumped over the bridge! She jumped over ... in the human form!
小叶尼塞： 曲娘——曲娘跳过去了！她竟然以人身的样子……跃过去了……！

Yenisei: She didn't fall! I'm not sure if I saw it clearly ... I think, for an instant, she turned into a real Lùshǔ.
小叶尼塞： 她没有坠下去，甚至在半空中的时候，我以为是我眼花了……似乎有一瞬间，她真的变成了鹿蜀。

Yenisei: Is this the power of The Divination, the magic of "Ask and Acquire"?
小叶尼塞： 难道这就是问卜，是“所求必应”……

Yenisei: Oh, wait! The people in the city have come back, so maybe ...
小叶尼塞：对了！这些城中的人都变回来了，说不定——

A voice now long unheard also sounds from beside them.
许久未闻的声音也在身旁响起。

Krolik: What ... the?
克罗利克：什么……这……？

Krolik: Ugh, what's going on? Ah! My head hurts ...
克罗利克：啊，这到底是怎么了？头痛欲裂……

Yenisei: Mr. Krolik!
小叶尼塞：……克罗利克先生！

In the crowd, all the companions they once had lost are now returned to them.
人群之中，同伴失而复得。

Jurien: Oh, dear ... I had the strangest dream ...
尤利恩：天哪……难道我是做了一场怪梦吗……

Yenisei: And Mr. Jurien, everyone!
小叶尼塞：还有——尤利恩先生他们——

Yenisei: They are over there! Madam, let's go see them!
小叶尼塞：他们都在那边！别斯米尔女士，我们也过去吧！

Without waiting for an answer, Yenisei waves from a distance and immediately runs toward them.
不等回答，小叶尼塞远远招手示意，随即奔向他们。

Yenisei: Here! We are here ...
小叶尼塞：这里，我们在这边——

Bessmert: Bǎizǎi Nánféng Suìzhāochūn.
别斯米尔：……“百载难逢岁朝春”……

Bessmert: It's indeed a rare occasion.
别斯米尔：的确难得。

6#1
6#1

“所求必应”
Ask and Acquire NS-22

Street, Inside the City
城中街上

Storyteller: Previously, we were at ...
说书先生：上回说到——

Citizen VI: Lùshǔ the Xiángruì came to the human world to go through the god's test, but she repented!
城中居民 VI：说到祥瑞鹿蜀人间历劫，幡然悔悟！

Storyteller: Exactly. She had been troubled by the repentance until the New Year's Eve. That night, her tutor straightened her out, and she was very grateful. After that, she bid him goodbye and went to the broken bridge alone.
说书先生：正是。且说那鹿蜀，衔草结环，除夜叩拜了先生开解之恩，自城中一别，独往断桥去也。

Storyteller: However, ladies and gentlemen, the Shuòrì this year happened to be the beginning of spring. Such a coincidence happens only once every 100 years. On this peculiar day, the thunderstorm was raging, and all the strangest things happened!
说书先生：须知今岁朔日亦交春，端的是百年难遇，云中却狂雨乱坠，异象频生——！

Storyteller: The cliff was shrouded in confusing fog, and below was a bottomless abyss! No one had ever jumped over the bridge successfully, yet the Lùshǔ decided to make an attempt, for the sake of the people who believed in her! She was determined to retrieve the tortoise shell divination ...
说书先生：即使那崖岸上是致人晕眩之雾气，崖下是去不可返之深渊，鹿蜀身负了众人期望，决意跃过这无人可征之断桥，为它所庇佑者，寻觅重启龟甲问卜之法——

Citizen VI: That's not it! She used the wooden chip! Not the tortoise shell!
城中居民 VI：你说错啦！是木签，不是龟甲！

Storyteller: Emm ...
说书先生：这……

Citizen II: You've told this story for many times, and still getting it wrong? You have to admit you're not young anymore.
城中居民 II：这故事我们都听过好几遍了，这也讲错，您确实糊涂了。

Storyteller: Well, there is no such thing as a perfect story. Adaptations are always allowed, right? Please pretend you didn't hear me and forget about it ...
说书先生：说故事，总有疏漏或再编，劳烦各位听过的，就当作是没听过一般，权且忘了罢……

Citizen VII: Give me a break. He's telling that story again? I thought he'd be done with it after last time. I even bought a ticket!
城中居民 VII：这说书的，怎么又开始了？原先我还记着他说不会再讲了，抢过他最后一场的坐堂票呢——

Citizen V: "Last time"? When, last year? Did you sleep for a whole year?
城中居民 V：原先？你这一觉睡得……原先是哪个原先？翻过年以前？

Storyteller: I hear you, gentleman in blue.
说书先生：堂后蓝衣公子之问，我可全数听说了。

Citizen VII: Now he's listening ...
城中居民 VII：耳朵这么好使……

Storyteller: You know, you're part of the story, just like me.
说书先生：我这回来，就像你，可是这鹿蜀传奇的一部分。

Citizen VII: Me? What do you mean?
城中居民 VII：我？什么意思？

Storyteller: Listen and you'll know. So the Lùshǔ jumped over the bridge, awakened the Yuān Temple, and revived the Pèilín River. As a result, more and more people come to the Pèi City at festivals, so I start telling stories again.
说书先生：鹿蜀跃桥，唤醒渊庙，复生河流。沛霖川恢复往日充盈，人们年节走动频繁，于是我便重拾旧业了。

Storyteller: As for you ...
说书先生：至于你——

Storyteller: The Lùshǔ took over your tavern and turned you into her kind because you were an unscrupulous profiteer. You gave short weight to the people. That caused the decline of your business, yet you blamed it on the poor harvest.
说书先生：那鹿蜀收了你的酒馆，将你变为它类，原是你自己卖酒时缺斤少两坏了名声，却怪时节收成不良，营生不易。

Storyteller: But I think the Lùshǔ saved you from the plight! She ran the tavern for you, and you had a good sleep during that time. In a word, you did nothing good, but things ended up well for you!
说书先生：这鹿蜀，可算是解了你的困境！替你经营酒坊，还令你好好睡上一觉，醒来呀，坐享其成便是——

Citizen VI: What? No way!
城中居民 VI：还有这样的美事！

Citizen VI: I want that, too. If only somebody could finish my essay when I fall asleep!
城中居民 VI：我也想睡一觉起来，就有人帮我写了策论！

Storyteller: Already writing a political essay at this age? You have a promising future, young man ...
说书先生：小小年纪便习写策论，年少有为，年少有为啊……

Storyteller: But I think you should go home now and get some sleep. You need to rest well, so you can continue with your studies tomorrow.
说书先生：不过，还是早些回去，洗洗睡了，明日里起来温书要紧。

Storyteller: After all, the essay matters much more than the story, right?
说书先生：听故事可写不来策论，是不是?

Amidst the festive hustle and bustle, a farewell brews in front of the city gates.
节日热闹的喧嚷之外，一场话别正在城门前酝酿。

This is the place from which people come, and people go.
人们从这里进入，也从这里离开。

Bessmert: I have so many things to write about this time, enough for me to write a travel note.
别斯米尔：这次的素材相当充足，足够我写上一本恰到好处的游记了。

Bessmert: What should I call it? Travel in the East? Journey to Pèi City?
别斯米尔：这本游记，应该叫什么好……《东方游记》?《沛城游记》?

Yenisei: Neither of them sounds good.
小叶尼塞：……听上去都不太对。

Yenisei: There are already too many Travels and Journeys. I think you are different from those authors, Madam, so ...
小叶尼塞：写“游记”的人已经太多了，女士。我认为，您是与他们不同的，所以……

Gětiān escorts the group to a spot near the city gate, where the road splits into two. On one side lies the road up the mountain, and on the other lies the road down.
葛天将一行人送到城门外不远处，道路便分开两边。一边是上山的路，一边是下山的路。

He slowly descends to the ground, standing still, stiff and slightly uncomfortable.
他停下来，缓缓落到地上，略有不适地站稳。

The human companions of the two arcanists retreat in caution and fear from the strange bird creature.
两位神秘学家的人类同伴都警惕而畏惧地向后退去。

Getian: Indeed. Unlike others, the two of you have experienced it in its entirety.
葛天：是不同。两位皆得了始终。

Yenisei: What do you mean?
小叶尼塞：这是什么意思?

Getian: There was a beginning, and now here is an end. Forget not where you came from at the end —this is entirety.
葛天：有始有终，不忘来时心念，便是得出始终。

Getian: Thus, happiness is found.
葛天： 有福之人亦如此。

Bessmert: I'm sorry that I still don't understand your riddles.
别斯米尔： 很遗憾，我还是没有听懂。

Getian: That's no matter.
葛天： 无妨。

Krolik: Emm ... Sorry to interrupt you. Can we go? I really want to go home right away ...
克罗利克： 我们……我们能走了吗？很抱歉打扰你们，但我真的很想回家……

Bessmert: Ah, then we shall ...
别斯米尔： 啊，那我们——

Getian: Please wait. There's one more thing.
葛天： 烦请稍待。我还有一事相问。

Bessmert: Certainly, please.
别斯米尔： 那么，您请说。

Getian: The questions you asked—have you had the answers?
葛天： 两位所问，是否都已得到解答？

Yenisei: ...
小叶尼塞： ……

Bessmert: I'm not sure.
别斯米尔： 我不清楚。

Getian: What do you mean?
葛天： 不清楚？

Bessmert: When Jiǔ Niángzǐ jumped over the bridge, Yenisei saw a pattern being formed where I wrote my question.
别斯米尔： 那天曲娘跃过断桥之后，小叶尼塞告诉我，在我先前写下了问题的地方，出现了一个图像。

Bessmert: We didn't understand it. It didn't bother us either, perhaps because there was no answer to my question ...
别斯米尔： 我们看不明白，也没太在意，因为我的问题或许本身就没有解答——

Getian: A question is asked, and a divination is made. What you saw might be a Hexagram, not the interpretation of it.
葛天： 问卜之问，问卜之卜。前者提出问题，后者卜筮解答。你们得到的，应是卦象，而非卦辞。

Getian: Do you still remember what it looks like?
葛天： 还记得那个图形，长什么模样吗？

Yenisei thinks for a moment and uses a rock hammer handle to draw crooked and twisted lines in the sand, with occasional breaks in the middle of them.
小叶尼塞思索着，用地质锤的把手在沙地上划下歪歪扭扭，中间偶有断开的几条线。

Yenisei: It changed a little ... and ended up like this.
小叶尼塞： 它变化了一下……最后是这样。

Getian: The Hexagram of Water and Fire.
葛天： 水火既济。

Getian: I'd assume this belongs to an elderly person. What about yours?
葛天： 我猜，这卦应属年长之人。你又如何？

Yenisei is stunned for a moment, then draws a few more lines. By the end of it, her offering is already rather messy, so much so that she stretches out a section of it.
小叶尼塞愣住片刻，又划下几横，到最后已经有些潦草，以至于支出去一节。

Fortunately, Gětiān can still read it.
所幸葛天尚能辨认。

Getian: This is ... Xū, the Hexagram of waiting. Though I don't know what could be derived from it ...
葛天：此为……需卦。虽不知变卦几何……

Getian: The interpretation is simple. Above is Water, the stranding dragon, advising patience. Below is uprightness, which means you will smooth away the obstacles.
葛天：不过需卦本真简明。上为水险，是龙困浅滩，未到时机。下为刚健，遇凶亦可化险为夷。

Yenisei: Which means ...?
小叶尼塞：什么意思?

Getian: You will find your water. All you need to do is wait.
葛天：你会找到那片水域，只是需得等待时机。

Yenisei: Yes, thank you. I didn't know that.
小叶尼塞：……说了跟没说一样。

Getian: As for your Hexagram ...
葛天：至于“既济”……

Getian: You have gone across the river. A decision has been made.
葛天：既已渡河，那便已做出选择。

Bessmert: I see.
别斯米尔：原来是这样。

Yenisei: Turns out The Divination doesn't help at all.
小叶尼塞：所以这问卜其实一点用也没有。

Getian: It does, if you believe in it.
葛天：信则有。

Bessmert: No. I know what you mean.
别斯米尔：不，我知道了。

Bessmert: It is exactly how I expected it to be. Thank you, Mr. Gětiān.
别斯米尔：这与我现在所想的一样。谢谢您，葛天先生。

Getian: No need.
葛天：不必言谢。

Bessmert: And what about you? Have you learned your answer?
别斯米尔：您呢？您问了吗？有解答了吗?

Getian: It told me to let things be.
葛天：它令我顺其自然。

Getian: Since I have left the mountain ... I should follow what's inside my mind.
葛天：所以我决定……既然已经下山，那便从心而为了。

Gětiān turns his head and points his wings toward the path up the mountain.
葛天转过头去，以翅膀指向上山的道路。

Getian: I remember that at the end of the Pèilín River, where the lanterns float, stands a great building.
葛天：我仍记得，河灯曾经漂向的沛霖川尽头，远远立着一栋宏伟的楼宇。

Getian: It might be real or illusional. I have seen it many times, yet I have never thought of going there.
葛天：或真实，或虚幻。即使是数次亲眼所见，我却从未心念往去，一探究竟。

The two of them look in the direction pointed out by Gětiān, only seeing the jungle into which Jiǔ Niángzǐ disappeared, and nothing more.
两人也随着葛天所指方向看过去，只看到曲娘消失的那片丛林，再看不到更远更多。

Yenisei: There's nothing there.
小叶尼塞：那里什么也没有。

Getian: I will go anyway.
葛天：我仍会前去。

Yenisei: ...
小叶尼塞：……

Yenisei: Then ...
小叶尼塞：那……

Yenisei: What about Jiǔ Niángzǐ? She jumped over the bridge. Is she never coming back?
小叶尼塞：……曲娘呢？她也过去了。但她是不是，不会再回来了？

Gětiān doesn't answer, he only shakes his head. All Yenisei can do is glance over to Gětiān filled with unspoken inquiries.
葛天没有回答，摇了摇头。小叶尼塞只能征询地望向别斯米尔。

Bessmert turns toward the distant cliffs and jungle, standing without speaking for a long while.
别斯米尔也看着远处的山崖与丛林，许久没有说话。

Until at last she breaks her silence.
片刻后，她才开口。

Bessmert: Perhaps ...
别斯米尔：也许……

Bessmert: Perhaps we will meet again one day.
别斯米尔：也许在别的地方，会再见到的。

6#1
6#1

他日再逢
We Will Meet Again NS-23

The party journeys along the river for a long time, but the night never falls.
队伍沿着河流走了许久也没有迎来黑夜。

Most of them are in a hurry to leave—the same desire as before, but now much stronger than ever before, more than enough to bring the long-awaited harmony of a common purpose to the team.
多数人都着急赶路，想要离开这里的相同念头前所未有地强烈，以至于成为了一种足以保证队伍和谐的共识。

And no one dares mention their experiences for the rest of the trip.
没有人再提及先前的经历。

Krolik: Let's make camp after we get out of the forest. What do you say?
克罗利克：我们在走出草原之后再扎营休息，可以吗?

Bessmert: I'm fine with it. How are you feeling, Mr. Jurien?
别斯米尔：我没有异议。尤利恩先生，您感觉怎么样?

Jurien: I'm fine with that.
尤利恩：我也没有问题。

Yenisei: ...
小叶尼塞：……

A few still harbor a lingering curiosity, one they endure for a long time, and until unable to resist, they turn around to see if the ancient city on the mountainside is still in sight.
只有少数人仍保有一种迟疑的好奇，忍耐许久，终于还是在途中回过头去，想要再看一看那山腰的古城，是否还在视线之中。

But while this is not a story where those who look back might turn into pillars of salt, there remains no trace of the strange city that should have still been in view.
这并非只要回头便变为盐柱的故事，但也确实再也找不到一丝那奇异城市曾经存在的痕迹。

And as they walk onward, the revived river known as the Pèilín too has changed its appearance.
甚至，连同他们一路沿着走下来，被称为“沛霖川”的复生河流，也一起变了模样。

Yenisei: ...!
小叶尼塞：……!!!

Yenisei: Madam, the river ...
小叶尼塞：女士，这条河——它——

The once-wide river invisibly splits into slender tributaries behind them, spread out across the lush spring meadows like a rope net.
一条原本宽阔的大河，不知不觉间竟在人们身后分裂为数道纤细的支流，如同绳网一般，安静盘踞在春季茂盛的草甸上。

Even if they wanted to find it, they might never distinguish the one that would lead them back.
即使想找，也再也辨不清回去的那支。

Bessmert: What is it?
别斯米尔：怎么了?

Team Member II: The compass is working!
考察队员 II：——指南针！指南针能用了！

Team Member II: Great!
考察队员 II：好极了——

Their fellow traveler excitedly raises his hands, briefly blocking Yenisei's gaze from Bessmert.
同行者激动地抬起双手，短暂阻隔了小叶尼塞回望别斯米尔的视线。

The girl takes advantage of the situation and withdraws the words she cannot say. She only gently shakes her head.
女孩顺势收回未能出口的话，转而轻轻摇头。

Yenisei: Nothing. Let's move.
小叶尼塞：……没什么，女士。我们继续走吧。

Yenisei: The compass is working, which means we can rely on the map again.
小叶尼塞：指南针可以使用的话，地图也能重新派上用场。

Bessmert: Oh, that's good. As for the book I'm going to write ...
别斯米尔：哦，是的。另外关于这本游记……

Yenisei: Yes? Have you decided the title?
小叶尼塞：嗯？您想好名字了？

Bessmert: Yes. I will call it ...
别斯米尔：没错。我想，我会叫它——

Bessmert: "Notes on Shuòrì."
别斯米尔：“朔日手记”。

Yenisei: Notes on Shuòrì ...
小叶尼塞：《朔日手记》……

Yenisei: Yes, that's the title.
小叶尼塞：是的，是这个名字。

She flips over a page and continues reading.
她将手稿翻过一页，继续读着。

Yenisei: "The title is actually not a good choice for a book on geographical discoveries."
小叶尼塞：“这名字对一本以地理探索与发现为主要内容的书籍来说，其实算不上一个良好的选择。”

Yenisei: "On one hand, there is no doubt that 'Shuòrì' is a difficult word for the target readers of this book."
小叶尼塞：“一方面，‘朔日’对本书未来潜在的读者来说，实在是一个晦涩难懂的名词。”

Yenisei: "On the other hand, the word 'Notes,' in most cases, is used to describe the collections of informal essays. They usually record the daily talks of professional writers, and thus include a variety of ideas and inspirations."
小叶尼塞：“而另一方面，‘手记’常见于称呼随笔性质的文章合集。这种合集常常是职业作家夜话笔录的结果，其中饱含思想的碰撞与灵感的曙光。”

Yenisei: "As a geographer, however, I don't possess enough knowledge of literature to write the real 'Notes,' nor does the assistant who takes dictations from me, unfortunately ..."
小叶尼塞：“作为并不专精文字的地理研究者，我的文学素养显然还没有到达那样高深的程度。更遗憾的是，负责为我记录文字的助手同样如此……”

Yenisei: Haha ...
小叶尼塞：哈哈……

Yenisei: "Even so, we have decided to use these words for the title. Postscript: The title has also been included in the first draft we sent to the editors of Motherland Documentary and the Department of Publication Review."
小叶尼塞：“……但无论如何，我们还是定下了这个名字。批注：这一决定，也见于寄给《祖国纪实》月刊编辑和书报审查部门的初稿中。”

Yenisei: The next page is missing. Let me see ...
小叶尼塞：缺页。之后是——

Yenisei: Oh, found it.
小叶尼塞：找到了。

Yenisei: "June 4, sunny. I never knew the journey back to Omsk would take so long. My assistant and I set off from Yekaterinburg last year, and we didn't arrive until now ..."
小叶尼塞：“六月四日，天气晴。我从未想过，在与助手从叶堡出发后，竟然直到次年六月才终于回到鄂木斯克……”

Yenisei: "In Omsk, we met the governor again. I left him some drafts of this book in return for the help from the local Scientific Research Association."
小叶尼塞：“在那里，我们与总督再次面谈，为感谢当地科学研究协会的帮助，我留下了一部分《朔日手记》的草稿供他们使用。”

Yenisei: "Those drafts have recorded the steppe ecosystem around the Om River in detail. For example, before we arrived in Omsk, we followed a herd of sheep across the river. The wool on their tails was apparently matted."
小叶尼塞：“其中包含大部分鄂木河周边草原生态的详细记录，例如在抵达鄂木斯克以前，我们曾跟随一群尾部有显著毛绒结团症状的绵羊涉水渡河。”

Yenisei: "I recorded this detail because the way they crossed the water was almost a miracle. It is known to all that sheep can be easily drowned because their thick wool holds them back in water."
小叶尼塞：“之所以着重记述这一点，是因为那简直是种神迹似的景象。众所周知，绵羊极易溺水，它们厚重的毛在遇水时只是负担。”

Yenisei: "Yet things seemed different for those sheep. They had been trained by the local herders and were able to cross the river swiftly, as if they were only several balls of cotton floating on the water ..."
小叶尼塞：“然而这群绵羊却与众不同。在当地牧民的训练下，它们渡河的动作极快且轻，几乎像是漂在河上的数团棉花一样自在，甚至……”

Ms. Radio: "... When they came to the shore, I noticed that their hooves were in the shape of a round cake with one slice missing."
无线电小姐：“……甚至直到它们靠岸，你才会发现，原来它们还长着被切掉一块的蛋糕似的蹄子。”

Vertin: Hmm ...
维尔汀：……唔……

Ms. Radio: "They climbed out of the water with their little cake hooves, shook themselves dry, and continued on to the next pasture, never hesitant to go forward, never looking back."
无线电小姐：“靠岸之后，那些绵羊用蛋糕蹄子攀爬上去，稳当地甩落一身潮湿，继续向着水草丰茂的地方走去，从不瞻前顾后。”

Ms. Radio: "Seeing all these, I hope I will be as determined as these sheep in my future journey ..."
无线电小姐：“见过了这一切之后，我认为，这也将是我日后所有旅程的目标……”

Ms. Radio: "Today's article was an extract from a geographic manuscript from St. Pavlov Foundation Far East Branch, recorded by Yenisei."
无线电小姐：“今日电台选段，来自圣洛夫基金会远东分部收藏地理学手稿——《朔日手记》。记录员：小叶尼塞。”

Ms. Radio: "Next is the news broadcast ..."
无线电小姐：“现在，将进行今日新闻播报……”

Vertin: ...
维尔汀：……

Vertin: Mmm ...
维尔汀：呃……

Vertin: Ms. Radio?
维尔汀：无线电小姐?

Ms. Radio: Yes, I'm here.
无线电小姐：您好，我在。

Vertin: I ... What time is it now?
维尔汀：现在——现在是什么时候了?

Ms. Radio: It's 4:15 p.m.
无线电小姐：下午四点十五分。

Vertin: The nap went on a little longer than I thought.
维尔汀：……看起来，我睡了一个漫长的午觉。

Ms. Radio: Yes. How are you feeling?
无线电小姐：是的，您感觉如何?

Vertin: Think I had a dream. Many animals were jumping over a broken bridge.
维尔汀：我觉得我做了梦。有好多动物在跳过一个断掉的木桥。

Ms. Radio: I read you a story which has zebras and sheep in it.
无线电小姐：在先前的推送中，我为您阅读了一个包含斑马和绵羊的故事。

Vertin: Zebras and sheep?
维尔汀：斑马，绵羊?

Vertin: I don't remember that ...
维尔汀：不，我好像也记不清了……

Vertin: Hmm?
维尔汀：嗯?

???: Excuse me. Is Timekeeper in the room?
???：——请问，司辰在吗?

Vertin: I am.
维尔汀：我在。

???: May I come in? There is something I need to confirm with you ...
???：我可以进来吗？有些事情需要征询您的意见——

Vertin: I'm sorry, who's that?
维尔汀：抱歉，请问你是?

Sonetto: Hmm? It's me, Sonetto.
十四行诗：嗯？是我，十四行诗。

Vertin: I might have taken too long a nap. Never mind, please come in.
维尔汀：……这个午觉可能的确太漫长了。没事，请进吧。

Sonetto: Timekeeper, you don't look very well. Are you alright?
十四行诗：司辰，您看上去有些恍惚……您感觉还好吗?

Vertin: It's ok. I had a weird dream.
维尔汀：还好，只是做了奇怪的梦。

Vertin: What's going on?
维尔汀：怎么了?

Sonetto: Oh, it's a letter from the Foundation. A colleague from the Russian branch was transferred to the headquarters today. She has shown a strong willingness to perform long-term field missions ...
十四行诗：啊，是基金会来信。日前有一位来自俄罗斯分部的同事调职到总部，她对能够长期外出调查的工作表达出了强烈的意愿……

Sonetto: Thus, the headquarters intends to transfer her to the Timekeeper Squad. Would you have a meeting with her? It is said that she is experienced in geographical exploration and survival in the wilderness. She could be a great helper.
十四行诗：所以总部倾向于将她也编入司辰小队，您要不要见一下她？据说她有丰富的地理探索和野外应急处理经验，也许能成为很好的助力。

Vertin: Geographical exploration? What's her name?
维尔汀：地理探索？她叫什么名字?

Sonetto: Please hold on. Let me check her file here.
十四行诗：请稍等，她的资料在这里。

Sonetto: And her name is ...
十四行诗： 名字是——

Sonetto: Yenisei.
十四行诗： ——小叶尼塞。

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